GREEN CLIMATE FUND

**Meeting of the Board**
30 June – 3 July 2025
Port Moresby, Papua New Guinea
Provisional agenda item 11

**GCF/B.42/02/Add.09**
9 June 2025

# Consideration of funding proposals – Addendum IX

## Funding proposal package for FP267


### Summary

This addendum contains the following seven parts:

a) A funding proposal titled "Scaling up ecosystem-based approaches to managing climate-intensified disaster risks in vulnerable regions of South Africa ("Eco-DRR")";
b) No-objection letter issued by the national designated authority(ies) or focal point(s);
c) Environmental and social report(s) disclosure;
d) Secretariat's assessment;
e) Independent Technical Advisory Panel's assessment;
f) Response from the accredited entity to the independent Technical Advisory Panel's assessment; and
g) Gender documentation.

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# Funding Proposal

| | |
|---|---|
| Project/Programme title: | Scaling up ecosystem-based approaches to managing climate-intensified disaster risks in vulnerable regions of South Africa (“Eco-DRR”). |
| Country(ies): | South Africa (“SA”). |
| Accredited Entity: | SANBI |
| Date of first submission: | [2023/03/31] |
| Date of current submission | [2025/04/11] |
| Version number | [V.7] |

GREEN CLIMATE FUND

## GLOSSARY

| Acronym | Description |
|---|---|
| **AML** | Anti-Money Laundering |
| **ARA** | Adaptation Result Area |
| **BCR** | Benefit Cost Ratio |
| **BIPA** | Biodiversity, Information and Policy Advice |
| **BRAM** | Biodiversity, Research, Assessment and Monitoring |
| **CFT** | Combating Terrorism Financing |
| **CMA** | Catchment Management Agency |
| **COGTA** | Department of Cooperative Governance and Traditional Affairs |
| **CSIR** | Council for Scientific and Industrial Research |
| **DALRRD** | Department of Land Reform and Rural Development |
| **DDM** | District Development Model |
| **DFFE** | Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment |
| **DFFE: EP** | Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment: Environmental Programmes |
| **DM** | District Municipality |
| **DRR** | Disaster Risk Reduction |
| **DSBD** | Department of Small Business Development |
| **DTI** | Department of Trade and Industry |
| **DWS** | Department of Water and Sanitation |
| **EbA** | Ecosystem Based Adaptation |
| **Eco-DRR** | Ecosystem Based Disaster Risk Reduction |
| **EIRR** | Economic Internal Rate of Return |
| **EPWP** | Expanded Public Works Programme |
| **ESMF** | Environmental and Social Management Framework |
| **ESMP** | Environmental and Social Management Plan |
| **GCF** | Green Climate Fund |
| **GDP** | Gross Domestic Product |
| **GEF** | Global Environment Facility |
| **GIS** | Geographic Information System |
| **GRM** | Grievance Redress Mechanism |
| **IAP** | Invasive Alien Plant |
| **IDP** | Integrated Development Plan |
| **LM** | Local Municipality |
| **M&E** | Monitoring and Evaluation |
| **MERL** | Monitoring, Evaluation, Reporting and Learning |
| **MISA** | Municipal Infrastructure Support Agent |
| **MOA** | Memorandum of Agreement |
| **MOU** | Memorandum of Understanding |
| **MoV** | Means of Verification |
| **MSME** | Micro Small- and Medium- Sized Enterprises |
| **NAFAB** | National Adaptation Funds Advisory Body |
| **NBI** | National Business Initiative |
| **NCCAS** | National Climate Change Adaptation Strategy |
| **NCCRP** | National Climate Change Response Policy |
| **NDC** | Nationally Determined Contributions |
| **NDMC** | National Disaster Management Centre |
| **NGO** | Non-Governmental Organisation |
| **NPV** | Net Present Value |
| **PCC** | Presidential Climate Commission |
| **PDMC** | Provincial Disaster Management Centre |
| **PMG** | Project Management Group |
| **PMU** | Project Management Unit |
| **PPP** | Public Private Partnership |
| **PSC** | Project Steering Committee |

| | |
|---|---|
| **SALGA** | South African Local Government Association |
| **SANBI** | South African National Biodiversity Institute |
| **SANParks** | South African National Parks |
| **SAWS** | South African Weather Service |
| **SCM** | Supply Chain Management |
| **SDG** | Sustainable Development Goal |
| **SFC** | Sustainable Finance Coalition |
| **SMME** | Small, Medium and Micro Enterprises |
| **SEEA** | System of Environmental-Economic Accounting |
| **Stats SA** | Statistics South Africa |
| **TAMDEV** | Technical Assistance, Mentorship and Development Programme |
| **TNC** | Third National Communication |
| **TOC** | Theory of Change |
| **UNFCCC** | United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change |
| **USD** | United States Dollar |
| **WUA** | Water User Association |
| **WWF** | World Wide Fund For Nature |
| **ZAR** | South African Rand |

## Contents



***Note to Accredited Entities on the use of the funding proposal template***

- Accredited Entities should provide summary information in the proposal with cross-reference to annexes such as feasibility studies, gender action plan, term sheet, etc.
- Accredited Entities should ensure that annexes provided are consistent with the details provided in the funding proposal. Updates to the funding proposal and/or annexes must be reflected in all relevant documents.
- The total number of pages for the funding proposal (excluding annexes) **should not exceed 60**. Proposals exceeding the prescribed length will not be assessed within the usual service standard time.
- The recommended font is Arial, size 11.
- Under the GCF Information Disclosure Policy, project and programme funding proposals will be disclosed on the GCF website, simultaneous with the submission to the Board, subject to the redaction of any information that may not be disclosed pursuant to the IDP. Accredited Entities are asked to fill out information on disclosure in section G.4.

**Please submit the completed proposal to:**
fundingproposal@gcfund.org

**Please use the following name convention for the file name:**
"FP-[Accredited Entity Short Name]-[Country/Region]-[YYYY/MM/DD]"

## A. PROJECT/PROGRAMME SUMMARY

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **A.1. Project or programme** | Project | **A.2. Public or private sector** | Public |
| **A.3. Request for Proposals (RFP)** | *If the funding proposal is being submitted in response to a specific GCF Request for Proposals, indicate which RFP it is targeted for. Please note that there is a separate template for the Simplified Approval Process and REDD+.* Not applicable | | |

**A.4. Result area(s)**

*Check the applicable GCF result area(s) that the overall proposed project/programme targets below. For each checked result area(s), indicate the estimated percentage of **GCF and Co-financers' contribution** devoted to it. The total of the percentages when summed should be 100% for GCF and Co-financers' contribution respectively.*

| | GCF contribution | Co-financers' contribution[1] |
|---|---|---|
| **Mitigation total** | Enter number % | Enter number % |
| ☐ Energy generation and access | Enter number % | Enter number % |
| ☐ Low-emission transport | Enter number % | Enter number % |
| ☐ Buildings, cities, industries and appliances | Enter number % | Enter number % |
| ☐ Forestry and land use | Enter number % | Enter number % |
| **Adaptation total** | Enter number % | Enter number % |
| ☒ Most vulnerable people and communities | 60 % | 50 % |
| ☐ Health and well-being, and food and water security | 0 % | 0 % |
| ☐ Infrastructure and built environment | 0 % | 0 % |
| ☒ Ecosystems and ecosystem services | 40 % | 50 % |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **A.5. Expected mitigation outcome** *(Core indicator 1: GHG emissions reduced, avoided or removed / sequestered)* | NA | **A.6. Expected adaptation outcome** *(Core indicator 2: direct and indirect beneficiaries reached)* | 5,481,886 (male 2,598,883 Female 2,883,003) | |
| | | | DIRECT 366,088 (male 168,034 female 198,054) | INDIRECT 5,115,798 (male 2,430,849 female 2,684,949) |
| | | | 0,61% | 8,47% |
| **A.7. Total financing (GCF + co-finance[2])** | 49,51 million USD | **A.9. Project size** | Small (Upto USD 50 million) | |
| **A.8. Total GCF funding requested** | 40,10 million USD *For multi-country proposals, please fill out annex 17.* | | | |

[1] Co-financer's contribution means the financial resources required, whether Public Finance or Private Finance, in addition to the GCF contribution (i.e. GCF financial resources requested by the Accredited Entity) to implement the project or programme described in the funding proposal.
[2] Refer to the Policy of Co-financing of the GCF.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **A.10. Financial instrument(s) requested for the GCF funding** | *Mark all that apply and provide total amounts. The sum of all total amounts should be consistent with A.8.*<br>☒ Grant 40,11 million USD<br>☐ Equity Enter number<br>☐ Loan Enter number<br>☐ Results-based payment Enter number<br>☐ Guarantee Enter number | | |
| **A.11. Implementation period** | 8 years | **A.12. Total lifespan** | 20 years |
| **A.13. Expected date of AE internal approval** | 4/30/2025 | **A.14. ESS category** | B |
| **A.15. Has this FP been submitted as a CN before?** | Yes ☒ No ☐ | **A.16. Has Readiness or PPF support been used to prepare this FP?** | Yes ☒ No ☐ |
| **A.17. Is this FP included in the entity work programme?** | Yes ☒ No ☐ | **A.18. Is this FP included in the country programme?** | Yes ☒ No ☐ |
| **A.19. Complementarity and coherence** | Yes ☒ No ☐ | | |
| **A.20. Executing Entity information** | The Executing Entity is the same as the Accredited Entity, namely the South African National Biodiversity Institute (SANBI), which is a Direct Access Entity. SANBI will work closely with the Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment (DFFE), in support of executing its reporting obligations and commitments as the National Designated Authority. | | |

**A.21. Executive summary (max. 750 words, approximately 1.5 pages)**

1. The intensity and frequency of droughts, extreme rainfall events and wildfires across South Africa have increased markedly over the past five decades (Engelbrecht, 2023). Climate change models indicate that these trends will continue and accelerate (GCI & SANBI, 2024). This will likely affect livelihoods, food and water security as well as increasing the cost of living for South Africans – particularly those in rural and peri-urban communities (Shields, 2024).
2. The impacts of these climate hazards include damage to both built and ecological infrastructure; and impacts on local livelihoods, including from reduced availability of water for both domestic and agricultural use, decreased productivity of croplands and rangelands due to erosion, aridification and soil nutrient leaching, and reduced buffering of flood and drought impacts by the natural environment. Climate change will exacerbate these impacts on already-strained ecosystem goods and services that underpin social and economic development through a range of pathways. Within rural and peri-urban communities, these climate change impacts result in water insecurity, in damage to ecological infrastructure and in livelihood insecurity.
3. Currently, there is a lack of (or limited) understanding of the value of climate change adaptation among government entities and communities and, as such, the types of approaches and interventions needed to support climate resilience. This is primarily due to a lack of discourse regarding climate change adaptation and the required response due to a lack of a strong evidence base of the benefits that would be realised. In addition, institutional complexity between the spheres of government contributes to suboptimal intergovernmental and cross-sectoral coordination, resulting in fragmented implementation of climate change adaptation efforts (Cerna, 2013; Adom, et al., 2022). Other factors that contribute to the lack of adaptive capacity among government entities is poorly defined legal mandate at the local level, limited number of climate change staff at district and local levels, lack of comprehensive climate change plans at local level, outdated (or absence of) information on climate change to inform integrated development plans, insufficient financial resources, inadequate human capacity at the provincial and local levels, absence of political will at the local level, and a poor understanding of climate change adaptation issues by communities (Sibiya, et al., 2023).
4. Well-functioning ecosystems and ecological infrastructure can play a key role in achieving positive societal and development outcomes, by enhancing food and water security, safety, health and well-being. Ecosystem-based adaptation (EbA) and ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction (Eco-DRR) draw from practices like conservation and ecosystem restoration to enhance ecosystem resilience. Both EbA and Eco-DRR approaches (such as the combination of restoration, conservation, sustainable use and management of wetlands, land and other natural

resources with disaster risk reduction (DRR) interventions e.g. early warning systems and emergency planning), are gaining traction as coupled climate adaptation and development options due to their ability to offer multiple benefits to people, ecosystems, and biodiversity.

5. The Eco-DRR project will aim to scale up EbA and Eco-DRR approaches for the management of climate intensified disaster risks, in targeted regions of South Africa. These targeted regions include 4 district municipalities (DMs) – namely Alfred Nzo, Ehlanzeni, Ngaka Modiri Molema and Sekhukhune.
6. This project recommends that EbA and Eco-DRR be fully integrated into both natural resource management and DRR approaches at the national and sub-national level in South Africa, and be adequately resourced so that climate benefits are realised, and sustainable investments are secured
7. The mainstreaming of these approaches will enhance the resilience of ecological infrastructure and communities that are vulnerable to climate change, and create an enabling environment for replication and scaling. The high-level Theory of Change is presented below:

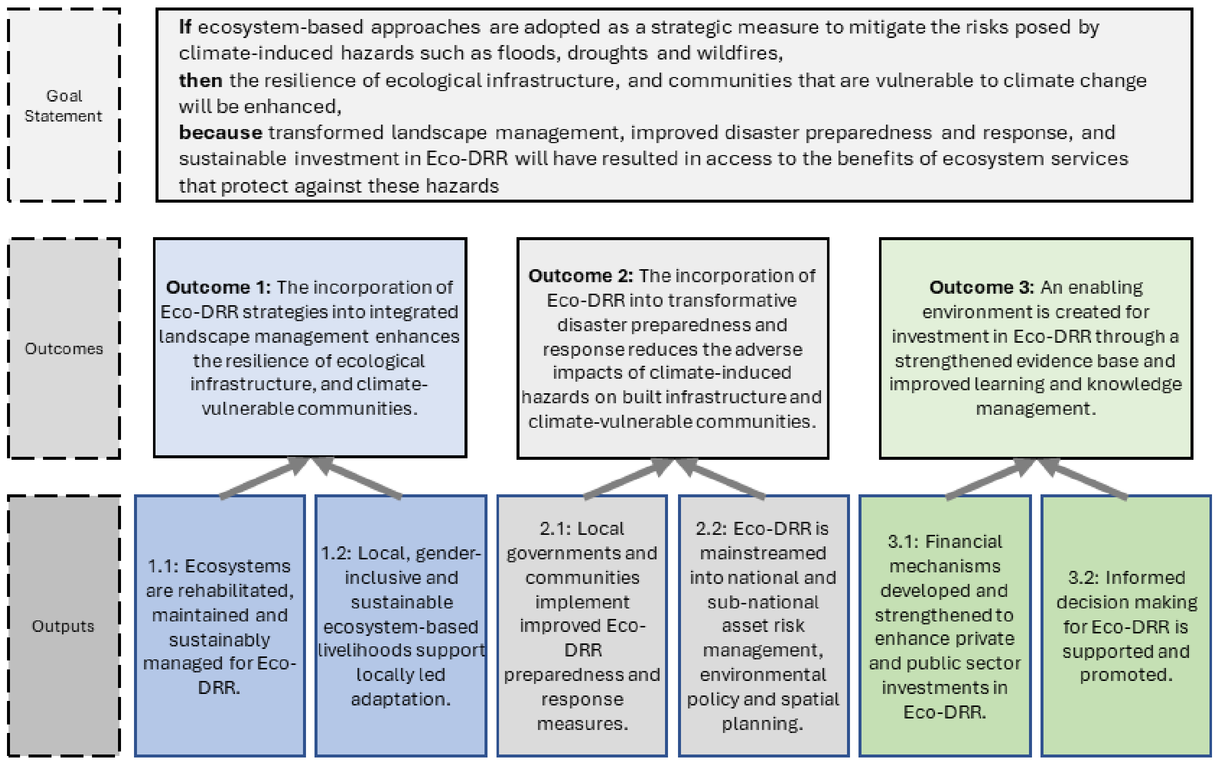


**Figure 1: High-level theory of change**

8. The project addresses GCF's Targeted Results 2024-2027 including those set for ecosystems (*support for developing countries that results in 120 to 190 million hectares of terrestrial and marine areas conserved, restored or brought under sustainable management*) and food systems (*support for developing countries that results in 190 to 280 million beneficiaries adopting low-emission climate-resilient agricultural and fisheries practices, securing livelihoods while reconfiguring food systems*) (GCF, 2023). This will be done by improving landscape management to enhance resilience of ecological infrastructure as well as supporting communities and livelihoods through promotion of local, gender-inclusive and sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods.
9. The project aims to actively ensure that marginalised groups, especially women and youth, are supported to adapt to climate change and do not face exacerbated inequalities due to their increased vulnerability to the impacts of climate change. Understanding the capacities, needs and priorities of women in relation to climate vulnerability will help inform the response and actions by ensuring a gender-sensitive approach. Further to the above, interventions will be designed and implemented in a manner that targets and benefits youths in the short-, medium- and long-term. This integration is essential for promoting equitable access to resources and opportunities.
10. The proposed project will address four barriers that constrain the achievement of the preferred adaptation solution.
    - *Barrier 1: Challenges within the enabling environment regarding collaboration, coordination, capacity and integration of Eco-DRR approaches.*
    - *Barrier 2: Absence of inclusive and participatory community engagement and agency for addressing climate change-induced disasters*.
    - *Barrier 3: Inadequate resourcing and lack of an evidence base to catalyse investment in ecological infrastructure for Eco-DRR.*

- *Barrier 4: Limited implementation of EbA and Eco-DRR at scale*. Many of the EbA and Eco-DRR interventions implemented in South Africa over the past two decades have been small-scale in nature, with a primary focus on job creation. As a result, the positive impact of these measures has not been well documented and the impact well understood.

11. The Eco-DRR project strongly aligns with South Africa's Climate Change Act (Act 22 of 2024) which places a clear emphasis on the implementation of a range of actions to support adaptation. The project also aligns with South Africa's Third National Communication (TNC) (DEA, 2018) to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), the draft Fourth National Communication to the UNFCCC which is in preparation (DFFE, 2024) and the South Africa's National Climate Change Adaptation Strategy (NCCAS) (DEFF, 2019) – all of which highlight the need for a comprehensive approach to adaptation, including improved infrastructure, land-use practices and ecological infrastructure to build adaptive capacity – all of which is covered under the Eco-DRR project. In addition, the Eco-DRR project is in alignment with GCF's programming priorities for 2024-2027, namely supporting paradigm shifts towards climate-resilient ecosystems and food systems (GCF, 2024).
12. The establishment of working partnerships with national and sub-national government, traditional leaders and local communities and civil society actors at national and local levels through the design of the Eco-DRR project provides a robust basis for the governance and oversight, as well as implementation of the project.
13. The project will service ARA1: Most vulnerable people and communities as well as ARA4: Ecosystems and ecosystem services and as such the project aims to improve the resilience to climate change of 5,481,886 beneficiaries (direct and indirect) as well as ensure that 68,010 hectares of land are brought under restoration and/or improved ecosystems.

# B. PROJECT/PROGRAMME INFORMATION

## B.1. Climate context (max. 1000 words, approximately 2 pages)

### National Climate Context

14. South Africa has average monthly temperatures ranging from 15–36°C in summer and -2–26°C in winter (World Bank, 2021). Rainfall over South Africa is highly variable, with the west of the country being arid to hyper-arid and the east and south-east of the country being humid (Landman, et al., n.d.). The increasing frequency and severity of hydrometeorological events – notably high temperature events, floods and droughts - have been recorded in recent decades (Engelbrecht, 2023) e.g. Cape Town "Day Zero" (2017-2019), the Eastern Cape drought (2015-2020) and the floods in KwaZulu Natal (2022) (IFRC, 2024). Fire plays an important role in South African ecosystems (Trollope, 1999). However, with increasing numbers of people, assets and infrastructure being at the boundary between developed land and fire-prone vegetation, communities are becoming increasingly exposed to wildfires. There is also a demonstrable link between fire hazard and the expansion of invasive alien plants (IAPs) (FCSIR, 2019).

### Observed and projected climate changes and extreme events in the targeted district municipalities (DMs)

**Table 1: Climate Change Trends in the 4 DMs**

| Climate variable / hazard | Observed climate (1981-2000) | Near future projected change (2021-2040) | Mid-future projected change (2041-2060) | Far-future projected change (2081-2099) | Summary |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Alfred Nzo DM** (GCI & SANBI, 2024) | | | | | |
| **Annual mean rainfall** | Annual mean precipitation from 600 mm in the northern interior to above 1100 mm over the coastal regions. | -10 – 70mm / year | 10 – 70 mm / year | -100 – 10 mm / year | Projected increases in near- and mid-future annual mean rainfall (low confidence); projected decreases in far-future (medium confidence). |
| **Extreme rainfall days** | Observed annual number of extreme rainfall days ranging from 2 days over the northern interior to more than 12 days over the coastal strip. | 0 – 1.5 days / year | 0 – 1.5 days / year | 0 - >2 days / year | Projected increase in frequency of extreme rainfall events (high confidence). |
| **Annual mean temperature** | Mean temperature ranges from 14 ℃ over the northern interior to more than 20 ℃ over the coastal strip. | 0 – 2.2 ℃ / year | 2.2 – 3.2 ℃ / year | 2.2 – 4.2 ℃ / year | Projected increase in annual mean temperature from near into far-future (virtually certain) |

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Very hot days** | Very hot days ranges from 1 day over the north to 5 days over the SW interior regions. | -8 – 8 days / year | 0 – 16 days / year | 0 – 32 days / year | Projected increase in warm extremes (virtually certain) |
| **Ehlanzeni DM** (GCI & SANBI, 2024) | | | | | |
| **Annual mean rainfall** | Annual mean precipitation ranges from 450 mm over the northern Lowveld to more than 1 000 mm over the SW Highveld. | 0 – 60 mm / year | 30 – -60 mm / year | 0 – -90 mm / year | Projected decrease in annual mean rainfall (medium confidence in the near- to mid-future, high confidence in the far-future). |
| **Extreme rainfall days** | Average annual number of days with heavy precipitation ranges from 3 days over the northern Lowveld to 10 days over the SW Highveld. | -0.5 – 1 days / year | -0.5 – 2 days / year | -1.5 – 1 days / year | Projected general increase in the frequency of heavy rainfall events (medium confidence). |
| **Annual mean temperature** | Annual mean temperature ranges from 14 ℃ over the SW Highveld to 24 ℃ over the eastern Lowveld. | 0 – 2.2 ℃ / year | 1.2 – 3.2 ℃ / year | 3.2 – 4.2 ℃ / year | Projected increase in annual mean temperature (virtually certain) |
| **Very hot days** | Average annual number of very hot days ranges from less than 1 day over the SW Highveld to more than 40 days over the eastern Lowveld. | -20 - 40 days / year | -20 – 40 days / year | 0 - >80 days / year | Projected increase in warm extremes from near into far-future (high confidence). |
| **Ngaka Modiri Molema DM** (GCI & SANBI, 2024) | | | | | |
| **Annual mean rainfall** | Annual mean precipitation ranges between 360 mm in the west to 660 mm in the east. | -75 – 0 mm / year | -50 – 25 mm / year | <-100 – -50 mm / year | Projected decrease in annual mean precipitation (high confidence). |
| **Extreme rainfall days** | Observed number of heavy precipitation days ranges on average from 1 day in the west to 5 days in the east. | -0.8 – 0.5 days / year | -0.4 – 0.8 days / year | -0.4 - >0.8 days / year | Projected general increase in the frequency of extreme rainfall events (low confidence for the near-future, high confidence for the mid- to far-future). |
| **Annual mean temperature** | Annual mean temperature ranges from 17 ℃ in the south to 21 ℃ in the north. | 1.2 – 2.2 ℃ / year | 2.2 – 3.2 ℃ / year | > 4.2 ℃ / year | Projected increase in annual mean temperature (virtually certain). |
| **Very hot days** | Annual mean number of very hot days ranges from 4 days in the south to more than 16 days in the north. | 0 – 30 days / year | 0 – 60 days / year | 30 – 120 days / year | Projected increase in warm extremes (virtually certain). |
| **Sekhukhune DM** (GCI & SANBI, 2024) | | | | | |
| **Annual mean rainfall** | Annual mean precipitation ranges from 450 mm over NW parts to 750 mm in the SE. | -30 – 30 mm / year | -60 – 30 mm / year | -120 – -30 mm / year | Projected decrease in annual mean precipitation (high confidence). |
| **Extreme rainfall days** | Annual number of heavy precipitation events ranges from 2-4 days across the district, and reaches 6 days in the far SE. | -0.5 – 1 days / year | -0.5 – 2 days / year | -1 – 1.5 days / year | Projected increase in the frequency of heavy precipitation events (medium confidence). |
| **Annual mean temperature** | Annual mean temperature ranges from 14 ℃ over the SE highlands to 22 ℃ in the NW. | 1 – 2 ℃ / year | 2 – 3 ℃ / year | 3 - >4 ℃ / year | Projected increase in annual mean temperature (virtually certain) |
| **Very hot days** | Annual mean number of very hot days ranges from 2 days over the highlands in the SE to more than 12 days in the NW. | -25 – 25 days / year | -25 – 50 days / year | 0 - >100 days / year | Projected increase in warm temperature extremes (virtually certain). |

**Impacts of climate change and increased climate variability on communities**

The greater frequency and severity of floods, droughts and wildfires are expected to disproportionately impact already marginalised communities. These impacts reduce the resilience of these communities to subsequent climate impacts and economic or societal shocks. The degradation of natural systems has resulted in an increasing inability of ecosystems to provide the services that assist reducing the levels of impact of these hazards.

**Table 2: Summary of hazards, impacts and adaptation activities for the four DMs[3]**

| Hazard | Impact | Adaptation Activity |
|---|---|---|
| Increased intensity of single-event rainfall occurrences increases the risk of both **pluvial and fluvial flooding** (Engelbrecht, et al., 2019; World Bank, 2021; Le Maitre, et al., 2019; GCI & SANBI, 2024) | • Direct threat to life and livelihoods.<br>• Direct threat to infrastructure within flood-prone areas and increased insurance premiums.<br>• Physical isolation of rural communities during flooding events due to damage to roads and bridges.<br>• Decreased water quality in ecosystems due to floods.<br>• Crop damage from heavy rain leading to increased risk of crop failure; threats to subsistence agriculture, rural livelihoods and food security (Let's Respond Toolkit, n.d.). | • **DRR preparedness and response measures**: The development of technologies and approaches that improve the dissemination of early warning products and messages related to floods, droughts and wildfires are critical to protect communities. This can be maintained and tested through simulation drills in which communities are supported to practice evacuation routes, communication procedures and emergency response actions.<br>• **Clearing of IAPs:** The removal of IAPs and woody plants to enhance the hydrological functioning of rivers and wetlands, especially winter baseflows, improves the water yield (Le Maitre, et al., 2020). Removal of this biomass can develop various value-adding opportunities (Irlich, et al., 2014). IAPs increase the risk and intensity of wildfires by changing local vegetation structures, and providing denser fuel loads (van Wilgen, 2015). Thus, their removal will reduce the impact associated with wildfires.<br>• **Improved landscape management in upper catchment areas:** Improved management of upper catchment areas to reduce erosion and siltation, improve groundwater recharge, and improve downstream hydrological response.<br>• **Improved rangeland management**: Rotational grazing, resting and fencing will reduce overgrazing which will have benefits in terms of livestock productivity, increasing infiltration and reducing runoff, and increased biodiversity in rangelands. Where the condition of rangelands is particularly poor, interventions including revegetation, reseeding, brushpacking and zai pits to facilitate water ponding are also used to improve the condition of grassland and soils. Improved rangeland management also reduces fuel loads and disrupts fuel continuity which decreases ignition and the initial spread of fires (Wollstein & Johnson, 2022).<br>• **Wetland and riverine rehabilitation**: The use of brushpacks and vegetative strips, fencing and revegetation as well as harder approaches such as earth berms or gabions can be used to ensure infrastructural integrity is re-established and hydrological functioning is improved in rivers and wetlands. |
| Increase in the **frequency of fire weather occurrence**, including an increase in temperature and greater variance in rainfall (Think Hazard, 2020; FCSIR, 2019) | • Direct threat to human life, livelihoods and infrastructure.<br>• Risk of major loss of livestock and grazing, crops which creates threats to financial sustainability of subsistence farming operations and rural livelihoods – thereby also reducing food security.<br>• Loss of biodiversity as wildfires destroy habitats, threatening plant and animal species (Let's Respond Toolkit, n.d.). | |
| Increase in **intensity and frequency of drought** (Engelbrecht, et al., 2019; World Bank, 2021; WWF, 2023) | • Threat to human life and livelihoods by contributing to water insecurity.<br>• Decreased water quality in ecosystem due to increased concentrations of effluent.<br>• Increased evaporation, reduced soil moisture, reduced runoff and river base flow. Compounded by reduced mean annual precipitation, systemic water shortages will limit economic growth.<br>• Increased risk / frequency of dry land crop-failure coupled with increased mortality and reduced productivity among livestock. Threatens subsistence agriculture, rural livelihoods and food security.<br>• Loss of biodiversity as drought leads to a decrease in plant growth (Let's Respond Toolkit, n.d.). | |

## B.2 (a). Theory of change narrative and diagram (max. 1500 words, approximately 3 pages plus diagram)

### Problem Statement

15. The intensity and frequency of droughts, extreme rainfall events and wildfires across South Africa have increased markedly over the past five decades. Climate change models indicate that these trends will continue and accelerate. This will likely affect livelihoods, food and water security as well as increasing the cost of living for South Africans – particularly those in rural and peri-urban communities (Shields, 2024). The impacts of these climate hazards include damage to both built and ecological infrastructure; impacts on local livelihoods, including from reduced availability of water for both domestic and agricultural use, decreased productivity of croplands and rangelands due to erosion, aridification and soil nutrient leaching, and reduced buffering from the natural environment of flood and drought impacts. Climate change will exacerbate these impacts on already-strained ecosystem goods and services that underpin social and economic development through a range of pathways. Within rural and peri-urban communities,

[3] More detailed tables on the hazards, impacts and adaptation activities per DM can be found in the project's Climate Risk and Vulnerability Assessment, attached to Annex 2: Feasibility Report.

these climate change impacts result in water insecurity, in damage to ecological infrastructure and in livelihood insecurity (Figure 2).

16. Climate change compounds several ongoing anthropogenic impacts, including inter alia overgrazing, the rapid spread of IAPs, soil compaction and the removal of natural vegetation cover, exacerbating the cycle of land degradation and poverty across large parts of rural South Africa. Due to women's strong reliance on natural resources, the cycle of degradation and decreasing resilience makes them particularly vulnerable. For example, the loss of biodiversity forces women to spend more time and walk greater distances to collect fuel, water and food (Mubarak, 2021).
17. Similarly, youth are just as vulnerable to degradation and climate change as current and future generations depend on biodiversity and natural resources to maintain and improve their quality of life (Kemesh & Kabalan, 2021). Youth are particularly affected by climate change induced displacement and migration which disrupts education and community ties. In addition, economic opportunities for youth are negatively impacted by climate change as traditional livelihoods that many young people rely on are threatened by water insecurity. This is further exacerbated by limited opportunities for youth to participate in decision-making processes related to climate change (The Commonwealth, 2024). Continental studies have shown that as high as 20% of migrants are under the age of 19 with climate related insecurities being a key driver (Mpandeli, et al., 2020).
18. The increased intensity of flood, drought and wildfire cycles is particularly concerning given that soil erosion by water already affects over 70% of the country and is expected to increase by 5–10% in South Africa's eastern interior by 2070 because of the interconnected effects of land use and climate change (DEA, 2018; Borrelli, et al., 2020). This increase is equivalent to the loss of 10–40 tons/km$^2$/year, with most of this being eroded from catchments where agriculture is practised (Compton, et al., 2010). This not only impacts on rangeland quality but also impacts the functioning of ecological infrastructure.
19. Currently, there is a lack of (or limited) understanding of the value and benefits accrued from climate change adaptation response among government entities, the private sector and communities. As such, the types of approaches and interventions needed to support climate resilience are not well understood or the case for investment supported. This is primarily due to a lack of discourse around climate change adaptation due to the lack of a strong evidence base. Other factors that contribute to the lack of adaptive capacity among government entities is limited intergovernmental coordination, poorly defined legal mandate at the local level, limited number of climate change staff at district and local levels, lack of comprehensive climate change plans at local level, outdated (or absence of) information on climate change to inform integrated development plans, insufficient financial resources, inadequate human capacity at the provincial and local levels, absence of political will at the local level, and a poor understanding of climate change adaptation issues by communities (Sibiya, et al., 2023).

**Preferred Solution**

20. Well-functioning ecosystems and ecological infrastructure can play a key role in achieving positive societal and development outcomes, by enhancing food and water security, safety, health and well-being. "Ecosystem-based Adaptation" (EbA) and "Ecosystem-based Disaster Risk Reduction" (Eco-DRR) draw from practices like conservation and ecosystem restoration to enhance ecosystem resilience. The South African Strategic Framework and Overarching Implementation Plan for EbA (DEA and SANBI, 2016) emphasises the role of EbA as part of an integrated climate change adaptation response. The national position on EbA sets out to integrate ecosystem services and traditional biodiversity conservation considerations formally into climate change adaptation responses and explicitly emphasises human well-being and adaptation co-benefits of healthy ecosystems, linking these to long-term social and economic resilience.
21. Both EbA and Eco-DRR approaches (such as the combination of restoration, conservation, sustainable use and management of wetlands, land and other natural resources with disaster risk reduction (DRR) interventions e.g. early warning systems and emergency planning), are gaining traction as coupled climate adaptation and development options due to their ability to offer multiple benefits to people, ecosystems, and biodiversity. They, can be cost-effective, enable community involvement and utilize traditional and local knowledge systems towards improved preparation for and response to climate change impacts. Because of their inclusive and interdisciplinary nature, EbA and Eco-DRR can simultaneously address various policy objectives at local, regional, and national levels, including climate change adaptation, DRR, and sustainable development strategies. Therefore, it is recommended that EbA and Eco-DRR be fully integrated into both natural resource management and DRR approaches at the national and sub-national level in South Africa, and be adequately resourced so that climate benefits are realised, and sustainable investments are secured.
22. The Eco-DRR project will aim to scale up EbA and Eco-DRR approaches for the management of climate intensified disaster risks, in targeted regions of South Africa. The mainstreaming of these approaches will enhance the

resilience of ecological infrastructure and communities that are vulnerable to climate change, and create an enabling environment for replication and scaling.

23. The proposed Eco-DRR project signifies a transformative stance on environmental and natural resource management in South Africa to improve the resilience of communities who are vulnerable to climate change. The project will be transformative in the way it:
    - Delivers a new integrated approach to landscape / catchment management that includes social processes, local and indigenous knowledge and science, and is able to integrate climate change adaptation and DRR considerations into its planning and prioritisation processes;
    - Enhances the sub-national DRR function so that it is able to factor ecological infrastructure considerations into settlement planning and asset management and maintenance, and into community level disaster response measures;
    - Unlocks new forms of finance for Eco-DRR through improved efficiencies in public sector finance and new flows of funding from private sector investors;
    - Integrates social learning processes throughout project activities to enable adaptive management, cross-sectoral integration as well and positive feedback across policy, research and implementation; and,
    - Develops an evidence base for scaling and replication, in South Africa and beyond.
24. The project aims to actively ensure that marginalised groups, especially women, are supported to adapt to climate change and do not face exacerbated inequalities due to their increased vulnerability to the impacts of climate change. To this end the project will mainstream gender equity outcomes throughout the project life cycle, supported by effective monitoring and evaluation. Understanding the capacities, needs and priorities of women in relation to climate vulnerability will help inform the response and actions by ensuring a gender-sensitive approach. Engagements and direct community involvement throughout the course of the project will explore and develop approaches that not only ensure that the inputs of women and girl-children are brought into the design of climate adaptation responses, but also that these interventions are prioritised towards reduced vulnerability.
25. Further to the above, the project will engage with youths to understand the push-pull dynamics that influence the decisions that are made by young people regarding future economics activities and whether to move to urban settings where access to services and employment are more readily available. Noting that access to opportunities to upskill and take up innovative business prospects are possibly key drivers, the project will undertake interventions to engage with youths and to develop Eco-DRR related opportunities that will meet their social and economic needs in the short-, medium- and long-term.

**Barriers to the preferred solution**

26. The proposed project will address four barriers that constrain the achievement of the preferred adaptation solution.
27. *Barrier 1: Challenges within the enabling environment regarding collaboration, coordination, capacity and integration of Eco-DRR approaches.* Mandates exist horizontally across a range of sectoral government departments with some being national, provincial or local competencies. Institutional complexity between the spheres of government contributes to suboptimal intergovernmental and cross-sectoral coordination, resulting in fragmented implementation of climate change adaptation efforts (Cerna, 2013; Adom, et al., 2022). This is exacerbated by the limited institutional and technical capacity for undertaking Eco-DRR initiatives.
28. *Barrier 2: Absence of* inclusive *and participatory community engagement and agency for addressing climate change-induced disasters*. Communities have not been adequately engaged and empowered to take up adaptation interventions in peri-urban and rural parts of South Africa. Local level engagement, inclusive decision-making and social learning processes are fundamental, and the absence of these has contributed to past interventions failing to take youth, gender and other social and community considerations into account. There has been limited incorporation of local and traditional knowledge systems into adaptation responses.
29. *Barrier 3: Inadequate resourcing and lack of an evidence base to catalyse investment in ecological infrastructure for Eco-DRR.* The absence of implementation at scale and a comprehensive documented evidence base that demonstrates the conditions / contexts under which EbA and Eco-DRR are effective hinders sustained investments into this programme of work. South Africa’s constrained fiscal environment, competing demands for public sector funds, and a lack of appreciation of the possible returns on private sector investment further hinder resource mobilisation efforts.
30. *Barrier 4: Limited implementation of EbA and Eco-DRR at scale.* Many of the EbA and Eco-DRR interventions implemented in South Africa over the past two decades have been small-scale in nature, with a primary focus on job creation. As a result, the positive impact of these measures has not been well documented and the impact well understood.
31. The goal statement for the Eco-DRR project is the following:

**If** ecosystem-based approaches are adopted as a strategic measure to mitigate the risks posed by climate-induced hazards such as droughts, floods and wildfires,

**Then** the resilience of ecological infrastructure and communities that are vulnerable to climate change will be enhanced,

**Because** transformed landscape management, improved disaster preparedness and response, and sustainable investment in Eco-DRR will have resulted in access to the benefits of ecosystem services that protect against these hazards.

32. To achieve this goal statement, the Eco-DRR project has been structured under three outcomes:
   - **Outcome 1** will support the incorporation of Eco-DRR strategies into integrated landscape management towards enhancing the resilience of ecological infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities. through a site-based programme of work that improves ecosystem condition and supports locally led adaptation. **Outcome 2** will support the incorporation of Eco-DRR into transformative disaster preparedness and response and the mainstreaming of Eco-DRR approaches into asset risk management, environmental policy and spatial planning processes.
   - **For Outcome 3**, the project will overcome barriers by creating an enabling environment for investment in Eco-DRR through a strengthened evidence base and improved learning and knowledge management.

33. Figure 2 illustrates how the components of the project respond to the identified climate change hazards and associated impacts.

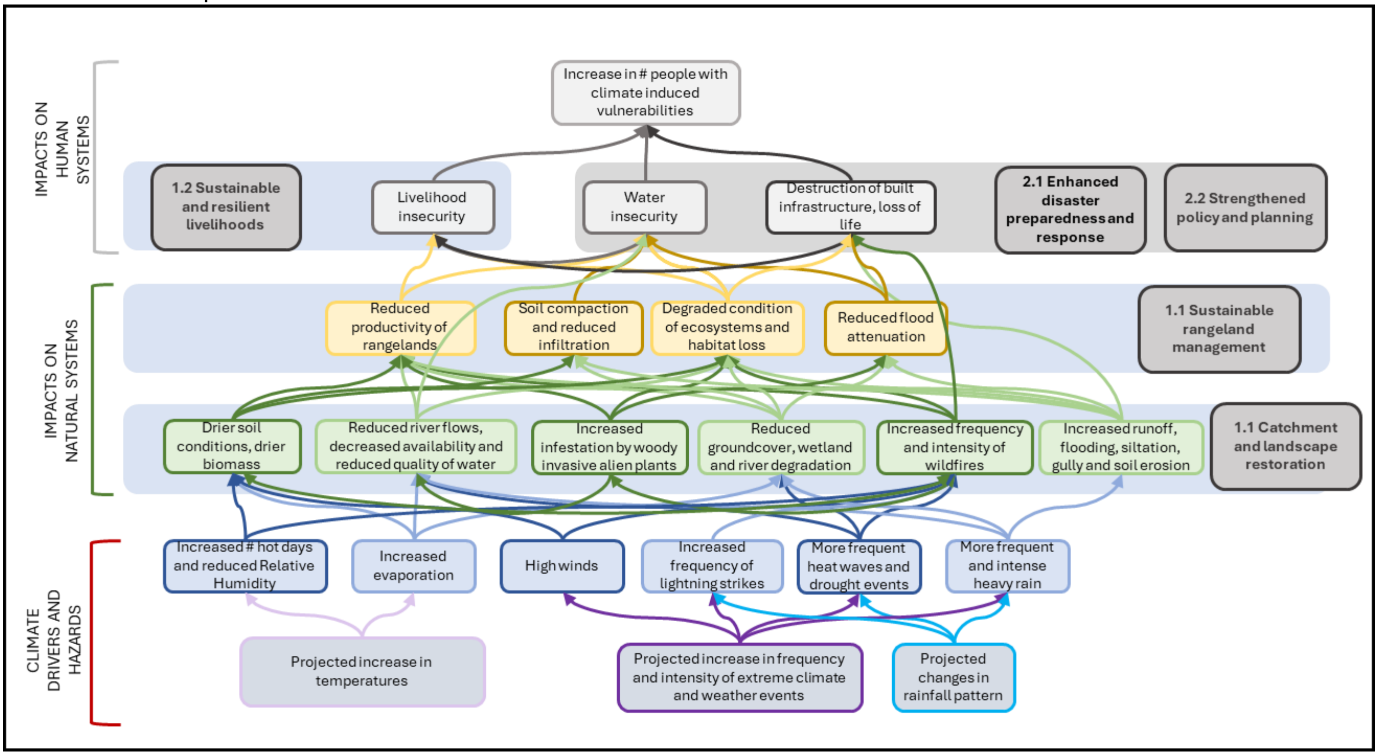


**Figure 2: Climate impact pathways linked to project components and identified climate change hazards (SANBI, 2024)**

34. The main assumptions underpinning the proposed project are:
   - Local engagement will be underpinned by project staff and non-governmental organisations (NGOs) towards community supported improvements in ecosystem management across landscapes to maximise Eco-DRR benefits
   - Mandated national and sub-national government institutions will support cross-sectoral and collaborative approaches for addressing key policy, planning and institutional challenges
   - Long-term climate adaptation strategies provide a strategic framework for Eco-DRR with the enabling environment and institutional capacities strengthened at national, provincial and local levels, and this will enable the continued implementation of Eco-DRR at scale.
   - Private and public sector investors will actively engage with the project to recognise the benefits that can be accrued from improved ecosystem management and Eco-DRR initiatives.

- The capacities and capabilities that are built across relevant institutions and structures through the project's interventions and related learning processes, will be maintained and strengthened across the various spheres of government.

35. A summary of the proposed Theory of change (ToC) is provided in the figure below.

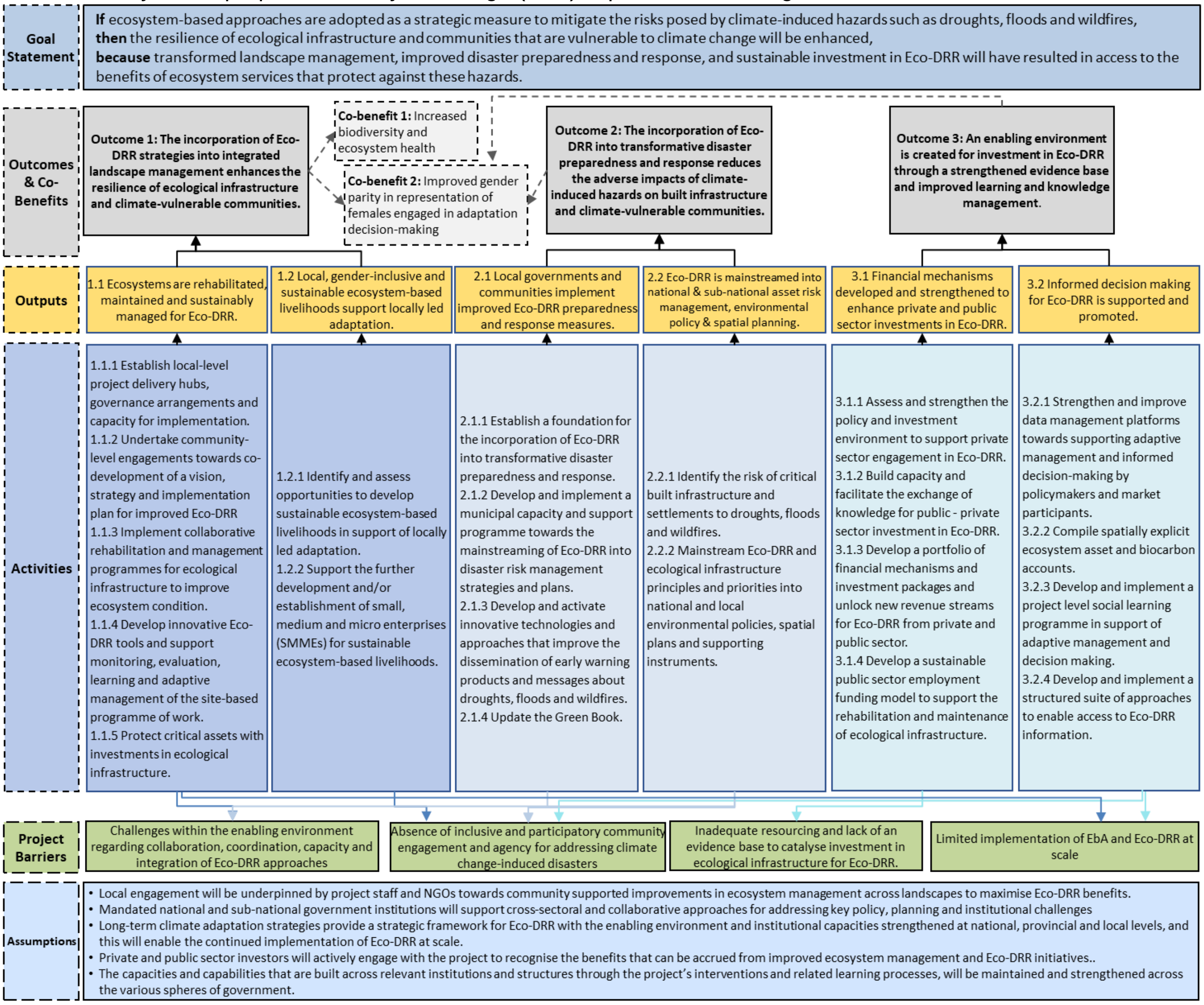


**Figure 3. Theory of change for the proposed project.**

## B.2 (b). Outcome mapping to GCF results areas and co-benefit categorization

| Outcome number | GCF Mitigation Results Area (MRA 1-4) | | | | GCF Adaptation Results Area (ARA 1-4) | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | MRA 1 Energy generation and access | MRA 2 Low-emission transport | MRA 3 Building, cities, industries, appliances | MRA 4 Forestry and land use | ARA 1 Most vulnerable people and communities | ARA 2 Health, well-being, food and water security | ARA 3 Infrastructure and built environment | ARA 4 Ecosystems and ecosystem services |
| Outcome 1 | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☒ | ☐ | ☐ | ☒ |
| Outcome 2 | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☒ | ☐ | ☐ | ☒ |
| Outcome 3 | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☒ | ☐ | ☐ | ☒ |

If any co-benefits have been identified in section B.2(a), fill in the Co-benefit table below to map each co-benefit to the corresponding category as defined in the FP guidance note.

| Co-benefit number | Co-benefit | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Environmental | Social | Economic | Gender | Adaptation | Mitigation |
| Co-benefit 1 (Environmental): Increased biodiversity and ecosystem health | ☒ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| Co-benefit 2 (Social and Gender): Improved gender parity in representation of females engaged in adaptation decision-making | ☐ | ☒ | ☐ | ☒ | ☐ | ☐ |

## B.3. Project/programme description (max. 2500 words, approximately 5 pages)

### Project Outcomes[4]

36. The project will be implemented through three interconnected Outcomes, in four DMs and across four Provinces in South Africa. The DMs were selected through a thorough desktop analysis (including a climate risk and vulnerability assessment) supported by a number of stakeholder engagement processes and an assessment of the receiving institutional and enabling environment. These DMs were selected due to their strong climate rationale, identification of vulnerable communities, alignment with past, current or future projects, and a supportive enabling environment at a local level. More details on the selection of the DMs can be found in Annex 2 (Feasibility Study).

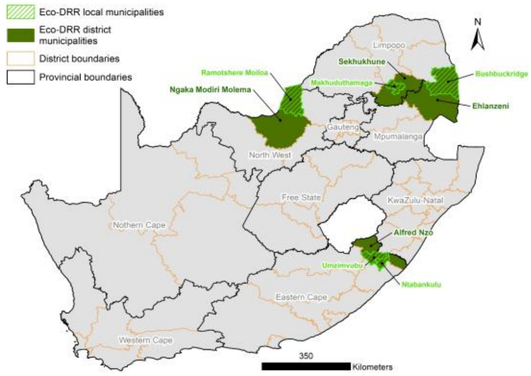


**Figure 4: DMs that form the focus of the Eco-DRR project.**

**Outcome 1: The incorporation of Eco-DRR strategies into integrated landscape management enhances the resilience of ecological infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities.**

37. Outcome 1 focuses on the mainstreaming of disaster risk and climate change considerations into landscape management approaches, and the implementation of EbA and Eco-DRR measures in Alfred Nzo, Ehlanzeni, Ngaka Modiri Molema and Sekhukhune DMs. These efforts will enhance the ability of ecosystems, catchments and landscapes to act as natural buffers and provide essential protection services against droughts, floods, and wildfires, thus reducing community vulnerabilities to climate change. This will support transformative approaches to landscape management and generate learning that can support both replication and upscaling. The Outcome will also explore how gender-inclusive and sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods can be enabled or improved in support of locally-led adaptation. Additionally, the outcome will focus on youth and the criticality of ensuring that the skills deficits that frequently exist within rural contexts are addressed. The upskilling of youths through job creation linked to sustainable ecosystem-based livelihood options by looking at small, medium and micro enterprises (SMMEs) and the Eco-champs model, will provide opportunities for youth to innovate and to support in developing sustainable and climate resilient futures.

***Output 1.1. Ecosystems are rehabilitated, maintained and sustainably managed for Eco-DRR.***

38. Communities vulnerable to climate change will have their resilience improved through the rehabilitation of degraded ecological infrastructure and the adoption of sustainable land management practices, selected against agreed upon eligibility criteria. These criteria have been included in the Design Report (Annex 21), and will be confirmed in the projects Operations Manual, to be developed in the Operationalisation Phase of the project[5]. SANBI will have the final authority in selecting the communities using the eligibility criteria, with inputs from stakeholders to support the decision-making process. While there have been programmes to undertake these interventions, the scale of the landscape degradation and challenges, the ability to sustain these and the failure to assess the impact of these environmentally and socio-economically has left a deficit in an understanding of how to ensure these interventions can become sustainable in the long-term (van Wilgen, et al., 2022). In addition, past interventions did not employ a strong climate change lens that ensured solutions were sustainable and responsive to future climate change hazards. As such, the integration of climate change adaptation into the Eco-DRR project design provides a new

[4] SANBI will not be involved in the on-granting of GCF proceeds under any Activity within this Project, and only technical assistance to the beneficiaries will be provided.

[5] The project's Operationalisation Phase will be used to develop the Operations Manual for the project, which will build on Annex 21 of the Design Report. This phase will be used to select specific intervention sites and activities, as per the relevant eligibility criteria, and will be used to conclude the contracting arrangements with the relevant partner organisations. More details on the Operationalisation Phase are provided in Section 4.2 of Annex 21: Design Report.

approach to ecosystem rehabilitation and management in the country. The Eco-DRR interventions will build upon and improve DFFE approved methods and standards that have been screened in Annex 6 against the environmental and social safeguards. These improvements will be developed to address a climate future where more extreme climate hazards will impact on rural and peri-urban communities. Furthermore, GCF's, DFFE's and other relevant safeguards will be adhered to, coupled with the application of new approaches and standards that incorporate climate change. The investment of $324,78 per hectare in these methods will augment landscape productivity by improving soil health and water infiltration, and enhance the capacity of critical ecosystems to provide goods and services that reduce the impact of extreme weather events.

*Activity 1.1.1. Establish local-level project delivery hubs, governance arrangements and capacity for implementation.*

39. Focusing on target sites in the Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs, this activity will establish local level 'landscape/ catchment convener' teams in project delivery hubs and the necessary governance and coordination arrangements for Output 1.1. These arrangements will build on and leverage off existing structures working with and through existing catchment partnerships that will facilitate effective engagement. The criteria for site selection within the two DMs is presented in Annex 21: Detailed Project Desing Report. SANBI will be the decision-making authority in selecting the final sites, with inputs from stakeholders to support the decision-making process.

*Activity 1.1.2. Undertake community-level engagements towards the co-development of a vision, strategy and implementation plan for improved Eco-DRR.*

40. Catchment conveners will lead a social learning process that supports the co-development of a vision, strategy and implementation plan for the site-based work and associated social and capacity building processes in Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs. This will be critical to ensure local knowledge and priorities inform the programme of work, that benefits accrue optimally to local communities and that the work is ultimately sustained. Local level facilitators (Eco-Champs) will assist with knowledge exchange, community engagement and project facilitation. The Eco-champs will be sub-contracted through the project partners (which will be determined in the Operationalisation Phase ). Criteria for the selection of the Eco-champs has been included in Annex 21: Detailed Project Design Report. The Eco-champs will not have any managerial or decision-making responsibility for the implementation of any part of Activity 1.1.2. Rather, their role is facilitatory to support knowledge exchange, capacity building and awareness raising within communities.

*Activity 1.1.3. Implement collaborative rehabilitation and management programmes for ecological infrastructure[6] to improve ecosystem condition.*

41. Costed rehabilitation and management plans will be developed and implemented in Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs, in collaboration with local stakeholders. These will include intensive and extensive rehabilitation work. Results of collaborative learning through implementation will be documented. NGOs already active in the DMs and communities will be responsible for implementation of the site-based interventions. During the Operationalisation Phase, and once the scope and location of interventions have been finalised, a call for proposal will be issued which NGOs can respond to. Thereafter, NGOs will be selected, as per SANBI's Supply Chain Management (SCM) processes and contracts will be established which will outline scope of work, roles and responsibilities etc. SANBI, as the Executing Entity, will oversee all project partners (e.g. the NGOs in this instance). No contracts will be established with regards to local communities, and they will not have any managerial or decision-making responsibility for the implementation of any part of Activity 1.1.3. Whilst SANBI will hold the ultimate decision-making responsibility for the project, NGOs may have managerial or decision-making responsibility for the implementation of parts of Activity 1.1.3 which they are leading, which will be stipulated in their contractual agreements. Eligibility criteria for the interventions under Activity 1.1.3 and selection of the NGOs has been included in Annex 21: Detailed Project Design Report. These will be confirmed in the project's Operations Manual, that will be developed in the Operationalisation Phase of the project.
42. Several elements of degradation, linked to climate change, were identified in the priority DMs and include reduced productivity of rangelands, soil compaction and reduced infiltration, soil erosion, degradation in the condition of ecosystems and loss of ecological goods and services. Proposed interventions to address these challenges include:
    - **Clearing of IAPs**: The removal of non-indigenous herbaceous IAPs and woody plants to enhance the hydrological functioning of rivers and wetlands (Le Maitre, et al., 2020). Biomass removal can develop various value-adding opportunities (Irlich, et al., 2014).

[6] Works on land will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase and will be linked to conjunctive use, management and development of ecological and built infrastructure.

- **Improved landscape management in upper catchment areas**: Improved management of upper catchment areas to reduce erosion and siltation, improve groundwater recharge, and improve downstream hydrological response.
- **Improving rangeland management practices**: Better rangeland management to improve grassland and soil condition to increase infiltration and reduce runoff.
- **Rehabilitating wetlands and riverine infrastructure**: Rehabilitation to ensure infrastructural integrity is re-established and hydrological functioning is improved in rivers and wetlands.

43. These interventions will entail a strong focus on youth-centred job creation and capacity building whereby local communities are trained and capacitated to better manage and improve ecological infrastructure.
44. The areas for these interventions in Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs are given in Table 3.

**Table 3. Summary of proposed ecosystem rehabilitation and rangeland management interventions in the targeted DMs**[7].

| Type of intervention | DM | | TOTAL (ha) |
|---|---|---|---|
| | Alfred Nzo (ha) | Ehlanzeni (ha) | |
| **Clearing of IAPs** | 2337.00 | | 2337.00 |
| **Improved landscape management in upper catchment areas** | | 14517.00 | 14,517.00 |
| **Improved rangeland management** | 10203.18 | 25575,70 | 35,778.88 |
| **Wetland and riverine rehabilitation** | 234.31 | 608.40 | 842.71 |
| **Total Area of Land under Improved Management** | **12774.49** | **40701.10** | **53,475.59** |

*Activity 1.1.4. Develop innovative Eco-DRR tools to support adaptive management of the site-based programme of work.*

45. Protocols that guide the biophysical activities and that monitor implementation to inform adaptive management, and scaling will be developed. This will include the use of standards-based restoration and rehabilitation, and the development of tools and protocols that will guide implementation across the two DMs. This approach builds on and improves the work that has been done by DFFE in Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs with aim of creating transformative change. These approaches to land and environmental management include methods from such programmes as Herding for Health (Peace Parks Foundation, n.d.) and Living Catchments (Tau, et al., 2020), the development of protocols and methods for sustained interventions include the use of participatory citizen science tools such as CRiSTAL, the Umzimvubu Catchment Partnership approach, and methods developed by Rhodes University through the Tsitsa project (Weaver, 2023), as well as the introduction of technologies to support regularised citizen-based monitoring and information exchange, building on the lessons of such tools as the Mini-SASS (Mini-SASS, n.d.) and others.
46. DFFE will be an important stakeholder during this activity to support co-creation, collaboration and knowledge exchange. Noting that it is a government entity and that all government entities are required to promote cooperative governance across sectors and departments, a Memorandums of Agreement (MOA) will be used to engage with DFFE. In addition, whilst SANBI will hold the ultimate decision-making responsibility for the project, DFFE may have managerial or decision-making responsibility for the implementation of parts of Activity 1.1.4, which will be stipulated in their MOA. This will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase.

*Activity 1.1.5. Protect critical assets with investments in ecological infrastructure*[8]*.*

47. This activity will demonstrate the linkages between climate change impacts and the condition of the natural environment. It will seek to rehabilitate ecological infrastructure to protect selected priority municipal assets from drought, floods and wildfires where these hazards are impacting local communities. By protecting priority municipal assets, less tangible but positive outcomes for communities can be realised such as sedimentation avoided in dams to ensure continued access to water; access to schools, healthcare facilities etc. maintained due to roads / bridges not being washed away; reduction in solid waste entering water bodies; and the overall improvement in communities' living environment.
48. The criteria for site selection within Ngaka Modiri Molema and Sekhukhune DMs is presented in Annex 21: Detailed Project Desing Report. These will be confirmed in the project's Operations Manual, that will be developed in the Operationalisation Phase of the project. SANBI is the decision-making authority in selecting the final sites, with

[7] The interventions and hectares presented in the table are indicative only and will be confirmed during the Operationalisation Phase of the Eco-DRR project.
[8] Works on land will be determined during operationalisation and will be linked to conjunctive use, management and development of ecological and built infrastructure.

inputs from stakeholders to support the decision-making process. The relative areas and scale of these interventions in Ngaka Modiri Molema and Sekhukhune DMs are given in Table 4.

**Table 4. Summary of proposed Eco-DRR interventions to support the protection of critical assets in the targeted DMs[9].**

| Type of intervention | DM | | Total (ha) |
|---|---|---|---|
| | Ngaka Modiri Molema (ha) | Sekhukhune (ha) | |
| **Clearing of invasive woody alien plants** | | 110.76 | 110.76 |
| **Improved rangeland management** | 1548.84 | 12842.54 | 14391.38 |
| **Wetland and riverine rehabilitation** | 9.16 | 23.40 | 32.56 |
| **Total Area of Land under Improved Management** | **1558.00** | **12976.70** | **14534.70** |

49. Using the lessons learned from the intervention, a policy brief will be created that will support replication and upscaling of these interventions provincially and nationally, and will be linked to the activities under Output 2.2.

***Output 1.2. Local, gender-inclusive and sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods support locally led adaptation.***

50. Resilient and sustainable economic frameworks for local communities will be strengthened through the introduction of gender-inclusive, ecosystem-based livelihood stacking strategies to diversify income sources and reduce vulnerability in the Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs. Successful EbA can potentially facilitate public-private partnerships, leveraging additional funding and offering financial incentives to investors. Working closely with programmes under government entities such as Department of Small Business Development (DSBD), the Small Enterprise Development Agency and Small Enterprise Financing Agency, the potential for public-private partnerships (PPPs) will be explored to demonstrate a clear pathway to private sector investment. The DSBD, the Small Enterprise Development Agency or the Small Enterprise Financing Agency may have managerial or decision-making responsibility for the implementation of parts of Output 1.2. which will be stipulated in their MOAs. This will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase.

*Activity 1.2.1. Identify and assess opportunities to develop sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods in support of locally led adaptation.*

51. As part of the project design, only initial assessments were undertaken through engagements with key government officials and NGOs. This activity will therefore include a more detailed assessment of community livelihoods in Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs. This will assess their dependencies on natural, physical and social capital and their vulnerability to climate change. The analysis will link livelihoods to market opportunities for the various ecosystem-based commodity value chains and opportunities linked to green job creation. This will pay particular attention to gender aspects by ensuring women are empowered through gender-sensitive sources of employment, capacity building and awareness raising.
52. Engagements with youth will be structured to identify how their innovative skills can be further developed to create ecosystem-based livelihood opportunities that are directly linked to youth employment, career development and upskilling that is long-term, sustainable and impactful.

*Activity 1.2.2. Support the further development and/or establishment of small, medium and micro enterprises (SMMEs) for sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods*

53. This activity will include reviewing business cases that have been developed for existing SMMEs in the targeted DMs and revising or refining them where necessary. This will be accompanied by the development of new business cases to support the establishment of ecosystem-based SMMEs. To ensure the success of SMMEs, support will be provided to take the business cases to market[10] through market soundings and providing support to engage with local business chambers and industry associations, and giving mentorship support to engage associated value chains.

**Outcome 2. The incorporation of Eco-DRR into transformative disaster preparedness and response reduces the adverse impacts of climate-induced hazards on built infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities.**

54. Led by the South African Local Government Association (SALGA) and the National Disaster Management Centre (NDMC), Outcome 2 will enhance the resilience of communities and critical built infrastructure against climate-

[9] The interventions and hectares presented in the table are indicative only and will be confirmed during the Operationalisation Phase of the Eco-DRR project.
[10] The approach will be similar to what was done with Thekga Industries, a SMME that has been supported by private businesses to enable secondary industry projects linked to climate change markets.

induced hazards in all four target DMs to develop and implement effective strategies, plans and responses, that are inclusive of Eco-DRR. Noting that both SALGA and NDMC are government entities and that all government entities are required to promote cooperative governance across sectors and departments, MOAs will be used to engage with them. Whilst SANBI will hold the ultimate decision-making responsibility fo the project, SALGA and/or NDMC may have managerial or decision-making responsibility for the implementation of activities under Outcome 2 which will be stipulated in their MOAs. This will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase.

55. Lessons learned will be exchanged between the DMs, Provincial and National Departments. Important stakeholders include the National Business Initiative's (NBI) Technical Assistance, Mentorship and Development Programme (TAMDEV)[11] and the Municipal Infrastructure Support Agent (MISA)[12]. Their roles and responsibilities will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase. SANBI will have the final managerial authority over the implementation of all activities under Outcome 2, including those supported by TAMDEV and MISA.
56. The criteria for site selection within the four DMs for Outcome 2 is presented in Annex 21: Detailed Project Desing Report and SANBI is the decision-making authority in selecting the final sites with inputs from stakeholders to support the decision-making process.

***Output 2.1. Local governments and communities implement improved Eco-DRR preparedness and response measures.***

57. The capacity of the target DMs and local communities to adopt more proactive responses to climate-induced hazards that are inclusive of Eco-DRR will be strengthened. This will include establishing a foundation for the incorporation of Eco-DRR into transformative disaster preparedness and response in the DMs, and capacitating municipalities (using the TAMDEV and MISA skill sets such as local government coordination and collaboration as well as infrastructure development, operation and maintenance) to include Eco-DRR in disaster risk management strategies and plans. More details regarding TAMDEV's and MISA's roles and skillsets will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase.

*Activity 2.1.1. Establish a foundation for the incorporation of Eco-DRR into transformative disaster preparedness and response in the target DMs.*

58. This activity will establish the necessary foundations through a baseline assessment to determine the current state and associated challenges and gaps in disseminating early warnings about floods, droughts and fires to communities in the target DMs. Through this assessment the partnerships that are needed to support the improved disaster management and dissemination of early warning information will be strengthened and will include a range of local, provincial and national stakeholders.

*Activity 2.1.2. Develop and implement a municipal capacity and support programme towards the mainstreaming of Eco-DRR into disaster risk management strategies and plans in the four DMs.*

59. A programme of support to build capacity and mainstream Eco-DRR into disaster risk management strategies and plans will be developed. The activity aligns with SALGA's existing work to support and build capacity and will specifically leverage the skills and expertise that is provided through the TAMDEV programme. SALGA and the TAMDEV programme have a suite of projects and programme activities across municipalities in South Africa, and the Eco-DRR project will engage with them to align interventions and to bring in necessary skills to support the project's activities. SALGA's and TAMDEV's roles and responsibilities will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase. Training materials and related participatory learning processes will be developed and/ or strengthened and a training programme will be implemented.

*Activity 2.1.3. Develop and activate innovative technologies and approaches that improve the dissemination of early warning products and messages about droughts, floods and wildfires in the four DMs.*

60. Capacity building sessions will be designed and held to improve the dissemination of early warnings. Impact-based communication materials, messaging and channels will be designed for the receiving environment. New technological innovations could include the use of mobile telephone networks to issue warnings, automated signage to issue warnings, and the possibility of mobile phone applications. Equally important will be people-centred early

[11] The TAMDEV programme matches highly skilled retirees and semi-retirees to relevant senior civil servants within local government for the transferring of skills (mentoring) and/or technical assistance to unblock catalytic projects that have been jointly identified by NBI, DMs, LMs, private sector funders and other relevant players

[12] The Municipal Infrastructure Support Agent (MISA) is a national government component constituted in terms of Section 7(2) Schedule 3 of the Public Service Act of 1994 (as amended), accountable to the Minister for Cooperative Governance and Traditional Affairs. This initiative is an integral part of the Department of Cooperative Governance's programme towards improving municipal infrastructure provisioning and maintenance for accelerated service delivery, in line with the objectives of the Back to Basics Strategy

warning systems through social innovations to support community-based communications. Real-time climate and weather alerts, advisory services and approaches will be activated, maintained and tested through simulation drills.

*Activity 2.1.4. Update the Green Book*

61. Developed by the Council for Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR), the Green Book supports climate change adaptation in South Africa by providing an online repository of downscaled, baseline and future, municipal climate risk data and insights, as well as adaptation information that can be integrated into broader settlement planning (Green Book, n.d.). The Green Book is currently used widely and is the focus of ongoing municipal capacity building efforts. However, while hosted at the CSIR and supported in principle by Government, the system is not being updated and as such the updating of information on the system will prove a critical part of upscaling Eco-DRR, as well as building climate resilience at municipal levels. The critical updates to the content/data/information will reflect the latest scientific advancements in climate science and adaptation, as well as updated socio-economic data. The Green Book will be improved through including updated population profiles and projections, vulnerability indices, climate change projections, hazard assessments, water supply vulnerability, ecosystem conditions and climate adaptation actions. Once updated, more hands-on mainstreaming and planning support, will be provided to the four focal DMs using the updated tool, information and data. Thereafter, options for the development of a mobile telephone-based Application to make this data and information more accessible, will be explored.

***Output 2.2. Eco-DRR is mainstreamed into national and sub-national asset risk management, environmental policy and spatial planning.***

62. National and sub-national environmental policies, management, development and spatial plans, and supporting instruments generally recognise the threat of climate change, and at the national level, EbA and Eco-DRR are recognised as important climate change adaptation responses. The translation of EbA and Eco-DRR into local-level policies and plans is limited. SANBI in partnership with the DMs, TAMDEV and MISA, will build the capacity of policy and decision makers to mainstream EbA and Eco-DRR measures into policy, planning and budgetary processes.
63. The roles, responsibilities and arrangements between SANBI, SALGA, MISA, DMs and NBI (including its TAMDEV programme) will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase. Since SALGA, MISA and the DMs are government entities that are required to promote cooperative governance across sectors and departments, MOAs will be used to engage with them. SALGA, MISA and the DMs may have managerial or decision-making responsibility for the implementation of activities under Output 2.2. which will be stipulated in their MOAs. This will be determined during operationalisation. A similar approach will be implemented during the Operationalisation Phase for NBI to determine its roles and responsibilities. Stakeholders will engage with the output and its activities through the appropriate governance structures by providing guidance, coordination and inputs and no contracts will be required in this regard. These stakeholders, including their roles and responsibilities, will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase. SANBI will have the final managerial authority over the implementation of all activities under Output 2.2.

*Activity 2.2.1. Identify the risk of critical built infrastructure and settlements to droughts, floods and wildfires[13].*

64. Vulnerability assessments of both built infrastructure and community settlements to droughts, floods and wildfires within the target DMs and a baseline assessment of existing risk management frameworks, tools and approaches for ecological and built infrastructure will be compiled. This will include risk assessments of current and planned built infrastructure and the mapping of linkages between these risks and the potential benefits that ecological infrastructure investments can provide in reducing these risks. The inclusion of ecological infrastructure investment priorities in DMs' infrastructure master plans and asset registers will be supported. Identifying funding sources for these costed plans will explore the range of financial instruments including Municipal Infrastructure Grant and others (SANBI, 2020).

*Activity 2.2.2. Mainstream Eco-DRR and ecological infrastructure principles and priorities into national and local environmental policies, spatial plans and supporting instruments.*

65. This activity will support the mainstreaming of Eco-DRR and ecological infrastructure principles into relevant policies, spatial plans and other instruments at national and sub-national levels. A baseline assessment will be conducted to identify gaps in policy coherence, stakeholder capacity, cross-sectoral alignment, and institutional arrangements for integrating Eco-DRR principles into national and local plans, policies and supporting instruments, including the District Development Model (DDM). A programme of work will then be co-created with key role players to build capacity and support the updating and mainstreaming of Eco-DRR into identified national and local plans, policies

[13] Activity 2.2.1 is limited to conducting vulnerability and risk assessments and does not involve the implementation of financial instruments under the project.

and supporting instruments. These role players include (but are not limited to) national and provincial government stakeholders as well as municipalities. More details on this will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase where role players' managerial or decision-making authority over the implementation of parts of Activity 2.2.2 will be determined through contractual arrangements / MOAs. Tools, guidelines and knowledge products will be developed to support.

**Outcome 3: An enabling environment is created for investment in Eco-DRR through a strengthened evidence base and improved learning and knowledge management.**

66. In Outcome 3, the evidence base that emerges from Outcomes 1 and 2 of the project will be used to inform processes to enhance private and public sector investment in EbA and Eco-DRR. In so doing, this output will also contribute to ensuring a viable exit strategy for the project. This Outcome will also focus on strengthening the evidence base for Eco-DRR, to support learning and adaptive management and ultimately scaling. This outcome will be implemented at a national level and will draw on lessons learned from the four DMs (i.e. Alfred Nzo, Ehlanzeni, Ngaka Modiri Molema and Sekhukhune DMs).

***Output 3.1. Financial mechanisms developed and strengthened to enhance private and public sector investments in Eco-DRR[14].***

67. This Output will focus on understanding and improving the enabling environment for private and public sector investments in Eco-DRR and developing appropriate financial mechanisms that enhance investment. The activities will not necessarily be implemented on the chronological order shown below. That is, for the private sector, this will be achieved by strengthening the policy and investment environment, and through the development of financial mechanisms and investment packages (Activity 3.1.1). For the public sector, focus will be placed on the development of a transformed and sustainable public sector employment funding model that supports Eco-DRR (Activity 3.1.4). A private-public community of practice will support capacity building, learning and engagement around financial mechanisms for the biodiversity economy and Eco-DRR (Activity 3.1.2). Finally, a portfolio of financial mechanisms and investment packages will be developed and institutional options proposed to establish a national platform / finance facility to support long-term, sustained investments into Eco-DRR (Activity 3.1.3).

*Activity 3.1.1. Assess and strengthen the policy and investment environment to support private sector engagement in Eco-DRR[15].*

68. This activity will assess the policy and investment environment for private sector engagement in Eco-DRR towards addressing gaps and barriers to such investments and areas for improvement. In so doing, it will identify and assess EbA and Eco-DRR-linked financial mechanisms, the financial sector's current integration of biodiversity and climate-related risks and opportunities into financial planning and decision-making and emerging opportunities such as the South African carbon credit and biodiversity and water credit policy landscape. This will link with the work being undertaken by the Taskforce on Nature-related Financial Disclosures Global and African Natural Capital Alliance. The assessments will also identify where there are opportunities to strengthen the frameworks that financial institutions use to assess biodiversity and climate-related risks and opportunities.

*Activity 3.1.2. Build capacity and facilitate the exchange of knowledge for public - private sector investment in Eco-DRR.*

69. This activity seeks to build capacity, support the exchange of knowledge and foster a mutual understanding between the private and public sector by convening a community of practice for capacity building, learning and engagement around financial mechanisms for Eco-DRR. A strong business case that showcases the benefits of investing in Eco-DRR and a portfolio of potential investment mechanisms will be developed to support improved engagement and investment in ecological infrastructure and associated Eco-DRR.
70. Public and private sector (including financial institutions) capacity will be built to understand the investment environment, and private sector (including financial institution) capacity will be built to support the integration of biodiversity and climate considerations into their planning and operations with a focus on the adoption and implementation of the set of disclosure recommendations and guidance for organisations made by the Taskforce on Nature-Related Financial Disclosures and the Taskforce on Climate-Related Financial Disclosures.

[14] For Output 3.1, GCF proceeds will be used solely for the capacity building of public and private sector players offering financial mechanisms investing in Eco-DRR, and will not serve as a source of financing for these mechanisms to make actual investments in Eco-DRR.

[15] Activity 3.1.1 is not contingent on the implementation or achievement of any milestones under any work undertaken by the Taskforce on Nature-related Financial Disclosures or the African Natural Capital Alliance.

*Activity 3.1.3. Develop a portfolio of financial mechanisms and investment packages and unlock new revenue streams for Eco-DRR from private and public sector.*

71. This activity aims to implement (with support provided to operationalise) a range of financial mechanisms that will provide more comprehensive investments into Eco-DRR. Parallel to this, viable funding vehicles will be identified and assessed to strengthen (where necessary) the development of investment options linked to outlined project opportunities. This will include the potential for seed finance through the on-granting experience of SANBI as well as other initiatives under the banner of the DSBD and Small Enterprise Development Agency and Small Enterprise Financing Agency. This will build upon the experiences of the National Business Initiative (NBI), World Wide Fund for Nature (WWF)[16], Sustainable Finance Coalition (SFC), Conservation South Africa and others to develop fit-for-purpose vehicles to support business development and matching these to the appropriate financial arrangements. This will include options such as the establishment of business accelerators, use of incubators to progressively take businesses to scale, providing support to establish cooperative arrangements, and the development of business partnerships linked to value chains. Investment packages will then be developed that aim to attract both public and private sector investment in Eco-DRR. These packages will outline project opportunities for potential funders / financiers. The sites for Activity 3.1.3. have not been identified and the identification of these sites will be part of the endeavours to upscale the project, as these sites will be different to the sites put forward under Outcome 1. The criteria for the selection of sites for Activity 3.1.3 will be developed in the Operationalisation Phase of the project.
72. Importantly, this activity will also help to explore the business case and institutional options to establish a national platform / finance facility to be hosted by a government or private sector entity. Such an entity would then provide the platform for the long-term roll-out of develop investment options, the implementation of incubators for SMMEs and / or the use of potential accelerators all to further develop the pipeline of Eco-DRR projects. It will be essential to align with ongoing processes and to work with the various sector stakeholders who are working towards developing finance facilities to support climate adaptation. The approaches and portfolio of projects would then be further developed after the project ends, with co-finance/parallel finance. The finance facility's long-term vision and operational sustainability will be developed by the Eco-DRR project together with developing the initial criteria for businesses, SMMEs, community groups, private sector/public sector to enter the incubator/ accelerator to access the support required to get projects fundable. Other than providing the financial support to scope and development the business case for such facility, no GCF funds will be used to operationalise the facility or be channelled into downstream projects.

*Activity 3.1.4. Develop a sustainable public sector employment funding model to support the rehabilitation and maintenance of ecological infrastructure.*

73. Informed by Outcome 1, a business case inclusive of an operational and proposed funding model for a transformed operation model for public sector investment in natural resource management and Eco-DRR will be developed. National government partners, such as the DFFE, the Presidency, the Department of Cooperative Governance and Traditional Affairs (COGTA), Department of Trade and Industry (DTI) and others, will be engaged to co-develop this model and reflect on how it might inform relevant national processes. National government partners are required to promote cooperative governance across sectors and departments which is part of their mandate. As such, MOAs will be used to engage with them for co-development purposes. They may have managerial or decision-making responsibility for the implementation of activities under Activity 3.1.4, which will be stipulated in their MOAs. This will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase. SANBI will have the final managerial authority over the implementation of activities under 3.1.4.

***Output 3.2. Informed decision making for Eco-DRR is supported and promoted.***

74. Informed decision making on Eco-DRR will require the bridging of existing knowledge gaps, growing effective learning facilitation practices, providing a solid evidence base, and highlighting the costs, benefits and impacts of investing in ecological infrastructure, EbA and Eco-DRR. The project will facilitate a range of engagement platforms and establish various communication channels and practices to exchange knowledge and information.

*Activity 3.2.1. Strengthen and improve data management platforms towards supporting adaptive management and informed decision-making by policymakers and market participants.*

75. This activity will support the review and assessment of the current Eco-DRR data management environment and develop recommendations for system improvement. It will then strengthen and improve data management platform(s) in support of Eco-DRR and other elements of the biodiversity/ climate change nexus and develop

[16] WWF South Africa currently hosts the Africa hub for the Dutch Fund for Climate and Development which is a blended finance mechanisms aimed at developing bankable nature and climate solutions. WWF is also a founding partner in the Green Outcomes Fund.

protocols and standards for data collection to meet data needs and ensure consistency and quality across all project sites. In support of project monitoring, evaluation, reporting and learning (MERL) and adaptive management of the project, biophysical modelling of selected ecosystem services will be undertaken, and validated and refined using field data and stakeholder inputs. Monitoring networks, systems and protocols will be established to track the effectiveness of Eco-DRR measures.

*Activity 3.2.2. Compile spatially explicit ecosystem asset and biocarbon accounts*[17]*.*

76. This activity entails producing selected ecosystem service accounts and spatially explicit biocarbon accounts in biophysical and monetary terms using the System of Environmental-Economic Accounting (SEEA) Ecosystem Accounting Framework. The project will explore synergies between ecosystem asset and biocarbon accounts compiled and the air emission and energy accounts compiled by Statistics South Africa (SEEA Central Framework) to enhance integrated environmental-economic analysis. This activity will also explore the use of Natural Capital Accounting as a tool to analyse trends in natural capital use and dependencies across regions, user groups or communities and sectors, and potential hidden costs of ecosystem degradation. This will identify where transformative policy or planning interventions could be needed and further develop Natural Capital Accounts in South Africa as a tool that informs sustainability and resilience strategies. Knowledge products will synthesize lessons learned and share insights.

*Activity 3.2.3. Develop and implement a project level social learning programme in support of adaptive management and decision making*.

77. The development and implementation of a systematic approach to generating and recording project lessons, and for communicating these in support of adaptive management and scaling will be undertaken. A programme of work will be developed and implemented that captures learnings and emerging insights within and across the project as part of the evidence base for Eco-DRR. Project level forums, working groups, think tanks and other engagement platforms will be convened and learnings documented to foster partnerships and further knowledge exchange.
78. To support the social learning programme, deeper research will be undertaken to surface the learning that will emerge in the programme. To this end, SANBI will partner with academic institutions and expert organisations to develop the core social learning action research agenda, for a systematic research programme. A core group of graduate researchers led by university-based academics would allow for the systematic, in-depth research including the development of papers and journal articles to support the Eco-DRR evidence base. The nature of these arrangements including roles, responsibilities and contractual aspects with academia and expert organisations will be determined in the Operationalisation Phase and will be guided by SANBI's SCM policy. SANBI will have the final managerial authority over the implementation of activities under Activity 3.2.3.

*Activity 3.2.4. Develop and implement a structured suite of approaches to enable access to Eco-DRR information.*

79. The aim of this activity is to ensure easy access to Eco-DRR information and knowledge products that promote informed decision-making. In this regard, a project level information sharing mechanism will be established, ideally within an existing platform, and a communications strategy will be developed. This will be designed to complement and support the social learning process activities.

## B.4. Implementation arrangements (max. 1500 words, approximately 3 pages plus diagrams)

80. The project governance arrangements is presented in the diagram below.

[17] The implementation of Activity 3.2.2 is not contingent on the implementation or achievement of any milestones under any work conducted by Statistics South Africa.

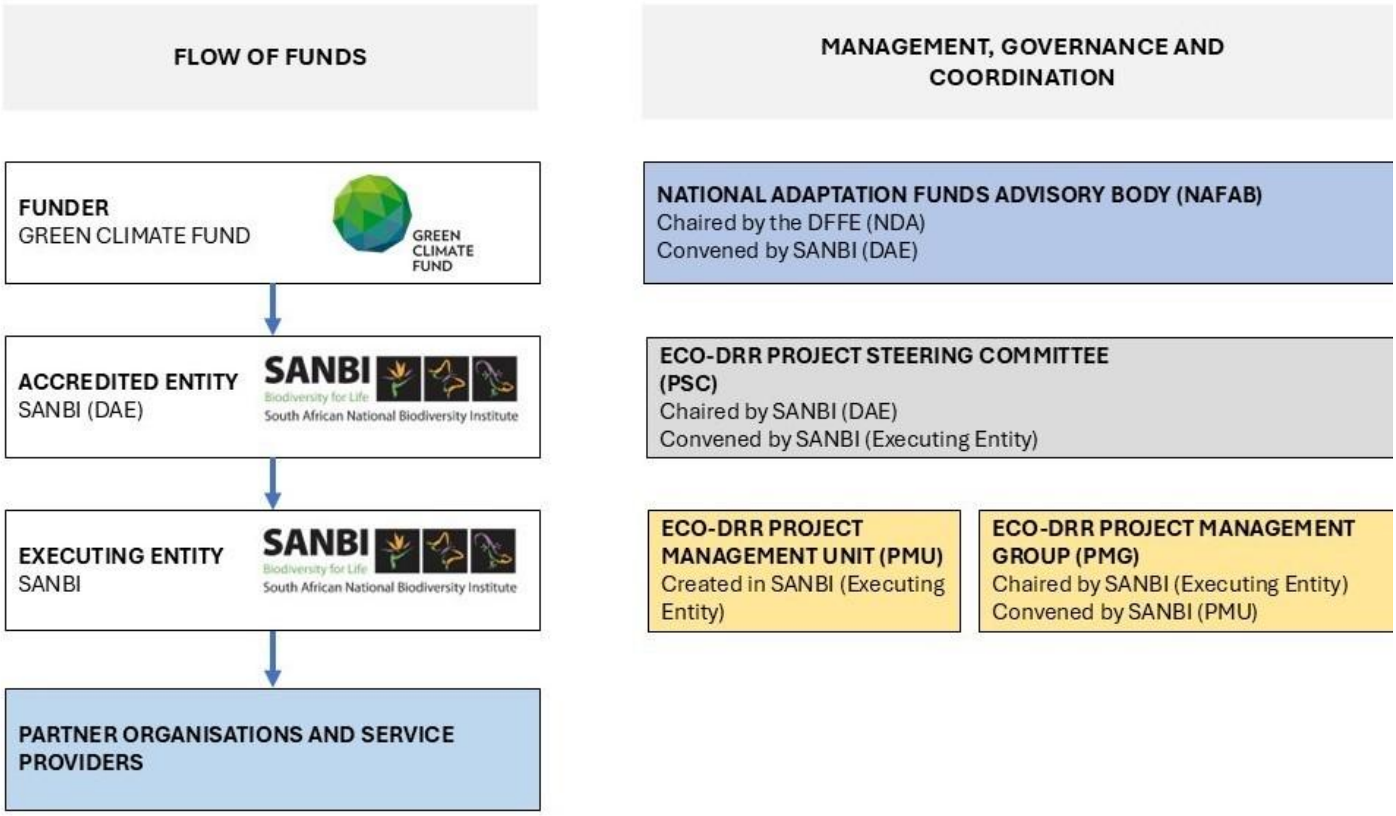


**Figure 5: Project Governance Model**

81. SANBI retains final authority in making all decisions regarding the implementation of the Eco-DRR project. SANBI is also the Executing Entity for all activities and sub-activities under the project.
82. SANBI, through the PMU, will take responsibility for monitoring strategic issues and then informing the projects operational structures of implications. At a municipal level, ongoing engagement with municipal leadership and staff will need to be undertaken by the PMU to ensure awareness of potential shifts in local-level plans and policies and if the interventions are still in alignment with the municipalities' goals and objectives.
83. The project's design will include the following governance structures:
    - NAFAB as an advisory body that guides SANBI, as a Direct Access Entity, on whether projects align with national climate change adaptation objectives and communicates GCF expectations for projects based on the emerging environment.
    - The Project Steering Committee (PSC) as an oversight committee that reviews the work of the project to ensure compliance with project deliverables and GCF requirements.
    - The PMU as the central technical hub for the conceptualisation and execution of project activities. The PMU is supported by a Project Management Group (PMG), which comprises technical experts[18] from various institutions outside of SANBI. These experts weigh in with technical and strategic guidance in furtherance of the project's objectives. The PMG periodically convenes reference group meetings to strategically consult on the operationalisation of project activities.
84. Task Teams will support on thematic categories of work relating to the project. The Outcome and DM Tasks teams presented in Figure 5 are multi-governmental structures that are not housed within any particular entity. These task teams promote cross-sectoral and intergovernmental coordination and collaboration, noting that government entities are mandated to adopt cooperative governance approaches. These task teams will be comprised of SANBI staff together with other stakeholders (more details on this can be found in Annex 21: Detailed Project Design Report).
85. As the Direct Access Entity, SANBI will sign the grant agreement with GCF and will be accountable to the GCF for the disbursement of funds and the achievement of the project objective and outcomes according to the approved work plan. The financial management between the Direct Access Entity / Executing Entity and the various partners working on the project will be governed by South Africa's Public Finance Management Act, the Municipal Finance Management Act and SANBI's Supply Chain Management policy and procedures for the procurement of Goods and Services, all of which are aligned to the procurement regulations stipulated by National Treasury.

[18] No contracts will be required for the technical experts as these will be government officials from other departments.

86. For the Eco-DRR project SANBI will be both Accredited Entity and (the only) Executing Entity and as such the governance arrangements have been designed to clarify accountability and a division of responsibility. No other Executing Entities will be involved in the implementation of the project. Contractual arrangements with other organisations and service providers that will support implementation will be finalised during the project's Operationalisation Phase. SANBI has a standardised approach to the implementation of such projects that includes a detailed Operationalisation Phase supported by rigorous engagements with all those involved. Thus, the Operationalisation Phase will ensure that all contractual arrangements made will be fit-for-purpose and based upon the findings of this phase. There will be no contractual arrangements between SANBI and project beneficiaries.
87. Importantly, it is part of the SANBI policies and internal risk management approaches to not enter into any contractual agreements until the financial arrangements that underpin these agreements have been finalised.
88. SANBI as Executing Entity will be responsible for the following functions: (i) coordinating activities to ensure the delivery of agreed outcomes; (ii) certifying expenditures in line with approved budgets and work-plans; (iii) facilitating, monitoring and reporting on the procurement of inputs and delivery of outputs; (iv) coordinating interventions financed by GCF with other parallel interventions; (v) approval of Terms of Reference for consultants and tender documents for sub-contracted inputs; and (vi) reporting to GCF on project delivery and impact. All reporting to the GCF will take place through the PSC which will include annual workplans and associated budgets, which will require the approval of the Committee, as well as progress and expenditure reporting. This will include the tracking of expenditure of in-kind and grant support provide by partners.

89. SANBI's SCM policy governs process, systems and decision-making with regards to the planning, sourcing, contracting and contract management of goods and services. This aligns with the South African government's SCM policies which must be complied with by all government entities including SANBI. In this regard, and in alignment with SANBI's SCM policy, SANBI can only enter into contractual arrangements with project partners once the requisite budget is available.
90. Supply chain and associated procurement requirements will only be finalised during operationalisation - once the scope and location of interventions have been finalised. A call for proposal will be issued which project partners can respond to. Thereafter, project partners will be selected as per SANBI's SCM processes and contracts will be established which will outline scope of work, roles and responsibilities etc. SANBI, as the Executing Entity, will oversee all contractual arrangements and will have the ultimate decision-making authority. Reports / decisions will be signed off by SANBI, through the PSC. Contracted partners will have some managerial or decision-making responsibility during implementation of the project as stipulated in contractual arrangements that will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase.
91. SANBI has the authority to directly receive funds into its own bank account. SANBI can receive funds directly from GCF without funds first flowing through a particular ministry or body in the government. According to Section 10(2) of NEMBA, SANBI is established as a juristic person, and Section 12(d) grants it the ability to open and manage its own bank accounts to carry out its responsibilities. Section 13(5) of the PFMA stipulates that funds received by a national public entity listed in Schedule 3 must be deposited into the bank account of the respective institution. No approvals, licences or permits are required. SANBI has previously opened a US$ bank account to receive GCF Readiness grant funds. SANBI will transfer funds from the US$ bank account to SANBI's ZAR account as and when funds are expensed and or disbursed onwards. The project funding flows are given in Figure 6.

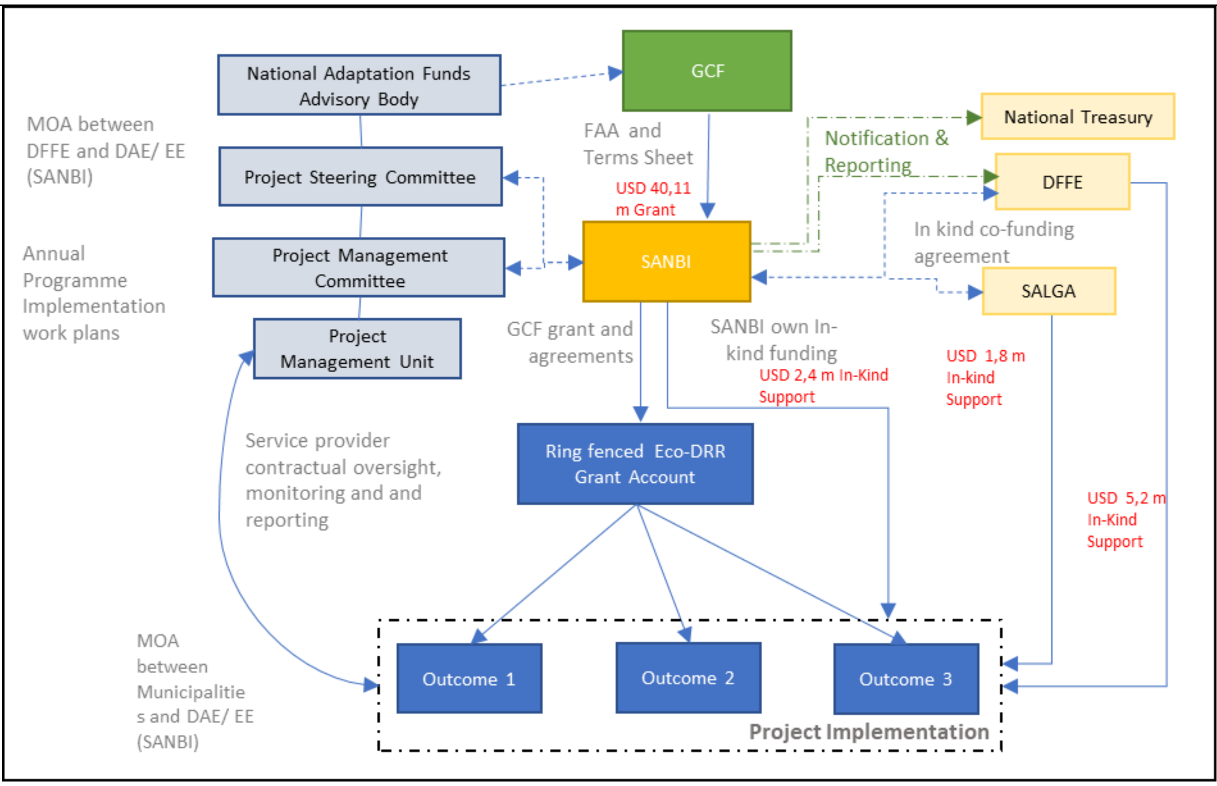


**Figure 6: Eco-DRR Project Funding Flows**

92. The GCF does not directly finance the underlying interventions and will provides the funds to the Accredited Entity (SANBI), who will manage and facilitate the financial flows in support of project implementation. The underlying requirements in terms of the drawdown, management, and reporting will be stipulated in the Funded Activity Agreement and the Terms Sheet. Co-financing will be provided by the DFFE and SALGA, using funds from the fiscus supported by a co-financing agreement (Figure 6). This co-financing will be provided through in-kind support, rather than through transfers to the ring-fenced project account. This will be supported by contractual arrangements that will finalised during the Operationalisation Phase, while letters of co-finance commitment have been secured and submitted as part of the submission to GCF.
93. There will be no direct transfers, or on-granting, of any GCF or project funds to beneficiaries. All expenditure will be based upon contractual arrangements finalised during the project's Operationalisation Phase. While letters of co-finance commitment have been received, it is the policy of SANBI to not enter into any contractual arrangements until project funding is secured.
94. There will be no subsidiary agreements, and all contractual agreements will be developed in accordance with SANBI's Supply Chain Management Policies.

## B.5. Justification for GCF funding request (max. 1000 words, approximately 2 pages)

95. The request for financing to GCF is premised on the increasing number of South Africans that are vulnerable to increased levels of climate change related hazards, including floods, droughts and wildfires. Climate impacts are already evident in the country and are expected to worsen in the future – thus reducing incomes, threatening food and water security and increasing the cost of living for South Africans (Johnston, et al., 2024). The Government of South Africa also faces pressing development and governance challenges, seeking to maximise the socio-economic and environmental benefits of public sector expenditure, while addressing the additional challenges of adapting to climate change. Securing the necessary financial resources to support the various dimensions of adaptation, particularly in areas outside of major urban centres where the vulnerability of communities to the increasing risk of climate induced hazards is most acute, is proving increasingly difficult.
96. While South Africa is currently classified as an upper middle-income country (World Bank, n.d.), this classification hides the extreme socio-economic inequality across the country, with the country having the highest Gini Coefficient in the world, in 2023. Thus South Africa continues to face increasing pressures due to growing unemployment and political challenges coupled with increasing fiscal constraints due to the costs of social protection supported by a relatively small tax base. As a result, there is a significant budget gap as the country grapples with meeting its social obligations. South Africa's macroeconomic indicators have weakened (including the downgrading of national credit rating to sub-investment grade by major rating agencies), the fiscal deficit rose, and financing of projects such as

the Eco-DRR has become increasingly challenging for government. Gross domestic product (GDP) growth, which averaged 3.5% percent during 2001 and 2010, has since fallen to an average of ~1.5% between 2011 and 2024. Also, with the latent impacts of the COVID-19 pandemic are still present, South Africa is continuing to face considerable economic pressure, reducing the overall availability of public finances to support the planning and execution of climatic interventions such as the Eco-DRR project. The investment by GCF is thus viewed as being critical in the establishment of this project, while also being catalytic in developing new approaches to crowd-in private sector finance to support Eco-DRR. The austerity measures implemented by the Government of South Africa has seen the budgets set aside for Environmental Programmes cut by over US$86 million over the last three financial years. As such, this has significantly reduced the funding available to support EbA and Eco-DRR interventions. Noting the importance of this project in supporting the improved resilience of rural communities and the projects intent to develop ecosystem-linked value chains, this support will be catalytic in assisting the local economy of rural and peri-urban areas.

97. Estimates are that climate finance in South Africa needs to increase by three to five-fold from the current average of approximately USD 7,5 billion. It has been reported that an average of USD 19 billion per year is needed to meet the 2050 net zero goal, and as much as USD 30,5 billion per year to meet the 2030 nationally determined contributions (NDC) targets (de Aragão Fernandes, et al., 2023).
98. South Africa also has a high proportion of peri-urban and rural communities living in formal and informal settlements that often have limited access to safe services with poor infrastructure. Within these vulnerable communities, women and children are often most vulnerable to the impacts of climate change as they are often more reliant on access to natural resources that are required to support livelihoods. These communities are often also situated in areas that are exposed to hazards such as floods, which place both lives and livelihoods at extreme risk.
99. The quantum of GCF funding for the Eco-DRR project will be managed by the Direct Access Entity to implement initial proof of concept projects at scale, that enable the project to lead to transformative change in the long-term. These projects will develop and demonstrate the interventions that will enable the project to make a material contribution towards the achievement of climate adaptation benefits in areas where climate induced drought, flooding and wildfire are forecasted to have a significant impact.
100. The South African government has prioritised the protection and sustainable management of the environment with DFFE: EP, both at national and provincial levels, being responsible for ecosystem rehabilitation and restoration, and safeguarding the functioning of natural ecosystems through interventions focused on job creation. The range of DFFE: EP programmes, while focused on sustainable environmental management, also seeks to address social development through poverty alleviation and skills development within the natural resource management sector. Under this banner, the Working for Water, Working for Wetlands, Working on Fire, and Working for Ecosystems have all been useful programmes that have used this approach. However, despite the good work that's been achieved by these programmes at relatively small scale, much is needed from a financial and technical perspective to meet the growing adaptation needs of the country. Reflective experience from these programmes has demonstrated that ongoing budget cuts and challenges in fund disbursement has reduced the ability of these programmes to realise impact. This has resulted in poorly managed and poorly maintained efforts to combat ecological degradation that have not had the long-term desired outcomes. The DFFE: EP programme of work has therefore faced challenges in undertaking consistent planning and in managing and maintaining its stakeholder relationships and communications (SANBI, 2017). Additionally, the DFFE: EP programme has not incorporated climate change into the programme design and the required protocols for subsequent follow-up work, this is a significant weakness noting that evidence has indicated that the spread of alien invasive plants is exacerbated by climate change (Turbelin & Catford, 2021). Lastly, much of DFFE: EP's work focused on small-scale interventions and there is a strong need for EbA to be implemented at scale to demonstrate impact and support the case for increased public and private sector investments.
101. The additionality of the GCF financial support is thus significant, as this will provide not only the evidence to underpin the value of the investment in EbA and Eco-DRR but will also assist to unlock a range of investment approaches that will change the manner in which these interventions are financed. This will change the grant based, government financing model to introduce private sector investments and the use of blended financing options where public sector finance is used to de-risk private sector investment. As such the GCF support will be both catalytic and transformative.
102. This project proposes a new effective and cost-effective Eco-DRR approach, with activities in focal landscapes in vulnerable regions, and public-private-community partnerships providing pathways to scale across the country. The country has made important policy commitments enabling this approach, but significant barriers exist to its implementation at scale. It is well noted that national government, through the fiscus, has a critical role to play in supporting investment into climate adaptation programmes such as the Eco-DRR. However, investments have been

lacking in support of the management and maintenance of ecological infrastructure. This sector is often viewed as 'a public goods' sector with an uncompelling case for private sector investment.

103. The development of bankable projects, especially focused on ecological infrastructure, has been challenging. To address this, DFFE, in 2023, reaffirmed its commitment to protecting ecological infrastructure through the Working for Water programme by allocating USD 152 million of grant funding over the next five years to remove IAPs and create 38 839 work opportunities every year - primarily in rural communities throughout the country. Within the provinces being targeted by this project, Limpopo will receive USD 12,1 million, North West USD 10,6 million and Eastern Cape USD 17 million from DFFE (DFFE, 2023). However, over the financial years 2023/24, 2024/25 and 2025/26 this budget has been subsequently cut by a USD86 million (National Treasury, 2024). Furthermore, according to DFFE there are 10 million hectares of invasive alien plants (10% of the total country area) that require attention, and this is spreading at a rate between 5 and 10% per annum. The scale of effort required and the widening fiscal deficit, estimated at 5% of GDP and USD 1,26 billion (Bloomberg, 2024), places these efforts at significant risk (Rakabe, 2024).
104. This lack of investment over time has contributed towards the development of funding gaps for such sectors despite these national commitments and (apparent) private sector innovation. Thus, GCF funding, coupled with state action will play an extremely important role in catalysing private sector finance through interventions under this project to develop investment packages as well as providing support through accelerators and incubators for the demonstration of the impact of investments in EbA and Eco-DRR at scale, and the upscaling of Eco-DRR approaches, which would otherwise not be possible.
105. The Government of South Africa, through local implementing municipalities, have little financial capacity to meet the initial costs of establishing a project of this nature. Municipal-scale projects are often capital-intensive and access to funding can be a major constraint, particularly for small, less financially stable municipalities where there often significant vulnerabilities to climate-induced hazards. In these more rural areas, where communities are impoverished, there is weak capacity to pay for services. In addition, the funding that is made available through the fiscus for disaster risk is currently focused upon the management and mitigation of impacts, rather than focusing on the reduction of disaster risk in advance of such events, and climate change is rarely explicitly considered. These institutions often lack the capacity to plan and develop such integrated solutions, to develop the bankable projects that could secure the required funding and lack the capacity to then raise the needed funds.
106. The feasibility study (Annex 2) and associated Benefit Cost Analysis (Annex 3) showed that these Eco-DRR interventions could show an Economic Internal Rate of Return (EIRR) around 56% as an average across all the projects assessed. This is particularly so where ecological infrastructure investments enable avoided direct and indirect damage costs to built infrastructure.
107. The GCF grant funding is necessary to overcome this combination of financial, technical, institutional and market barriers that together prevent climate-vulnerable locations in South Africa from adequately building resilience to increasing climate hazards. With the GCF's focus on transformative investments to upscale climate risk management, the Fund is well placed to help remove these barriers and unlock financial flows that will enable the new approaches developed under this project, to be embedded in the South African governance and planning frameworks. Getting the management and maintenance of ecological infrastructure embedded into the planning instruments at these local levels will then assist in accessing existing development finance and municipal revenue streams for rehabilitating and maintaining this ecological infrastructure.

### B.6. Exit strategy (max. 500 words, approximately 1 page)

108. The long-term mainstreaming and upscaling of Eco-DRR will be a critical dimension of the country's adaptation response to the increased impact of droughts, floods and wildfires. The design of the project is such that the project outcomes produce the enabling environment required to support the upscaling that is needed. Nevertheless, the following aspects are part of the project's approach to ensuring an effective exit strategy.

**Political support and ownership**

109. With support from the National Adaptation Funds Advisory Body (NAFAB) (chaired by DFFE), and DFFE as the national designated authority, the project has high-level political support and ownership by the Government of South Africa. Additionally, the structure of the projects governance framework is such that it ensures the inclusion of key state actors who are key to the longer-term implementation of policies, plans and interventions that will upscale the Eco-DRR principles that the project will develop and strengthen. These principles will also be mainstreamed into a range of climate and water sector strategies that sector government departments will implement.

**Partnerships**

110. Establishing partnerships with key state actors is key to the longer-term upscaling of Eco-DRR interventions. Noting that these need to take place at municipal levels with the support of capacitated institutions and staff, the

partnership with COGTA[19], NDMC and SALGA is essential in ensuring that these approaches become standardized across all municipalities. These actors will also continue efforts to build the appropriate levels of capacity across all municipalities. With local government having an important mandate to drive local socio-economic development and the provision of services, COGTA has a key role to facilitate across different sectors of government in ensuring that ongoing support is provided to municipalities. NDMC is responsible for ensuring that the National Framework for Disaster Risk Management provides clear guidance across all spheres and sectors of government for managing climate change-related risk. They also ensure that an effective communications strategy is in place for early warnings to communities vulnerable to climate change impacts. SALGA supports, represents and advises local government action, participates in the intergovernmental system, ensures climate adaptation and mitigation actions are integrated into development plans, and promotes public education, awareness and communication of information on climate change.

**Private Sector Engagement**

111. While public sector partnerships are an essential part of developing a sustainable policy, planning, and institutional framework to be supportive of ongoing Eco-DRR projects, the private sector and their investment in Eco-DRR will be critical to the longer-term sustainability of these interventions. Recognising this, a key element of the project design is to develop financial mechanisms and supportive investment packages that will facilitate the ongoing engagement of the private sector. A key element of the Eco-DRR project will be the ability of the project to ensure that this engagement is initiated, improved and secured for future projects. There has been to some degree a level of mistrust between the Government and the private sector and as such the development of this partnership during the roll-out of the project will be a key outcome. Towards this end, the project design process has engaged with the NBI, the SFC and others who will play an ongoing role to support emergent enterprises. The mechanisms developed under Outcome 3 to support these businesses will be maintained with these actors playing a key role to support business accelerators, provide support through incubation and/ or matching businesses across value chains through market soundings and matching processes. This will be a profound outcome for the project as this enables the reproduction of these support interventions across other parts of the country.

**Organisational and institutional capacity**

112. A key element of the project's sustainability is the development of sufficient capacity and competencies to support the management and implementation of the project as well as that of the interventions themselves at municipal and local levels. The building of the necessary staff cohorts with the appropriate skills (such as technical, financial, project management and social learning facilitation) within SANBI, other sector actors as well as municipalities is recognised as key part of the ability to ensure project implementation, as well as taking Eco-DRR interventions to scale, across the country.

**Programme exit strategy and longer-term ownership**

113. A successful exit strategy will ensure continuity of projects undertaken during the course of the Eco-DRR project. Outcome 3 of the project design includes the development of investment packages and support mechanisms that will seek to upscale Eco-DRR and support the reduction of community vulnerability through the improvement of livelihood options linked to such investments. Equally important will be that this also will include the development of a business case for a transformed operation model for public sector investment in natural resource management and Eco-DRR. Additionally, the project will provide support to the DFFE to operationalise this model and this will be an important part of ensuring that these Eco-DRR interventions are continued in the long-term. Importantly, through the mainstreaming of Eco-DRR into national and local level policy and planning instruments there will be a requirement for government departments to ensure Eco-DRR interventions are implemented.

## C. FINANCING INFORMATION

### C.1. Total financing

| (a) Requested GCF funding (i + ii + iii + iv + v + vi + vii) | Total amount | Currency |
|---|---|---|
| | 40,10 | million USD ($) |

[19] COGTA is a government entity that is required to promote cooperative governance across sectors and departments. MOAs will be used to engage with COGTA and their managerial or decision-making responsibility for the implementation of any of the activities under the project will be stipulated in the MOA (which will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase).

| GCF financial instrument | Amount | Tenor | Grace period | Pricing |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| (i) Senior loans | - | - | - | - |
| (ii) Subordinated loans | - | - | - | - |
| (iii) Equity | - | - | - | - |
| (iv) Guarantees | - | - | - | - |
| (v) Reimbursable grants | - | - | - | - |
| (vi) Grants | 40,10 mil | NA | NA | - |
| (vii) Results-based payments | - | - | - | - |

| **(b) Co-financing information** | **Total amount** | **Currency** |
|---|---|---|
| | 9,40 | million USD ($) |

| Name of institution | Financial instrument | Amount | Currency | Tenor & grace | Pricing | Seniority |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| SANBI | In kind | 2,39 | million USD ($) | Not applicable | - | - |
| DFFE | In kind | 5.24 | million USD ($) | Not applicable | | |
| SALGA | In kind | 1,77 | million USD ($) | Not applicable | | |

| **(c) Total financing (c) = (a)+(b)** | **Amount** | **Currency** |
|---|---|---|
| | 49,51 | million USD ($) |

| | |
|---|---|
| **(d) Other financing arrangements and contributions (max. 250 words, approximately 0.5 page)** | As part of the funding application development, there are on-going discussions with on-the-ground NGOs, civil society and private sector entities on how to leverage the existing project / programmes that are currently underway in the area through in-kind or other contributions. Parallel finance in the form of ongoing projects that can be linked to the Eco-DRR project includes the Alfred Nzo DM Hameln Pyrmont Partnership, Service Statistics for Biodiversity and Landscapes – Wattle Clearing in Matatiele Local Municipality (LM), Environmental and Rural Solutions' Work in Matatiele LM, Matatiele Watershed Protection and Stewardship Project, Umzimvubu Catchment Partnership's work, DFFE-Led Working for Water and Working on Fire Projects, Senqu LM EbA Project, South African National Parks (SANParks) Grasslands National Park, Kruger to Canyons Rangeland Restoration Project, Kruger to Canyons Corridor Project, Kruger to Canyons Catchment Investment Programme and the Global Environment Facility (GEF) 7: Mainstreaming Sustainable Land Management for Large-Scale Impact in the Grazing Lands of Limpopo and Northern Cape provinces in South Africa. |

## C.2. Financing by component

*Please provide an estimate of the total cost per component and output as outlined in section B.3. above and disaggregate by source of financing. More than one co-financing institution can fund a single component or output. Provide the summarised cost estimates in the table below and the detailed budget plan as annex 4.*

| Component | Output | Indicative cost Options | GCF financing | | Co-financing | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | Amount Options | Financial Instrument | Amount Options | Financial Instrument[20] | Name of Institutions |
| Outcome 1 | Output 1.1 | 22,73 mil | 19,11 mil | Grants | 3,62 mil | Grants | DFFE, SANBI |
| | Output 1.2. | 1,64 mil | 0,80 mil | Grants | 0,84mil | Grants | DFFE, SANBI |
| Outcome 2. | Output 2.1. | 5,43 mil | 4,25 mil | Grants | 1,18mil | Grants | SANBI, SALGA |
| | Output 2.2. | 4,28 mil | 3,68 mil | Grants | 0,60 mil | Grants | SANBI, SALGA |
| Outcome 3. | Output 3.1. | 4,01 mil | 3,61 mil | Grants | 0,40 mil | Grants | DFFE, SANBI |
| | Output 3.2. | 5,12 mil | 4,74 mil | Grants | 0,38 mil | Grants | DFFE, SANBI |
| Project Management | Cross Cutting | 4,30 mil | 1,91 mil | Grants | 2.39 mil | Grants | SANBI |

[20] Co-financing will be in-kind.

| | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Monitoring and Evaluation | Cross Cutting | 2,01 mil | 2,01 mil | Grants | | | |
| **Indicative total cost (USD)** | | 49,51 million | 40,10 million | | 9,40 million | | |

**C.3 Capacity building and technology development/transfer (max. 250 words, approximately 0.5 page)**

| | |
|---|---|
| C.3.1 Does GCF funding finance capacity building activities? | Yes ☒ No ☐ |
| C.3.2. Does GCF funding finance technology development/transfer? | Yes ☒ No ☐ |

114. While the existing natural resource management interventions can continue to be implemented in their current form, the Eco-DRR Project aims to influence existing programmes by being more responsive to climate change pressures. This approach brings together stronger alignment of existing resources and enables strategic implementation by strengthening the knowledge and capacity base needed to fast-track replication, upscale pilot projects, improve coordination, strengthen communication, and enhance learning and research activities.

115. These knowledge exchange interventions will underpin the development of awareness regarding climate change impacts at local, sub-national and national levels and will support the successful scaling and implementation of Eco-DRR projects in South Africa as an adaptation response. These interventions will focus upon developing improved awareness across a broader swathe of stakeholders, while providing more focused technical capacity building interventions at national, provincial district and local government levels. These governmentally focused interventions will deepen the understanding of the environmental sectors' climatic risks while taking into consideration updated analysis, knowledge, and insights. Strengthened by this experience and evidence, the Government of South Africa, through DFFE and SANBI, can successfully and actively develop an updated climate strategy to better adapt and mitigate climate risk. This will then support the implementation of a longer-term pipeline of projects as well as assist in addressing various barriers to implementation such as institutional and regulatory frameworks.

## D. EXPECTED PERFORMANCE AGAINST INVESTMENT CRITERIA

*This section refers to the performance of the project/programme against the investment criteria as set out in the GCF's Initial Investment Framework.*

**D.1. Impact potential (max. 500 words, approximately 1 page)**

116. The Eco-DRR project will primarily contribute to two of the eight results areas outlined in the GCF's Integrated Results Management Framework, these being:
- Adaptation Results Area (ARA) 1: Most vulnerable people and communities; and
- ARA 4: Ecosystems and ecosystem services.

117. In this regard, the Core Indicator 2: Direct and indirect beneficiaries reached and Core Indicator 4 Hectares of natural resource areas brought under improved low-emission and/or climate-resilient management practices will be used to quantitatively track the climate-focused outcomes of the GCF funding provided to the project. Noting the GCF's strategic target for 2024-2027 in terms of support for developing countries to conserve, restore or bring areas of land under sustainable management practices (target is 120-190 million hectares), the Eco-DRR project will bring 68010.29 hectares of land under improved and sustainable management to reduce the impacts of droughts, floods and wildfire.

118. The project will benefit an estimated 5,481,886 people (approx. 53% female) from peri-urban and rural communities that are vulnerable to climate change in focal landscapes, including household members of adults participating in project activities. There will be specific attention paid to women and youth at intervention levels where women play a critical role in securing livelihoods and addressing water and food security. With the project providing support to the development of livelihoods options, the focus on youth is important, given the high rate of youth unemployment. In this regard, the project aims to involve 65% young people.

119. It has been assumed that each household comprises of 4 people which is based on household averages per province. Mpumalanga's average household size is 3.82 (National Treasury, 2021), Eastern Cape's is 3.97 (National Treasury, 2021), Limpopo's is 3.91 (National Treasury, 2021), and North West's is 3.37 (National Treasury, 2021).

120. Direct beneficiaries are community members who are better able to cope with the impacts of climate change intensified droughts, floods, and wildfire at the close of the GCF-supported project. This also includes community members in the focal landscapes who: i) are employed on environmental public works programmes in the focal landscapes with new climate impact measures (e.g. slope management, IAP removal, erosion reduction, river bank

stabilisation, wetland rehabilitation, rangeland management, environmental monitors etc.), co-financed by the South African government (e.g. Working for Water, Working for Wetlands etc); ii) are participants in GCF-supported climate-adaptive livelihood opportunities through SMME or cooperative opportunities including such aspects as initial processing of cleared biomass for bio-refineries or for biochar, and sustainable livestock production (with associated animal products) and marketing on rehabilitated rangelands; iii) are participants in GCF-supported and Government co-financed initiatives for communities; and iv) are employed on projects for municipal built and ecological infrastructure co-financed by the South African government. In particular, the community members from group i) and group iv), through employment via the Eco-DRR project, will have improved livelihoods to better cope with flood events (more details are unpacked in the feasibility study (Annex 2)). The discussions with private sector actors and with communities regarding the livelihoods options will impact upon the number of direct beneficiaries and early-stage engagement with the private sector will be critical.

121. Linked to the GCF strategic priorities for 2024-2027 in terms of adaptation, the project will undertake interventions focused on improvement of early warning systems and disaster response preparedness in each of the four DMs. This will have indirect impact on the lives of all residents in these districts as they become increasingly aware of the impacts of climate change induced hazards and the onset of potential disasters. The use of various technologies will raise awareness and will be supported by people-centred early warning. These approaches will be developed to fit for purpose in each DM. This will have impact broadly across each DM and as such the population of each DM has been included as indirect beneficiaries.

122. The integration of Eco-DRR into settlement planning in the four DMs will likely have impact on many of the people living within these jurisdictions. Plus, the lessons learned can be shared more broadly across South Africa with the support of key stakeholders such as SALGA. The ability of the programme to share the evidence base and build knowledge in other landscapes where increased climate resilience is evident, and will impact on the uptake of these approaches in new locations. It can be expected that other communities within the LMs, where site-based interventions have taken place, will also likely indirectly benefit from the improved capacity developed locally through the site-based interventions. However, the level of beneficiation is not clear at this juncture, and this can be reassessed during the project’s Operationalisation Phase after more detailed baseline assessments have been undertaken.

123. The GCF 2024-2027 strategic plan places emphasis catalysing climate finance from the wider finance ecosystem, engaging key actors such as local private sector early-stage ventures, micro small- and medium- sized enterprises (MSMEs) and national and regional financial institutions. Aligned to this, the development of innovative financing mechanisms under Outcome 3 will impact on the ability to upscale Eco-DRR through the development of investment packages and the provision of business support. This will have profound impact on the number of indirect beneficiaries. At this stage, this is not possible to quantify with any level of accuracy.

124. A core aspect of the project design is the recognition of the importance of addressing barriers in the enabling environment that serve to hinder the upscaling of Eco-DRR approaches. As such, these aspects are important in providing the basis for the paradigm shift that is required in South Africa. This includes working with institutions to support transformational change in policy and planning, as well as in building capable institutions and organs of state, this is supported by the projects efforts to build an evidence base and share knowledge and experience. These two aspects will be supportive of developing transformational shifts in the manner in which Eco-DRR is taken to scale. As such, the project will track the following core indicators:

- Core indicator 5: Degree to which GCF investments contribute to strengthening institutional and regulatory frameworks for low-emission climate-resilient development pathways in a country-driven manner;
- Core indicator 7: Degree to which GCF investments contribute to market development/transformation at the sectoral, local or national level; and
- Core indicator 8: Degree to which GCF investments contribute to effective knowledge generation and learning processes, and use of good practices, methodologies and standards.

### D.2. Paradigm shift potential (max. 500 words, approximately 1 page)

125. According to the paradigm shifting pathways across the four pillars of the GCF strategic plan (GCF, 2022), the Eco-DRR project will involve the following:

- **Transformational planning and programming**
  - Participatory multi-stakeholder processes and effective free, prior and informed consent
  - Public policies, regulatory frameworks to promote green infrastructure investments
  - Land use and ecological-economic zoning to enhance ecological connectivity
  - Ecosystem-based solutions improving nationally determined contributions or projects by ecosystem type and geography

  - Building with nature planning
- **Catalysing climate innovation**
  - Pilot, test and evaluate new methods for valuing and incorporating ecosystem services through natural capital accounts
- **Mobilisation of finance at scale**
  - Blended finance for EbA / Eco-DRR
  - Public private financing
  - Vehicles to support business development including accelerators and incubators
  - Market sounding and business matching
  - Private incentives and partnerships in ecosystem management
- **Coalitions and knowledge to scale up success**
  - Participatory monitoring, evaluation and learning
  - Harmonised monitoring and assessment
  - Data centres for ecosystems
  - Exchange platforms, in particular, south-south

126. The productivity of South African rural landscapes has decreased over the past two centuries in part due to changing conditions in the climate and landscape, as well as poor or exploitive environmental management practices at localised levels. In addition, peri-urban areas are vulnerable to climate-related hazards, in part, due to declining traditional informal institutions and the associated forms of collective action and interdependence within these communities (Revi, et al., 2014; Chitakira & Ngcobo, 2021). It is particularly important to note that as these peri-urban areas are at the wildland urban interface they are frequently exposed to degrading ecosystems and as such to the impacts of climate change induced hazards.
127. The proposed GCF project will catalyse impacts beyond the four target sites by developing the business case for major public and private sector investments, as well as community buy-in, into rehabilitating the functionality of these ecosystems, thereby restoring the environmental goods and services that reduce the prevalence and impacts of droughts, floods and wildfires. This will be achieved by quantifying the ecological and financial benefits of adapting ecosystem-focused management practices to increase rangeland quality, improve soil health, increase ecosystem carbon stocks, increase rainwater infiltration and support surface water availability and regulation, and reduce wildfire frequency and intensity.
128. The potential for climate adaptive land management to build climate change resilience is currently not commonly integrated into land management plans by government or rural and peri-urban communities. By contrast, there are private sector initiatives that focus on enhancing adaptive approaches which result in increased community resilience as well as ecosystem services support. The proposed GCF project will bridge the gap between the communities, governance agencies, and the private and public sectors by building trust, sharing knowledge and ensuring collaboration between government, private sector, communities, NGOs, academia and civil society. This will showcase a model for co-creating solutions where communities and the private sector may scale up and replicate activities across South Africa. Examples of these partnerships include the Umzimvubu Catchment Partnership in the Eastern Cape, Kruger to Canyons' and Conservation South Africa's work in Mpumalanga and Eastern Cape provinces and Environmental and Rual Solution's work in the Eastern Cape province. These approaches would reduce the impacts of droughts, floods and wildfires as well as support enhanced productivity of the ecosystems and enable commercially viable outcomes that benefit communities, private sector, and government alike.
129. Each location will have specific local barriers to investment to overcome. These are likely to include a range of operational elements, the need for practice support and the capacity of local communities to negotiate appropriate contracts with private companies. The Eco-DRR project will, via local NGOs and/or community-based organisations, address these barriers and facilitate an upscaling of private sector engagement in the development of various and appropriate financing mechanisms.
130. Assessing the policy and investment environment for private sector engagement in Eco-DRR towards addressing gaps and barriers to such investments will identify areas for improvement that will create an improved enabling environment for investment. The identification and assessment of EbA and Eco-DRR-linked financial mechanisms, the financial sector's current integration of biodiversity and climate-related risks and opportunities into financial planning and decision-making and emerging opportunities (such as the South African carbon credit and biodiversity and water credit policy landscape) will also be an essential part of shifting the investment paradigm.
131. Lessons learned in the engagement between rural and peri-urban communities and private sector communities through the local site-based work under Outcome 1 will be shared nationally and be integrated into the approaches developed under Outcome 3. These lessons will also be used by the proposed GCF project to adjust government

plans, policies, legislation and strategies to ensure that there is an enabling environment for private sector investment into the upscaling of Eco-DRR interventions.

132. To support upscaling, the knowledge products developed under Output 3.2 will provide critical learning and guidance for other DMs to adopt EbA and Eco-DRR at a larger scale. Additionally, integrating Eco-DRR into national policies and municipal development plans (under Outcome 2) will create an enabling framework for long-term, countrywide adoption.

133. Similarly, for sustainability and ensuring financial and institutional anchoring of the project, public and private sector engagements and possible financial facility arrangements, under Outcome 3, will provide the basis for long-term financing beyond GCF support. While the project will have developed financial structuring options and investment packages, the scoping of a financing facility that will be able to leverage SANBI's on-granting experience to provide a platform for future financing of Eco-DRR interventions still needs to be determined. GCF funds will only be used to develop financial structuring options and investment packages, as well as the scoping and development of institutional options for such a financing facility.

## D.3. Sustainable development (max. 500 words, approximately 1 page)

134. Under the South African governance framework, municipalities have a critical role in driving local socio-economic development. The Eco-DRR Programme is designed to deliver a range of benefits to beneficiaries such as households (rural, peri-urban) and industries, and to municipal governments, and thereby to South Africa. Over and above the core benefits that the Eco-DRR project will realise, there are additionally two important co-benefits.

135. **Co-benefit 1: Environmental**. Through the implementation of the Eco-DRR project there will be improvement in the health of both terrestrial and aquatic ecosystems. These benefits include rehabilitation in support of ecosystem services, including improved groundwater retention, increased surface water and river baseflows, regeneration of soil health and fertility, enhanced soil stability and soil horizon depth, increased soil organic carbon, and improved agricultural produce and grazing productivity. It is important to note that beyond the rehabilitation efforts that are needed to support climate change resilience, where feasible, the project will also support ecosystem restoration. The biodiversity will be strengthened by providing additional suitable habitat and increasing landscape connectivity, this includes both terrestrial and aquatic species. These co-benefits together with the projects core benefits all contribute towards achieving Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) 15: Life on Land, SDG 2: Zero Hunger, SDG 3: Good Health and Wellbeing, SDG 6: Clean Water and Sanitation, and SDG 13: Climate Action.

136. **Co-benefit 2: Social and Gender.** Climate change disproportionally impacts upon people in low-income and impoverished communities. In rural communities, women and girl children are responsible for a range of productive activities, as well as taking care of the family unit. Climate change impacts upon women most significantly yet they are often excluded from decision making processes that impact upon them, most typically in communal areas where Traditional Leadership is a key part of the governance framework. Women are also vulnerable within peri-urban conditions as women control fewer resources than men in informal settlements and are frequently exposed to gender-based violence (Patel, et al., 2018). Furthermore, women in these settings often lack access to sanitation and face disruptions to paid work as a result of climate change events (Patel, et al., 2018). The Eco-DRR project will actively engage with women within communities to fully understand their needs and to leverage their local knowledge into site-based actions, will design these local interventions to facilitate their participation and involvement, as well as support the development of commodity value-chains that support the economic empowerment of women. This will contribute to attaining SDG 1: No Poverty, SDG 3: Good Health and Wellbeing, SDG 10: Reduced Inequalities and SDG 5: Gender Equality.

## D.4. Needs of recipient (max. 500 words, approximately 1 page)

137. With the impacts of climate change being felt across the country, South Africa's NCCAS (2019) acts as a common reference point for climate change adaptation efforts in South Africa in the short to medium-term, providing guidance across all levels of government, sectors, and stakeholders affected by climate variability and change. The NCCAS also acts as the National Adaptation Plan and presents priority interventions to enhance the country's resilience and ensure adequate responses to climate change. These include:

- Reducing human, economic, environment, physical and ecological infrastructure vulnerability and building adaptive capacity.
- Developing a coordinated climate services system that provides climate products and services for key climate vulnerable sectors and geographic areas.
- Developing a vulnerability and resilience methodology framework that integrates biophysical and socioeconomic aspects of vulnerability and resilience.
- Facilitating the mainstreaming of adaptation responses into sectoral planning and implementation.

- Promoting research application, technology development, transfer and adoption to support planning and implementation.
- Building the necessary capacity and awareness for climate change responses.
- Establishing effective governance and legislative processes to integrate climate change in development planning.
- Enabling substantial flows of climate change adaptation finance from various sources.
  Developing and implementing an M&E system that tracks implementation of adaptation actions and their effectiveness.

138. The NCCAS facilitates the degree to which development initiatives at different levels of government and business integrate and reflect critical climate change adaptation priorities, and thus inform resource allocation by the various stakeholders towards climate change resilience. It also guides stronger coherence and coordination on climate change adaptation activities between different institutions and levels of government. These governance and institutional aspects are complex due to a range of structural issues across the differing spheres of government.
139. While South Africa has retained its institutional capacity in some areas, over the last decade there has also been a steady decline in institutional capacity, efficacy, and governance. The National Planning Commission recognised that in many areas service delivery has fallen dramatically short of expectations. As municipalities face challenges in meeting even basic service-delivery needs, they are not well-placed to develop and roll-out new approaches that see EbA approaches being translated into integrated built and ecological solutions. This requires national government, with key partners such as SANBI, NDMC, SALGA and others, to strategically guide a project that pulls together complex technical, institutional and financial solutions to establish a new approach that is supportive of EbA.
140. The pressure on municipalities to deliver services in support of local economic development is profound. In the large metropolitan municipalities these challenges exist linked to very rapid urbanisation and the need to expand services to meet the growth. However, in more rural contexts these challenges are notably different where the size of indigent communities is significant and the need to provide basic services is difficult in landscapes that are disparate and sizeable. The Municipal Infrastructure Grant that is provided to municipalities has to finance a range of infrastructural solutions and with the funds available being insufficient to meet all the needs. This is worse in rural contexts where the ability of communities to pay for services is limited due to weak livelihood options.
141. In many instances the capacity of municipalities is weak with many not having the technical skills and competencies to work with infrastructure and develop integrated solutions. In these institutions the understanding of the benefits accrued from well-functioning ecosystems is frequently limited. Often, in rural municipalities there is not a town-engineer and there is a dependency on the procurement of technical skills. With limited understanding of how to develop technical Terms of Reference or with insufficient finance to support such procurement, there are often delays in process and an inability to progress the solutions needed to build resilience. Building municipal understanding of the importance of Eco-DRR and the ways in which built and ecological infrastructure can be used conjunctively will assist in developing climate adaptation responses that are more sustainable.

## D.5. Country ownership (max. 500 words, approximately 1 page)

142. The country's NCCAS supports South Africa's ability to meet its obligations in terms of the Paris Agreement on Climate Change by defining the country's vulnerabilities, plans to reduce those vulnerabilities and the required resources for such action. The strategy seeks to reduce the vulnerability of society, the economy and the environment to the effects of climate change and provides a common reference point for climate change adaptation efforts in South Africa in the short to medium-term.
143. In addition, the country has promulgated its first Climate Change Act (Act 22 of 2024) which guides the development of an effective climate change response and a long-term, just transition to a low-carbon and climate-resilient economy and society for South Africa in the context of sustainable development. The Act recognises the urgency in addressing the threat of climate change and emphasises the need for an effective, progressive, coordinated and integrated response. A key focus of the Act is alignment of policies, establishment of provincial and municipal forums, establishment of the Presidential Climate Commission (PCC), development of adaptation strategies and plans, and placing greater obligations on provincial governments and municipalities. The Act also requires that the Minister prescribe a mechanism to support and finance South Africa's climate change response, planning and implementation by national, provincial and local government in consultation with the Minister of Finance (see Clause 18). The Eco-DRR project can be instructive in informing the development of such a mechanism.
144. The proposed project has been designed to create synergy and complementarity with a raft of ongoing projects and initiatives related to climate-induced impacts, with a number of these also having valuable geographic congruency. These provide for valuable entry points in some of the sites, an ability to dovetail and expand the reach of the project for greater aggregated impact, and important approaches to both the science and community engagement process

that will support the project. More details regarding the complementarity of the Eco-DRR project with past and ongoing initiatives can be found in Annex 2 (Feasibility Study).

145. The Eco-DRR project strongly aligns with South Africa's Climate Change Act (Act 22 of 2024) which places a clear emphasis on the implementation of a range of actions to support adaptation. South Africa's Third National Communication (TNC) (DEA, 2018) to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), the draft Fourth National Communication to the UNFCCC which is in preparation (DFFE, 2024) and the South Africa's NCCAS (DEFF, 2019) recognise that climate change effects will lead to increasingly severe and frequent floods, droughts and wildfires, which will substantially impact infrastructure and communities. In response to these hazards, these instruments highlight the need for a comprehensive approach to adaptation, including improved infrastructure, land-use practices and ecological infrastructure to build adaptive capacity – all of which is covered under the Eco-DRR project.

146. Furthermore, South Africa, in recognition of the urgency to not only respond to climate disasters but to build and entrench climate resilient approaches to mitigation and adaptation, has established the Presidential Climate Commission, responding directly to Conference of the Parties 27, in pursuing a Just transition. This commission is an independent, statutory, multistakeholder body whose primary purpose is to oversee and facilitate a just and equitable transition towards a low-emissions and climate-resilient economy. Part of this transition is to meet the Nationally Determined Contributions targets by establishing transition pathways are adequately funded and invested in. Equally important is the PCC's commitment to track, monitor and report on any climate financing invested in the country to meets its targets and objectives. Commitment to achieving the proposed revised target ranges of 398 to 510 Mt CO2-eq for 2025, and 398 to 440 Mt CO2-eq for 2030, as identified by the DFFE (Marquard, et al., 2021).

147. The proposed GCF project is closely aligned with the mid- and long-term climate change adaptation priorities in South Africa, including priority activities outlined in multiple national and sectoral climate change strategies, such as NCCAS, National Climate Change Response Policy (NCCRP), National Disaster Management Framework under the Disaster Management Act of 2002, and National Strategy for Dealing with Biological Aliens in South Africa, 2014. South Africa's TNC under the UNFCCC shows that "Alien invasive plants use considerable amounts of water which is then not utilisable to downstream users with the water reduction in some primary catchments in as high as 8 percent". The Implementation Framework for the NCCAS includes "Intervention 1: Reduce Human and Economic Vulnerability, Ensure Resilience of Physical Capital and Ecological Infrastructure and Build Adaptive Capacity", with three highly relevant action areas to which the project responds: 1.1.20 Adopt climate resilient approaches to natural resource management to rehabilitate and maintain ecosystem goods and services; 1.1.23 Protect and conserve South Africa's most vulnerable ecosystems and landscapes; 1.1.24 Monitor and control the spread of alien invasive species that benefit from climate change; and 1.1.4 Capacitate and operationalise South Africa's National Disaster Management Framework to strengthen proactive climate change adaptive capacity, preparedness, response and recovery.

148. In addition to addressing climate change adaptation priorities, the proposed project supports South Africa's socio-economic development goals, including those in the National Strategy towards Gender Mainstreaming in the Environment Sector, and as outlined in the National Development Plan 2030. These include: i) poverty alleviation; ii) job creation; iii) growth in the green sector; and iv) development of rural economies. The project's focus on rural communities is of particular importance, as alleviating rural poverty is a high priority of the South African government but has proven remarkably challenging because of a number of systemic socio-economic challenges. Furthermore, the proposed GCF project is aligned with the government approved DDM, which aims to improve integrated planning and delivery across the spheres of government, and result in a single, strategically focussed "One Plan" for each District and Metropolitan Municipality in the country.

149. The project design is such that it works across various sectors and as such needs to work with the differing spheres of government as well as key public entities and civil society partners. National government departments including DFFE, COGTA, Department of Agriculture, Land Reform and Rural Development (DALRRD), as well as associated entities including the SALGA, and SAWS[21]. These actors are supportive and aligned with the project design as will from part of the project's governance arrangements. The project design reflects the importance of local level implementation and as such provincial government departments of environment have been engaged together with both LM and DM actors. These key stakeholders are aligned with the projects intent and are committed to support the projects implementation.

[21] Both DALRRD and SAWS are government entities that are required to promote cooperative governance across sectors and departments. MOAs will be used to engage with DALRRD and SAWS, and their managerial or decision-making responsibility for the implementation of any of the activities under the project will be stipulated in the MOA (which will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase).

## D.6. Efficiency and effectiveness (max`. 500 words, approximately 1 page)

**Value for Money**

150. The theory of change involves enhancing the efficiency and effectiveness of environmental public works programmes so that they are more effective in reducing disaster risk. In addition, it involves harnessing existing sources of public finance that are currently not being utilised for rehabilitation and maintenance of ecological infrastructure, to be more effective in reducing climate risk. The actual methods to be used for landscape rehabilitation and maintenance to reduce the risk ecosystem degradation will be based on approaches used for the past 25 years through the DFFE: EP programmes (including Working for Water, Working for Ecosystems, and Working for Wetlands), and on international best practice for Eco-DRR. This will also build upon the methods outlined in standard-based rehabilitation approaches. The project will facilitate the new application of these methods in the context of municipal finance, providing assistance to develop missing technical and financial capacity, and most importantly providing a model of how investment in ecological infrastructure can help municipalities meet their targets for climate change adaptation, DRR, and job creation.
151. Piloting new approaches to integrated ecological and built infrastructure investment through co-financed technical assistance to communities and municipalities, and inclusion of private sector to move projects from planning to execution will enable the development of cost-effective models that can be widely disseminated and scaled up. There are also efficiencies to be gained through utilising the currently largely unused potential in value addition to the estimated ~160 million tons of woody biomass currently available from standing invasive alien and encroacher vegetation across the country, and in supporting small-scale livestock farmers to maintain rehabilitated rangelands in good condition through sustainable co-management practices and selling excess livestock through enhanced market access. There is appetite within the private sector and the local SMMEs to explore these opportunities as evidenced by studies undertaken by the NBI, the SFC, Conservation South Africa and others. Equally, investors and financiers including the commercial banks do have interest in engaging with such opportunities, while being mindful of the risk profiles.
152. It is estimated that the cost of the proposed project will be US$49,507,650. Of this, the contribution from the GCF sought is US$40,104,179. The proposed project will entail co-financing of US$9,403,471. GCF intervention into this project is critical, as outlined in Section B.5 above. In the absence of GCF funding it would be impossible to implement the proposed project given the limited institutional capacity for Eco-DRR interventions in the relevant DMs combined with insufficient municipal budget for such programmes and the rising national debt of the Government of South Africa.
153. In the absence of this project, substantial loss and damage due to increased levels of flooding would be brought about in the DMs. To underscore the potential for avoided damages for Eco-DRR projects aimed at mitigating flood impact in South Africa, Wesgro noted that the estimated impact of the 2019 floods in KwaZulu Natal alone resulted in both physical loss and damage and economic losses of about US$1 billion (Wesgro, 2020). Santam, a large insurance firm in South Africa estimated these losses as high as US$3 billion (Santam, 2023). In addition, the proposed project will help minimise the knock-on effects of flooding events on the livelihoods of the rural communities who make up the majority of the populations in the target area and help spur local economic growth. For the assessment of projects in the Feasibility Study (Annex 2) the impact of flood damages on built infrastructure was estimated to be USD 21,5 million, which through the implementation of Eco-DRR interventions was reduced to approximately USD 5,4 million.
154. The efficiency of the Eco-DRR can be assessed using several Value for Money metrics. Traditionally, the GCF seeks to understand how the project under consideration compares to similar projects in the region, for which the GCF has provided funding. Accordingly, the table below sets out the total cost and GCF cost per beneficiary for the proposed project. Given the availability of data, at this stage we have assumed that the total number of direct and indirect beneficiaries can be represented by the population of the DMs as at the most recent census, which are set out in the table below.

**Table 5: Potential total project beneficiaries**

| DM | No. of direct beneficiaries | No. of indirect beneficiaries | Total per DM |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Alfred Nzo DM** | 43,628 | 892,833 | 936,461 |
| **Ehlanzeni DM** | 249,124 | 2,021,773 | 2,270,897 |
| **Ngaka Modiri Molema DM** | 3,268 | 934,455 | 937,723 |
| **Sekhukhune DM** | 70,068 | 1,266,737 | 1,336,805 |
| **TOTAL** | **366,088** | **5,115,798** | **5,481,886** |

**Table 6: Potential cost per beneficiary**

| | Cost/Beneficiary |
|---|---|
| **GCF Cost per Beneficiary (Across the Total Including Direct and Indirect)** | US$ 7.32 |
| **Total cost per Beneficiary** | US$ 9.03 |

155. These metrics demonstrate that the proposed Eco-DRR project is an efficient use of GCF funding, with a total cost to each person affected, directly or indirectly, by the project of around US$ 9. This represents an efficient use of GCF resources, given the scale of avoided damages alone (as described above) as well as the positive benefits that are likely to flow from the project, including i) contributing to the climate resilience and disaster preparedness of communities, ii) ensuring enhanced eco-system service delivery within and around the programme areas, and iii) building the capacity of communities and government to plan and implement EbA for DRR. Comparing this metric to similar projects elsewhere further highlights the efficiency of the proposed project. For example, a similar project — Improving Climate Resilience of Vulnerable Communities and Ecosystems in the Gandaki River Basin, Nepal — which also focused on ecosystem-based solutions to DRR, had an estimated total project cost of between US$ 18.4 and US$ 24.4 per beneficiary.
156. Another metric that can be used to assess the cost effectiveness of the proposed project is the project benefit-cost ratio. In the economic analysis (Annex 3), an economic cost benefit assessment was undertaken on the sites selected during feasibility within each of the four DMs. The outcomes of the analysis are shown in the table below, considering the 50$^{th}$ and 90$^{th}$ percentile climate change projection.

**Table 7: Cost-benefit outcomes (base case) – 2024 values at the 50$^{th}$ and 90$^{th}$ percentile projections**

| | Totals (50$^{th}$ percentile) | Totals (90$^{th}$ percentile) |
|---|---|---|
| Total costs of interventions (US$, million, undiscounted) | 18.75 | 18.75 |
| Net present Value (NPV) (US$, million, discounted) | 14.69 | 65.16 |
| Benefit cost ratio (BCR) | 1.94 | 5.19 |
| EIRR % | 16.89% | 49.65% |

157. At the 50th percentile, the proposed interventions and sites selected during feasibility deliver a Net Present Value (NPV) of USD 14.69 million and a Benefit-Cost Ratio (BCR) of 1.94, demonstrating that every dollar invested yields 1.94times the return. An Internal Rate of Return (IRR) of 16.89% reflects a robust and economically efficient investment that modestly exceeds typical discount rates. At the 90th percentile, the proposed interventions and sites selected during feasibility deliver a Net Present Value (NPV) of USD 65.16 million and a Benefit-Cost Ratio (BCR) of 5.19 , demonstrating that every dollar invested yields 5.19 times the return. An Internal Rate of Return (IRR) of 49.65% reflects a robust and economically efficient investment that modestly exceeds typical discount rates.
158. These metrics highlight that the proposed interventions and sites selected during feasibility remain economically viable and delivers value for money. The interventions collectively avoid damage costs of 44 million and 142 million USD (undiscounted). The provisioning of ecosystem services are the largest contributor to benefits amounting to 15 million USD (undiscounted), underscoring the value of sustainable management practices for long-term natural resource availability.
159. It is important to note that the sites and interventions assessed in the economic analysis are for the sites selected during feasibility. Due to the results from the CBA, it was recommended that the sites be expanded and built infrastructure included. As such, the sites and interventions put forward in this funding proposal have been adjusted when compared to those in the economic analysis and site finalisation will need to be undertaken during the Operationalisation Phase of the Eco-DRR project. More detailed analysis of costs and benefits will be undertaken during operationalisation once the sites and interventions have been finalised.

**Impact of GCF funding**

160. DFFE, together with DWS, has implemented several projects aimed to improve the country's water security and seeks to remove invasive species to improve the resilience of South Africa's water and biological reserve to increased climatic stresses. However, this is still not sufficient. In the past few years the country has seen a significant advancement of invasive species. In 2017, new estimates indicated that a condensed invaded (by IAPs) area of 1.50 million hectares (ha) of South Africa's landscape, will see a reduction of water flow by 1,444 million cubic metres per year, equivalent to 2.9% of the naturalised mean annual runoff. Equally, these species often block up water courses hence exacerbating the impacts of flooding.
161. Currently, R2 billion is budgeted for environmental programmes in South Africa. This number falls short by 83% of the R12 billion required to make a substantial difference[22]. The environmental programme has experienced recent

budget cut. The budget for the current financial year (2025/26) and for next financial year (2026/27) has been reduced by USD 73,5 million (Parliamentary Monitoring Group, 2024). This decrease in budget is in response to growing pressure on the South African government to invest elsewhere. There are concerns that these budgets will be further cut due to fiscal constraints. Private sector investment and partnerships in the sector continue to be limited owing to competing developmental priorities, a limited awareness of the water security risks posed by increases in climate risk and invasive plants, and constrained knowledge regarding the commercial and ecological investment opportunities that exist in various environment initiatives looking to combat climate change. This has resulted in limited or non-existent sustainable funding models and partnerships that can really leverage the work already undertake to scale of the country-wide impact so desperately needed. Hence, the urgent need to make the case for sustaining and growing investments in EbA and Eco-DRR.

162. A key outcome of this project is to develop, strengthen and implement new models with the primary outcome of upscaling the role of private sector in Eco-DRR. Considerations around partnerships with financial institutions as well as private sector will need to be carefully facilitated to achieve this. Off-take agreements will also be facilitated to ensure that both the SMME and the project is protected.

163. Government is a necessary conduit for supporting pilot projects that benefit rural isolated areas. A developmental project of this nature focused on a holistic approach to influencing various levels (micro to macro-level and across the value chain) supported by public sector funding has the ability to leverage more private sector funding. However, this will require adjustments to the enabling environment to make it more conducive for private sector engagement. The GCF funding will therefore be catalytic in developing a more financially sustainable model for EbA and the implementation of Eco-DRR. Without the GCF funding, the current situation in terms of sustainable EbA is likely to only get worse.

[22] GBVC End of term evaluation report

# E. LOGICAL FRAMEWORK

*This section refers to the project/programme's logical framework in accordance with the **GCF's Integrated Results Management Framework** to which the project/programme contributes as a whole, including in respect of any co-financing.*

## E.1. Project/Programme Focus

☐ Reduced emissions (mitigation)

☒ Increased resilience (adaptation)

## E.2. GCF Impact level: Paradigm shift potential (max 600 words, approximately 1-2 pages)

| Assessment Dimension | Current state (baseline) | | Potential target scenario (Description) | How the project/programme will contribute (Description) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Description | Rating | | |
| **Scale** | Climate induced droughts, floods, and wildfires currently negatively impact on local communities, livelihoods and local economies, particularly in rural contexts. Built infrastructure solutions that are developed to mitigate the impacts of these hazards, are often insufficient, poorly designed and with little to no integration with ecological infrastructure. Projects to date that look at integrated solutions to these hazards are few and disparate and often supported through research projects that do not look to build institutional capacity or transform governance paradigms, and most often are in cities where capacity exists. | Medium | A paradigm shift would involve less reliance on only built infrastructure solutions with municipalities recognising the value of using solutions that integrate ecological infrastructure with built infrastructure thereby developing improved and sustained resilience to climate change. The upscaling of this approach will require improved practices and methods as well as institutionalisation and capacitation at local levels. Further it will require municipalities to understand the value of Eco-DRR interventions in ensuring that existing and new infrastructure is climate resilient, with this being integrated into policy and planning instruments as well as becoming entrenched within design and development processes. Innovative financing instruments will provide catalytic support in taking Eco-DRR interventions to scale.<br>The project will reach 366 088 direct beneficiaries in communities within four DMs. With the developed capacity within local municipalities there is opportunity to realise upscaling across these municipalities with the District. | The undertaking of projects in four DMs will produce the lessons and evidence needed to inform changes to policy and planning instruments to catalyse change. The building of local capacities will assist these municipalities to expand this work into other landscapes within their areas of jurisdiction. In working with SALGA, NDMC and other sector partners the project will provide the basis for broader exchange across municipalities as well as provincial and national government departments, thereby driving the process to upscale Eco-DRR approaches and principles.<br><br>While investment packages developed under Output 3.1 will support taking these approaches to scale, knowledge products developed under Output 3.2 will provide critical learning and guidance for other DMs to adopt EbA and Eco-DRR at a larger scale. This will be further supported by the integration of Eco-DRR into national policies and municipal development plans (under Outcome 2) will create an enabling framework for long-term, countrywide adoption.<br>. |
| **Replicability** | Existing projects are generally (with some exceptions) small scale, with insufficient funding and technical support to have these approaches entrenched and sustained. In addition, the fuller environmental and economic value-chain that could be developed is also not well understood. An economy of scale can be achieved with such projects, but there is a | Medium | A paradigm shift would involve the upscaling of Eco-DRR interventions into rural districts to reduce the impacts of droughts, floods, and wildfires on these communities and their livelihoods. Municipalities with improved levels of understanding of the value-add of integrating ecological and built infrastructure will work with communities to develop climate resilient projects that use these integrated approaches. These | By working with sectoral government departments at national and local levels to address the mainstreaming of Eco-DRR approaches into policy and planning instruments the project will create a new governance and developmental understanding of the importance of these approaches. Partnership with SALGA and NDMC will ensure that these transformational shifts will be communicated effectively with municipalities, with the evidence base and knowledge products to |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | reluctance to invest if the approach appears to be unproven or there is inadequate skills and capacity within landscapes and at municipal levels to drive such projects. Policy and planning instruments and associated reporting requirements do not entrench Eco-DRR approaches. Additionally, municipal finances are under increasing levels of pressure with little being secured to reduce the risk of climate-induced hazards such as floods, wildfires and drought. | | climate smart interventions will have reduced the impacts of these hazards and improved the livelihoods of communities.<br><br>The capturing of lessons learned across the various project interventions will provide the basis for training and the exchange of knowledge products under Outcome 3. These will be supportive of improving replicability across the country. Exchanges between municipalities will be supportive of this. | support this awareness and understanding. The clarification of benefits and the financial incentives developed will assist in unlocking future projects across the country.<br><br>The project while building institutional capacity through Outcomes 1 and 2, will also capture this knowledge into knowledge products and tools under Outcome 3, that will be available to other municipalities and institutions. |
| **Sustainability** | The realisation of Government of the need to address increasing climate vulnerabilities across the country has been outlined in the various climate adaptation, environmental and DRR strategies. However, there is still much to be achieved in strengthening the policy and planning frameworks, the strategies to implement EbA and the institutional arrangements and capacity to develop and implement the sustainable Eco-DRR solutions required. Unfortunately, there are also limited financial resources available to sustainably support such initiatives. | Medium | The paradigm shift would be realised when government strategies and plans are driven by a clear and directed approach that ensures Eco-DRR interventions are a required part of all climate-smart solutions. These will become sustainable when- they are also supported by the crowding-in of private sector capital, other commercial funding, and public development finance to provide a range of financing options that will unlock future interventions.<br><br>Improvements in understanding and capacity at municipal scales will result in master planning that ensures Eco-DRR interventions are mainstreamed into DRR and management approaches, with appropriate financial resources to support these interventions.<br>The sustained support of enterprise support vehicles such as business accelerators and incubators will support the sustained development of SMME linked to ecosystem value chains.<br><br>Th establishment of communities of practice together with knowledge exchange platforms will build institutional capacity, while the development of funding options (under Outcome 3) will give the basis for a more sustainable implementation of eco-DRR approaches beyond the lifespan of the project and GCF support. | While the Eco-DRR project will work with national and provincial government and municipalities to build their capacity with regards to climate adaptation and Eco-DRR as an approach to reduce the risk of climate induced droughts, floods, and wildfires, the project will work with public and private sector partners to develop fit-for-purpose financing arrangements that can provide various blended financing options, utilising public and private sector finance, to develop sustainable project investment solutions.<br><br>The development of new institutional options for the previous work undertaken by the DFFE: Environmental Programmes will provide more sustainable institutional arrangements to support EbA. While the identification, strengthening and development of innovative financing approaches, and the design of investment packages will be instrumental in supporting follow-up projects.<br><br>The AE will strengthen the financial and institutional anchoring of the project and the Eco-DRR approaches by detailing how public and private sector engagement (under Outcome 3) will ensure long-term financing beyond GCF support. Embedding Eco-DRR into local government policies, national adaptation plans, and municipal budgeting frameworks (under Outcome 2) will ensure continuity and institutional ownership |

## E.3. GCF Outcome level: Reduced emissions and increased resilience (IRMF core indicators 1-4, quantitative indicators)

*Select appropriate IRMF core and supplementary indicators to monitor project/programme progress. More than one IRMF (core and or supplementary) indicators may be selected as applicable for each GCF results area and project/programme outcome (as defined in the table in section B.2(b)). If IRMF indicators are unable to measure any given project/programme outcomes, project/programme-specific indicators should be developed under section E.5 (project/programme specific indicators).*

| GCF Result Area | IRMF Indicator | Means of Verification (MoV) | Baseline | Target | | Assumptions / Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | Mid-term | Final[23] | |
| ARA1 Most vulnerable people and communities | Core 2: Direct and indirect beneficiaries reached | Baseline study, household surveys and questionnaires, key informant interviews, Geographic Information System (GIS) and spatial mapping, Regular project reporting and annual progress reports informed by models and hazard projections/ based on science | 0 males and 0 females reached | Direct and indirect beneficiaries with improved climate-resilient livelihoods and receiving increased protection from climate induced droughts, flooding and wildfire events:<br>Direct Total:<br>109 826<br>(M: 50 410<br>F= 59 416)<br>Indirect Total:<br>1 534 739<br>(M: 729 254<br>F: 805 485 | Direct beneficiaries with improved climate-resilient livelihoods and receiving increased protection from climate induced droughts, flooding and wildfire events:<br>Direct Total:<br>366 088<br>(M: 168 034<br>F: 198 054)<br>Indirect Total:<br>5 115 798<br>(M: 2 430 849<br>F: 2 684 949) | The GCF-funded interventions have increased resilience or reduced vulnerability in targeted communities engaged with Eco-DRR interventions. These adaptation benefits are expected to be realised within the duration of the project and into the future, linked to the improvement of both ecological and built assets.<br>For reporting during the project implementation period, a beneficiary is only counted and reported on once when a measurable adaptation benefit has been observed on the ground as an outcome. |
| | Supplementary 2.1: Beneficiaries (female/male) adopting improved and/or new climate-resilient livelihood options | Local assessments including household surveys and monitoring of community participation, noting that only beneficiaries who have received GCF-funded support and are applying improved or new livelihood options will be counted. Regular progress monitoring and annual reporting informed by spatial mapping | 0 males and females benefitting from the adoption of diversified, climate resilient livelihood options | Direct beneficiaries adopting improved, climate-resilient livelihood approaches:<br>Total = 109,826<br>(F=58,078; M = 51,748) | Direct beneficiaries adopting improved, climate-resilient livelihood approaches:<br>Total = 366,088<br>(F =193,594; M = 172,494) | Through local level intervention implementation supported by training and capacity building, local communities within the areas of implementation will directly benefit from the GCF-funded intervention and will successfully be able to establish climate resilient livelihoods. These are calculated using the number of households within the areas of implementation. Only beneficiaries who have received GCF-funded support and are applying improved or new livelihood options should be counted. |

[23] The final target means the target at the end of project/programme implementation period. However, for core indicator 1 (GHG emission reduction), please also provide the target value at the end of the total lifespan period which is defined as the maximum number of years over which the impacts of the investment are expected to be effective.

| | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Supplementary 2.4: Beneficiaries (female/male) covered by new or improved early warning systems | Baseline assessment of existing or new early warning systems that will be improved or developed, supported by household surveys and statistical information available on the population within the area to be covered by each early warning system. Where existing systems are expanded the additional population coverage will provide the additional beneficiaries.<br><br>Updated annually through progress reports informed by science of shadow of early warning systems | 0 males and females benefitting from new or improved early warning systems | Total (direct and indirect) beneficiaries receiving increased protection from new or improved early warning systems<br>Total = 1,644,566<br>(F=864,901; M= 779,665) | Total (direct and indirect) beneficiaries receiving increased protection from new or improved early warning systems<br>Total = 5,481,886<br>(F=2,883,003; M=2,598,883) | The roll out of improved early warning system and hazard avoidance protocols at DM level will impacts on the climate resilience of the populations of each DM.<br>Beneficiaries "covered" means those individuals residing within an area covered by the early warning system supported by GCF-funded interventions and can receive or have received early warning information. The population of each DM and the split of male and female beneficiaries is determined from the Census 2022 data.<br>Where one early warning system caters to more than one hazard, the beneficiary population is counted only once |
| ARA4 Ecosystems and ecosystem services | Core 2: Direct and indirect beneficiaries reached[24] | Baseline study, key informant interviews, Geographic Information System (GIS) and spatial mapping, Regular project reporting and annual progress reports | 0 males and 0 females reached | Direct and indirect beneficiaries with improved climate-resilient livelihoods and receiving increased protection from climate induced droughts, flooding and wildfire events:<br>Direct Total:<br>109 826<br>(M: 50 410<br>F= 59 416)<br>Indirect Total:<br>1 534 739<br>(M: 729 254<br>F: 805 485 | Direct and indirect beneficiaries with improved climate-resilient livelihoods and receiving increased protection from climate induced droughts, flooding and wildfire events:<br>Direct Total:<br>366 088<br>(M: 168 034<br>F: 198 054)<br>Indirect Total:<br>5 115 798<br>(M: 2 430 849<br>F: 2 684 949) | The GCF-funded interventions have increased resilience or reduced vulnerability in targeted communities engaged with Eco-DRR interventions. These adaptation benefits are expected to be realised within the duration of the project and into the future, linked to the improvement of both ecological and built assets.<br>For reporting during the project implementation period, a beneficiary is only counted and reported only once when a measurable adaptation benefit has been observed on the ground as an outcome. |
| | *Core Indicator 4 Hectares of natural resource areas* | GIS mapping of baseline areas and areas of changed management practices and/ or in land cover. Regular reporting of progress and annual assessments of implementation progress | 0 ha of natural resource areas as under improved | Interim estimated natural resource area in hectares supported to implement climate resilient management practices.<br>Total= 20,400.00 ha | Total estimated natural resource area in hectares supported to implement climate resilient management practices. | The natural resource areas in this indicator refer to those under productive use including rangelands; and shrublands and woodlands for collection of wood and non-wood forest products. |

[24] Core 2: Direct and indirect beneficiaries reached under ARA4 overlaps with Core 2: Direct and indirect beneficiaries reached under ARA1

| | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | *brought under improved low-emission and/or climate-resilient management practices* | | management practices | (assume 30% of the final target at mid-term). | Total= 68,010.29 ha | This project involves both the introduction of improved management practices and bringing the same area under protection, rehabilitation or improved ecosystems, thus the project reports this area under both this indicator and Supplementary 4.1 |
| | Supplementary 4.1: Hectares of terrestrial forest, terrestrial non-forest, freshwater and coastal marine areas brought under resoration and/or improved ecosystems | GIS mapping of baseline areas and areas of changed management practices and/ or in land cover. Regular reporting of progress and annual assessments of implementation progress | 0 ha of natural resource areas as under improved management practices | Interim estimated ecosystem area rehabilitated in hectares supported to Eco-DRR services<br>Total= 20,400.00 ha (assume 30% of the final target at mid-term). | Total estimated ecosystem area rehabilitated in hectares supported to Eco-DRR services<br>Total= 68,010.29 ha | Measures the area of natural resources that have been conserved, rehabilitated, or brought under improved ecosystem and biodiversity management practices for improving resilience to climate change.<br>Rehabilitation of ecosystems will assist the recovery of ecosystem functioning to fully deliver Eco-DRR services in support of resilience against climate change induced hazards. |

## E.4. GCF Outcome level: Enabling environment (IRMF core indicators 5-8 as applicable)

*Select at least two relevant IRMF core (enabling environment) indicators to monitor and elaborate the baseline context and project/programme's targeted outcome against the respective indicators. Rate the current state (baseline) vis-à-vis the target scenario and select the geographical scope of the outcome to be assessed. Describe how the project/programme will contribute towards the target scenario. Refer to a case example in the accompanying guidance to complete this section.*

| Core Indicator | Baseline context (description) | Rating for current state (baseline) | Target scenario (description) | How the project will contribute | Coverage |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Core Indicator 5: Degree to which GCF investments contribute to strengthening institutional and regulatory frameworks for low emission climate- | The Climate Change Act, NCCRP and the NCCAS exist with a range of environmental and water sector instruments providing direction in terms of the importance of climate adaptation and environmental security. This is supported by national, catchment and local scale | *medium* | Co-creatively working with stakeholders and communities of practice, the policy, regulatory and planning frameworks are appropriately strengthened to mainstream Eco-DRR and ecological infrastructure | The project design is built around working at various scales to develop the insights, experience, and evidence to support the necessary improvements needed in policy, regulatory and planning instruments horizontally between | *National level (one country)* |

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| resilient development pathways in a country-driven manner | plans that provide technical and operational guidance. These instruments and the institutional frameworks are in place but are poorly integrated between sectors and levels of government to produce the integrated outcomes needed to ensure climate resilience. As a result, solutions are often unidimensional without ecological and built solutions working together. | | principles and priorities into national and local environmental policies, regulations, spatial plans and supporting instruments to improve ecosystem-based approaches in support of disaster risk management at all levels. | sectors and vertically between spheres of government and society. The principles of engagement, exchange and co-creation at various levels will provide the basis for developing robust improvements in these frameworks, particularly at municipal levels (Outcome 2) and national levels (Outcome 3). Partnerships with SALGA, NDMC, DFFE and other sector actors will enable the project to ensure these improvements are mainstreamed with the appropriate political and institutional support. | |
| Core indicator 7: Degree to which GCF Investments contribute to market development/transformation at the sectoral, local, or national level | While there are numerous drivers, and a range of strategic instruments that support the development of EbA and Eco-DRR, there are also significant barriers to the upscaling of these approaches and the sustainable investment in EbA and Eco-DRR projects that will ensure climate resilience of vulnerable communities to the increasing impacts of drought, flooding and wildfires as a result of climate change. Funding of interventions to date have to a greater extent come from public sector grants with significant shortfalls in the funding needed to enable transformative change. Meanwhile, private sector financial support and the design of innovative financing instruments is nascent, requiring catalytic support to develop paradigm shifting approaches at national and local levels. | *medium* | The development of experience and evidence through local interventions will generate the datasets and natural capital accounts that reflects the goods and services provide by ecosystems and Eco-DRR interventions. This will inform improved policy and planning as well as support the design of innovative financing tools and the development of investment packages to support upscaling, with the support of both the public and private sector. | This project will work at national, district and municipal scales to build the capacity of public and private actors to invest in Eco-DRR and thereby incentivising the development of future climate change adaptation projects. The development of a knowledge base targeted towards improving financial and market investment in Eco-DRR approaches will be critical in building institutional and community capacity to ensure effective uptake of Eco-DRR principles and practices, nationally.<br>Therefore, at the community level, the project will support local market development by introducing or supporting climate-resilient livelihood options within target communities. The introduction of these sustainable livelihoods will increase market | *Multiple sub-national areas within a country* |

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| | | | | access and diversity for community members and will be supported by capacity building within communities to encourage the uptake and self-sufficient management of these livelihoods. | |
| Core indicator 8: Degree to which GCF investments contribute to effective knowledge generation and learning processes, and use of good practices, methodologies and standards | The extent that Eco-DRR approaches are integrated into local development planning (through, for example, Integrated Development Plan (IDP) processes) to realise implemented interventions is limited. This because there is poor technical understanding of climate change impacts at community level and how the use of integrated ecological and built infrastructural solutions can produce climate resilience. This is because there is limited access to appropriate baseline knowledge of climate contexts at community level and how Eco-DRR interventions can provide appropriate and adaptive response to these climate vulnerabilities. This is further exacerbated by weak understanding at political levels of the value of upscaling investments in EbA. | *medium* | Eco-DRR projects are being implemented across the country to support climate change adaptation, with associated knowledge and lessons learned being shared across interventions. Thereby, ensuring the co-creation of innovative best practice and the ongoing development and improvement of ecosystem restoration and rehabilitation standards. | The development of a credible project level social learning programme will provide a systematic approach to capturing and recording project lessons, and for communicating these in support of adaptive management and scaling. This will be underpinned by a project level reporting approach that will monitor progress as well as documents learnings and emerging insights. While these lessons will be translated into knowledge products, the hosting project level forums, working groups, think tanks and other engagement platforms to foster partnerships and further knowledge exchange will be core to the projects approach. | *Multiple sub-national areas within a country* |

## E.5. Project/programme specific indicators (project outcomes and outputs)

*This section should list out project/programme-specific performance indicators (outcomes and outputs) that are not covered in sections above (E.1-E.4). List down tailored indicators to monitor /track progress against relevant project/programme results (outcomes/outputs). AEs have the freedom to decide against which outcomes they would like to set project/programme specific indicators. If any co-benefits are identified in sections B.2(a)(b), and D.3, AEs are encouraged to add and monitor co-benefit indicators under the "**Project/programme co-benefit indicators**" section in table below. Add rows as needed.*

*Please number each outcome and output as shown below to indicate association of outputs to the contributing outcome. The numbering for outputs under this section should correspond to the output numbering in annex 4 (detailed budget plan).*

| Project /programme results (outcomes/ outputs) | Project/programme specific Indicator | Means of Verification (MoV) | Baseline | Target | | Assumptions / Note |
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| | | | | Mid-term | Final | |

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| **Outcome 1:** The incorporation of Eco-DRR strategies into integrated landscape management enhances the resilience of ecological infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities. | | | | | | |
| Output 1.1: Ecosystems are rehabilitated, maintained and sustainably managed for Eco-DRR. | Number of Eco-DRR interventions undertaken. | Field surveys and GIS mapping of changes in land cover.<br>Eco-DRR intervention design and planning reports<br>Project progress and monitoring reports and annual reports | 0 project | Total estimated area in hectares rehabilitated, maintained and sustainably managed:<br>Total = 20,403.1 ha | Total estimated area in hectares rehabilitated, maintained and sustainably managed:<br>Total = 68,010.29 ha | Local sector institutions, municipalities and traditional leadership support the implementation of Eco-DRR interventions at each intervention. Community engagement and capacitation enables Eco-DRR interventions to be implemented and maintained appropriately to mitigate the impacts of droughts, floods and wildfires. |
| | Number of community and stakeholder engagement forums/committees established | Stakeholder mapping supported by key informant interviews.<br>Meeting records<br>Project progress and monitoring reports and annual reports | 0 | 4 stakeholder engagement forums (1 per DM)<br>8 Community engagement working groups (2 per DM<br>Traditional Leader meetings held in each DM | 4 stakeholder engagement forums (1 per DM)<br>8 Community engagement working groups (2 per DM<br>Traditional Leader meetings held in each DM | Working in cooperation with local communities and traditional leadership provides the foundation for sustainable Eco-DRR interventions through community capacitation and embedding improved landscape management practices.<br>Maintenance of meeting records will be imperative to monitor attendance and progress, |
| Output 1.2: Local, gender-inclusive and sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods support | Number of SMME's[25] supported | Key informant interviews,<br>Project progress and monitoring | 0 | 4 (2 per DM ie Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni) | 8 (4 per DM ie Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni) | Support to existing or new SMMEs will be provided through the development of business cases for ecosystem based SMMEs. These will be developed as appropriate for the DM and the ecosystem-based value chains in these areas. |

[25] https://www.dsbd.gov.za/sites/default/files/legislation/national-small-busniess-amendment-act2003.pdf

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| locally led adaptation. | | reports and annual reports | | | | |
| | Number of youth supported with regards to capacity building, job creation, career development and long-term investment in their future . | Focus groups and key informant interviews, Project progress and monitoring reports and annual reports | 0 | 100 (50 per DM ie Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni) | 200 (100 per DM ie Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni) | Specific attention will be placed on supporting youth through work under the project and with local NGOs as well as through the support to develop SMMEs. Focus will be on job creation, upskilling, training and capacity building and career development linked to ecosystem-based livelihoods. Records will be maintained and will be captured in progress reports |
| | Number of females supported to develop ecosystem-based livelihoods | Surveys supported by questionnaires. Focus groups and key informant interviews, Project progress and monitoring reports and annual reports | 0 | 50 (25 per DM ie Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni) | 300(150 per DM ie Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni) | Specific attention will be placed on supporting women either through SMMEs or through other initiatives focused on the exchange of indigenous knowledge and the improvement of local practices. Records will be maintained and will be captured in progress reports |
| **Outcome 2:** The incorporation of Eco-DRR into transformative disaster preparedness and response reduces the adverse impacts of climate-induced hazards on built infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities. | | | | | | |
| Output 2.1: Local governments and communities implement improved Eco-DRR preparedness and response measures. | Change in the effectiveness of initiatives in enhancing local capacities for Eco-DRR preparedness and response measures | Baseline study followed by surveys and questionnaires. Focus groups. Training and workshop records. Regular Eco-DRR project progress reports and annual reports | Baseline to be determined at beginning of project implementation through awareness surveys and status assessments | 35% improvement in awareness from baseline | 70% improvement in awareness from baseline | Support of Ward Councillors and Traditional Leaders is ensured to facilitate improved awareness, uptake of hazard avoidance practices and overall preparedness to respond to disasters.<br>All target communities can be reached and engaged effectively, regardless of their geographical location, socio-economic status, or cultural background. |

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| | Number of hazard avoidance and disaster response drills undertaken | Records of participation Project progress and monitoring reports and annual reports | 0 | 8 drills (2 held in each of the 4 DMs) | 32 drills (8 held in each of the 4 DMs) | To support communities to effectively avoid the impacts of climate change induced hazards, hazard avoidance procedures and drills will be undertaken in each DM.<br>Records of attendance will be maintained. |
| Output 2.2: Eco-DRR is mainstreamed into national and sub-national asset risk management, environmental policy and spatial planning. | Change in national and sub-national policies and plans that incorporate Eco-DRR | Government data/ records, Project processes to support policy and plan improvements Regular Eco-DRR project progress reports and annual reports | 0 | 4 policy and/ or planning instruments (one per DM) | 10 policy and /or planning instruments and planning cycle (two planning cycles per DM, and 2 national planning instruments) | Political and strategic support of national, provincial and local government support the mainstreaming of Eco-DRR principles and practices into policy instruments and plans at national, provincial and local levels. |
| **Outcome 3:** An enabling environment is created for investment in Eco-DRR through a strengthened evidence base and improved learning and knowledge management. | | | | | | |
| Output 3.1: Financial mechanisms developed and strengthened to enhance private and public sector investments in Eco-DRR | Number of new investment packages developed | Baseline study. Review of expenditure reporting. Regular Eco-DRR project progress reports and annual reports | 0 | Financial mechanisms and investment frameworks developed | 4 investment packages developed | Private and public sector have meaningfully engaged regarding the financing environment, opportunities and risks for each business (SMME) opportunity. Potential financing models for each opportunity would have been developed providing private sector financiers with investment options that can be selected and/or adapted. |

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| | Improved public sector funding model to support rehabilitation and maintenance of ecological infrastructure | Government data/records, Regular Eco-DRR project progress reports and annual reports | Baseline review of current model | Performance review of Eco-DRR hubs | Business cases developed. | Engagement with national, provincial and local sector partners support the co-creation of new model. Support will be provided to engage with National Treasury to discuss the model and the various funding requirements (business case) and the institutional establishment route. Further support will be provided to transfer functions and staff, and to develop the first strategic business plan |
| Output 3.2: Informed decision making for Eco-DRR is supported and promoted | Improvements in levels of Natural Capital Accounting in intervention landscapes | Key informant interviews, Regular Eco-DRR project progress reports and annual reports | 0 ecosystem asset and biocarbon accounts in intervention landscapes | Ongoing collation of biophysical, social and economic data to support modelling of selected ecosystem services | Ecosystem service accounts (physical and monetary) developed. Spatially explicit biocarbon accounts developed | The data collation and management systems are improved to support the conceptual frameworks for Eco-DRR and underpin the modelling needed to develop the Natural Capital Accounts. |
| | Number of knowledge products disseminated | Website or platform analytics, Project progress reports and annual reports | 0 knowledge products disseminated | 10 knowledge products disseminated (2 per DM and 2 national) | 20 knowledge products disseminated (4 per DM and 4 national) | Agreement is reached by key partners and stakeholders on what knowledge products are required and how these need to be communicated to ensure uptake and application.<br>Knowledge products are available and accessible to all key stakeholders through online platforms. |
| | Enhanced uptake and usage of knowledge products | Website or platform analytics, surveys, key informant interviews | No uptake of knowledge products | 20% uptake amongst stakeholders | 30% uptake amongst stakeholders | Stakeholders complete surveys and engage in interviews to determine if there has been uptake.<br>Knowledge products are available and accessible to all key stakeholders through online platforms. |
| | Number of project level forums, working groups, think tanks and other engagement platforms to | Focus groups, Field observation | 0 Eco-DRR learning platforms | 6 Eco-DRR learning platforms | 6 Eco-DRR learning platforms | Key stakeholders at national, provincial and local levels understand climate risk and the need for climate resilient Eco-DRR practices to |

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| | foster partnerships and deepened learning and further knowledge exchange | visits, Records of all forums and meetings. Project progress reports and annual reports | | functional (1 per DM and 2 national) | functional (1 per DM and 2 national) | be amplified. Stakeholders are available and willing to participate, with engagement being formalised where appropriate. |
| | Number of reflective social practice capacity development modules hosted | Records of all sessions, as well as progress reports | 0 reflective social practice capacity development modules | 10 reflective social practice capacity developmen t modules | 20 reflective social practice capacity development modules | Project team and key partners work out of a reflective social practice to generate learning throughout the project. |
| | Ease of accessing information relating to assessments, ecosystem service valuations and knowledge products relating to the economic value of Eco-DRR practices. | Baseline assessment; Survey on ease of access[26], Key Informant interviews, document review | Score card: Level 0 | Score card: Level 1 | Score card: Level 3 | Traditional methods of information dissemination can be adequately fused with modern knowledge systems to enable information to be effectively distributed to rural communities without access to online systems. Targets are based on realistic expectations and desired ease of access score for the baseline, middle and end of the project. |
| **Project/programme co-benefit indicators** | | | | | | |
| Co-benefit 1 (Environmental): Increased biodiversity and ecosystem health | Number of ha of previously degraded land rehabilitated/restored representing increased suitable habitat for fauna and flora | Restoration/ rehabilitation progress monitoring report | 0 | Total= 20,400.00 ha (assume 30% of the final target at mid-term). | 68,010.29ha | Assuming that biodiversity will be strengthened by providing additional suitable habitat and increasing landscape connectivity for vulnerable species. |
| Co-benefit 2 (Social and Gender): Improved gender parity in representation of | Increase in adaptation solutions that respond to females' priorities in local planning tools or through design thinking workshops. | Focus groups, Key informant interviews, Document reviews (project reports, | Adaptation priorities in local planning tools are not differentiated by gender | A minimum of 10% of adaptation actions as per the local planning | 30 to 40% of adaptation actions as per the local planning tools responds to | The project makes considerable efforts to promote women's participation and engagement in climate resilience - including developing long-term adaptation solutions through design thinking workshops, enhancing |

[26] Ease of access scorecard for Eco-DRR information. Level 0: Considerable gaps exist in the available information base, with information siloed across different sectors and platforms and not packaged in accessible formats, limiting access the relevant information; Level 1: Platform in place to provide centralized access, but considerable information gaps still exist and information is not adequately packaged; Level 2: Platform in place to provide centralized access, with all information packaged in accessible formats tailored to specific sectors, but gaps still exist in the information base; Level 3: All relevant information is available, easily accessible and packaged in an appropriate manner. Score card survey to be developed by M&E officer.

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| females engaged in adaptation decision-making | | planning documents etc) | | tools responds to priorities expressed by females | priorities expressed by females | the capacity of women to shape local development and spatial planning. |

## E.6. Project/programme activities and deliverables

*All project activities should be listed here with a description and sub-activities. Significant deliverables should be reflected in annex 5 implementation timetable. Add rows as needed.*
*Please number the activities as shown below to indicate association of activities to the related outputs provided above in section E.5. Similarly, please number sub-activities as shown below to associate to the related activity.*

| Activities | Description | Sub-activities | Deliverables |
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| Activity 1.1.1. Establish local-level project delivery hubs, governance arrangements and capacity for implementation. | Local-level project delivery hubs, and governance arrangements are established in the two DMs (Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni) to promote cross-sectoral cooperation and collaboration which will be supported by capacity building to ensure these structures are sufficiently capacitated to manage and coordinate the interventions in each DM. | • Sub-activity 1.1.1.1. Establish and maintain local-level intervention coordination hubs and governance arrangements with dedicated programme support, building into existing structures where possible, in the Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs.<br>• Sub-activity 1.1.1.2. Establish intervention implementation support teams.<br>• Sub-activity 1.1.1.3. Review existing training material and methodologies.<br>• Sub-activity 1.1.1.4. Develop and build on existing training materials and facilitate trainings, workshops and learning exchange programmes, working with Eco-champs approach where possible.<br>• Sub-activity 1.1.1.5. Participate in reflection and learning within and between the target landscapes, as per the programme of work in Output 3.2.<br>• Sub-activity 1.1.1.6. Timeously contact the local municipal, provincial and national offices to make inquiries about obtaining environmental authorisations, consents and licences before starting any project activities. Determine the preferred application processes for obtaining these environmental authorisations, consents and licences by liaising with relevant municipal, provincial and national officials (if applicable). Allocate time for the application approval processes into project timeframes to avoid delays with commencement of the project. | • 4 X Intervention coordination hubs<br>• 4 X Stakeholder engagement forums (1 per DM for Alfred Nzo, Ehlanzeni, Ngaka Modiri Molema and Sekhukhune)<br>• 8 X Community engagement working groups (2 per DM for Alfred Nzo, Ehlanzeni, Ngaka Modiri Molema and Sekhukhune) including Traditional Leader meetings held in each DM<br>• 4 X Intervention implementation support teams<br>• 1X Report on the review of existing training material and methodologies<br>• 5 X Training materials developed<br>• 4 X Training sessions, workshops and learning exchange programmes conducted<br>• Liaising with the municipal, provincial and national structures about their preferred application processes and estimated timeframes for obtaining consents or licences to undertake project activities. |
| Activity 1.1.2. Undertake community-level engagements | An Eco-DRR vision, strategy and implementation plan are co-developed with community-level stakeholders to ensure buy-in and support as well | • Sub-activity 1.1.2.1. Working with local communities, co-develop a common vision and strategy for Eco-DRR in Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs | • Vision and strategy for 2 X targeted DMs<br>• Implementation plans for 2 X targeted DMs |

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| towards the co-development of a vision, strategy and implementation plan for improved Eco-DRR | as enabling community participation within the two targeted DMs (Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs). | • Sub-activity 1.1.2.2. Co-develop implementation plans for agreed interventions in integrated ecosystems and management plans to guide implementation. | • 2 X Management plans for Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs. |
| Activity 1.1.3. Implement collaborative rehabilitation and management programmes for ecological infrastructure to improve ecosystem condition. | Degraded ecological infrastructure is rehabilitated, maintained and sustainably managed through collaborative efforts. | • Sub-activity 1.1.3.1. Develop costed implementation plans for the agreed programme of work.<br>• Sub-activity 1.1.3.2. Rehabilitate and manage the ecological infrastructure in Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs in support of Eco-DRR.<br>• Sub-activity 1.1.3.3. Implement stewardship and collaborative community-based grazing management interventions to improve ecosystem condition and soil health in support of Eco-DRR. | • 2 X Costed implementation plans<br>• 8 X Monitoring and progress reports for ecological infrastructure rehabilitation and management in Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs<br>• 2 X Baseline reports in Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs<br>• 2 X Monitoring systems in Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs<br>• 8 X Monitoring and progress reports for rangeland improvement through stewardship and collaborative community-based grazing management interventions |
| Activity 1.1.4. Develop innovative Eco-DRR tools to support adaptive management of the site-based programme of work. | Tools and other associated instruments are developed to support monitoring, evaluation and learning while also promoting adaptive management in Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs. | • Sub-activity 1.1.4.1. Review and collate existing information on standards-based rehabilitation and restoration<br>• Sub-activity 1.1.4.2. Develop standards-based rehabilitation and restoration tools and protocols to guide implementation in Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs.<br>• Sub-activity 1.1.4.3. Develop data and information collation and management standards, protocols, and procedures.<br>• Sub-activity 1.1.4.4. Develop innovative Eco-DRR participatory citizen science tools and protocols for M&E.<br>• Sub-activity 1.1.4.5. Establish baselines and long-term monitoring systems to track restoration and rehabilitation objectives, and undertake continuous monitoring, reporting and periodic evaluation of progress, using participatory validation of progress where possible.<br>• Sub-activity 1.1.4.6. Document lessons learned to support the development of business models (for knowledge exchange under Outcome 3) | • 1 X Report on existing standards-based restoration, rehabilitation and maintenance<br>• 2 X Standards-based restoration, rehabilitation and maintenance tools developed<br>• 2 X Standards, protocols, and procedures developed for data and information collation and management<br>• 2 X Eco-DRR tools developed that focus on citizen science and protocols for M&E<br>• 1 X Baseline biophysical assessment and mapping report<br>• 8 X Annual monitoring and evaluation progress report<br>• 8 X Annual reflection and learning report for Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs<br>• 8 X Annual lessons learned report |

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| Activity 1.1.5. Protect critical assets with investments in ecological infrastructure. | Through the identification of critical municipal assets in Ngaka Modiri Molema and Sekhukhune DMs, investments in ecological infrastructure are promoted to protect these assets from climate change. | • Sub-activity 1.1.5.1. Drawing on the risk assessments that are undertaken in Output 2.2, prioritise and identify a critical municipal asset that can be protected from climate change through an investment in ecological infrastructure in the Ngaka Modiri Molema and Sekhukhune DMs.<br>• Sub-activity 1.1.5.2. Set up a memorandum of understanding (MOU) between relevant parties, outlining roles and responsibilities and budgeted maintenance arrangements.<br>• Sub-activity 1.1.5.3. Develop and implement the intervention<br>• Sub-activity 1.1.5.4. Develop a Policy Brief to support replication and scaling nationally. | • 2 X Identified municipal asset in Ngaka Modiri Molema and Sekhukhune DMs<br>• 2 X MOUs[27] between relevant parties with roles, responsibilities, budgets and maintenance arrangements<br>• 2 X Implementation report for interventions in the DMs<br>• 1 X Policy brief on replication and scaling nationally |
| Activity 1.2.1. Identify and assess opportunities to develop sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods in support of locally led adaptation. | Sustainable ecosystem-based livelihood opportunities are identified that link to adaptation in Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs. | • Sub-activity 1.2.1.1. Conduct a baseline assessment on ecosystem-based livelihoods and locally led adaptation in Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs.<br>• Sub-activity 1.2.1.2. Assess the receiving environment for the uptake of ecosystem-based livelihoods and locally led adaptation.<br>• Sub-activity 1.2.1.3. Assess market opportunities for the various commodity value chains linked to ecosystem-based livelihoods and locally led adaptation.<br>• Sub-activity 1.2.1.4. Assess opportunities to create green jobs in support of developing ecosystem-based livelihoods.<br>• Sub-activity 1.2.1.5. Assess what are the current and proposed kinds of land uses in the areas surrounding the project sites.<br>• Sub-activity 1.2.1.6. Assess if the current or proposed surrounding land uses pose any positive or negative direct, indirect or cumulative impacts to the project. Determine whether these impacts of an environmental, social or economic nature. | • 2 X Baseline assessment report in Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs<br>• 2 X Assessment report on the receiving environment, including an assessment of the current and proposed kinds of land uses in neighbouring areas and the impact of these surrounding land uses on the project<br>• 2 X Assessment report on market opportunities<br>• 2 X Assessment report on green jobs opportunities |
| Activity 1.2.2. Support the further development and/or | SMMEs are established and/or further developed with a focus on sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods. | • Sub-activity 1.2.2.1. Support the development of capacity for sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods and locally led adaptation, with a focus youth, women and people living with disabilities.<br>• Sub-activity 1.2.2.2. Review business cases for existing SMMEs, and revise/refine where necessary. | • 8 X Capacity building activities undertaken and reported.<br>• 4 X Business cases revised/refined<br>• 4 X New business cases developed<br>• 1 X Business development and mentorship programme established. |

[27] The parties involved in the MOUs, as well as roles, responsibilities and arrangements, will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase.

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| establishment of small, medium and micro enterprises (SMMEs) for sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods. | | • Sub-activity 1.2.2.3. Develop business cases for the establishment of ecosystem-based SMMEs.<br>• Sub-activity 1.2.2.4. Roll out business development and mentorship programmes to support SMME establishment and operationalisation.<br>• Sub-activity 1.2.2.5. Establish small business communities of practices and learning platforms. | • 8 X Annual report on progress of business development and mentorship programme<br>• 1 X Report on communities of practice and learning platforms established |
| Activity 2.1.1. Establish a foundation for the incorporation of Eco-DRR into transformative disaster preparedness and response in the target DMs. | Eco-DRR is incorporated into the four DMs' approaches to disaster preparedness and response | • Sub-activity 2.1.1.1. Strengthen partnerships for the dissemination of early warnings between meteorological agencies, PDMCs, DMs, LMs, traditional authorities and community structures[28].<br>• Sub-activity 2.1.1.2. Undertake a baseline assessment to determine the challenges and gaps in disseminating early warnings from the DMs to the LMs and onwards to community structures, the incorporation of Eco-DRR in disaster risk management strategies and plans and associated capacity gaps regarding disaster preparedness and avoidance. | • 8 X Annual report on partnerships strengthened and dissemination of early warnings<br>• 4 X Baseline assessment on gaps and challenges in the DMs, LMs and community structures |
| Activity 2.1.2. Develop and implement a municipal capacity and support programme towards the mainstreaming of Eco-DRR into disaster risk management strategies and plans in the four DMs. | Eco-DRR is mainstreamed into the four DMs' disaster risk management strategies and plan through the capacitation and support of municipalities. | • Sub-activity 2.1.2.1. Develop and strengthen training material on mainstreaming Eco-DRR into disaster risk management strategies and plans.<br>• Sub-activity 2.1.2.2. Develop a framework for assisting municipalities to strengthen Eco-DRR in DMs' disaster management plans.<br>• Sub-activity 2.1.2.3. Develop tools for supporting the LMs to integrate Eco-DRR in their disaster contingency plans.<br>• Sub-activity 2.1.2.4. Develop and implement a capacity building programme and continually conduct capacity building training to support relevant officials to mainstream Eco-DRR into disaster risk management strategies and plans.<br>• Sub-activity 2.1.2.5. Integrate Eco-DRR principles into existing disaster management plans. | • 4 X Training materials strengthened and/or developed<br>• 1 X Framework for strengthening of Eco-DRR in DMs' disaster management plans developed<br>• 4 X Tools developed to support LMs in integrating Eco-DRR into disaster contingency plans<br>• 1 X Eco-DRR municipal capacity building programme<br>• 8 X Annual report on implementation of capacity building programme<br>• 4 X Capacity building / training sessions conducted<br>• 1 X Report on the integration of Eco-DRR principles into existing disaster management plans |

[28] The traditional authorities and community structures will not have any managerial or decision-making authority for implementation of sub-activity 2.1.1.1. The meteorological agencies, PDMCs, DMs and LMs are government entities that are required to promote cooperative governance across sectors and departments. MOAs will be used to engage with them, and their managerial or decision-making responsibility for the implementation of any of the activities under the project will be stipulated in the MOA (which will be determined during the Operationalisation Phase).

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| Activity 2.1.3. Develop and activate innovative technologies and approaches that improve the dissemination of early warning products and messages about droughts, floods and wildfires in the four DMs. | Dissemination of early warning products relating to droughts, floods and wildfires is improved through the development of innovative approaches | • Sub-activity 2.1.3.1. Strengthen institutions and build capacity towards improving the dissemination of early warnings.<br>• Sub-activity 2.1.3.2. Develop of a suite of practices to strengthen dissemination of early warnings, including development of impact-based communication materials and messaging and establishment of effective communication channels for disseminating real-time climate and weather alerts.<br>• Sub-activity 2.1.3.3. Activate and maintain real-time alert systems and advisory services to support communities.<br>• Sub-activity 2.1.3.4. Organise simulation drills to practice evacuation routes, communication procedures and emergency response actions.<br>• Sub-activity 2.1.3.5. Develop and strengthen training material and continually conduct capacity building training on Eco-DRR including climate risk communication and emergency procedures. | • 4 X Capacity building sessions held with institutions to improve early warning dissemination<br>• 4 X Impact-based communication materials and messaging<br>• 1 X Communication channels improvement report<br>• 4 X District level real-time alert systems report<br>• 32 X Simulation drills held, monitored and reported<br>• 4 X Early warning product training materials developed<br>• 4 X Early warning capacity building / training sessions held on Eco-DRR, climate risk communication and emergency procedures |
| Activity 2.1.4. Update the Green Book | The Green Book is updated to reflect the latest data in relation to climate change vulnerability at a municipal level to inform future planning. | • Sub-activity 2.1.4.1. Update the Green Book using recently developed downscaled DM climate projection data<br>• Sub-activity 2.1.4.2. Mainstream updated Green Book results to DMs and LMs | • 1 X Updated Green Book<br>• 1 X Report on communication and mainstreaming of updated Green Book tool into municipal planning |
| Activity 2.2.1. Identify the risk of critical built infrastructure and settlements to droughts, floods and wildfires. | Priority built infrastructure and settlements are identified in the four DMs as well as their risks to droughts, floods and wildfires. | • Sub-activity 2.2.1.1. Map ecological infrastructure and the targeted built infrastructure in the four DMs.<br>• Sub-activity 2.2.1.2. Undertake a baseline assessment of existing risk management frameworks, tools and approaches for ecological and built infrastructure in the DMs.<br>• Sub-activity 2.2.1.3. Undertake risk assessments of current and planned built infrastructure within each DM, and the links between these risks and the condition of ecological infrastructure.<br>• Sub-activity 2.2.1.4. Develop costed plans for safeguarding built infrastructure from climate change, including the restoration, rehabilitation and management of ecological infrastructure, the long term maintenance costs and the risks associated with the rehabilitation objectives.<br>• Sub-activity 2.2.1.5. Identify funding sources to support the implementation of costed plans (linked to Output 3.1) | • 1 X Report detailing mapping of ecological infrastructure and targeted built infrastructure in the DMs<br>• 1 X Baseline assessment of risk management frameworks, tools and approaches<br>• 4 X Risk assessments of current and planned built infrastructure within each DM<br>• 4 X Costed plans for safeguarding built infrastructure from climate change<br>• 1 X Report on funding sources identified for implementation<br>• 1 X Report on identified intervention sites<br>• 1 X Report on advocating for the reflection of ecological infrastructure investment in DMs' infrastructure master plans and assets registers |

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| | | • Sub-activity 2.2.1.6. Identify intervention sites for implementation in Output 1.1.<br>• Sub-activity 2.2.1.7. Support processes to advocate for the reflection of ecological infrastructure investment priorities, as identified in the risk assessments, in DM infrastructure master plans and asset registers. | |
| Activity 2.2.2. Mainstream Eco-DRR and ecological infrastructure principles and priorities into national and local environmental policies, spatial plans and supporting instruments. | Eco-DRR and ecological infrastructure principles are mainstreamed in national and local planning instruments and policies to promote the integration of ecological and built infrastructure. | • Sub-activity 2.2.2.1. Conduct a baseline assessment to identify gaps in policy coherence, stakeholder capacity, cross-sectoral alignment, and institutional arrangements for integrating Eco-DRR principles into national and local plans, policies and supporting instruments, including the District Development Model. Baseline assessment to include stakeholder engagement to understand what the gaps are in existing plans and policies and implementation concerns.<br>• Sub-activity 2.2.2.2. Co-create a programme of work with key role players to build capacity and support the mainstreaming of Eco-DRR into identified national and local policies, spatial plans and supporting instruments.<br>• Sub-activity 2.2.2.3. Develop relevant tools, guidelines and knowledge products to support the mainstreaming work.<br>• Sub-activity 2.2.2.4. Facilitate the uptake of knowledge towards the integration of Eco-DRR principles into national and local plans, policies and supporting instruments nationally. | • 1 X Baseline assessment on gaps in the enabling environment preventing integration of Eco-DRR principles<br>• 4 X Stakeholder engagement<br>• 1 X Programme of work to build capacity for mainstreaming Eco-DRR into identified plans and policies<br>• 8 X Tools, guidelines and knowledge products developed<br>• 1 X Report on the uptake of knowledge towards the integration of Eco-DRR principles into national and local instruments |
| Activity 3.1.1. Assess and strengthen the policy and investment environment to support private sector engagement in Eco-DRR | Private sector engagement in Eco-DRR is enhanced through the strengthening of the policy and investment environment | • Sub-activity 3.1.1.1. Undertake an analysis of and compile an evidence base for the benefits of investing in Eco-DRR for the private sector and/or markets.<br>• Sub-activity 3.1.1.2. Conduct a comprehensive assessment of the financial sector's current integration of biodiversity and climate-related risks and opportunities.<br>• Sub-activity 3.1.1.3. Support processes to strengthen the enabling policy environment for private sector investment in the biodiversity/climate change nexus.<br>• Sub-activity 3.1.1.4. Identify and strengthen tools and frameworks that financial institutions can use to assess biodiversity and climate-related risks and opportunities. | • 1 X Analysis and evidence base report on the benefits of investing in Eco-DRR<br>• 1 X Assessment report of the financial sector's integration of biodiversity and climate-related risks and opportunities<br>• 1 X Report on processes supported to strengthen the enabling environment<br>• 4 X Tools and frameworks strengthened to assess biodiversity and climate-related risks and opportunities<br>• 4 X Biodiversity-linked financial products |

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| | | • Sub-activity 3.1.1.5. Develop biodiversity-linked financial products | |
| Activity 3.1.2. Build capacity and facilitate the exchange of knowledge for public - private sector investment in Eco-DRR. | Public private sector investment in Eco-DRR is strengthened by building capacity and facilitating knowledge exchange. | • Sub-activity 3.1.2.1. Convene a community of practice for capacity building, learning and engagement around financial mechanisms for Eco-DRR.<br>• Sub-activity 3.1.2.2. Develop a suite of guidelines, tools and knowledge products to support improved engagement and investment by the public and private sectors.<br>• Sub-activity 3.1.2.3. Develop knowledge products for informing public and private sector investment in ecological infrastructure to support DRR.<br>• Sub-activity 3.1.2.4. Build capacity in financial institutions towards integration of biodiversity and climate considerations into their planning and operations, through facilitated workshops and learning exchanges to share best practices on nature-related financial disclosures.<br>• Sub-activity 3.1.2.5. Develop and implement an Eco-DRR information dissemination campaign to catalyse private sector investment and transform public finance expenditure operational models. | • 1 X Report on community of practice convened for capacity building, learning and engagement<br>• 4 X Guidelines, tools and knowledge products for improved engagements and investments by public and private sector<br>• 4 X Knowledge products for informing public and private sector investment in ecological infrastructure to support DRR<br>• 4 X Workshops and learning exchange sessions to build capacity in financial institutions<br>• 1 X Eco-DRR information dissemination campaign<br>• 8 X Annual reports on the implementation of the Eco-DRR information dissemination campaign |
| Activity 3.1.3. Develop a portfolio of financial mechanisms and investment packages and unlock new revenue streams for Eco-DRR from private and public sector. | Investment packages are developed that support private sector in overcoming barriers in investing in Eco-DRR as well as exploring revenue streams to support Eco-DRR investments. | • Sub-activity 3.1.3.1. Implement a portfolio of financial mechanisms in identified sites that provide more comprehensive financial investments into Eco-DRR.<br>• Sub-activity 3.1.3.2. Assess and map viable funding vehicles in target landscapes to strengthen where necessary, and pair with appropriate funders.<br>• Sub-activity 3.1.3.3. Compile investment packages to attract private sector investment in Eco-DRR, including implementation plans and budget.<br>• Sub-activity 3.1.3.4. Catalyse private sector investment in large-scale EbA. | • 1 X Report on implementation of financial mechanisms in identified sites<br>• 1 X Assessment and mapping report on viable funding vehicles in target landscapes<br>• 4 X Investment packages with implementation plans and budgets to attract private sector investment in Eco-DRR<br>• 1 X Report on catalysing private sector investment in large-scale EbA |
| Activity 3.1.4. Develop a sustainable public sector employment funding model to support the rehabilitation and | Ecological infrastructure is rehabilitated and maintained by a public sector employment funding model that ensures viable and sustainable support in the long-term. | • Sub-activity 3.1.4.1. Undertake a review of the performance of the Eco-DRR hubs and an assessment of relevant South African public sector employment programmes, including challenges and lessons.<br>• Sub-activity 3.1.4.2. Develop a business case for sustainable public sector funding for the rehabilitating | • 1 X Review and assessment report on the performance of the Eco-DRR hubs and relevant South African public sector employment programmes<br>• 1 X Business case for sustainable public sector funding<br>• 1 X Report on support provided to national government partners to embed new model |

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| maintenance of ecological infrastructure. | | and maintenance of ecological infrastructure in support of the biodiversity/climate change nexus.<br>• Sub-activity 3.1.4.3. Support national government partners to embed new model for public sector funded rehabilitation and maintenance of ecological infrastructure. | |
| Activity 3.2.1. Strengthen and improve data management platforms towards supporting adaptive management and informed decision-making by policymakers and market participants. | Data collection, management and collation is strengthened to improve the understanding around how ecological infrastructure reduces the impact of disasters, promotes adaptive management and enables informed decision-making. | • Sub-activity 3.2.1.1. Develop recommendations for strengthening data management systems through the review and assessment of existing data, information, and conceptual frameworks for Eco-DRR.<br>• Sub-activity 3.2.1.2. Strengthen and improve data management platform(s) in support of Eco-DRR and other elements of the biodiversity / climate change nexus.<br>• Sub-activity 3.2.1.3. Develop protocols and standards for data collection to meet data needs and ensure consistency and quality across all project sites and ensure ongoing collation of biophysical, social and economic data to support modelling of selected ecosystem services.<br>• Sub-activity 3.2.1.4. Undertake biophysical modelling of selected ecosystem services and validate and refine using field data and stakeholder inputs.<br>• Sub-activity 3.2.1.5. Establish monitoring networks, systems and protocols to track the effectiveness of Eco-DRR measures. | • 1 X Report on recommendations for strengthening data management frameworks<br>• 1 X Report on data management platforms strengthened<br>• 2 X Protocols and standards for data collection documented<br>• 1 X Report on biophysical modelling of selected ecosystem services including field data and stakeholder inputs<br>• 1 X Monitoring networks, systems and protocols improvement guideline to monitor the effectiveness of Eco-DRR measures. |
| Activity 3.2.2. Compile spatially explicit ecosystem asset and biocarbon accounts. | Ecosystem assets and biocarbon accounts are established that are spatially explicit to support planning and investments in ecological infrastructure. | • Sub-activity 3.2.2.1. Produce ecosystem service accounts in physical terms using the SEEA Ecosystem Accounting framework.<br>• Sub-activity 3.2.2.2. Produce spatially explicit biocarbon accounts in line with the SEEA Ecosystem Accounting framework<br>• Sub-activity 3.2.2.3. Produce ecosystem service accounts for a suite of ecosystem services in monetary terms using the SEEA Ecosystem Accounting framework<br>• Sub-activity 3.2.2.4. Investigate the synergies between ecosystem asset accounts and biocarbon accounts (SEEA Ecosystem Accounting) compiled in this project and the air emission and energy accounts (SEEA Central Framework) compiled by Statistics South Africa, to enhance integrated environmental-economic analysis under the SEEA framework. | • 2 X Ecosystem service accounts in physical and monetary terms using SEEA ecosystem accounting framework<br>• 2 X Spatially explicit biocarbon accounts<br>• 1 X Report on synergies between ecosystem asset accounts and biocarbon accounts<br>• 4 X Natural Capital Accounts knowledge products synthesising lessons learned to support Eco-DRR upscaling |

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| | | • Sub-activity 3.2.2.5. Develop knowledge products, synthesise lessons and share experience and results to support rehabilitation and investment in ecological infrastructure to support Eco-DRR. | |
| Activity 3.2.3. Develop and implement a project level social learning programme in support of adaptive management and decision making. | A project level social learning programme is implemented that strengthens adaptive management and decision making in relation to Eco-DRR | • Sub-activity 3.2.3.1. Develop a systematic approach to capturing and recording project lessons, and for communicating these in support of adaptive management and scaling.<br>• Sub-activity 3.2.3.2. Undertake a programme of work that generates and captures learnings and emerging insights, including growing capacity for a reflective social practice.<br>• Sub-activity 3.2.3.3. Host and document project level forums, working groups, think tanks and other engagement platforms to foster partnerships and further knowledge exchange.<br>• Sub-activity 3.2.3.4. Produce a series of research papers and journal articles to support the Eco-DRR evidence base | • 1 X Report on systematic approach to capturing and recording project lessons<br>• 8 X Annual progress reports on implementation of the programme of work that generates and captures learnings and emerging insights<br>• 8 X Project level forums, working groups, think tanks and other engagement platforms<br>• 1 X Report on project level forums, working groups, think tanks and other engagement platforms<br>• 4 X Research papers and journal articles to support the Eco-DRR evidence base |
| Activity 3.2.4. Develop and implement a structured suite of approaches to enable access to Eco-DRR information. | Access to Eco-DRR information is facilitated and enabled through a structured suite of approaches that ensures all information related to the Eco-DRR project are readily accessible and available to stakeholders. | • Sub-activity 3.2.4.1. Develop a project level knowledge and information platform and communications strategy.<br>• Sub-activity 3.2.4.2. Develop project-based communication materials, including in local languages<br>• Sub-activity 3.2.4.3. Develop climate change education and interpretation materials.<br>• Sub-activity 3.2.4.4. Implement the strategy and develop and maintain the knowledge and information platform. | • 1 X Project level knowledge exchange and communications strategy with a post project sustainability plan<br>• 4 X Project-based communication materials in local languages<br>• 4 X Education and interpretation materials<br>• 8 X Annual progress reports on the implementation of the knowledge exchange and communications strategy<br>• 8 X Annual report on maintenance of knowledge exchange platforms |

## E.7. Monitoring, reporting and evaluation arrangements (max. 500 words, approximately 1 page)

164. Monitoring, reporting and evaluation of the Eco-DRR Project will be aligned to the requirements of GCF as detailed in the GCF master accreditation agreement as well as the following documents: 1) GCF's Integrated Results Management Framework; 2) GCF's Evaluation Policy; 3) GCF's Monitoring and Accountability Framework; 4) GCF's Restructuring and Cancellation Policy; and 5) Sustainability Policies. Further to this, reporting will also align with the implementation timetable and logical framework. This approach supports 'inwardly' focused reporting to strengthen processes and the achievement of outputs and outcomes, whilst also enabling 'outwardly' focused reporting to the GCF and other key stakeholders on the attainment of impact.
165. The reporting requirements will require the following reports to be submitted by SANBI to the GCF:
    - Inception Report
        - Submitted at the end of the 6-month Inception Phase, the Inception Report will detail the activities undertaken in this phase i.e. the establishment of the PMU and appointment of key staff, establishment of PSC, PMG and Task Teams and the development of the required governance modalities, and the development of a workplan for the Operationalisation Phase of the project, which will be approved by the project governance structures.

- Annual Performance Report
  - Submitted on an annual basis, the report will detail implementation progress in terms of activities and deliverables as per the logframe. Impact performance will also be presented including reporting on GCF and project-specific indicators. Additionally., the report will include financial performance, project budge expenditure, accredited entity fees usage, co-financing committed / disbursed and performance on environmental and social safeguards as well as the implementation of the gender action plan.
- Semi-annual financial statements (audited/un-audited)
- Interim Evaluation Report
- Project Completion Report
- Final Evaluation Report

# F. RISK ASSESSMENT AND MANAGEMENT

## F.1. Risk factors and mitigations measures (max. 3 pages)

166. The risk management approach is informed by general risk management practice and specifically the GCF Risk Guidelines (2019) with regards to risk identification, assessment, categorisation, impact evaluation and proposed mitigation measures to reduce risk impact. In addition, it must be noted that:

- No interventions will be undertaken in any jurisdiction which is subject to or affected by United Nations Security Council Resolutions
- No individual or entity that is listed on any United Nations Security Council sanctions list, including the United Nations Consolidated Sanctions list will be involved in any manner with the project or its activities, either as a counterparty, implementer, or beneficiary. Sanction screening will be conducted by the PMG (with support from the PMU) throughout project implementation to ensure that any potential sanctions exposure is identified in a timely manner
- There are no intentions to directly distribute or disburse funds to beneficiaries as support will be provided to communities through a range of in-kind technical and operational guidance and support, and businesses through support via the use of such mechanisms as accelerators, incubators, market soundings and business matching, as well as support to leverage both private and public sector finance.
- Noting the governance arrangements set out for the project, the monitoring, management and mitigation of project risks will be standard agenda items for the PSC and the PMG, such that these are monitored on a regular basis. These risks will be translated into a project risk management tool that the PSC will be accountable to maintain, supported by the inputs and reporting from the PMG.
- Over and above the risks listed hereunder, SANBI is not aware of any risks linked to foreign arbitral awards against any Executing Entity/ies in the Republic of South Africa, and this is not perceived to be a risk to the Eco-DRR project. Additionally, SANBI is not aware of any other legal issues or risk that may impact upon the project other than those listed in this due diligence report and also in the ESMF.
- The due diligence process that will be implemented for contractors will be used to manage conflict of interest. This will be done by using a Declaration of Interest (SBD 4 as per South Africa's procurement) which requires bidders to disclose any relationships or interests that could create a conflict of interest with the evaluation or adjudication of the bid. The purpose of the Declaration of Interest (SBD 4) is the following:
- Transparency and Accountability: The declaration aims to ensure transparency and accountability in the procurement process, preventing potential conflicts of interest and fostering ethical conduct.
- Combating Corruption: It helps to combat corruption and ensure that bids are awarded fairly and on merit, rather than based on personal connections or relationships.
- Ensuring Impartiality: The declaration ensures that the evaluation and adjudication of bids are conducted impartially, without any influence from personal relationships or interests.
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    - Combating Corruption: It helps to combat corruption and ensure that bids are awarded fairly and on merit, rather than based on personal connections or relationships.
    - Ensuring Impartiality: The declaration ensures that the evaluation and adjudication of bids are conducted impartially, without any influence from personal relationships or interests.
- Regarding whistle-blowing, a Whistleblowing Hotline is fully functional and is administered and managed by Advance Call: Ethics and Fraud Hotline. Advance Call reports any cases of fraud or misconduct to SANBI Management for investigation if warranted. The Whistleblowing Hotline can also be used to receive complaints regarding Environmental and/or Social Harms and Gender Discrimination. The Advance Call system allows for anonymous whistleblowing. SANBI also receives and administers formal, informal and anonymous matters from various communication mediums. This includes a dedicated internal SANBI fraud email address, administered by SANBI's Director: Governance, Risk and Compliance. The protection of Whistleblowers is included in SANBI's Fraud Prevention Policy. SANBI also maintains Hotline Registers of all reported matters reported through the hotline. SANBI's Risk Management and Fraud Prevention Committee, which is chaired by the Chief Operations Officer, adjudicates on alleged cases reported through the

whistleblowing system or other approved means. These cases are reported quarterly to the Audit and Risk Committee, which is a sub-Committee of the SANBI Board. Enterprise Risk Management Reports are presented at SANBI's Audit and Risk Committee, as per the process above. SANBI's Hotline Registers include details of the incident, progress in its resolution, status and responsible party. More details on this can be found in Annex 7: Summary of Consultations, Site Level Stakeholder Engagement Plan and Grievance Mechanism

- No project activities will be implemented in areas or jurisdictions affected by the UNSC sanctions and no individual or entity listed on any UNSC sanctions list will be involved in the project. This screening will be undertaken on a regular basis and will be overseen by the PMG, with reporting to the PSC.

**Selected Risk Factor 1: Political flux**

| Category | Probability | Impact |
|---|---|---|
| Governance | Medium | Medium |

**Description**

167. Both business and project sustainability are highly affected by a country's political environment and government policies, which are in varying levels of flux, as evident over these past decade.

**Mitigation Measure(s)**

168. The project governance structures that will be put in place for the project will need to keep abreast of national shifts in policy and strategy as well as the governance and financial frameworks to ensure ongoing alignment.

**Selected Risk Factor 2: Oversight and governance**

| Category | Probability | Impact |
|---|---|---|
| Governance | Medium | High |

**Description**

169. The oversight and management of a project of this scale that will work across national, provincial and municipal spheres of government is complex. Additionally, this large-scale project will involve many different stakeholders entering the project life cycle at different stages with different roles, responsibilities, requirements and risk-management capabilities which has the potential to create levels of inconsistency in project management approaches.

**Mitigation Measure(s)**

170. SANBI has a long and successful track record for the implementation for projects that required multi-layered project governance arrangements. In addition, DFFE has a strong track record in implementing a large number of GEF-funded projects as well as government's Expanded Public Works Programme (EPWP), including Working for Water, Working for Ecosystems, Working for Wetlands and Working on Fire. Further to the above, governance arrangements will be put in place to ensure effective oversight, monitoring and reporting of the Eco-DRR project.

**Selected Risk Factor 3: Environmental and Social Safeguards**

| Category | Probability | Impact |
|---|---|---|
| Governance | Medium | Medium |

**Description**

171. The Eco-DRR Project not adequately meeting key environmental and social safeguards indicators is a key project risk.

**Mitigation Measure(s)**

172. There is a clear need to ensure compliance to GCF's environmental and social safeguards and this is supported by the DFFE as the National Designated Authority, and SANBI as the Executing Entity (and Direct Access Entity) – both of which are guided by national legislation and policies that emphasise the importance of adhering to environmental and social safeguards. In terms of these safeguards, the interventions to be undertaken would be categorised as Category B projects. The Eco-DRR project will utilise standardised processes and guidelines that will ensure that every intervention undertaken will adhere to, and report against these safeguards and regulatory standards.

| **Selected Risk Factor 4: Foreign exchange** | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Category** | **Probability** | **Impact** |
| Forex | Low | Low |
| **Description** | | |
| 173. The nature of this application is in the form of a grant, and whilst the grant will be accessed in US Dollars, this will be translated into South African Rands (ZAR), and ZAR will be used for all projects implementation activities. Depending on the tranche arrangements for the grant – this could potentially impact the actual ZAR funds available for project's implementation by SANBI. | | |
| **Mitigation Measure(s)** | | |
| 174. The rand has consistently depreciated against the USD for the last 10 years (Barker, 2023), and as such, the use of the current exchange rate in the project's budget is believed to be a conservative approach. Any significant changes that have a material impact on the project will be reflected on together with GCF management and programmed accordingly. The Eco-DRR project, specifically SANBI through the PMU, will track, monitor and report on all finances accessed and utilised under the project, so that there is a record and accountability for every dollar of grant received. | | |

| **Selected Risk Factor 5: Compliance (AML/CFT)** | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Category** | **Probability** | **Impact** |
| ML/FT | Low | Medium |
| **Description** | | |
| 175. GCF's Policy on Prohibited Practices strongly highlights the negative impacts of fraud and corruption, not only the project's implementation, but all entities involved. Instances of fraud and other corrupt practices, as outlined in the GCF's Policy on Prohibited Practices, will undermine the project's due diligence efforts as well as negatively impact upon the reputation of the GCF, DFFE as the National Designated Authority and SANBI as the Direct Access Entity and Executing Entity as well as the creditability of the Eco-DRR project. | | |
| **Mitigation Measure(s)** | | |
| 176. DFFE, as the National Designated Authority, together with SANBI as the Direct Access Entity and the Executing Entity, will strongly adhere to all GCF protocols and reporting mechanisms. In addition, these entities are governed by South Africa's procurement policies as outlined by National Treasury. The President has recently signed into law two key Acts of Parliament, namely the General Laws (Anti-Money Laundering (AML) and Combating Terrorism Financing (CFT)) Amendment Act, 2022 and the Protection of Constitutional Democracy Against Terrorism and Related Activities Amendment Act, 2022. The South African legislation, through the Public Finance Management Act 1 of 1999 and Municipal Finance Management Act 56 of 2003, provide for regulatory oversight and procedures to counter prohibited practices. These are supported by various national and provincial level audit processes. In the development and implementation of the Eco-DRR project, the procurement processes will ensure alignment with the GCF's Policy on Prohibited Practices, as well as build upon the systemic checks and balances that are provided by DFFE and SANBI. SANBI has developed and approved its AML / CFT policy which aligns with GCF's AML and CFT principles. This policy will be complied with during project implementation.<br>177. Procurement processes undertaken have to adhere to the Public Procurement Act (Act 28 of 2024) as well as the Preferential Procurement Regulation (2022) that stem from the Preferential Procurement Policy Framework Act (2000). SANBI has a Supply Chain Management Policy (2025) that outlines the procedures and processes that must be adhered to in alignment with these legal instruments as well as the guidance materials provided by National Treasury. Strict oversight over these processes is applied. In addition, these instruments do clarify the approaches to variations, payments and processes linked to dispute and terminations.<br>178. All appointments will be supported by due diligence of the parties to be contracted, together with contractual agreements. The SANBI and governmental policies regarding these contractual agreements and the associated accountabilities clarify the approaches that the project will utilise. These together the oversight of the project governance arrangements will minimise risks of money laundering, financing of terrorism or prohibited practices.<br>179. Internal controls for the minimisation of this risk include:<br>• Due diligence assessments prior to appointment or the finalisation of any contractual arrangements.<br>• Ongoing due diligence undertaken on an annual basis for all contract holders. | | |

- Oversight and maintenance of all transaction records.
- Regularised reporting inclusive of project progress and financial status.
- Project governance structures that oversee all aspects of project management and delivery, as well as staff oversight on all project activities at various levels of implementation.
- Annual training on aspects of supply chain management, money laundering, the financing of terrorism and prohibited practices.

180. This will be a standard item on the agenda of the Eco-DRR PSC so as to monitor progress and to ensure that swift, and adaptive management actions are required to address any changes in risk level. This will include monitoring any adjustments in GCF policy as well as those of the South African government. Likewise, the Eco-DRR PMG will maintain these aspects on their regular meetings

**Selected Risk Factor 6: Sufficient co-investment to support GCF investment**

| Category | Probability | Impact |
|---|---|---|
| Other | Low | Medium |

**Description**

181. In response to the impacts of climate change on the environment and rural communities, only through the leveraging of GCF funding will the realisation of the Eco-DRR project be achieved. This will build the foundations for Eco-DRR interventions, as well as support demonstration projects where lessons can be learned to either replicate or scale up those interventions. In the development of the full funding proposal, a range of discussions with impacted stakeholders were had to inform the interventions that either build on existing work or learn from the lessons from projects already undertaken. This was done with the view to build implementation sustainability by rooting interventions in other existing projects / programmes.

**Mitigation Measure(s)**

182. The Eco-DRR project, specifically the PMU, will ensure alignment with national, provincial and local plans and objectives thereby promoting co-investment from government and other actors. Engagement with stakeholders across sectors and spheres of government will be ongoing to explore opportunities for synergies in current and planned initiatives related to Eco-DRR. In addition, the involvement of relevant government departments, NGOs and private sector in the governance arrangements will ensure that all stakeholders are kept abreast of the project as well as promoting ownership and buy-in. These governance arrangements will provide the necessary platforms for stakeholders to identify opportunities for co-investment that aligns with strategic priorities and planned programmes of work.

# GCF POLICIES AND STANDARDS

## G.1. Environmental and social risk assessment (max. 750 words, approximately 1.5 pages)

183. The environmental and social risk associated with the Eco-DRR project was evaluated in accordance with the GCF's Environmental and Social Safeguards. It is expected that the Eco-DRR project will have both minimal to no adverse impacts and some limited adverse impacts on the biophysical and socioeconomic environment. As such, overall, the Eco-DRR project can be classified as a Category B project with some elements of Category C. This categorisation is supported by the Environmental and Social Risk Assessment and associated Environmental and Social Management Framework (ESMF).
184. The proposed project will have an overall positive impact on the environment in terms of reducing flood, wildfire and drought risk, reducing these disasters' impact on transport infrastructure, enhancing the generation and dissemination of early warning information to enable early action, improving settlement planning and rehabilitating degraded lands, in the selected project regions. The environmental and social risks assessed under this project are minor and can be mitigated and/or effectively managed with the implementation of an appropriate strategy.
185. An ESMF has been developed for the project to provide a framework for managing the identified environmental and social risks and enhancing the positive aspects of the project through the project cycle (Annex 6). The ESMF contains environmental and social baseline information at the national level and provides the framework and guidelines that ensure that the Eco-DRR Project beneficiaries are committed and able to comply with GCF Environmental and Social Policies. The ESMF is developed at a project level and provides the framework within which intervention specific Environmental and Social Management Plans (ESMPs) will be prepared (where

required as guided by regulations for environmental authorisations and ESIAs). Further, the ESMF has identified the high level environmental and social mitigation measures that are presented below.

**Table 8: Impacts and mitigation measures for interventions – particularly those linked to Output 1.1**

| Potential Impacts/Risks | Possible mitigation measures |
|---|---|
| **Change in landscape and land use** | Good housekeeping and site management to reduce potential negative visual impacts and limit areas that are disturbed<br>Design of facility to be in keeping of surrounding environment |
| **Visual impact of site** | Screening of site camp visual elements<br>Good housekeeping of the site<br>Once sites are finalised during operationalisation, engagement with communities will be held to understand possible visual impact and how this can be mitigated and/or avoided. |
| **Dust** | Keep roads clean<br>Ensure vehicle speed limits onsite are kept to a minimum and below 20 km/hour<br>Maintain groundcover for as long as possible to reduce the total surface area exposed to wind<br>Wet dry and dusty areas using non-potable water<br>Cover fine material stockpiles |
| **Noise** | Limit noise levels (e.g. install and maintain silencers on machinery)<br>Comply with Occupational Health and Safety Act (No. 85 of 1993) regulations regarding noise<br>Provision of training for workers and communities involved in implementation of interventions<br>Provision of personal protective equipment |
| **Litter and waste generation** | Manage waste collection areas (weather / windproof and animal proof)<br>Daily litter collection<br>Provision of adequate bins with lids<br>Weekly disposal scheduled<br>Proper management of any hazardous wastes generated |
| **Surface, groundwater, and soil contamination** | Ensure use of best available technologies<br>Contain wastewater before correct disposal e.g. contaminated water discharged into a conservancy tank / lined area<br>Manage run-off and stormwater from intervention activities<br>Site to provide adequate sanitation facilities<br>Introduction of best available technologies to support contamination prevention. |
| **Loss of vegetation / habitat and ecological processes / biodiversity** | Undertake search and rescue before implementation commences<br>Consider establishing a no-go area and habitat / vegetation buffer around the site<br>Limit working area as far as possible where there is natural vegetation |
| **Impact on existing site operations (due to shared access road / entrance)** | Facility vehicles / staff to have right of way over other vehicles (including delivery vehicles and subcontractors)<br>Appropriate security controls in place<br>Existing facility and infrastructure to be regarded as a no-go area |
| **Labour** | Source labour force locally<br>Ensure sexual exploitation, abuse and harassment procedures and grievance redress mechanisms (GRMs) are in place and operationalised<br>Implement gender action plan recommendations<br>Comply with Occupational Health and Safety Act (No. 85 of 1993) |
| **Community / Stakeholders** | Engage with stakeholders and implement stakeholder engagement plan recommendations |
| **Community safety** | Develop community safety plan together with stakeholders. |
| **Sexual exploitation, abuse and harassment** | Undertake an intervention level due diligence of exposure to these risks and develop, implement and monitor a sexual exploitation, abuse and harassment management plan. The management plan will form part of the project specific SEAH policy and protocol, which will be in place before the start of the project, and strengthened through the Operationalisation Phase, if required. |

186. The ESMF provides a capacity building component, that integrates with the stakeholder engagement plan Annex (7). Lastly, a Grievance Redress Mechanism (GRM) has been developed for the implementation of the Eco-DRR Project. The GRM focuses on safeguarding of communities involved in projects and is required for GCF funded projects. It is also an important tool toward conflict resolution, should it occur. The project-level GRM system will be set up by the PMU by the onset of the project, and strengthened during the Operationalisation Phase through

engagement with the LMs and target site communities. The GRM will be used at all stages of the project and will provide an accessible, rapid, fair and effective response and feedback mechanism to stakeholders.

### G.2. Gender assessment and action plan (max. 500 words, approximately 1 page)

187. Women and girls in developing countries are often more vulnerable than men and boys to the impacts of climate change and have less opportunity to effect change due to pre-existing gender inequalities regarding political leadership, access to information and resources, and mobility and voice. Equally important, due to economic marginalisation, political disenfranchisement, and differentiated labour responsibilities, women face the consequences of the climate crisis first and worst, and women lack equitable representation and power in crafting climate policies to address their needs. In a rural environment, the provision of hygiene and sanitation are often considered women's tasks. Women and girls are most often the primary users, providers, and managers of water in their households and tend to have the main responsibility for household hygiene. If water and eco-system services fall into disrepair, women and girls are usually the ones forced to travel long distances over many hours to meet their families' water needs. Women and children often bear the brunt of the lack of toilets and other sanitation facilities.
188. A gender assessment was conducted during the development of the full funding proposal to understand the differential vulnerability to, and impact of, climate change on women and men in South Africa in the targeted DMs. From the findings of this assessment, and an analysis of the proposed project solution, a gender action plan was developed. The process to produce these components included a desktop review of available literature, as well as stakeholder consultations held in the four DMs. The assessment undertaken demonstrates a sound legal, regulatory and policy framework that will underpin the approach of this project to achieve gender equality in the undertakings of the district-level interventions. The key outcomes of the assessment were:
    - At national level, there is clear gender legislation, policy and legal frameworks, and there have been credible strides in reducing the gender gap in education, political empowerment and outlawing discrimination; there are areas that still need to be addressed in order for South Africa to reach gender parity. The areas of concern are high levels of gender-based violence and sexual abuse, low participation of women in economic activities, and unequal pay.
    - While gender-disaggregated data is limited at national level, there is a greater paucity of data at provincial and district levels especially regarding gender indicators on land tenure, participation in decision-making, livelihood activities, and access to credit and finance. The limited available information was generally descriptive and non-quantitative.
    - Widespread gender disparities are more pronounced in rural areas and poor communities; making them more vulnerable to the impacts of climate change, with reduced capacity, resources and/ or opportunity to adapt.
    - Within the LMs' and DMs' institutional structures, the gender disparities are also very pronounced. The assessment found that few women held senior management jobs. Although district development plans made reference to gender inclusion, they do not yet specify specific gender indicators or details on how gender equality and social inclusion are to be integrated into the plans. The integration of gender considerations is a gap that was identified, to be addressed, in institutional leadership, into the future.
    - Overall, the gender analysis concluded that the prevailing patriarchal paradigms continue to permeate decisions and programme management in project districts, and create inequalities in social relations and cultural institutions.
189. The gender action plan seeks to ensure women are empowered and enabled to meaningfully contribute to, and benefit from, project and interventions and that stakeholders' actions and project processes make considerations for the needs, interests and vulnerabilities of women. The plan includes clear targets, gender-sensitive design features and quantifiable performance indicators to promote women's participation and benefits from the project. The project-level actions of the gender action plan include:
    - Embedding gender considerations in the establishment and operationalisation of the PMU
    - Integrating gender considerations into procurement policy
    - Budgeting for gender activities
    - Ensuring gender inclusion in Eco-DRR brand development and communications strategies
    - Publishing gender-focused knowledge products
    - Strengthening institutional capacity and awareness
    - Designing a gender framework and monitoring and reporting strategies
    - Appointing a Process Manager that Fulfils the Functions of a Social and Gender Oversight Officer

- Measuring gender disaggregated outcomes
- Undertaking continuous monitoring, evaluation, and learning
- Conduct monitoring that will feed into the reporting for the Strategy Toward Gender Mainstreaming in the Environment Sector 2016 – 2021 (Extended to 2025) including reporting on contributions towards national targets around gender for the sector and national climate change space.

190. Details regarding the gender action plan for interventions can be found in Annex 8.

## G.3. Financial management and procurement (max. 500 words, approximately 1 page)

**Government Stakeholders - MOAs**

191. SANBI will be the only Executing Entity for all activities and sub-activities in the project. SANBI will enter into various MOAs with key government stakeholders to support the implementation of the project. These agreements will particularly be focused upon the interventions undertaken within the four DMs that have been identified, but will also include elements of the national level work. These agreements will outline the scope of work, institutional roles and responsibilities, timeframes, monitoring and reporting, and approval processes. Typically, this will include agreements with government stakeholders (including SALGA, SAWS, DMs, and LMs) linked to location focused interventions in terms of undertaking planning and DRR, and for work focused on ecosystem-based solutions. The task teams will play an important role in this regard by providing a tailored support arrangement in project delivery hubs where SANBI, government stakeholders and others can coordinate and implement interventions.
192. A MOA with Stats SA[29] is in the process of being developed which will support the work related to natural capital accounting, with potential collaboration with the United Nations Statistics Division. These agreements will stipulate the activities to be undertaken, the budgets that will be allocated to these, as well as timelines.
193. Therefore, within the interventions, these government stakeholders, where they are using their own funds, they will procure advisory skills, labour, and equipment following traditional procurement strategies, including compliance with supply chain management requirements that are required by law. Thus, in the instance where a municipality procures separate service providers aligned with the objectives of the intervention, then they will adhere to the stipulations of the Municipal Finance Management Act. SANBI will be responsible for reviewing and approving all procurement processes to ensure compliance with national legislation as well as GCF's requirements. Where appropriate, government stakeholders will be able to use their own procurement systems provided that these are found to be compliant with GCF's and SANBI's standards in the due diligence assessment that will be undertaken ahead of contracting.
194. All interventions will need to go through a final project preparation stage which will include the final design and preparation, before the procurement strategy is determined. The decision as to which procurement strategy to follow will be determined through this final project preparation stage. The procurement strategy followed will inform the contracting structures.

**NGOs / Catchment Convenors**

195. In accordance with SCM processes, SANBI will issue a call for Expressions of Interest for Catchment Conveners active in the relevant DMs and with the requisite capacity to lead the relevant programmes of work, after which MoAs will be negotiated to support project implementation activities.

**Service Providers**

196. SANBI will also procure service providers, that will provide technical advisory support to the project.
197. These will be competitively procured and contracted by SANBI to address specific requirements as determined by the projects management team. These contracts will set out scope of anticipated work and remuneration schedules. Service providers will only be engaged and paid when there is specific work to be done for the project. Interventions may require additional support and request assistance from SANBI. This may be provided by SANBI staff but where appropriate, service providers will be procured using SANBI's supply chain management systems.

**Accounting and Audit**

198. The project will adopt SANBI's accounting systems and will be audited independently (auditors selected through a competitive bidding process where Terms of Reference are approved by the SANBI Finance Unit) on a yearly basis.

**Equipment and improper usage**

199. The use of the SANBI's supply chain system, protocols and contractual arrangements will ensure that all equipment, materials or technology are to be used appropriately for the purpose for which they were intended or

[29] Stats SA is a government entity and not a service provider / contractor.

purchased. This system and the contractual arrangements that support procurement provide clarity as to the use, purpose and ownership of such equipment, including the return of this to SANBI upon project completion. All equipment will be registered in a project database.

## G.4. Disclosure of funding proposal

☒ No confidential information: The accredited entity confirms that the funding proposal, including its annexes, may be disclosed in full by the GCF, as no information is being provided in confidence.

☐ With confidential information: The accredited entity declares that the funding proposal, including its annexes, may not be disclosed in full by the GCF, as certain information is being provided in confidence. Accordingly, the accredited entity is providing to the Secretariat the following two copies of the funding proposal, including all annexes:

- Full copy for internal use of the GCF in which the confidential portions are marked accordingly, together with an explanatory note regarding the said portions and the corresponding reason for confidentiality under the accredited entity's disclosure policy, and
- Redacted copy for disclosure on the GCF website.
  The funding proposal can only be processed upon receipt of the two copies above, if containing confidential information.

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## H. ANNEXES

### H.1. Mandatory annexes

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| ☒ | Annex 1 | NDA no-objection letter(s) **(template provided)** |
| ☒ | Annex 2 | Feasibility study - and a market study, if applicable |
| ☒ | Annex 3 | Economic and/or financial analyses in spreadsheet format |
| ☒ | Annex 4 | Detailed budget plan **(template provided)** |
| ☒ | Annex 5 | Implementation timetable including key project/programme milestones **(template provided)** |
| ☒ | Annex 6 | E&S document corresponding to the E&S category (A, B or C; or I1, I2 or I3): **(ESS disclosure form provided)**<br>☐ Environmental and Social Impact Assessment (ESIA) or<br>☒ Environmental and Social Management Plan (ESMP) or<br>☐ Environmental and Social Management System (ESMS)<br>☐ Others (please specify – e.g. Resettlement Action Plan, Resettlement Policy Framework, Indigenous People's Plan, Land Acquisition Plan, etc.) |
| ☒ | Annex 7 | Summary of consultations and stakeholder engagement plan |
| ☒ | Annex 8 | Gender assessment and project/programme-level action plan **(template provided)** |
| ☒ | Annex 9 | Legal due diligence (regulation, taxation and insurance) |
| ☒ | Annex 10 | Procurement plan **(template provided)** |
| ☒ | Annex 11 | Monitoring and evaluation plan **(template provided)** |
| ☒ | Annex 12 | AE fee request **(template provided)** |
| ☒ | Annex 13 | Co-financing commitment letter, if applicable **(template provided)** |
| ☐ | Annex 14 | Term sheet including a detailed disbursement schedule and, if applicable, repayment schedule |

### H.2. Other annexes as applicable

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| ☐ | Annex 15 | Evidence of internal approval **(template provided)** |
| ☐ | Annex 16 | Map(s) indicating the location of proposed interventions |
| ☐ | Annex 17 | Multi-country project/programme information **(template provided)** |
| ☐ | Annex 18 | Appraisal, due diligence or evaluation report for proposals based on up-scaling or replicating a pilot project |
| ☐ | Annex 19 | Procedures for controlling procurement by third parties or executing entities undertaking projects financed by the entity |
| ☐ | Annex 20 | First level AML/CFT (KYC) assessment |
| ☒ | Annex 21 | Operations manual (Operations and maintenance) |
| ☐ | Annex 22 | Assessment of GHG emission reductions and their monitoring and reporting (for mitigation and cross cutting-projects)[30] |
| ☒ | Annex X | Other references |

** Please note that a funding proposal will be considered complete only upon receipt of all the applicable supporting documents.*

[30] Annex 22 is mandatory for mitigation and cross-cutting projects.

**No-objection letter issued by the national designated authority(ies) or focal point(s)**

forestry, fisheries & the environment

Department:
Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment
**REPUBLIC OF SOUTH AFRICA**

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The Green Climate Fund
Songdo Business District
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Incheon
**REPUBLIC OF KOREA**
22004

**Email:** fundingproposal@gcfund.org

Dear Sir/Madam

**NO-OBJECTION LETTER IN RESPECT OF THE FUNDING PROPOSAL TITLED "SCALING UP ECOSYSTEM-BASED APPROACHES TO MANAGING CLIMATE-INTENSIFIED DISASTER RISKS IN VULNERABLE REGIONS OF SOUTH AFRICA" SUBMITTED BY THE SOUTH AFRICAN NATIONAL BIODIVERSITY INSTITUTE**

The funding proposal titled "Scaling up ecosystem-based approaches to managing climate-intensified disaster risks in vulnerable regions of South Africa" in South Africa submitted by the South African National Biodiversity Institute (SANBI) to the Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment (DFFE) on 20 March 2025 (proposal) bears reference.

The undersigned is the duly authorised representative of the DFFE, the national designated authority of South Africa.

Pursuant to Green Climate Fund (GCF) Decisions B.08/10, B.37/22 and B.41/02, the content of which the DFFE acknowledges to have reviewed, in my capacity as representative of the National Designated Authority, the DFFE's no-objection to the proposal is hereby communicated.

By communicating the DFFE's no-objection, it is implied that the –

(a) Government of South Africa has no objection to the proposal; and
(b) proposal is in conformity with the national priorities, strategies and plans of South Africa.

**NO-OBJECTION LETTER IN RESPECT OF THE FUNDING PROPOSAL TITLED "SCALING UP ECOSYSTEM-BASED APPROACHES TO MANAGING CLIMATE-INTENSIFIED DISASTER RISKS IN VULNERABLE REGIONS OF SOUTH AFRICA" SUBMITTED BY THE SOUTH AFRICAN NATIONAL BIODIVERSITY INSTITUTE**

The DFFE also confirms that its national process for ascertaining no-objection to the proposal has been duly followed.

Notwithstanding the foregoing, the DFFE expects the SANBI to take the necessary measures to ensure that the project, as described in the proposal, is implemented in a manner consistent with the applicable national laws.

The DFFE acknowledges that this letter will be made publicly available on the GCF website.

Yours sincerely,

**Ms Nomfundo Tshabalala**
**DIRECTOR-GENERAL**
**DATE:01/04/2025**

## Environmental and social safeguards report form pursuant to para. 17 of the IDP

| **Basic project or programme information** | |
|---|---|
| **Project or programme title** | Scaling up ecosystem-based approaches to managing climate-intensified disaster risks in vulnerable regions of South Africa ("Eco-DRR") |
| **Existence of subproject(s) to be identified after GCF Board approval** | Yes |
| **Sector (public or private)** | Public |
| **Accredited entity** | South African National Biodiversity Institute (SANBI) |
| **Environmental and social safeguards (ESS) category** | Category B |
| **Location – specific location(s) of project or target country or location(s) of programme** | The Provinces and Districts within the Republic of South Africa, where the interventions will be implemented are:<br>• Eastern Cape Province: Alfred Nzo District, Umzimvubu and Ntabankulu Local Municipalities;<br>• Limpopo Province: Sekhukune District, Makhuduthamaga Local Municipality;<br>• Mpumalanga Province: Ehlanzeni District, Bushbuckridge Local Municipality; and<br>• North West Province: Ngaka Modiri Molema District, Ramotshere Moiloa Municipality. |
| **Environmental and Social Impact Assessment (ESIA) (if applicable)** | |
| Date of disclosure on accredited entity's website | Friday, May 23, 2025 |
| Language(s) of disclosure | English |
| Explanation on language | English is an official language of South Africa, and is the most appropriate language for a technical document of this nature. It is also widely understood in the project's target areas. |
| Link to disclosure | https://www.sanbi.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/05/Environment-and-social-framework.pdf |
| Other link(s) | Green Climate Fund Projects - SANBI (https://www.sanbi.org/biodiversity/science-into-policy-action/nie-adaptation-fund/green-climate-fund/) |
| Remarks | An ESIA consistent with the requirements for a Category B project is contained in the "Annex 6: Environmental and Social Management Framework (ESMF). |
| **Environmental and Social Management Plan (ESMP) (if applicable)** | |
| Date of disclosure on accredited entity's website | Friday, May 23, 2025 |
| Language(s) of disclosure | English |
| Explanation on language | English is an official language of South Africa, and is the most appropriate language for a technical document of this nature. It is also widely understood in the project's target areas. |
| Link to disclosure | https://www.sanbi.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/05/Environment-and-social-framework.pdf |

| | |
|---|---|
| Other link(s) | [Green Climate Fund Projects - SANBI](https://www.sanbi.org/biodiversity/science-into-policy-action/nie-adaptation-fund/green-climate-fund/) (https://www.sanbi.org/biodiversity/science-into-policy-action/nie-adaptation-fund/green-climate-fund/) |
| Remarks | An ESMP consistent with the requirements for a Category B project is contained in the "Annex 6: Environmental and Social Management Framework (ESMF). |
| **Environmental and Social Management System (ESMS) (if applicable)** | |
| Date of disclosure on accredited entity's website | N/A |
| Language(s) of disclosure | N/A |
| Explanation on language | N/A |
| Link to disclosure | N/A |
| Other link(s) | N/A |
| Remarks | N/A |
| **Any other relevant ESS reports, e.g. Resettlement Action Plan (RAP), Resettlement Policy Framework (RPF), Indigenous Peoples Plan (IPP), Indigenous Peoples Planning Framework (IPPF) (if applicable)** | |
| Description of report | N/A |
| Date of disclosure on accredited entity's website | N/A |
| Language(s) of disclosure | N/A |
| Explanation on language | N/A |
| Link to disclosure | N/A |
| Other link(s) | N/A |
| Remarks | N/A |
| **Disclosure in locations convenient to affected peoples (stakeholders)** | |
| Date | Friday, May 30, 2025 |
| Place | • Eastern Cape Province, Alfred Nzo District Municipality:<br>- Umzimvubu Local Municipality: Mt Frere Office<br>- Umzimvubu Local Municipality: Mt Ayliff Office<br>- Ntabankulu Local Municipality Office<br>• Limpopo Province:<br>- Department: Economic Development, Environment and Tourism Office<br>• Mpumalanga Province: Ehlanzeni District Municipality:<br>- Bushbuckridge Local Municipality Office<br>• North West Province:<br>- Ngaka Modiri Molema District Municipality Office |
| **Date of Board meeting in which the FP is intended to be considered** | |
| Date of accredited entity's Board meeting | N/A |
| Date of GCF's Board meeting | Monday, June 30, 2025 |

**Note: This form was prepared by the accredited entity stated above.**

# Secretariat's assessment of FP267

| | |
|---|---|
| Proposal name: | Scaling up ecosystem-based approaches to managing climate-intensified disaster risks in vulnerable regions of South Africa ("Eco-DRR") |
| Accredited entity: | South African National Biodiversity Institute (SANBI) |
| Country: | South Africa |
| Project size: | Small |

## I. Overall assessment of the Secretariat

1. The funding proposal is presented to the Board for consideration with the following remarks:

| Strengths | Points of caution |
|---|---|
| This is the first project submitted by the South African National Biodiversity Institute, as a direct access entity, to the Board for approval. The funding proposal originated through support from a Readiness and Preparatory Support Programme grant and was subsequently advanced with support from the Project Preparation Facility. | The success of the project relies on strong collaboration with multiple national, regional/subregional, and local stakeholders. However, while engaging multiple partners may introduce some complexity during project initiation, it also presents valuable opportunities for alignment and synergy. |
| The Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment of South Africa, national designated authority to GCF, closely collaborated with the South African National Biodiversity Institute to develop the project. A strong alignment with national strategies, combined with multi-level stakeholder engagement and government support ensures significant country ownership and institutional legitimacy. | |
| The "Scaling up ecosystem-based approaches to managing climate-intensified disaster risks in vulnerable regions of South Africa" (Eco-DRR project) aims to scale up ecosystem-based adaptation and ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction. It also aims to directly contribute to the targeted results of the updated Strategic Plan for the GCF 2024–2027; specifically, target 5 (T5) related to ecosystems, by enhancing the conservation, restoration, and sustainable management of approximately 68,010 ha of land. The Eco- | |

| Strengths | Points of caution |
| --- | --- |
| DRR project further aims to contribute to target 1, through its input towards South Africa's nationally determined contribution, national adaptation plan and other targets – T2, T3, T5, T9, and T10. | |
| The Eco-DRR project is a holistic project designed to actively engage communities, non-governmental organizations, government agencies, and both public and private institutions so as to strengthen the resilience of ecological infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities, while creating an enabling environment to scale up ecosystem-based adaptation and ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction. | |

2. The Board may wish to consider approving this funding proposal in accordance with the terms listed in the term sheet agreed between the Secretariat and the accredited entity (AE), and, if considered appropriate, subject to the conditions set out in annex II to document GCF/B.42/02.

# II. Summary of the Secretariat's assessment

## 2.1 Project background

3. South Africa faces significant climate-change challenges, including increased temperatures, altered rainfall patterns and more frequent extreme weather events. These changes threaten water resources, agriculture, biodiversity and livelihood. Major climate hazards, including droughts, extreme rainfall events, and wildfires, have increased significantly over the past five decades. Climate change models project that these trends will not only continue but will intensify in the future. These hazards have far-reaching impacts, causing damage to both built and ecological infrastructure. They also severely affect local livelihoods through reduced water availability for domestic and agricultural use; declining productivity of croplands and rangelands due to erosion, aridification, and soil nutrient loss; and a diminished capacity of natural ecosystems to buffer the effects of floods and droughts. Moreover, the country still faces limited coordination and capacity to implement ecosystem-based adaptation (EbA) interventions at scale and lacks adequate resources and inclusive community engagement.

4. Climate change has been further intensified by human activities such as overgrazing, the spread of invasive alien plants, soil compaction, and the loss of natural vegetation – deepening the cycle of land degradation in rural South Africa. Addressing these challenges is particularly urgent.

5. To address these challenges, EbA and ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction (Eco-DRR) offer integrated, nature-based solutions that restore and protect ecological infrastructure, while reducing climate-related risks. By enhancing ecosystem resilience, these approaches help combat land degradation, support sustainable livelihoods and strengthen community capacity. This is precisely the goal of the project, "Scaling up ecosystem-based approaches to managing climate-intensified disaster risks in vulnerable regions of South Africa" (Eco-DRR project).

6. The Eco-DRR project aims to scale up EbA and Eco-DRR approaches to manage climate-intensified disaster risks in targeted regions of South Africa. By mainstreaming these approaches, the project will strengthen the resilience of ecological infrastructure and vulnerable communities, while creating an enabling environment for replication and further scaling.

7. The total budget for the project is USD 49.51 million with USD 40.11 million from GCF in the form of a grant and USD 9.4 million co-financed by the South African National Biodiversity Institute (SANBI) and other project partners in the form of in-kind contributions. USD 24.3 million is allocated for component/outcome 1, USD 9.7 million for component/outcome 2, USD 8.7 million for component/outcome 3, and the remaining USD 6.81 million is allocated for the programme management and monitoring and evaluation component.

8. This project will directly benefit 366,088 individuals which includes 198,054 women, 54 per cent of the total beneficiaries, and 168,034 males, 46 per cent in four targeted districts. Whereas the indirect beneficiaries of 5.1 million individuals includes 2.7 million females and 2.4 million males.

9. The project directly contributes to the targeted results of the updated Strategic Plan for the GCF 2024–2027 (USP-2), particularly target 5 (T5) on ecosystems, by supporting the conservation, restoration and sustainable management of approximately 68,010 ha of land. It also aligns with T1 through its contribution to South Africa's nationally determined contribution (NDC) and national adaptation plan (NAP) or national climate change adaptation strategy. As the first project submission by SANBI to the Board, it supports T2 by aiming to increase the number of direct access entities. Additionally, it advances T3 by developing early warning tools in the selected areas and promoting locally led adaptation through the active participation of local communities and municipal governments in project origination (T9). Lastly, the project supports T10 by creating and supporting eight businesses focused on EbA.

10. To achieve the above targets and the overall ambition, the project will have three components/outcomes as below:

## 2.2 Component-by-component analysis

*Outcome 1: The incorporation of Eco-DRR strategies into integrated landscape management enhances the resilience of ecological infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities (Total cost: USD 24.3 million; GCF cost: USD 19.9 million)*

11. Outcome 1 focuses on integrating climate and disaster risk considerations into landscape management and implementing EbA and Eco-DRR measures in four district municipalities. It aims to enhance ecosystem resilience, reduce community vulnerability, promote gender-inclusive and youth-focused ecosystem-based livelihoods, and support skills development through micro, small and medium-sized enterprises (MSMEs) and the Eco-Champs– laying the groundwork for replication, upscaling, and locally led climate adaptation.

12. Under output 1.1, five major activities will be implemented to rehabilitate, maintain, and sustainably manage ecosystems through Eco-DRR interventions:

(a) Activity 1.1.1 focuses on establishing local project delivery hubs, governance structures, and implementation capacity in two target sites: Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni District Municipalities;

(b) Activity 1.1.2 involves community-level engagement to co-develop a shared vision, strategy, and implementation plan for enhanced Eco-DRR. This includes mobilizing local non-governmental organizations (NGOs) to support outreach, facilitate knowledge exchange, and strengthen community engagement;

(c) Activities 1.1.3 and 1.1.5 focus on collaborative rehabilitation, management, and protection of critical ecological infrastructure assets. These activities, led by local NGOs, will incorporate traditional knowledge, engage communities, and scale up nature-based interventions. On-the-ground efforts will include clearing invasive alien plants, restoring upper catchment landscapes, and improving rangeland management practices to reduce soil compaction, increase infiltration, and prevent erosion – ultimately improving ecosystem condition and preserving ecosystem goods and services across 68,010 ha of land; and

(d) Activity 1.1.4 will focus on developing innovative Eco-DRR tools to support adaptive management of site-based interventions. These tools will be developed in close collaboration with the Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment (DFFE), drawing on lessons from ongoing initiatives and national programmes.

13. Under Output 1.2, the project focuses on promoting local, gender-inclusive and sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods to support locally led adaptation through the following methods:

(a) Activity 1.2.1 involves identifying and assessing opportunities to develop sustainable Eco-DRR-related livelihoods, with a focus on inclusivity and community resilience;

(b) Under Activity 1.2.2, a complementary focus is placed on supporting the development and growth of MSMEs linked to ecosystem-based approaches; and

(c) For both activities, SANBI will collaborate closely with national entities such as the Department of Small Business Development, the Small Enterprise Development Agency, and the Small Enterprise Finance Agency to explore clear pathways for private sector investment and long-term sustainability.

*Outcome 2: The incorporation of Eco-DRR into transformative disaster preparedness and response reduces the adverse impacts of climate-induced hazards on built infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities (Total cost USD 9.7 million; GCF cost: USD 7.9 million)*

14. Outcome 2 focuses on building the resilience of communities and essential infrastructure to climate-related hazards in all four target district municipalities. The initiative will support the design and execution of inclusive strategies, plans, and response actions that integrate Eco-DRR principles. This activity will be led by the South African Local Government Association and the National Disaster Management Centre together with SANBI. Other collaborators such as National Business Initiative’s Technical Assistance, Mentorship and Development Programme and the Municipal Infrastructure Support Agent will also involve some of the activities under this outcome.

15. Output 2.1 focuses on four main activities to strengthen the capacity of the targeted district municipalities and local community to adopt a more proactive response to climate hazards through Eco-DRR:

(a) Activity 2.1.1 will assess the current situation, challenges and gaps providing information about the climate hazards in all four district municipalities and investigate possible solutions to improve the proper dissemination of the information;

(b) Activity 2.1.2 will develop a municipal support programme to build capacity and integrate Eco-DRR into disaster risk management plans;

(c) Activity 2.1.3 will introduce innovative tools and technologies to improve early warning dissemination and strengthen community-based systems; and

(d) Activity 2.1.4 will update the Green Book (an online planning support tool that provides quantitative evidence on the impact that climate change and urbanization will have in South Africa) with current data to support climate adaptation planning and explore mobile app access for wider use.

16. Output 2.2 focuses on mainstreaming Eco-DRR into national and subnational assess risk management, environmental policy and spatial planning through the following activities:

(a) Activity 2.2.1 assesses the vulnerability of built infrastructure and settlements to climate hazards in target district municipalities, and identifies how ecological infrastructure can reduce these risks. Support will be provided to integrate these priorities into infrastructure plans and to identify potential funding sources; and

(b) Activity 2.2.2 will mainstream Eco-DRR and ecological infrastructure into national and local policies, spatial plans and related instruments through capacity-building, policy alignment, and the development of practical tools and guidelines.

*Outcome 3: An enabling environment is created for investment in Eco-DRR through a strengthened evidence base and improved learning and knowledge management (Total cost: USD 8.7 million; GCF cost: USD 7.9 million)*

17. Under outcome 3, output 3.1 will develop financial mechanisms to strengthen and enhance private and public-sector investment in the Eco-DRR project. To achieve this goal, the following sets of activities will be carried out:

(a) Activity 3.1.1 which will assess the policy and investment landscape for private-sector engagement in Eco-DRR, and identify gaps, opportunities, and financial mechanisms that can support nature-based investments;

(b) Activity 3.1.2 will build public and private-sector capacity through a community of practice, and develop a strong business case and knowledge tools to encourage investment in Eco-DRR;

(c) Activity 3.1.3 will develop and test financial mechanisms and investment packages to unlock new funding streams for Eco-DRR, and explore the establishment of a national finance platform to sustain long-term investment; and

(d) Activity 3.1.4 will design a sustainable public-sector employment funding model to support long-term rehabilitation and maintenance of ecological infrastructure, co-developed with national government partners.

18. Under Output 3.2, the following activities will be carried out to support and promote informed decision-making for Eco-DRR:

(a) Activity 3.2.1 will assess and improve existing Eco-DRR data management systems, develop data collection protocols, and establish monitoring frameworks to support adaptive management and informed decision-making. Biophysical modelling and monitoring, evaluation, research and learning tools will also be enhanced using field data and stakeholder input;

(b) Activity 3.2.2 will compile ecosystem service and biocarbon accounts using the System of Environmental–Economic Accounting framework to support integrated environmental–economic analysis. The activity will also advance natural capital accounting to inform sustainability policies and produce knowledge products to share findings;

(c) Under Activity 3.2.3, a social learning programme will be developed to capture lessons across the project and promote adaptive management through forums, working groups and engagement platforms. SANBI will partner with academic institutions to conduct in-depth research and contribute to the Eco-DRR evidence base; and

(d) Activity 3.2.4 will develop a structured suite of tools and a communication strategy to improve access to Eco-DRR information. This will include a project-level knowledge-sharing platform aligned with the social learning process.

*Project management (Total cost: USD 4.4 million; GCF cost: USD 1.9 million) and monitoring and evaluation components (Total cost: USD 2.4 million; GCF cost: USD 2.4 million)*

19. SANBI will be the sole executing entity of the project and will conduct all the activities together with its implementing partners and collaborators. It will also retain final authority to make decisions on the implementation of the Eco-DRR project.

20. The project will be guided by three key governance structures: (i) National Adaptation Funds Advisory Body, which advises SANBI on alignment with national climate adaptation goals and GCF expectations; (ii) the Project Steering Committee, which provides oversight to ensure compliance with project deliverables and GCF requirements; and (iii) the Project Management Unit (PMU), the technical hub for implementation, supported by a Project Management Group of external experts who offer strategic and technical guidance through periodic reference group meetings.

# III. Assessment of performance against investment criteria

## 3.1 Impact potential *Scale: N/A*

21. The Eco-DRR project will directly benefit 366,088 community members from vulnerable and peri-urban communities of the local municipalities from the four selected district municipalities. Of these direct beneficiaries, 198,054 are female (54 per cent) and 168,034 male (46 per cent). The project also focuses on the 65 per cent involvement of the youth. Through project interventions, the direct beneficiaries will be able to cope with the climate change intensified hazards such as droughts, floods and wildfires. The project will also build the capacity of local communities, local municipalities, and regional and government officials to understand and enhance knowledge on the ecosystem and disaster risk management. It will also help communities to explore opportunities for livelihood through Eco-DRR management business. Also, the project will benefit 5.1 million community members indirectly, in the four targeted district municipalities. This is due to the benefits received from the improved early warning systems as well as the potential benefits provided from the development of the financing mechanism under outcome 3.

22. The project will also conserve, restore and rehabilitate 68,010 ha of land, adopting the EbA and Eco-DRR management, which is also a key priority under T4, of USP-2. Moreover, the project will also contribute to T1 of USP-2, as the project addresses South Africa’s need for the EbA and Eco-DRR management – key priorities of the country’s current NDC and NAP. It also contributes to T2 on providing support to direct access entities through the GCF Readiness and Preparatory Support Programme grant as well support from the Project Preparation Facility. Additionally, the project also supports T9 on adaptation action and T10 to support local business focused on eco based adaptation and disaster risk management.

## 3.2 Paradigm shift potential *Scale: N/A*

23. The proposed GCF project aims to generate impact beyond the four targeted sites by building a strong business case for large-scale public and private investment, along with community engagement, in restoring ecosystem functionality. This restoration will help recover vital environmental goods and services that mitigate the effects of droughts, floods and wildfires.

24. The project will demonstrate the ecological and financial value of adopting ecosystem-based management practices – such as improving rangeland conditions, enhancing soil health, boosting carbon storage, increasing rainwater infiltration, ensuring surface water availability,

and reducing wildfire risks. These benefits will be quantified using both existing data and new primary data collected from the project sites, as well as insights from similar initiatives across South Africa.

## 3.3 Sustainable development potential *Scale: N/A*

25. The project contributes to Sustainable Development Goal 5 (SDG 5) (Gender equality) and which actively promotes gender inclusion by ensuring that women are not only beneficiaries but also key participants in the project activities. With 54 per cent of the directly benefiting community members being women, the project will help address existing gender inequalities and enhance the adaptive capacity of households and communities by empowering women at the grass-roots level.

26. In line with SDG 13 (Climate action), the Eco-DRR project responds directly to the increasing frequency and severity of climate-related disasters such as droughts, floods and wildfires in South Africa. It applies EbA and Eco-DRR strategies to strengthen the resilience of ecosystems and vulnerable communities. By restoring degraded landscapes, wetlands and rangelands, the project reduces climate risks, enhances carbon sequestration and improves water security. It also builds local capacity and supports climate-smart land-management practices. These efforts contribute to national climate adaptation goals and demonstrate nature-based solutions as effective and sustainable approaches to climate action.

27. Lastly, contributing to SDG 15 (Life on land), at its core, the Eco-DRR project is about restoring and protecting ecosystems that are critical for biodiversity, soil health and ecosystem services. Activities such as alien invasive plant removal, wetland rehabilitation and sustainable grazing practices help reverse land degradation, promote revegetation, and improve habitat connectivity. These interventions support the recovery of native species, strengthen ecological resilience, and contribute to the sustainable use of terrestrial ecosystems. In doing so, the project directly supports SDG 15 by enhancing ecosystem integrity, preventing desertification, and fostering long-term biodiversity conservation.

## 3.4 Needs of the recipient *Scale: N/A*

28. South Africa faces multiple, interconnected challenges driven by climate change, environmental degradation, and socioeconomic vulnerabilities. A project like the Eco-DRR project is essential because it offers a nature-based, cost-effective, and inclusive solution to these growing risks.

29. Large areas of rangelands, wetlands and catchments have been severely degraded, reducing their ability to regulate water, store carbon and support biodiversity. At the same time, many rural communities face limited resilience to climate shocks. The Eco-DRR project responds to these needs by offering an integrated, nature-based solution that restores critical ecosystems, strengthens climate resilience, creates green jobs, and improves water and land management. It also supports national efforts to embed EbA into policies and planning, helping South Africa transition toward more sustainable and inclusive development. Also, there is a lack of coordination at the community and municipality levels, projects like Eco-DRR will help not only to build the resilience of the community but also to improve coordination and collaboration at the district municipality and community levels.

## 3.5 Country ownership *Scale: N/A*

30. The Eco-DRR project aligns closely with national and sectoral priorities, particularly in ecosystem restoration, disaster risk reduction, and climate-resilient natural resource

management. It also supports socioeconomic goals such as poverty alleviation, green job creation and rural development, and is consistent with South Africa's District Development model for integrated service delivery.

31. The project also contributes to NDC 2021 as well the country's NAP (or national climate change adaptation strategy), as it prioritizes EbA and Eco-DRR.

32. Moreover, the project was also co-created in close collaboration with DFFE, South Africa's National Designated Authority to GCF, through the support of a grant from the Readiness Programme. DFFE will oversee and guide the project acting as the advisory board, to ensure that its outcomes align to the country's need for climate adaptation. The project will also closely collaborate with various other national actors like the South African Local Government Agencies Association, National Business Initiative, Department of Small Business Development and Small Enterprise Development Agency among others. The country ownership for the project is therefore very high.

## 3.6 Efficiency and effectiveness *Scale: N/A*

33. The proposal presents a solid economic analysis to demonstrate the project's efficiency and effectiveness. The analysis covers four regions in South Africa targeted for ecosystem rehabilitation interventions, including alien vegetation clearing, gully and wetland rehabilitation, rotational grazing support, erosion control, and provisioning of ecosystem services.

34. The economic analysis applies the 50th percentile climate scenario as the base case, in line with international best practice. Under this scenario, the economic results remain positive, with a net present value of USD 14.7 million, an internal rate of return of 17 per cent, and a benefit–cost ratio of 1.94 all exceeding the 6 per cent social discount rate. These results demonstrate the overall viability of the proposed interventions from an economic perspective.

35. However, while the overall results are positive, they are largely driven by the performance of one region, Sekhukhune, which shows a disproportionately high economic return. The remaining three regions – Alfred Nzo, Ehlanzeni and Ngaka Modiri Molema – do not show positive economic returns during the project lifespan under current assumptions. This shows unevenness of investment benefits across the target sites and the allocative efficiency of the proposed funding distribution.

36. Furthermore, during the appraisal, it was identified that the economic analysis does not align with the actual intervention coverage per region, particularly in terms of hectares targeted for sediment reduction, landscape management and wetland rehabilitation. This misalignment is significant and likely affects the regional economic performance estimates. The AE confirmed this discrepancy. Based on economic analysis findings, it was recommended that the intervention sites be expanded and built infrastructure included to improve cost-effectiveness. As such, the interventions presented in the funding proposal have been adjusted from those reflected in the current economic analysis.

37. It is recommended that the AE submit an updated economic analysis once the intervention areas and scopes for each region are finalized. This follow-up analysis will be important for confirming the project's allocative efficiency and the viability of investments across all targeted sites. Moreover, the AE also confirmed that the total hectare coverage will remain unchanged, as per the targets presented in the logical framework.

38. The project is fully grant-financed, with no cost recovery or revenue-generating components. This financing modality is appropriate, considering the non-commercial nature of the benefits (e.g. ecosystem restoration, climate-resilience, and support to vulnerable communities). The adaptation cost is USD 109.5 per direct beneficiary and USD 7.3 per total

beneficiary. While South Africa is an upper-middle-income country, it faces significant macro-fiscal constraints. The debt-to-gross domestic product ratio is projected at 74 per cent in fiscal year 2023/2024, and the country is rated subinvestment grade by all three major credit rating agencies. These conditions limit the government's fiscal space and capacity to finance public adaptation projects through debt. In this context, GCF grant support is critical to enable investment in EbA without exacerbating fiscal vulnerability.

# IV. Assessment of consistency with GCF safeguards and policies

## 4.1 Environmental and social safeguards

39. **Project overview.** The project aims to enhance the resilience of ecological infrastructure and vulnerable communities by scaling up EbA and Eco-DRR approaches in four identified district municipalities covering four provinces in South Africa. The project has been structured through three outcomes: (i) Outcome 1: incorporation of Eco-DRR strategies into integrated landscape management enhances the resilience of ecological infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities; (ii) Outcome 2: incorporation of Eco-DRR into transformative disaster preparedness and response reduces the adverse impacts of climate-induced hazards on built infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities; and (iii) Outcome 3: an enabling environment is created for investment in Eco-DRR through a strengthened evidence base and improved learning and knowledge management. Physical interventions with direct environmental and social impacts and risks are expected from outputs under outcome 1 which includes invasive alien plant removal, rangeland management (rotational resting and grazing, rotational fencing, revegetation and zai pits) and wetland and riverine rehabilitation (brush packs, vegetative strips, and hard interventions such as gabions). Outcomes 2 and 3 involve capacity-building, strategy development, assessments, policy strengthening, institutional strengthening, knowledge-sharing and management where environmental and social risks are likely to be benign. Potential positive environmental and social impacts are foreseen to outweigh the adverse risks. Co-benefits include improved ecosystem services, improved groundwater retention, increased water flows, improved soil stability, reduced flooding, and reduced risk of wildfire, among others.

40. **Environmental and social risk category and safeguard instrument.** The project is categorized as B, aligned with the accreditation level of the AE. Taking into account the nature, potential scale and general location of the interventions under output 1.1, and the vulnerability of the receiving environments and communities, the project has been screened as having a mix of low and moderate environmental and social risks and impacts. Overall, the interventions are assessed to have potential limited adverse environmental and/or social risks and impacts that individually or cumulatively, are few, generally site-specific, largely reversible, and readily addressed through mitigation measures. The identified potential risks, impacts and issues are likely to have the following characteristics: (i) predictable and expected to be temporary and/or reversible; (ii) low in magnitude; (iii) site-specific, without likelihood of impacts beyond the actual footprint of the project; and (iv) low probability of serious adverse effects to human health and/or the environment. The project's risks and impacts can be easily mitigated in a predictable manner.

41. An environmental and social management framework (ESMF) has been prepared for the project which outlines a systematic approach to screen, assess, manage and mitigate potential environmental and social risks and impacts. The ESMF ensures that project interventions are carried out responsibly and sustainably, complying with legal requirements, GCF environmental and social safeguards policy and standards, and international standards. Environmental and social impact assessments with site-specific environmental and social management plans will be prepared for the interventions categorized as having moderate risks during implementation.

Environmental authorizations and water use licences will be secured, as required by national laws. Continuous screening will be undertaken during implementation to ensure that no category A interventions will be supported.

42. **Compliance with GCF environmental and social safeguards (ESS) standards**. The following paragraphs describe how the project complies with the standards.

43. **ESS 1: Assessment and management of environmental and social risks and impacts**. The project's ESMF has identified the following environmental and social risks and impacts associated with the project: (i) labour and occupational health and safety risks; (ii) pollution from the use of herbicides; (iii) community health and safety risks, including potential spread of vector-borne diseases; (iv) habitat loss and erosion from transformation or removal of vegetation; (v) loss of access to resources as the project interventions will be located on communal lands; and (vi) changes to natural water flows. The AE has identified mitigation measures in the ESMF, which will be further detailed in the environmental and social management plans, as necessary, during implementation, when the specific sites for the interventions have been identified. An exclusion list has been developed as part of the ESMF to provide guidance on interventions that will not be considered under the project. The progress of ESMF implementation, including any issues or challenges encountered during implementation, will be monitored closely by the PMU.

44. **ESS 2: Labour and working conditions**. All workers and contractors to be engaged in the project will be required to adhere to International Labour Organization, South Africa, SANBI and GCF labour-related policies and standards that promote non-discrimination and equal opportunity regarding employment. Labour requirements will be sourced locally to ensure community involvement, with training to be provided by the project, as needed. Local management procedures will be followed to promote sound worker–management relationships, enhance the development benefits by treating workers in the project fairly, and provide safe and healthy working conditions. Forced and child labour will be prohibited by the project as reflected in the exclusion list. Workers are anticipated to be exposed to occupational health and safety risks, specifically in relation to invasive alien species removal (i.e. handling of machineries), rangeland management interventions, and activities involving typical construction-related impacts and risks such as increase in noise, increase in dust, exposure to physical hazards, etc. To address these risks, the project will implement various mitigating measures, such as implementing good housekeeping practices and proper site management. Engineering and administrative controls, provision of personal protective equipment, and development of emergency procedures will be incorporated in the site-specific management plans.

45. **ESS 3: Resource efficiency and pollution prevention.** The impacts and risks are assessed to be localized and can be managed through environmentally sound methods and protocols. The project is not expected to generate significant emissions and waste materials nor consume large amounts of water or energy given the nature of interventions. Nevertheless, SANBI has identified mitigating measures in the ESMF, including solid and hazardous waste management; soil, surface and groundwater management; dust management, etc. There are moderate risks identified regarding the potential use of herbicides to support the removal of invasive alien plants. An integrated pest management approach will be adopted to ensure the strategic use of herbicides, and which will consider cultural practices and biological controls. If the use of herbicides is identified to be the most appropriate option for invasive alien plant removal, detailed assessments and corresponding management plans will be prepared prior to commencement to determine the most appropriate and safe option, taking into consideration national regulatory requirements and the lowest impact on the surrounding environment and communities. Further screening and due diligence will be undertaken during implementation to address site-specific risks and impacts.

46. **ESS 4: Community health, safety and security.** The project interventions are identified as having limited potential risks with regard to health, safety and security. The project seeks to minimize the spread of diseases through the promotion of rotational grazing which prevents the build-up of manure which attracts vectors. Safety risks regarding accessibility to intervention sites are foreseen (i.e. potential poisoning due to the use of hazardous material containers). This will be addressed through good housekeeping practices. Security and conflict at the intervention sites are assessed as unlikely. However, there is a possibility of conflict between contractors/consultants and the community at the local level. The project will actively engage communities to manage expectations and will use conflict resolution mechanisms, a grievance redress mechanism (GRM), sexual exploitation, abuse and harassment (SEAH) procedures, and gender-based approaches to support the management of such risks.

47. **ESS 5: Land acquisition and involuntary resettlement.** Project interventions will be located in communal lands where land acquisition and involuntary resettlement are not foreseen. The AE will continuously engage with communities and traditional authorities to allow for the co-development of appropriate strategies to ensure access to resources are not restricted and livelihoods are not affected during intervention implementation. Project interventions that involve land acquisition or involuntary resettlement, and interventions that permanently or temporarily result in access restrictions on resources will be excluded outright as per the exclusion list.

48. **ESS 6: Biodiversity conservation and sustainable management of living natural resources.** The project aims to improve ecosystem health through the rehabilitation, maintenance and improvement of management of natural resources. Biodiversity in the intervention sites is expected to be improved by providing additional suitable habitat and by increasing landscape connectivity for terrestrial and aquatic species. The project includes the removal of invasive alien species and will ensure that rehabilitation works will not introduce any invasive alien plants. Interventions that are assessed to have high biodiversity risks that could potentially result in irreparable damage to terrestrial, soil and aquatic biodiversity, including identified threatened species and habitats, will be excluded from project financing.

49. **ESS 8: Cultural heritage**. The proposed interventions are unlikely to be located in areas considered to have archaeological, paleontological, historical or cultural, artistic, religious values or to contain critical cultural heritage. The exclusion list to be used during further screenings will exclude outright interventions that negatively impact or harm cultural resources/areas.

50. **Implementation arrangements**. The PMU will be responsible for ensuring day-to-day compliance with the ESMF, stakeholder engagement plan, and GRM. Environment and Programme and Safeguards Officers and Social Gender Oversight Officers will be engaged to monitor, verify and inspect activities on the ground regarding ESMF and GRM implementation. Contractors, through their Designated Environmental Officers and Social and Gender Officers, will ensure implementation of mitigating measures. For the effective execution of responsibilities for environmental and social risk management, capacity-building will be provided to all relevant SANBI personnel, including PMU staff, relevant executing institution representatives, implementing departments and municipality representatives, contractors and community members.

51. **Stakeholder engagement**. Multiple stakeholder engagements with government officials (national, provincial and local levels), including traditional leaders, academia, NGOs and civil society, were undertaken while carefully considering gender and cultural aspects during the project planning process (2021–2024). The key outcomes that shaped the project include: (i) identification of priority hazards; (ii) site selection based on a consensus-driven approach; (iii) agreement on the approach to community-level engagements; (iv) alignment with past, current and planned projects assured; and (v) obtaining buy-in from key actors in the natural resource management space. The PMU will continue with the stakeholder consultations during project

implementation as detailed in the stakeholder engagement plan. Monitoring, evaluation, research and learning of stakeholder engagements will be led by the PMU, with inputs from the beneficiary communities and other relevant stakeholders to assess project impacts and effectiveness of stakeholder engagements.

52. **Grievance redress mechanism**. The AE has presented a project-level GRM; the SANBI institutional GRMs (whistleblowing hotline and environmental and/or social harms and gender discrimination complaints process); and the GCF Independent Redress Mechanism as channels for inquiries and complaints related to the project. The project-level GRM will be established in each of the targeted district municipalities through the PMU, and refined through community consultations during the project's operationalization. The GRM will not impede access to judicial or administrative remedies that may be relevant or applicable. To ensure awareness of the GRM at all levels, information on it will be disseminated through community meetings, local media, community workshops, poster distribution and local partnerships.

53. **GCF Indigenous Peoples Policy & ESS 7 (Indigenous Peoples).** The AE has undertaken an assessment against the Indigenous Peoples Policy and has confirmed that the district municipalities in the project area do not contain Indigenous Peoples.

54. **Sexual exploitation, abuse and harassment.** The revised GCF Environmental and Social Policy adopted by decision B.BM-2021/18 requires safeguarding from SEAH in GCF-financed activities. The AE provided SEAH safeguarding in its submission of the funding proposal. Potential SEAH risk factors related to rangeland management and wetland rehabilitation include an influx of contractors and workers who are mainly male into programme areas; altering power dynamics among community members and within households as women are empowered; low-income levels in the target communities; limited control of resources by women compared to men; and high levels of gender-based violence and sexual abuse at the national level. Proposed interventions will be screened using the SEAH risk screening checklist which is appended to the ESMF and an outline of an SEAH management plan is also included in the document which will be developed and implemented. Mitigation measures that will be implemented encompass SEAH training for all relevant staff and local leaders within programme areas; a code of conduct that contractors and implementing partners will be required to sign with guidelines on appropriate interactions and consequences for violations; and awareness-raising for community members. The programme will establish a GRM with confidential reporting mechanisms and safe documentation practices. Survivors will be referred to established local support services, including psychosocial support, medical assistance, legal aid and referrals to specialized service providers. The AE will also ensure access to support resources and follow-up services as needed. The institutional level GRM of the AE and the GCF Independent Redress Mechanism will also be available to receive complaints. All mechanisms will be communicated to stakeholders using a variety of methods, and SEAH prevention measures will be monitored and evaluated at the intervention level. The AE will also report to GCF through annual performance reports.

## 4.2 Gender policy

55. The AE has provided a gender assessment and action plan and therefore complies with the requirements of the updated GCF Gender Policy. The gender assessment highlights that women in the project's focal area face disproportionate vulnerability to climate-induced disasters. Structural inequalities such as limited access to land, water, and financial resources constrain women's participation in natural resource management and climate-adaptive livelihoods. Climate hazards like flooding and drought exacerbate these barriers by disrupting access to markets, healthcare, and other essential services disproportionately affecting women who are overrepresented in subsistence agriculture and caregiving roles. The lack of gender-responsive disaster early warning systems and limited decision-making power further exclude

women and marginalized groups from participating in local planning and risk management efforts. These gaps are compounded by institutional weaknesses: district municipalities lack dedicated gender budgets or action plans, and Gender Focal Points often lack authority, resources and clarity in their roles, preventing meaningful gender integration into local development and environmental planning processes.

56. The gender action plan defines activities, indicators, targets for women's participation and benefit, corresponding timelines, budget and gender expertise. The gender action plan indicates that the programme will develop a gender analysis and action plan for each subproject once they have been identified. It prioritizes capacity-building in gender mainstreaming and increases in the active inclusion of women in the planning, implementation and monitoring of Eco-DRR activities. The plan includes targets and support for women-led MSMEs, alongside skills training and access to markets and resources. To improve disaster preparedness and equitable risk communication, the plan calls for localized early warning systems designed with the needs of women in mind. Measures to prevent and address gender-based violence, including safe reporting mechanisms and training for programme implementers ensure a safer and more inclusive implementation environment. Collectively, activities under the gender action plan aim to ensure equitable benefit-sharing, strengthen women’s climate resilience, and close the gap between policy commitments and on-the-ground realities.

## 4.3 Risks

### 4.3.1. Overall programme assessment (medium risk)

57. The Secretariat considers the overall programme as medium risk.

### 4.3.2. Accredited entity/executing entity capability to execute the current programme (medium risk)

58. SANBI will serve both AE and EE for this project. No other EEs will be involved in the project implementation. The governance arrangements have been designed to clarify accountability and division of responsibility. This is the first funding proposal submitted by the AE and the Secretariat engaged with AE through Readiness and PPF. The AE has a standardised approach to the implementation of similar types of projects that includes a detailed Operationalisation Phase supported by the robust oversight and advisory mechanism.

### 4.3.3. Programme-specific execution risks (medium risk)

59. Complex implementation arrangement: The project spans multiple levels of government and partners, involving diverse stakeholders with varying roles, which complicates coordination and risks inconsistencies in deliverables if not effectively aligned. To mitigate these challenges, a robust, multi-tiered governance structure has been established, including a Project Management Group (PMG) with technical representatives from key institutions apart from PMU and PSC. A detailed inception phase will clarify operational and contractual arrangements, ensuring stakeholders understand their roles from the start. The project will also align with national cooperative governance frameworks, with regular consultations and reference group meetings to facilitate ongoing coordination, communication, and problem-solving throughout the implementation.

### 4.3.4. Compliance risk (Low risk)

60. The proposed project activities generally present lower risks of money laundering/terrorist financing (ML/TF).

61. The AE has assessed risk of ML/TF or other prohibited practices as low due to established internal controls such as counterparty due diligence conducted prior to contracting, ongoing due diligence refreshes on an annual basis, annual anti-money laundering/countering the financing of terrorism (AML/CFT) training, as well as project-specific measures such as monthly monitoring, management, and mitigation of any identified project risks.

62. On the basis of the proposed project activities and the AE's existing internal controls and mitigation measures to be implemented for this specific project, the overall compliance risk is determined to be low.

#### 4.3.5. GCF portfolio concentration risk

63. In case of approval, the impact of this proposal on the GCF concentration risk remains within the monitoring thresholds of the Risk Appetite Statement in terms of result areas, single proposal or AE concentration.

| **Summary risk assessment** | |
|---|---|
| Overall project/programme | Medium |
| Accredited entity (AE)/executing entity (EE) capability | Medium |
| Project/programme-specific execution | Medium |
| Compliance | Low |
| GCF portfolio concentration | Within the monitoring threshold |

## 4.4 Fiduciary

64. As the accredited and executing entity, SANBI retains full fiduciary responsibility for the implementation of the Eco-DRR project, it holds final decision-making authority over all project activities and sub-activities. The PMU of SANBI serves as the operational and technical hub, responsible for ensuring effective execution, strategic oversight, and alignment with GCF fiduciary standards. The PMU will also be accountable for engaging with municipal stakeholders to monitor policy shifts and maintain alignment with local development plans.

65. To strengthen fiduciary governance, the project incorporates robust oversight and advisory mechanisms, including: (i) the National Adaptation Funds Advisory Body, which advises on the project's alignment with national adaptation priorities and GCF expectations; (ii) the Project Steering Committee, which provides oversight on deliverables and compliance with GCF requirements; and (iii) the Project Management Group, a multi-institutional body of technical experts that advises on strategic and technical matters. These layered governance structures are designed to ensure transparency, accountability, and effective risk management throughout the project lifecycle.

## 4.5 Results monitoring and reporting

66. The results pathway articulated in the proposal is grounded in the theory that scaling up EbA and Eco-DRR interventions across vulnerable districts in South Africa will reduce the exposure and vulnerability of communities and ecosystems to climate-intensified hazards (i.e. floods, droughts and wildfires). The project's theory of change clearly maps how the integration of ecological infrastructure management into disaster preparedness, asset protection and landscape restoration contributes to climate resilience. The proposal also identifies the importance of inclusive governance and evidence-based policy engagement in enabling long-term systemic adaptation.

67. The project aligns with GCF results areas and indicators focusing on two GCF adaptation result areas (ARAs): ARA 1 (Most vulnerable people and communities); and ARA 4 (Ecosystems

and ecosystem services). Accordingly, the project commits to report against the following two GCF Core and Supplementary Indicators: Core Indicator 2: Direct and indirect beneficiaries reached with estimated 366,088 direct beneficiaries (168,034 male, 198,054 female) and 5,115,798 indirect beneficiaries (2,430,849 male, 2,684,949 female); Core Indicator 4: Hectares of natural resources under improved climate-resilient management practices with an estimated 68,010 ha expected to benefit from rehabilitation and/or improved ecological management. The project also includes supplementary indicator 2.4 (Beneficiaries (female/male) covered by new or improved early warning systems) and supplementary indicator 2.5 (Number of beneficiaries adopting innovations that strengthen climate change resilience (captured through Eco-DRR innovation and livelihoods adoption mechanisms)).

68. The logical framework (section E) and monitoring and evaluation plan (annex 11 to the funding proposal) present a coherent results architecture with appropriate baselines, targets, means of verification, and assumptions. The plan also includes spatial monitoring, participatory data collection mechanisms and social-learning methodologies that support adaptive management and iterative learning. Approximately USD 1.6 million is allocated to monitoring, evaluation, research and learning activities over the eight-year implementation period. The monitoring and evaluation design is robust and complies with the requirements of the GCF Integrated Results Management Framework and the GCF Evaluation Policy.

## 4.6 Legal assessment

69. The Accreditation Master Agreement was signed with the Accredited Entity on 12 July 2017 (the “AMA”), and it became effective on 31 October 2019. The Accredited Entity’s five-year accreditation term lapsed on 30 October 2024 but was extended by Decision B.37/18, paragraph (q) until the earlier of three years from the date of lapse of the five-year accreditation term or the date on which a revised accreditation framework is adopted by the Board.

70. The Accredited Entity has not provided a legal opinion/certificate confirming that it has obtained all internal approval and it has the capacity and authority to implement the project.

71. The proposed project will be implemented in the Republic of South Africa, country in which GCF is not provided with privileges and immunities. This means that, amongst other things, GCF is not protected against litigation or expropriation in this country, which risks need to be further assessed. Moreover, the ability of GCF to undertake redress activities and/or investigations in the country may be hindered due to the absence of privileges and immunities for relevant GCF personnel.

72. Therefore, it is recommended that the Board considers whether disbursements of GCF proceeds should only be made after GCF has obtained satisfactory protection against litigation and expropriation in the country, or has been provided with appropriate privileges and immunities for GCF and its personnel.

73. To address the matters raised in this section, it is recommended that any approval by the Board is made subject to the following conditions:

(a) Submission by the Accredited Entity to the Fund of a certificate or legal opinion, in form and substance satisfactory to the GCF Secretariat, within 120 days after Board approval, confirming that the Accredited Entity has obtained all final internal approvals needed by it and has the capacity and authority to implement the proposed project;

(b) Signature of the funded activity agreement in a form and substance satisfactory to the GCF Secretariat within 180 days from the date of Board approval, or the date the Accredited Entity has provided a certificate or legal opinion confirming that it has obtained all final internal approvals, whichever is later; and

(c) Completion of the legal due diligence to the satisfaction of the GCF Secretariat.

# Independent Technical Advisory Panel's assessment of FP267

| | |
|---|---|
| Proposal name: | Scaling up ecosystem-based approaches to managing climate-intensified disaster risks in vulnerable regions of South Africa ("Eco-DRR") |
| Accredited entity: | South African National Biodiversity Institute (SANBI) |
| Country: | South Africa |
| Project size: | Small |

## I. Assessment of the independent Technical Advisory Panel[1]

1. South Africa faces multiple, interconnected challenges driven by climate change, environmental degradation, and socioeconomic vulnerability. The intensity and frequency of droughts, extreme rainfall events and wildfires across the country have increased markedly over the past decades. Climate change models indicate that these trends will continue and accelerate and increasingly affect food and water security and the livelihoods of South Africans, particularly in rural and peri-urban communities.

2. The goal statement for the proposed project reads: IF ecosystem-based approaches are adopted as a strategic measure to mitigate the risks posed by climate-induced hazards such as droughts, floods and wildfires, THEN the resilience of ecological infrastructure and communities that are vulnerable to climate change will be enhanced, BECAUSE transformed landscape management, improved disaster preparedness and response, and sustainable investment in Eco-DRR will have resulted in access to the benefits of ecosystem services that protect against these hazards (see figure 1 below).

3. This adaptation-focused project contributes to GCF adaptation results area 1 (Most vulnerable people and communities) and 4 (Ecosystems and ecosystem services). The project has three anticipated interconnected outcomes:

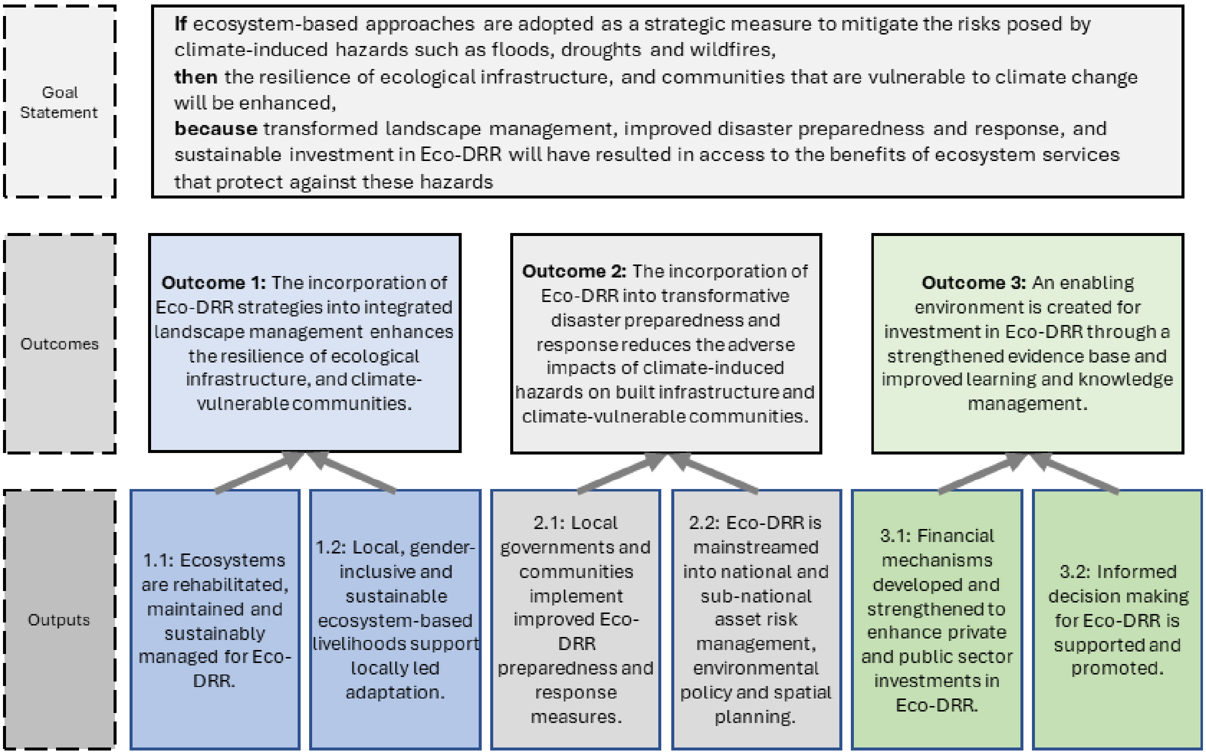
(a) Outcome 1: The incorporation of ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction strategies into integrated landscape management to enhance the resilience of ecological infrastructure and climate-vuln2erable communities;

(b) Outcome 2: The incorporation of ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction into transformative disaster preparedness and response to reduce the adverse impacts of climate-induced hazards on built infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities;

(c) Outcome 3: The creation of an enabling environment for investment in ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction through a strengthened evidence base and improved learning and knowledge management.

[1] In its assessment, the independent Technical Advisory Panel (iTAP) considered the document package as submitted on 21 April 2025, along with written responses to questions posed by iTAP and discussed in a Zoom call between iTAP, the accredited entity and the GCF Secretariat held on 13 May 2025.

**Figure 1. Scaling up ecosystem-based approaches to managing climate-intensified disaster risks in vulnerable regions of South Africa (Eco-DRR project) theory of change overview**




Source: Funding proposal, figure 1, page 5: High-level theory of change.

4. The Eco-DRR project, which requests a USD 40,104,179 grant[2] from GCF, is to be implemented over a period of eight years. In-kind co-financing is provided by three national institutions:

(a) South African National Biodiversity Institute (SANBI), contribution valued at USD 2.39 million;

(b) South African Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment (DFFE), contribution valued at USD 5.24 million; and

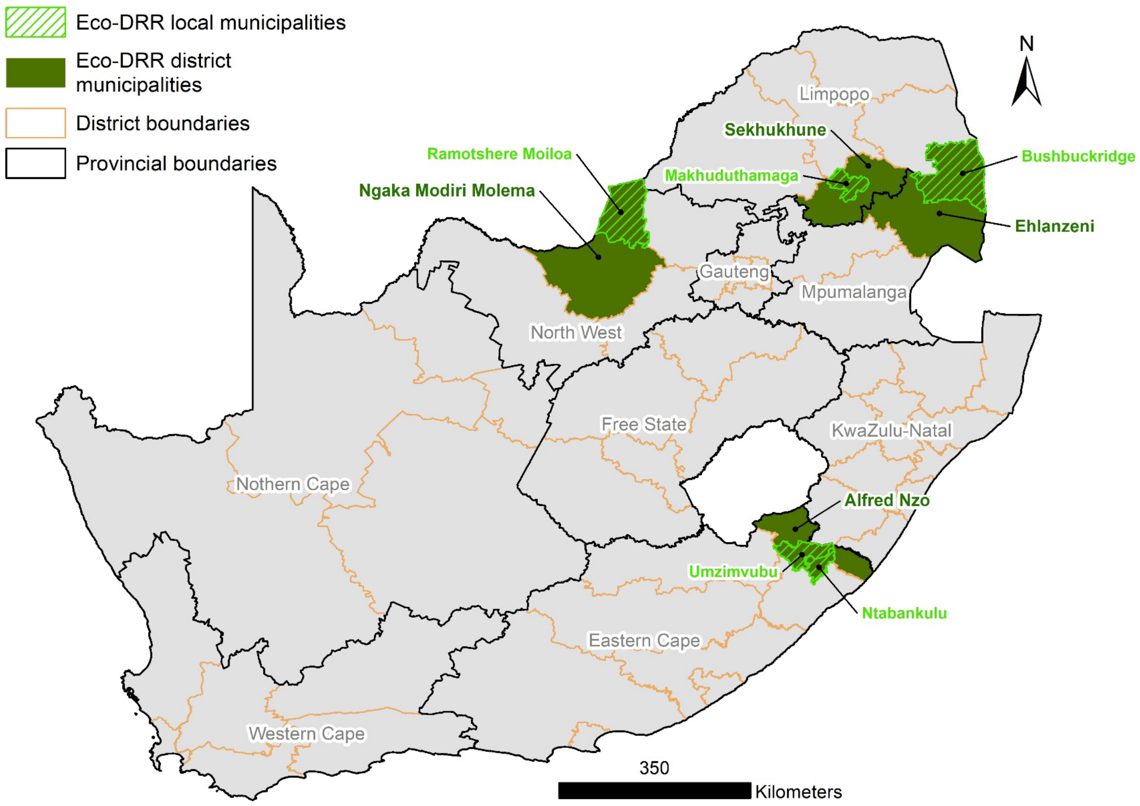
(c) South African Local Government Association (SALGA), contribution valued at USD 1.77 million.

5. SANBI, the accredited entity (AE) and direct access entity, is also the sole executing entity of the project, which will be implemented in collaboration with a range of organizations. DFFE, which is also the GCF national designated authority, plays an important role in landscape management and will implement activities under outcome 1. SALGA and the National Disaster Management Centre will lead activities relating to community resilience under outcome 2.

6. The Eco-DRR project is to be implemented in four district municipalities, namely Alfred Nzo, Ehlanzeni, Ngaka Modiri Molema and Sekhukhune (see figure 2). These were selected because of their strong climate rationale, vulnerable communities, alignment with other projects, and a supportive enabling environment at the local level.

[2] Total figure from Annex 4: Eco-DRR budget 2025.04.17. The funding proposal (correctly) rounds this to USD 40.10 million in most places, but in section A10 (page 4), it reads as USD 40.11 million.

**Figure 2. Map of South Africa showing provincial and district boundaries and Scaling up ecosystem-based approaches to managing climate-intensified disaster risks in vulnerable regions of South Africa (Eco-DRR project) intervention areas**




Source: Funding proposal, figure 4, page 13: District municipalities that form the focus of the Eco-DRR project.

## 1.1 Impact potential *Scale: Medium to high*

7. From outcome 1, communities in Alfred Nzo, Ehlanzeni, Ngaka Modiri Molema and Sekhukhune are anticipated to benefit from rehabilitated, maintained and/or sustainably managed ecosystems. Activities include invasive alien plant removal and associated biocontrol, control of bush encroachment, changes in grazing management, revegetation with indigenous species, and a combination of hard and soft erosion control measures. These activities are expected to have a positive impact on beneficiaries by reducing their exposure to the climate change-induced hazards of droughts, floods and wildfires.

8. As per Annex 22, direct beneficiaries are community members within the specific targeted project implementation sites in the four district municipalities who are better able to cope with the impacts of climate change-intensified droughts, floods, and wildfire at the close of the GCF-supported project, along with community members gaining employment through the Eco-DRR project. To calculate the number of direct beneficiaries, the number of households in the sites were identified and then multiplied by four, which represents the average household size across participating provinces. With 91,522 households identified, the resulting number of direct beneficiaries amounts to 366,088 people.

9. Indirect beneficiaries include people who are better able to cope with the impacts of climate change-intensified droughts, floods and wildfires as a result of scaling up the project

activities. This includes people benefitting from other DFFE programmes and the improved integration of ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction into settlements planning across South Africa. The estimation of indirect beneficiaries includes the number of people residing in the local municipalities where the implementation sites are located, excluding those already counted as direct beneficiaries.

10. Benefits from outcome 2, which are improved early warning systems and information dissemination methodologies, led by district municipalities in collaboration with local municipalities, should have impacts on all people living within the district municipalities' area of jurisdiction. The beneficiary calculation does not include direct beneficiaries from this kind of preparedness activity, but calculates the full population of the four district municipalities as indirect beneficiaries. This amount to 5,115,798 people, which is also the total number of indirect beneficiaries of the full Eco-DRR project.

11. As summed up in Annex 22 (table 5):

(a) Outcome 1: Protection of vulnerable groups and ecosystems from floods, droughts and wildfires by clearing invasive alien plants, improving rangeland management and conducting wetland and riverine rehabilitation (366,088 people estimated to be direct beneficiaries);

(b) Outcome 2: Protection of vulnerable groups and built infrastructure from floods, droughts and wildfires through improved disaster risk reduction preparedness and response measures, coupled with mainstreaming of ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction into policy and spatial planning (5,115,798 people estimated to be indirect beneficiaries);

(c) Outcome 3: Enhanced enabling environment by improving investment in ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction, developing finance mechanisms and promoting informed decision-making. No beneficiaries calculated. (This is appreciated by the independent Technical Advisory Panel (iTAP) since such an estimate would have had to rely on too many untraceable assumptions.)

12. Spatially, the Eco-DRR project, by employing ecosystems-based approaches, seeks to ensure that more than 68,000 hectares of land be restored or brought under improved management. Sustained ecosystem rehabilitation and management stand to augment landscape productivity by improving soil health and water infiltration and enhancing the capacity of critical ecosystems to provide goods and services that reduce the impact of extreme weather events.

13. The Eco-DRR project greatly focuses on improving land management and disaster preparedness in the selected sites and municipalities. These concerted efforts, albeit limited in scale, seem likely to be realized. The impact potential is assessed to be medium to high.

## 1.2 Paradigm shift potential *Scale: Medium*

14. The overriding purpose of the Eco-DRR project – scaling up ecosystem-based approaches to managing climate-intensified disaster risks in vulnerable regions of South Africa – is to catalyse impact beyond the one-off investment in the targeted intervention municipalities. Beyond the piloting of activities in the selected areas, allowing for any spontaneous spin-off or replication, targeted scaling efforts consist of:

(a) Output 2.2 focuses on the mainstreaming of ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction into national and subnational risk management, environmental policy and spatial planning. This includes assessing how ecological infrastructure can reduce risks to settlements and built infrastructure, and how this can be integrated into infrastructure plans and possibly funded. The idea is to mainstream ecosystem-based approaches and ecological infrastructure into national and local policies, spatial plans, and related instruments through capacity-building, policy alignment, and the development of practical tools and guidelines;

(b) Outcome 3 sets out to improve the enabling environment for investment in ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction through a strengthened evidence base and improved learning and knowledge management. Output 3.1 seeks to develop financial mechanisms to strengthen and enhance both private and public sector investment in ecosystem-based approaches. This involves assessing the policy and investment landscape for private sector engagement in ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction and identifying gaps, opportunities and financial mechanisms that can support nature-based investments;

(c) Under outcome 3, the project also seeks to co-develop, with national government partners, a public sector employment funding model to support the long-term rehabilitation and maintenance of ecological infrastructure;

(d) Knowledge management includes, for example, social learning programmes to capture lessons learned across the project and promote adaptive management through forums, working groups, and engagement platforms;

(e) SANBI will also partner with academic institutions to conduct in-depth research and contribute to the building of an evidence base on ecosystem-based approaches;

(f) Activity 2.1.4 also seeks to update the Green Book. Developed by the Council for Scientific and Industrial Research, the Green Book supports climate change adaptation in South Africa by providing an online repository of downscaled, baseline and future municipal climate risk data and insights, as well as adaptation information that can be integrated into broader settlement planning. The critical updates to be made to the content, data and information are to reflect the latest scientific advancements in climate science and adaptation, as well as updated socioeconomic data. Options for the development of a mobile app to make this data and information more accessible will be explored.

15. The iTAP notes that a substantial share of the requested GCF grant is allocated towards capacity-building for local communities, municipal authorities, and regional officials in ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction. While such efforts can yield important enabling outcomes, their effectiveness hinges on a credible path to upscaling and sustainability. In the absence of concrete follow-on financing or implementation plans, there is a material risk that the programme will generate useful knowledge and plans, but without the means to translate them into tangible, climate-resilient infrastructure or services.

16. SANBI is engaged in environment and climate policymaking in South Africa, but the present project is not specifically targeting the country's policies or regulatory environment. It was explained in the question-and-answer session that the policy environment is generally favourable to ecosystem and nature-based approaches; it is the capacities and financing that is lacking. Hence, the project seeks to scale ecosystem-based approaches approach implemented at the local level in the selected municipalities, essentially by generating sufficient evidence about its effectiveness.

17. As explained in the funding proposal (page 35), "The actual methods to be used for landscape rehabilitation and maintenance to reduce the risk ecosystem degradation will be based on approaches used for the past 25 years through the DFFE" as well as on international best practice for ecosystem-based approaches. The project will facilitate the new application of these methods in the context of municipal finance, providing assistance to fill gaps in technical and financial capacity and a model for how investment in ecological infrastructure can help

municipalities meet their targets for climate change adaptation and disaster risk reduction, as well as job creation.

18. Whereas impact on the ground from the implementation of ecosystem-based adaptation (EbA) and ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction approaches is expected to be significant, it remains at the local level in the four district municipalities. Somehow the experience gained over the years is not sufficient for the 'take-off.' Hence, increased and/or continued focus on the building of an evidence base for EbA and ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction approaches may be needed. Also, the development of new financial instruments or even a mobile app, if explored, may help improve the enabling environment.

19. The persistence in implementing solid ecosystem-based approaches is important, but iTAP sees the scaling potential as relatively limited. Hence, the paradigm shift potential is assessed to be medium.

## 1.3 Sustainable development *Scale: High*

20. This programme contributes to multiple Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), notably SDG 1 (No Poverty), SDG 2 (Zero Hunger), SDG 3 (Good Health and Well-being), SDG 5 (Gender Equality), SDG 6 (Clean Water and Sanitation), SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities), SDG 13 (Climate Action) and SDG 15 (Life on Land).

21. Two co-benefits are specified:

(a) Co-benefit 1: Increased biodiversity and ecosystem health; and

(b) Co-benefit 2: Improved gender parity in the representation of women engaged in adaptation decision-making.

22. With the present design, the specified co-benefits are most likely to be generated. Moreover, the proposed project is likely to contribute to sustainable development and a broader set of co-benefits:

(a) Economic co-benefits: The landscape restoration activities look in-depth into how they can simultaneously support the local economy. For example, Eco-champs, to be subcontracted through the project partners, involves the upskilling of youths and creating jobs and enterprises in ecosystem-based livelihoods. The Eco-champs will support knowledge exchange, capacity-building and awareness-raising within communities. One of the activities will also explore the potential for a public sector employment funding model to support the rehabilitation and maintenance of ecological infrastructure. The project also seeks to strengthen the policy and investment environment to facilitate private sector engagement. This includes exploring the carbon credit and water credit policy landscape, which stand to generate economic co-benefits from environment and ecosystem management;

(b) Social co-benefits: The project seeks to develop capacity and competencies at municipal and local levels. The local-level intervention – and particularly locally led adaptation – should help boost climate-resilient livelihoods and social cohesion;

(c) Environmental co-benefits: Climate change compounds direct anthropogenic environmental damage, such as overgrazing and soil compaction. Increasing intensity of floods exacerbate soil erosion and broader ecological infrastructure. Addressing such compounded effects through ecosystem-based approaches should help not only in adapting to the effects of climate change but also in enhancing soil quality, vegetation cover and biodiversity. By restoring degraded landscapes, wetlands and rangelands, the project also enhances carbon sequestration, boosts carbon storage, and stands to improve water retention, infiltration and the broader security of supplies;

(d) Gender empowerment: Women often depend more directly on natural resources for their livelihoods and are hence more vulnerable to the loss of ecological infrastructure. The proposed project engages with communities, and women and girls are brought into the design of climate responses.

23. The focused and well institutionalized approach to working with communities and local authorities is likely to bring multiple co-benefits and contribute to sustainable and climate-resilient development. Altogether, the sustainable development potential is assessed to be high.

## 1.4 Needs of the recipient *Scale: High*

24. As highlighted above, South Africa faces multiple interconnected challenges driven by the combination of climate change, environmental degradation, and socioeconomic vulnerability. The impacts of climate change are being felt across the country, with increasing frequency and severity of hydrometeorological events – heat waves, floods and droughts – recorded in recent decades.

25. In terms of the Notre Dame Global Adaptation Initiative (ND-GAIN) country index,[3] South Africa's score is in the middle globally, scoring 95 out of 187 countries. It is particularly the readiness component (i.e. the economic, social and governance capacity to manage the effects of climate change) which pulls South Africa's score down.

26. Altogether, the needs of the recipient are assessed to be high. The proposed project is also undertaking many important steps towards addressing those needs, especially in the way that the disaster risk reduction methodologies are devised. The 'needs of the recipient' criterion is assessed as high.

## 1.5 Country ownership *Scale: High*

27. Country ownership and countries' capacity to implement development programmes is a challenge for many countries, South Africa included. Yet, this programme has been developed and brought to the GCF by a set of national institutions which are already well-ingrained in the environmental policymaking and policy implementation of the country.

28. The Eco-DRR project is well-aligned with and speaks to national climate goals and priorities. The project contributes to South Africa's key priorities of EbA and ecosystem-based disaster risk reduction management as well as the country's nationally determined contribution and its National Climate Change Adaptation Strategy.

29. The project has also been co-developed with stakeholders, particularly the district municipalities hosting the implementation and its national organization SALGA.

30. The national agencies involved in the co-creation, co-financing and nationally-led execution and implementation of this programme speak for a significant level of country ownership. This investment criterion is hence assessed as high.

## 1.6 Efficiency and effectiveness *Scale: Medium*

31. SANBI, serving as AE, is also the executing entity for all Eco-DRR activities. It acts through the project management unit (PMU) and a range of implementing partners and service providers. As depicted in figure 3 below, the project's governance oversight structure has several layers:

[3] Rankings // Notre Dame Global Adaptation Initiative // University of Notre Dame.

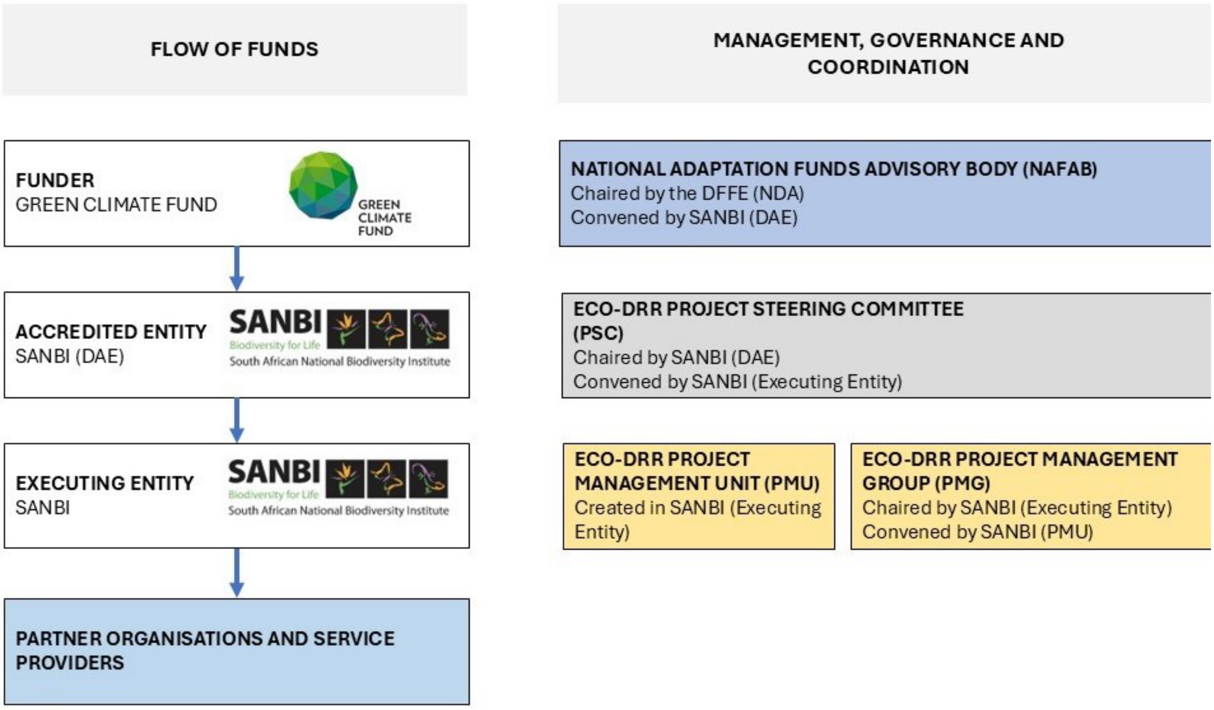
(a) The National Adaptation Funds Advisory Body guides SANBI on alignment with national climate change adaptation objectives;

(b) The project steering committee, chaired by DFFE, provides oversight and reviews the work of the whole project;

(c) The PMU, the hub for the conceptualization and execution of project activities, is supported by a project management group composed of technical experts from various institutions outside of SANBI;

(d) The PMU also needs to ensure awareness and alignment with local target municipalities' goals and objectives.

**Figure 3. Scaling up ecosystem-based approaches to managing climate-intensified disaster risks in vulnerable regions of South Africa (Eco-DRR project) governance model with flow of funds and management/coordination mechanisms**




Source: Funding proposal, figure 5, page 22: Project governance model.

32. The proposed project is costed at USD 49,507,650, with USD 40,104,179 requested from GCF, complemented with in-kind co-financing of USD 9,403,471. The GCF support is critical since municipal budgets would be insufficient, and the rising national debt of South Africa is noted to be on the increase. The grant financing, without cost recovery or revenue-generating components, is justified on the ground of the public nature of the benefits to be generated.

33. The iTAP notes, however, that a substantial amount of GCF grant funding is requested with no direct financial contributions from national or local South African institutions. The responses provided by the AE to concerns about financial sustainability in the written question-and-answer exchange cite the fiscal constraints of SANBI and its public sector partners. However, these explanations, while understandable, reinforce rather than resolve concerns about the programme's long-term viability. The AE has not presented a convincing case for how the institutional and technical capacity built under the programme will be sustained – or how climate impacts will be delivered – once GCF support concludes.

34. Moreover, iTAP notes a significant increase in the GCF funding request, compared to a previous original request amounting to less than half of the current request. The AE has not

demonstrated that the increased funding will yield proportionally greater impacts. With co-financing proportionally lower in the present proposal, this raises concerns about whether GCF resources are substituting rather than leveraging other sources of finance.

35. Given these factors, iTAP assesses the efficiency and effectiveness potential of the programme as medium. The absence of a credible pathway to financial sustainability, a weak co-financing structure, and limited prospects for private sector engagement diminish confidence that the programme's outputs will translate into lasting, climate-positive outcomes.

# II. Overall remarks from the independent Technical Advisory Panel

36. The programme stands to become a very important contribution to land restoration and disaster risk reduction in the four targeted district municipalities. It will also help build an evidence base for how ecosystem-based approaches will work in practice. The engagement with policy and the development of financial instruments may also help scale these approaches to the rest of the country and beyond.

37. The iTAP recommends that the Board approve this funding proposal.

# Response from the accredited entity to the independent Technical Advisory Panel's assessment (FP267)

| | |
|---|---|
| Proposal name: | Scaling up ecosystem-based approaches to managing climate-intensified disaster risks in vulnerable regions of South Africa ("Eco-DRR") |
| Accredited entity: | South African National Biodiversity Institute (SANBI) |
| Country: | South Africa |
| Project size: | Small |

| **Impact potential** |
|---|
| The impact potential is assessed to be medium to high.<br>The comments from the independent Technical Advisory Panel (iTAP) are noted and appreciated. |
| **Paradigm shift potential** |
| The independent Technical Advisory Panel noted that the persistence in implementing solid ecosystem-based approaches is important, but sees the scaling potential as relatively limited, and assesses the paradigm shift potential to be medium.<br>The comments from the iTAP are noted and appreciated.<br>SANBI has a slightly different opinion and looks forward to demonstrating that the paradigm shift potential is high. |
| **Sustainable development potential** |
| The sustainable development potential is assessed to be high.<br>The comments from the iTAP are noted and appreciated. |
| **Needs of the recipient** |
| The 'needs of the recipient' criterion is assessed as high.<br>The comments from the iTAP are noted and appreciated. |
| **Country ownership** |
| Country ownership is assessed to be high.<br>The comments from the iTAP are noted and appreciated. |
| **Efficiency and effectiveness** |

| |
|---|
| The efficiency and effectiveness potential of the project is assessed to be medium.<br>The comments from the iTAP are noted and appreciated.<br>SANBI is committed to paying particular attention to this area of the project. |
| **Overall remarks from the independent Technical Advisory Panel:**<br>SANBI notes iTAP's recommendation that the Board approve this funding proposal.<br>This is noted and appreciated. |

OUTPUT 5.2: SITE-BASED GENDER ASSESSMENT AND ACTION PLAN

(FINAL – V1.2)

# Provision of Project Preparation Services to the South African National Biodiversity Institute (SANBI) through the GCF Project Preparation Facility (PPF)

1 April 2025

# EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

**Background**

The impacts of climate change have been felt across South Africa with the frequency and severity of floods, droughts and wildfires increasing. Climate projections show that this trend, including changes in intensity and unpredictability, will continue. These hazards are leading to escalating risks of significant impacts on South Africa's wider economy and both the urban and rural livelihoods and its most vulnerable populations.

In response, South Africa's National Biodiversity Institute (SANBI) is preparing a full application, with the associated supporting documents, to the Green Climate Fund (GCF) to fund a programme to scale up ecosystem-based approaches to managing climate intensified disaster risks in vulnerable regions of South Africa (the Eco-DRR project). Ecosystem-based approaches are broadly accepted as a cost-effective and sustainable means to promoting resilience in communities vulnerable to climate change intensified drought, flood and wildfire and this project will utilise ecosystem-based approaches to reduce the impacts of climate change to the benefit of 5 481 886 people. This will be achieved through the rehabilitation of vulnerable catchments, the integration of ecosystem-based approaches into settlement planning and disaster risk reduction (DRR), and the creation of an enabling environment that unlocks private sector finance and scales best practices across South Africa.

**Gender Legislation and Institutional Frameworks**

The legal framework in South Africa for women's empowerment and gender equality is anchored in the Constitution, particularly in Chapter 2 of the Bill of Rights, which guarantees the rights of all citizens and specifically addresses equality. The National Policy Framework for Women's Empowerment and Gender Equity, along with various Acts such as the Promotion of Equality and Prevention of Unfair Discrimination Act, Employment Equity Act, and others, further solidify the commitment to non-discrimination and the empowerment of women. Notably, the Domestic Violence Act and Criminal Law (Sexual Offences and Related Matters) Amendment Act are crucial instruments in addressing gender-based violence, providing legal remedies and protection for victims. The legal landscape also encompasses legislation on abortion rights, children's rights, Lesbian Gay, Bisexual, Transgender, Queer (or Questioning), plus others' rights, and gender-responsive budgeting.

The institutional framework includes the Department of Women, Youth and Persons with Disabilities as the key institution for promoting gender rights, supported by the Department of Fisheries, Forestry and the Environment (with regards to gender-climate mainstreaming), the Commission for Gender Equality (the watchdog for gender rights), and NGOs like Gender Links, Sonke Gender Justice, and Women's Legal Centre – all of which play vital roles in advancing gender equality through advocacy, education, and support services. South Africa has also ratified international conventions such as the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women, the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, and the Beijing Declaration, aligning itself with global efforts to promote gender equality.

Despite legislative progress, challenges persist including gender-based violence, disparities in education and employment, and discriminatory social norms, particularly affecting women in rural areas and poor communities. In response to the country's commitment to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change, South Africa's 2025 Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) have been updated to be more gender-sensitive, and the finalisation of a National Climate Change Gender Action Plan is imminent. Ongoing efforts also include the implementation of the National Strategic Plan on Gender-Based Violence and Femicide, tracking gender equality allocations through frameworks like the Gender Responsive Planning, Budgeting, Monitoring, Evaluation, and Auditing Framework, and aligning with the "Strategy Towards Gender Mainstreaming in the Environment Sector (2016-2021)," which, was extended to 2025 and plays a key role in ongoing gender reporting and updating processes in the environment sector.

**Overview of Gender Status in South Africa**

In terms of demographics, the population stands at 62.03 million, with females comprising 51.5%, based on the 2022 census. Female-headed households increased to 41.9%, with notable variations among ethnic groups. The census also highlights challenges like high rates of disability among females, increasing widowed individuals with age, and notable shifts in marital status between 2011 and 2022- with an increase in single parents.

Regarding gender indices and ratings, South Africa ranks 20th globally in the Global Gender Gap Index, indicating progress towards gender parity. The country excels in political empowerment but faces challenges in economic participation and opportunity.

Gender issues manifest in access to financial resources, with women overrepresented in the poverty, and unemployment groups. Additionally, women experience lower participation in the labour market, lower pay compared to their male counterparts, and the burden of traditional gender roles. Inequalities in disadvantaging women also exist in access to water, land, energy, information, and technology. High rates of gender-based violence, particularly physical and sexual violence against women, continue. The gender challenges are more pronounced among women in the rural areas who, due to their dependence on natural resource, face more challenges compared to urban dwellers.

These findings concur with the Department of Women, Youth and Persons with Disabilities' 2019 assessment of gender status in South Africa from 1994 to 2019. The assessment found several achievements, including advancements in policies promoting gender equality, increased representation of women in decision-making and leadership positions particularly in the public sector, good to moderate improvements in access to education and healthcare for women, and efforts to address gender-based violence. However, challenges persisted in accessing equal economic opportunities, high rates of gender-based violence, and limited leadership in private sectors. The report highlighted the need for continued efforts to address these challenges and achieve true gender equality and empowerment for women in South Africa.

**Women's Status in the Four DMs where the Project will be Implemented**

The Alfred Nzo, Ngaka Modiri, Ehlanzeni, and Sekhukhune District Municipalities (DMs) present similar type of challenges for women, shaped by both climate change impacts and broader societal dynamics. Each DM grapples with adversities stemming from climate extremes, which often exacerbate existing gender disparities. These challenges emphasise the pressing need for inclusive, gender-sensitive interventions to address vulnerabilities across these regions.

In the four DMs, flooding emerges as a significant climate-induced hazard, threatening livelihoods and infrastructure due to factors such as deforestation, overgrazing, and soil erosion. The consequences of flooding are severe, affecting dwellings, agricultural activities, poor rangeland management and access to essential services, particularly in poorly planned settlements. The presence of invasive alien plants exacerbates these challenges, as they consume more water than indigenous plant species, reducing the availability of water in the ecosystem. In addition, invasive plants can alter soil composition and reduce water quality, exacerbating drought conditions thus highlighting the need for enhanced strategies to combat invasive species. Erosion further compounds vulnerabilities, emphasising the importance of improved infrastructure and environmental management practices. In Ehlanzeni DM, particularly additional factors, like overgrazing and sand mining, intensify flood risks. Drought and wildfires were also reported as challenges in the DMs.

In all of the DMs, women and other vulnerable genders face restricted access to essential services and economic opportunities as bridges and roads are washed away cutting off access to the essential services. Furthermore, inadequate early warning systems and actionable guidance intensify vulnerabilities, highlighting the need for targeted interventions to address gender disparities in disaster response. Women bear the brunt of caregiving responsibilities during disasters, exacerbating their physical and mental health burdens. Additionally, gender discrimination and limited decision-making power hinder women's participation in disaster management efforts, perpetuating gender disparities.

Overall, gender issues across the DMs include limited access to essential services, economic empowerment barriers, and entrenched gender norms that perpetuate disparities.

**DMs' Institutional Structures and Capacities**

Within the DMs' institutions, there was a notable absence of gender mainstreaming. It was evident that there were insufficient support systems and mechanisms in place to understand and embrace gender mainstreaming. This was reflected in the absence of gender plans or budgets in the Integrated Development Plans of DMs. The individuals designated as gender focal points, were also primarily responsible for social services, and lacked the authority to influence decisions, and were without action plans to guide their activities. In a few cases, these gender focal points struggled to define their roles and responsibilities. Across all DMs, gender focal positions were not effectively used to guide and influence implementation of the National Gender Policy within their institutions.

**Gender Analysis and Recommendations for the Gender Action Plan**

The assessments conducted in Alfred Nzo, Ngaka Modiri, Ehlanzeni, and Sekhukhune DMs reveal the intricate challenges confronted by women amidst climate change. The Eco-DRR project aims to address these gaps by adopting and implementing a gender sensitive approach that ensures gender responsiveness to climate change, DRR and ecosystem-based approaches. The project seeks to bridge the gap between the high-level conceptualisation of gender mainstreaming and its practical implementation at the grassroots level. It's crucial to ensure that gender considerations are integrated into every stage of the Eco-DRR project, from planning to execution, reporting, monitoring and evaluation to create more effective and inclusive strategies that benefit all members of the community.

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# LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

| Acronym | Definition |
|---|---|
| AGYW | Adolescent Girls and Young Women |
| BIPA | the Biodiversity Information and Policy Advice Division |
| CEDAW | Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women |
| CGE | Commission for Gender Equality |
| DFFE | Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment |
| DM | District Municipality |
| DRR | Disaster Risk Reduction |
| DWYPD | Department of Women, Youth and Persons with Disabilities |
| Eco-DRR | Ecosystem-Based Disaster Risk Reduction |
| ESMF | Environmental and Social Management Framework |
| ESS | Environmental and Social Safeguards |
| FG | Focus Group |
| GCF | Green Climate Fund |
| GDI | Gender Development Index |
| GDP | Gross Domestic Product |
| GEC | Gender Empowerment commission |
| GESF | Gender Equality Strategic Framework |
| GESI | Gender Equality and Social Inclusion |
| GFP | Gender Focal Point |
| GGGI | Global Gender Gap Index |
| GII | Gender Inequality Index |
| GRM | Grievance Redress Mechanism |
| HIV | Human Immunodeficiency Virus |
| IAP | Invasive Alien Plant |
| ICT | Information and Communication Technology |
| IDP | Integrated Development Plan |
| ILO | International Labour Organisation |
| KII | Key Informant Interview |
| LGBTQ+ | Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender, Queer (or Questioning), and others. |
| LM | Local Municipality |
| MMFR | Maternal Mortality in Facility Ratio |
| NGO | Non-Governmental Organisation |
| PEPUDA | Promotion of Equality and Prevention of Unfair Discrimination Act |
| PMG | Project Management Group |
| PMU | Project Management Unit |
| PSC | Project Steering Committee |
| PPP | Purchasing Power Parity |
| SADC | Southern African Development Community |
| SANBI | South Africa's National Biodiversity Institute |
| SDG | Sustainable Development Goal |
| SDIF | National Sanitary Dignity Implementation Framework |
| SEAH | Sexual Exploitation, Abuse and Harassment |
| SMME | Small, Medium and Micro Enterprises |
| Stats SA | Statistics South Africa |
| UN | United Nations |
| UNDP | United Nations Development Programme |
| USD | United States Dollar |
| WBL | Women, Business and the Law |

# LIST OF DEFINITIONS / CONCEPTS

For ease of reference, the following definitions and concepts are relevant for the programme and understanding this document:

**Gender** refers to the socially constructed roles, behaviours, activities, and attributes that a given society considers appropriate for men, women, and other gender identities. Unlike "sex," which is biologically determined, gender is shaped by social and cultural contexts, leading to varying expectations and norms across different societies (WHO, 2021).

**Gender in relation to climate change impacts-**When discussing gender in relation to climate, the focus often centres on women due to their increased vulnerability to the impacts of climate change, stemming from socio-cultural factors such as caregiving roles, limited access to resources like water, food, and energy, and unequal power dynamics (UNDP 2013, IPCC 2014). It is acknowledged that the LGBTQ+ community also faces specific challenges and vulnerabilities concerning climate change, including discrimination, marginalisation, and lack of legal recognition of their rights (OHCHR 2018). Efforts to address gender inequalities in the context of climate change aim for inclusivity and intersectionality, considering the diverse experiences and needs of different groups within society. However, there is a noticeable gap in research highlighting the specific adverse effects on other genders within the LGBTQ+ community. For this project, there were no concerns raised, or information provided regarding the impacts on LGBTQ+ individuals in the project sites.

**Gender intersectionality** is used to explain the idea that various forms of discrimination, such as those centered on race, gender, class, disability, sexuality, and other forms of identity, do not work independently but interact to produce particularized forms of social oppression

**Sex** refers to a set of biological attributes in humans and animals. It is primarily associated with physical and physiological features including chromosomes, gene expression, hormone levels and function, and reproductive/sexual anatomy (CIHR 2020).

**Gender Assessment**: is a systematic approach to understanding differences between the development needs and priorities of men and women and the variable impact of development programmes on them. It uses data to understand men's and women's different roles, responsibilities, decision-making power, incentives, and access to productive resources and basic services. Gender assessment includes contextual analysis of the socioeconomic, legal, and political environment as they affect gender-based roles and constraints in society (Asian Development Bank, 2021).

**Gender Action Plan** (GAP): is a tool to strategically plan and implement specific activities to enhance gender equity among a project's target groups. A GAP includes a summary of gender activities, action steps, timeframe, indicators and measures to be carried out by project implementing agencies (Asian Development Bank, 2021).

**Gender Equity**: refers to the fair distribution of benefits and responsibilities between women and men according to their respective needs. This may involve equal treatment or treatment that is different but considered equivalent in terms of rights, benefits, and opportunities. In the development context, a gender equity goal may introduce special measures to compensate disadvantaged women and men, to end inequality and foster autonomy (Asian Development Bank, 2021)

**Gender Sensitivity**: refers to the awareness, understanding, and consideration of the roles, expectations, and experiences of both men and women, as well as the recognition of the social, cultural, and economic factors that contribute to gender-based disparities. It involves being mindful of the ways in which gender influences and shapes individuals' opportunities, interactions, and perspectives (UNESCO, 2019).

**Gender Sensitive Approach**: aims to promote equality and address issues related to gender bias, discrimination, and stereotypes. This perspective recognises that men and women may have different needs, experiences, and challenges in various aspects of life, including education, employment, healthcare, and social relationships (UNDP 2018).

**GESI (Gender Equality and Social Inclusion)**: GESI recognises not only women but the vulnerability of other groups — such the youth, elderly and persons with disabilities — who are excluded from development opportunities- and refers to the integration of gender equality and social inclusion considerations into the design, implementation, monitoring, and evaluation of programs, policies, and projects ( Asian Development Bank 2013) .

**Gender Lens:** A gender lens is a tool or perspective used to analyse and understand how gender dynamics influence and shape various aspects of society, including social, economic, and political systems. It involves examining policies, practices, and interventions to identify and address gender disparities, inequalities, and biases (ILO 2018).

**Gender Mainstreaming**: Gender mainstreaming is a strategy aimed at integrating gender considerations and promoting gender equality as a fundamental principle across all areas of policymaking, programming, and institutional practices. It involves assessing the implications of policies, programs, and projects on gender relations and ensuring that gender perspectives are systematically incorporated into decision-making processes (UN Women, 2016).

Other terms used in conjunction with gender mainstreaming include:-

- **Gender bias:** When socio-cultural beliefs favour specifically men, women, boys or girls only (WHO 2021).
- **Gender blindness:** Inability to perceive that there are different gender roles, need, responsibilities of men, women, boys and girls, and as a result failure to realise that policies, programmes and projects can have different impact on men, women, boys or girls (UNFPA 2019).
- **Gender negative:** Negative outcomes that aggravate or reinforce existing norms and inequalities (WB 2020).
- **Gender responsive:** Addresses different needs, aims for equity in benefit-sharing, does not address root causes of inequality (UNICEF 2020).
- **Gender targeted:** Focus on number of women or marginalised populations (UN Women 2020)
- **Gender transformative:** Addresses root causes of inequality (ICRW 2016)

# 1 Introduction

## 1.1 PROJECT CONTEXT

The impacts of climate change have been felt across South Africa with the frequency and severity of floods, droughts and wildfires increasing. Climate projections show that this trend, including changes in intensity and unpredictability, will continue. These hazards are leading to escalating risks of significant impacts on South Africa's wider economy and both the urban and rural livelihoods and its most vulnerable populations.

In response, South Africa's National Biodiversity Institute (SANBI) is preparing a full application, with the associated supporting documents, to the Green Climate Fund (GCF) to fund a programme to scale up ecosystem-based approaches to managing climate intensified disaster risks in vulnerable regions of South Africa (the Eco-DRR project). Ecosystem-based approaches are broadly accepted as a cost-effective and sustainable means to promoting resilience in communities vulnerable to climate change intensified drought, flood and wildfire and this project will utilise ecosystem-based approaches to reduce the impacts of climate change to the benefit of 5 481 886 people. This will be achieved through the rehabilitation of vulnerable catchments, the integration of ecosystem-based approaches into settlement planning and disaster risk reduction (DRR), and the creation of an enabling environment that unlocks private sector finance and scales best practices across South Africa.

For implementation purposes the proposed project is divided into the following outcomes:

1. Outcome 1: The incorporation of Eco-DRR strategies into integrated landscape management enhances the resilience of ecological infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities.
2. Outcome 2: The incorporation of Eco-DRR into transformative disaster preparedness and response reduces the adverse impacts of climate-induced hazards on built infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities.
3. Outcome 3: An enabling environment is created for investment in Eco-DRR through a strengthened evidence base and improved learning and knowledge management.

Table 1-1 below provides the three project outcomes alongside the activities/interventions that are being proposed for each of the programme components.

*Table 1-1: Overview of Project Activities that will be Implemented under each outcome of the Eco-DRR project*

| **Outcome 1: The incorporation of Eco-DRR strategies into integrated landscape management enhances the resilience of ecological infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities.** |
|---|
| **Output 1.1: Ecosystems are rehabilitated, maintained and sustainably managed for Eco-DRR.** |
| **Activity 1.1.1:** Establish local-level project delivery hubs, governance arrangements and capacity for implementation. |
| **Activity 1.1.2:** Undertake community-level engagements towards the co-development of a vision, strategy and implementation plan for improved Eco-DRR |
| **Activity 1.1.3:** Implement collaborative rehabilitation and management programmes for ecological infrastructure to improve ecosystem condition. |
| **Activity 1.1.4**: Develop innovative Eco-DRR tools to support adaptive management of the site-based programme of work. |
| **Activity 1.1.5:** Protect critical assets with investments in ecological infrastructure. |

| |
|---|
| **Output 1.2: Local gender-inclusive and sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods support locally led adaptation.** |
| **Activity 1.2.1:** Identify and assess opportunities to develop sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods in support of locally led adaptation. |
| **Activity 1.2.2:** Support the further development and/or establishment of small, medium and micro enterprises (SMMEs) for sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods. |
| **Outcome 2: The incorporation of Eco-DRR into transformative disaster preparedness and response reduces the adverse impacts of climate-induced hazards on built infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities.** |
| **Output 2.1: Local governments and communities implement improved Eco-DRR preparedness and response measures.** |
| **Activity 2.1.1:** Establish a foundation for the incorporation of Eco-DRR into transformative disaster preparedness and response in the target DMs. |
| **Activity 2.1.2:** Develop and implement a municipal capacity and support programme towards the mainstreaming of Eco-DRR into disaster risk management strategies and plans in the four DMs. |
| **Activity 2.1.3:** Develop and activate innovative technologies and approaches that improve the dissemination of early warning products and messages about droughts, floods and wildfires in the four DMs. |
| **Activity 2.1.4: Update the Green Book** |
| **Output 2.2: Eco-DRR is mainstreamed into national and sub-national asset risk management, environmental policy and spatial planning.** |
| **Activity 2.2.1:** Identify the risk of critical built infrastructure and settlements to droughts, floods and wildfires. |
| **Activity 2.2.2:** Mainstream Eco-DRR and ecological infrastructure principles and priorities into national and local environmental policies, spatial plans and supporting instruments. |
| **Outcome 3: An enabling environment is created for investment in Eco-DRR through a strengthened evidence base and improved learning and knowledge management.** |
| **Output 3.1: Financial mechanisms developed and strengthened to enhance private and public sector investments in Eco-DRR.** |
| **Activity 3.1.1**: Assess and strengthen the policy and investment environment to support private sector engagement in Eco-DRR. |
| **Activity 3.1.2**: Build capacity and facilitate the exchange of knowledge for public - private sector investment in Eco-DRR. |
| **Activity 3.1.3**: Develop a portfolio of financial mechanisms and investment packages and unlock new revenue streams for Eco-DRR from private and public sector. |
| **Activity 3.1.4.**: Develop a sustainable public sector employment funding model to support the rehabilitation and maintenance of ecological infrastructure. |
| **Output 3.2: Informed decision making for Eco-DRR is supported and promoted** |
| **Activity 3.2.1**: Strengthen and improve data management platforms towards supporting adaptive management and informed decision-making by policymakers and market participants. |
| **Activity 3.2.2**: Compile spatially explicit ecosystem asset and biocarbon accounts. |
| **Activity 3.2.3**: Develop and implement a project level social learning programme in support of adaptive management and decision making. |
| **Activity 3.2.4**: Develop and implement a structured suite of approaches to enable access to Eco-DRR information. |

## 1.2 OBJECTIVES OF THE REPORT

Climate induced-disaster risks in South Africa are predicted to increase, and recent events have disproportionately impacted the poor and vulnerable members of society. The Green Climate Fund (GCF) and SANBI do recognise that women make up the majority of the most vulnerable in society and are disproportionately negatively impacted by the hazards of climate change. In this report, it is acknowledged that other minority genders and groups such as Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender, Queer (or Questioning), and others (LGBTQ+); the elderly and sick and people living with disabilities also experience far more impacts than the male and physically able people. As such, it is a requirement that a gender assessment and gender action plan be done for all project applications that will be supported by GCF. The purpose of this analysis is to identify key gender issues and constraints to be addressed through the Eco-DRR project as a way of ensuring that women and other vulnerable genders are fully included as beneficiaries and decision-makers and that their capacities are enhanced in building community resilience against climate change risks.

This gender assessment further outlines the institutional and policy framework in South Africa and the gender situational analysis in the four project DMs, namely Alfred Nzo DM in the Eastern Cape province, Ngaka Modiri Molema DM in North West Province, Ehlanzeni DM in Mpumalanga province and Sekhukhune DM in Limpopo province. The gender inequality landscape is described in this report, highlighting the implications for ecosystem-based responses to climate change. The issues highlighted include poverty, economic productivity, race and other apartheid historical systems that have amongst other things, placed women in rural areas with limited infrastructure while exacerbating existing issues such as gender-based violence.

This report is informed by a review of existing literature, secondary databases, inputs and perspectives of stakeholder engagements at each DM, expert inputs, review of legal instruments and any other relevant documents. Most of the statistics were obtained from Statistics South Africa (Stats SA), United Nations (UN) reports made by South Africa and a few other independent assessments. This report should be updated and remain relevant for the Eco-DRR project's lifespan.

In carrying out a gender assessment, the Eco-DRR project intends to fully adhere with GCF's gender principles and to align with South Africa's gender policies as well as the internationally ratified legal frameworks. This gender assessment and associated action plan will ensure that the Eco-DRR project is designed and implemented in support of and in alignment with other national development strategies that promote equal opportunities, poverty reduction and sustainable use of natural resources.

This gender assessment aims to:

- Identify how the **impacts of climate-induced disasters effect gender roles, norms, and power dynamics** within the project's local context.
- Pinpoint the **specific vulnerabilities and capacities of different genders** concerning ecosystems and climate change inducted hazards such as wildfires, droughts and floods. This information is crucial for tailoring disaster reduction strategies to address the unique needs and strengths of both men and women.
- Ensure that the project promotes **gender equality and social inclusion (GESI)**. This is important to prevent the exacerbation of existing gender inequalities and to create opportunities for all genders to actively participate in and benefit from ecosystem-based approaches and disaster reduction initiatives.
- Promoting the inclusion of women and other vulnerable genders in **decision-making processes** of the project.
- Addressing gender-based violence within the scope of the project by **developing strategies to prevent and respond to gender-based violence**, which may escalate during and after climate change induced disasters.
- **Incorporating local knowledge and perspectives** related to gender issues in the design and implementation of the Eco-DRR project. This will ensure that all interventions align with the cultural context and meet the needs of the affected communities.
- Identifying opportunities for **building the capacity of individuals** and organisations involved in the project to be able to mainstream gender and climate change during the projects' implementation.

In summary, a gender assessment aims to compile gender information that will aid the development of an inclusive and effective strategy and gender action plan that considers the unique needs, vulnerabilities, and capacities of different genders in the project sites.

The findings from the gender assessment were used to develop a gender action plan which is also included in this report. The purpose of this plan is to provide gender specific and time-bound framework within which to operationalise the relevant gender policies and the findings from the gender assessment. Implementation of the plan will require ensuring that SANBI and the associated governance structures including the Project Management Unit (PMU) has the established competencies, tools, and processes to achieve the outlined results. This gender action plan focuses upon the project level while also providing actions for the interventions. However, separate gender action plans will need be prepared for individual interventions that speak to the current action plan presented in this report.

# 2 Relevant Legal Framework

## 2.1 LEGAL, POLICY AND PLANNING INSTRUMENTS FOR GENDER EQUALITY AND WOMEN'S EMPOWERMENT IN SOUTH AFRICA

The **Constitution of the Republic of South Africa (1996)** promotes non–sexism, non–discrimination, equality and human dignity to all citizens of the country. Chapter 2 of The Bill of Rights, enshrines the rights of all people in the country. The Constitution and the Bill of Rights lay the foundation for non-discrimination and gives the government and its institutions the mandate for empowerment of women. Section 9 of the Constitution specifically addresses equality, and it has been interpreted to include protection against gender-based discrimination.

In line with the Constitution, South Africa's **National Policy Framework for Women's Empowerment and Gender Equity** was formulated by the Office on the Status of Women and adopted by Cabinet in 2000. The framework recognises women's rights and generally aims to promote gender equality, address discrimination and violence against women, and enhance women's participation in various aspects of society. The **South African National Gender Programme** was founded on the values outlined in this framework.

Other legal instruments that form the legal framework for women's empowerment and gender equality are:

- **Promotion of Equality and Prevention of Unfair Discrimination Act (Act 4 of 2000) (PEPUDA):** PEPUDA aims to promote equality and prevent unfair discrimination. It covers various grounds, including gender, and provides a framework for addressing discrimination through the establishment of equality courts. It gives the Commission on Gender Empowerment (CGE) powers to get involved in the equality court matters.
- **Employment Equity Act (Act 55 of 1998):** This Act seeks to promote equal opportunities and fair treatment in employment, including addressing issues of discrimination based on gender and other grounds. It requires employers to implement affirmative action measures to promote diversity and eliminate unfair discrimination.
- **Recognition of Customary Marriage Act (Act 120 of 1998)**: This Act recognises and regulates marriages that take place under African customary law. It includes provisions aimed at protecting the rights of spouses, particularly women, in customary marriages.
- **Civil Union Act (Act 17 of 2006):** The Act is a landmark piece of legislation in South Africa, signifying the country's progressive stance on LGBTQ+ rights. Enacted in 2006, it made South Africa the first country in Africa and the fifth in the world, outside of Europe, to legalise same-sex marriages. The Act provides a legal framework for the solemnisation and registration of civil unions between persons of the same sex, granting them the same legal status and benefits as traditional marriages.
- **Domestic Violence Act (Act 116 of 1998)**: The Act addresses the pervasive issue of domestic violence in South Africa. This legislation aims to protect victims of domestic abuse by providing legal remedies and recourse. The Act defines various forms of domestic violence, including physical, sexual, emotional, and economic abuse. It empowers the courts to issue protection orders to safeguard victims and ensures that law enforcement agencies take swift action in response to reported incidents of domestic violence.

- **Criminal Law (sexual offences and related matters) Amendment Act (Act 32 of 2007)**: The Act is a crucial legal instrument in combating sexual offenses in South Africa. Enacted in 2007, it addresses sexual offenses, including rape, sexual assault, and the grooming of minors. The Act enhances legal mechanisms for the prosecution of sexual offenses, strengthens the protection of victims, and imposes severe penalties on perpetrators, reflecting a commitment to combating gender-based violence.
- **The Choice on Termination of Pregnancy Act (Act 92 of 1996 as amended)**: The Act is a significant piece of legislation that legalises abortion in South Africa. This Act allows women to make choices regarding their reproductive health and provides a legal framework for safe and accessible abortion services. It ensures that women have the right to terminate a pregnancy under specified conditions, contributing to women's reproductive rights and health.
- **The Children's Act (Act 38 of 2005)**: This piece of legislation aimed at promoting and protecting the rights and well-being of children in South Africa. The Act covers various aspects of child welfare, including custody, guardianship, adoption, and protection from abuse and exploitation. It emphasises the best interests of the child as a primary consideration in all matters concerning children, reflecting a commitment to ensuring a safe and nurturing environment for the country's youth.
- **Gender Equality Strategic Framework (GESF) for Public Service (2009):** GESF is aimed at promoting and protecting the rights and dignity of women, especially those with disabilities. It mandates government departments to incorporate eight key principles in their action plans, including transformation for non-sexism, achieving equity targets, gender mainstreaming, capacity development for women's advancement, resource allocation for gender equality, and accountability.
- **Women Empowerment and Gender Equality Bill (2013):** This law seeks to establish a legislative framework for women's empowerment by ensuring a minimum of 50% representation of women in senior and top management positions within government departments and private companies. It emphasises access to opportunities, education, and training for women.
- **Strategy Toward Gender Mainstreaming in the Environment Sector 2016 – 2021 (Extended to 2025):** The strategy aims to comply with national and international gender priorities by ensuring that initiatives in the sector are aimed to support the creation of policies that support gender mainstreaming. It also seeks to ensure gender analyses and mainstreaming during the development of new projects and including gender perspective into the whole project cycle management (DFFE, 2016).
- **Gender Responsive Planning, Budgeting, Monitoring, Evaluation, and Auditing Framework (2019):** In 2019, Cabinet approved the framework that intends to systematically integrate a gender lens into public finance management and advance gender responsive budgeting. It requires gender-specific analysis and instruments at all stages of the budget cycle, including planning, preparation, execution, review, and external control.

To address the high cases of gender violence in the country, South Africa passed three bills in 2020 to amend two existing laws i.e. the Domestic Violence Act (Act 116 of 1998), and the Criminal Law (Sexual Offenses and Related Matters) Act, (Act 32 of 2007). The three amendments are: -

- The Domestic Violence Amendment Bill.
- The Criminal and Related Matters Amendment Bill; and

- Criminal Law (Sexual Offenses and Related matters) Amendment Bill.

The amendments to the **Domestic Violence Act (Act 116 of 1998)** were introduced through the Domestic Violence Amendment Bill. This bill aimed to strengthen the legal framework addressing domestic violence by refining definitions, enhancing protective measures, and expanding the scope of offenses covered under the original Act. The amendments sought to improve the effectiveness of the Act in providing support and recourse for victims of domestic violence.

Similarly, the **Criminal Law (Sexual Offenses and Related Matters) Act (Act 32 of 2007)** underwent changes through the Criminal Law (Sexual Offenses and Related Matters) Amendment Bill. This bill aimed to update and enhance the legislation related to sexual offenses, taking into account evolving societal norms and legal considerations. The amendments focused on refining definitions of sexual offenses, strengthening penalties for perpetrators, and incorporating advancements in forensic and investigative techniques to better address sexual crimes.

The **Criminal and Related Matters Amendment Bill (2020)** introduces changes in the criminal justice system, evidence procedures, and penalties for certain offenses. With regards to victims of sexual offenses, the bill streamlines and improves the efficiency of the criminal justice process while ensuring fairness and protection of rights for both victims and accused individuals.

In summary, the amendments allow victims of sexual offenses to make online protection order applications without being present in court; and regulate how information on offenders, victims and witnesses is handled and how offenses of sexual intimidation, incest etc are dealt with.

### 2.1.1 GCF'S Environmental and Social Safeguards (ESS) Standards

The GCF operates under a framework of ESS that guide its financing of climate-related projects. These safeguards ensure that activities funded by GCF do not cause harm to people or the environment and contribute to long-term sustainable development. In the interim, the ESS Standards align with the International Finance Corporation's Performance Standards and are critical for mainstreaming environmental and social considerations into GCF-funded projects. In addition, the GCF's Gender, Equality and Social Inclusion (GESI) Policy promotes the integration of gender considerations into climate projects to ensure that women, men, and marginalised groups equally benefit from GCF-funded activities. The GESI policy emphasises gender mainstreaming, participatory approaches, and equitable access to resources and decision-making processes. The GCF Governing Instrument states that: "*The Fund will strive to maximise the impact of its funding for adaptation and mitigation… promoting environmental, social, economic and development co-benefits and taking a gender-sensitive approach*."

In this regard the Revised Environmental and Social Policy (B.BM-2021/18) notes that all supported GCF activities will commit to:

- Avoid, and where avoidance is impossible, mitigate adverse impacts to people and the environment;
- Avoid, and where avoidance is impossible, mitigate the risks of Sexual Exploitation, Sexual Abuse and Sexual Harassment (SEAH) to people impacted by GCF-financed activities;
- Enhance equitable access to development benefits; and

- Give due consideration to persons in vulnerable positions and situations and marginalised populations, groups, and individuals, including women and girls, local communities, indigenous peoples, and other marginalised groups of people and individuals that are affected or potentially affected by GCF-financed activities and are especially vulnerable to exploitation or other potentially harmful unintended intervention impacts.

The Eco-DRR project will therefore be aligned with the GCF's ESS which are listed below:

1. Performance Standard 1: Assessment and Management of Environmental and Social Risks and Impacts;
2. Performance Standard 2: Labour and Working Conditions;
3. Performance Standard 3: Resource Efficiency and Pollution Prevention;
4. Performance Standard 4: Community Health, Safety, and Security;
5. Performance Standard 5: Land Acquisition and Involuntary Resettlement;
6. Performance Standard 6: Biodiversity Conservation and Sustainable Management of Living Natural Resources;
7. Performance Standard 7: Indigenous Peoples; and
8. Performance Standard 8: Cultural Heritage.

More details regarding GCF's safeguards can be found in the Environmental and Social Management Plan (Annex 6).

### 2.1.2 SANBI Environmental and Social Standards

**SANBI Policy on Gender Mainstreaming (2023)**

The SANBI Policy on Gender Mainstreaming (2023) is designed to affirm SANBI's policy position and commitment to contribute towards the realisation of social and economic gender equality by assessing the implications for women and men on any planned action, and incorporating measures to address identified past and current gender inequalities through the planned action. This will include clear project/programme performance targets to achieve an equitable allocation of socio-economic benefits such as training, employment opportunities and business development opportunities, etc. to all beneficiaries of SANBI programmes. It outlines the following key principles for gender mainstreaming: -

- **Gender representivity in recruitment and appointment** – Focuses on equal opportunities in the workplace with the proportion of women in positions across SANBI being aligned to the Employment Equity Plan. Recognises that quantitative targets are not sufficient for gender mainstreaming and that existing perceptions about traditional roles and responsibilities of women and men needs to shift to being more mindful of historical gender biases and imbalances.
- **Empowerment of women** – Highlights the need to empower all members of staff, especially women, noting that empowerment initiatives need to be conducted in a meaningful way, and where appropriate should align with the Human Capital Development strategy for the biodiversity sector. Gives special attention to areas of work where women are under-represented and/or underprivileged.
- **Gender-sensitive and family-friendly policies** – Looks at adopting language that is sensitive to gender, including policies should avoid being gender-neutral (where appropriate), by assuming that men and women are the same. Recognises and equally values the similarities and differences between women and men. Further recognises the

importance of balancing family-work life, thereby making provision for family responsibility leave and flexitime in its policies.

- **High-level leadership for gender mainstreaming** – Emphasises the need for gender mainstreaming to be championed at the highest level in the organisation, with women being in leadership positions to support this.
- **Raise awareness of gender issues** – Notes the need to practice the organisation's U-GREAT values (Ubuntu; Growth; Respect and tolerance; Excellence; Accountability and Transformation) as well as celebrating key commemorations that focused on women, children and youth, in an inclusive way to create awareness of gender relationships in the workplace and at home.
- **Recognition of the different needs of men and women** – Recognises that the needs of men and women differ, necessitating distinct responses and interventions, such as when providing accommodation, providing facilities for moms who are breastfeeding, etc. **Zero tolerance for sexual harassment and discrimination** – Focuses on providing a working environment that is free from sexual harassment, intimidation and discrimination, and will not tolerate any such behaviour in the workplace. **Gender mainstreaming in SANBI projects** – Showcases SANBI's commitment to implement gender mainstreaming best practices in its externally funded projects.
- **Gender mainstreaming in services** – Highlights the need to consider gender mainstreaming matters when procuring service providers, and ensure that procurement processes service providers in a manner that is gender sensitive.
- **Youth, women and staff members living with disabilities** - Endeavours to acknowledge, support, and encourage the role of youth, women, and persons with disabilities in all sectors of society with a focus on inclusion of youth, women, and persons with disabilities in its programmes.

**SANBI Gender Mainstreaming Framework**

The framework seeks to ensure compliance with the GCF's Gender Policy and related policies and standards, as well as the relevant SANBI policies and procedures, including SANBI's Gender Mainstreaming Policy, and South Africa's National legislation. The framework references a table summarising GCF requirements for gender mainstreaming at various project cycle stages, acknowledging that it isn't an exhaustive list of relevant GCF policies, guidance, and templates. It directs users to GCF's official documents for updated information and emphasises the need for compliance - not only with GCF policies - but also with SANBI's and national policies related to environmental and social risk management. The framework notes the gender mainstreaming considerations that are required at each step in the GCF project cycle, such as:

- **GCF Concept Note 1. Simplified Approval Process**: The GCF Gender Policy requires that accredited entities ensure that concept notes and funding proposals submitted for GCF financing meet the principles and requirements of the Gender Policy.
- **GCF Concept Note 2. Standard Process:** Concept notes submitted for GCF financing must meet the principles and requirements of the Gender Equality Policy The project concept note should reflect gender-related aspects and lay out objectives, activities, results, performance/impact indicators and operational costs that take into account gendered needs and interests related to climate change risks and impacts, as well as resilience.
- **Project Preparation Facility Application:** Funds from the Project Preparation Facility can support environmental, social and gender studies. Gender studies may include undertaking a gender assessment, developing a programme

or project level Gender Action Plan and/or incorporation of gender-responsive indicators and targets with baseline, in the logic framework of the funding proposal.

- **Simplified Approval Process Project Preparation Facility Application**: This includes completion of a Gender Assessment and Action Plan.
- **Funding Proposal (Standard Process):** Project and programme funding proposals are required to provide a gender assessment and a gender action plan.
- **Project Implementation and Monitoring and Evaluation**: Accredited entities must implement the project-level gender action plan developed in funding proposal and refine the gender-related baseline, indicators and targets (as needed). Periodic updates on gender assessments must be ensured and accredited entities must monitor and report on the progress made in implementing the gender action plan.

Overall, this framework ensures a structured approach to integrate gender considerations into SANBI's GCF projects, aligning with GCF's Gender Policy and related standards, aiming for gender equality and sustainable climate change outcomes.

## 2.2 RELEVANT GENDER INSTITUTIONS

The key government institution responsible for gender in South Africa is the **Department of Women, Youth and Persons with Disabilities (DWYPD)**. This Department falls under the Presidency and its mandate is to facilitate socio-economic empowerment and rights of women, youth and people with disability. It is also mandated to ensure that gender is mainstreamed in all sectors of South African society. The key policy that guides gender mainstreaming is the National Gender Policy Framework (2010). The framework sets standards and norms for the national gender programme. It also details a strategy for gender mainstreaming and provides guiding principles for its implementation. Most importantly, the policy details the long- and short-term mechanisms for determining the extent of gender justice and equality.

When discussing the integration of gender perspectives into climate-related initiatives, key institutions involved are the DWYPD and the **Department of Fisheries, Forestry, and Environment (DFFE).** The DFFE, tasked with coordinating the nation's responses to climate change for both adaptation and mitigation, holds a pivotal role in providing guidance and leadership regarding the intersection of gender considerations and climate change impacts. It is well-equipped to facilitate the mainstreaming of gender perspectives throughout the country. While these two institutions spearhead the process of integrating gender into climate initiatives, it's crucial to recognise that climate change affects all sectors and systems. Consequently, both public and private sectors must actively engage in addressing climate challenges and integrating gender perspectives into their actions.

One other equally important institution is the Commission of Gender Equality (**CGE),** an independent statutory body established under Chapter 9 of the Constitution of the Republic of South Africa. It functions as a watchdog, playing a crucial role in monitoring and evaluating policies and practices related to gender equality. The CGE's mandate is to uphold the provisions regarding gender equality outlined in the Constitution. Its primary role is to promote gender equality, protect the rights of individuals against gender discrimination, and monitor and evaluate the implementation of laws related to gender equality. Specifically, it aims to promote respect for, protect, develop, and achieve gender equality. Furthermore, it makes recommendations on any legislation affecting the status of women. The CGE has the authority to investigate complaints of gender discrimination, conduct public education campaigns, and advocate for policy changes. It operates independently of government structures and is accountable to Parliament, providing reports on its activities and findings.

In contrast, the **Gender Empowerment Commission (GEC)** operates as an advisory body within the DWYPD. It focuses on advocating for the empowerment of women and ensuring that gender considerations are integrated into government policies and programmes. Its primary mandate is to advocate for policies that eliminate gender discrimination, enhance the participation of women in decision-making processes, and address gender-based violence. The GEC plays a significant role in capacity building, public awareness, and collaboration with various stakeholders to advance gender equality. The GEC is structured to include representatives from various sectors, including government, civil society, and academia, ensuring a diverse perspective in its operations. This inclusive approach facilitates collaboration and strengthens the commission's effectiveness in addressing gender-related issues. The GEC reports directly to the Minister of Women, Youth and Persons with Disabilities, providing updates on its activities, findings, and recommendations. Funding for the GEC is primarily sourced from the government budget, which allocates resources to support its programmes and initiatives. Additionally, the GEC may receive financial support from international organisations and partnerships aimed at promoting gender equality and women's empowerment in South Africa.

Lastly, the **Human Rights Commission** is also key in protecting and upholding the rights of women and other marginalised groups. The Commission is mandated to investigate human rights violations against marginalised and vulnerable sectors of the society, involving civil and political rights.

### 2.2.1 Relevant Non- Governmental Organisations (NGOs)

NGOs play a crucial role in South Africa in advancing gender equality and addressing issues related to women's rights. These organisations often work on multiple fronts, including advocacy, education, and empowerment initiatives. They strive to challenge discriminatory practices and policies, promote women's participation in decision-making processes, and provide support to those affected by gender-based violence. NGOs in South Africa work collaboratively with government bodies, communities, and international partners to amplify their impact. By engaging in research, awareness campaigns, and community outreach, these NGOs contribute significantly to shaping a more equitable and inclusive society, fostering a transformative agenda for gender justice in South Africa. The most well-known NGOs working at the national level and tackling gender issues are listed below.

- **Gender Links** is an NGO that promotes gender equality and justice across South Africa. It works towards creating an environment where women and men can participate equally in all aspects of public and private life. It was established in 2001. Statis SA collaborates with Gender Links in producing the publication -Women Empowerment Gender Series. Gender Links has also participated in training certain DMs and local municipalities (LMs), to create a plan of action for addressing gender-based violence.
- **Sonke Gender Justice,** established in 2006, is a human rights organisation that works across Africa to promote gender equality and prevent gender-based violence. The organisation focuses on engaging men and boys in challenging harmful gender norms.

- **South African Women in Dialogue** is a network of women's organisations that collaboratively works towards gender equality and the empowerment of women in South Africa. It aims to amplify women's voices and advocate for women's rights.
- **Women's Legal Centre,** established in 1999, focuses on advancing women's rights through litigation, legal advice, and advocacy. It addresses issues such as gender-based violence, reproductive rights, and discrimination against women.
- **People Opposing Women Abuse** was established in 2007 as a feminist organisation that provides support services to survivors of gender-based violence and works to challenge the root causes of violence against women in South Africa.
- **Feminist South Africa** is an online platform and community that promotes feminist discourse and activism in South Africa. It serves as a space for sharing information, resources, and perspectives on feminist issues.

NGOs are operating in selected DMs, with some focusing on national efforts as well. Among these, the following NGOs were identified within the project sites:

- **Resoketswe Lebjane Foundation** provides legal aid services and advice to individuals in Bushbuckridge LM who may have their rights violated and cannot afford regular legal assistance.
- **DREAMS** supports adolescent girls and young women (AGYW) in the Ehlanzeni and Alfred Nzo DMs, empowering communities to maintain good health and remain human immunodeficiency virus (HIV)-free.
- **Right to Care** supports AGYW in Ehlanzeni DM by deploying healthcare workers to certain Department of Health clinics, aiding the AGWY in understanding their needs and preventing HIV and unplanned pregnancies.
- **Humana People to People** operates in five provinces, including Mpumalanga, addressing the needs of the underprivileged through local empowerment and support structures, in alignment with Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).
- **Nelson Mandela Aventis Project for Combating Tuberculosis** operates in the Mahikeng LM in collaboration with the Society for Family Health South Africa.
- **Shout-It-Now** offers youth-focused health services, including sexual and reproductive health support and assistance for survivors of gender-based violence, through mobile clinics and virtual engagement platforms.
- **Beyond Zero** provides health services, including HIV, tuberculosis, and sexually transmitted infections prevention and treatment programmes, across seven of the nine provinces in South Africa, with presence in all project DMs.
- **Health Systems Trust** focuses on health systems strengthening and providing support to the South African government.

Many of these NGOs primarily operate within the health sector and were highly active before the COVID-19 pandemic. However, some have scaled down or ceased operations in certain areas due to budgetary constraints. Up-to-date information on their current status could not be confirmed during consultations and will need to be confirmed during the inception stage of the project.

## 2.3 RELEVANT INTERNATIONAL CONVENTIONS

Over and above national legal instruments, South Africa is a signatory to several international conventions and protocols. The country has also ratified a total of 27 out of 189 UN International Labour Organisation (ILO) Conventions. Of these 27 conventions ratified by South Africa, 24 are in force. Signing a treaty expresses the intention to abide by the treaty but a country is not legally bound to do so. However, when a state ratifies a treaty, it agrees to be legally bound to the treaty.

The key gender equality and women's empowerment instruments adopted and or ratified by South Africa include:

a. Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW), 1972 (Adopted in 1995): CEDAW is an international treaty aimed at eliminating discrimination against women. South Africa ratified CEDAW in 1995, committing to address issues related to women's rights and gender equality.
b. Universal Declaration of Human Rights, 1948: The Universal Declaration of Human Rights is a foundational document affirming fundamental rights and freedoms for all individuals. It sets the principles that should apply universally, including gender equality.
c. Vienna Declaration for the Promotion and Protection of Human Rights, 1993: This declaration emerged from the World Conference on Human Rights in Vienna. It emphasises the importance of promoting and protecting all human rights, including those of women, as an integral part of the international human rights system. It was adopted by Sout Africa in 1993.
d. The Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action, 1995: Adopted at the Fourth World Conference on Women in Beijing, this document outlines a broad agenda for advancing women's rights and gender equality. It covers areas such as women's economic empowerment, education, health, and political participation.
e. The UN SDGs, 2015: Goal 5 of the SDGs is dedicated to achieving gender equality and empowering all women and girls. It addresses various aspects of gender inequality, including violence, education, and economic participation.
f. Optional Protocol to the African Charter on Human and Peoples' Rights on the Rights of Women in Africa, 2004: This protocol, also known as the Maputo Protocol, focuses on promoting and protecting women's rights in Africa. It addresses issues such as violence against women, child marriage, and discrimination.
g. The African Union Solemn Declaration on Gender Equality in Africa, 2004: The African Union's declaration indicates the commitment to promoting gender equality on the continent. It calls for actions to eliminate discrimination and enhance the status of women in various spheres of life.
h. The Southern African Development Community (SADC) Protocol on Gender and Development, 2008: The SADC protocol aims to advance gender equality and women's empowerment in the Southern African region. It covers areas such as education, health, and economic participation.
i. ILO Conventions C 100, C 111, C 182, C 004, C 041, C 045, C 189: These ILO conventions address various aspects of labour and employment, including discrimination and the rights of workers. They contribute to promoting gender equality in the workplace. South Africa has ratified several ILO conventions, including C 100 (Equal Remuneration Convention), C 111 (Discrimination in Employment and Occupation Convention), C 182 (Worst Forms of Child Labour Convention), C 004 (Forced Labour Convention), C 041 (Labour Inspection Convention), C 045 (Labour Inspection (Agriculture) Convention), and C 189 (Domestic Workers Convention).

### 2.3.1 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

In 2014, South Africa committed to achieving SDG number 5. The 2023 Voluntary Review revealed significant positive progress. Accomplishments include a reduction in teenage marriages, the elimination of human trafficking, an increase in gender awareness campaigns, and the implementation of gender training and policies.

South Africa has enacted progressive policies and legislation to promote women's empowerment and gender equality, resulting in improvements in women's quality of life. The National Strategic Plan on Gender-Based Violence and Femicide exemplifies these efforts. However, women[1] in the country still encounter challenges such as adverse health outcomes, including sexually transmitted illnesses and gender-based violence, leading to health complications and unfavourable socio-demographic outcomes.

A new report from Stats SA (2022) indicates progress in maternal health, specifically a decrease in the Maternal Mortality in Facility Ratio (MMFR) nationally. The MMFR decreased from 105.9 deaths per 100,000 live births in 2019 to 88.0 in 2020, reflecting a positive trend. The MMFR, encompassing deaths during pregnancy, childbirth, and the postpartum period, serves as a key measure of women's overall status, access to healthcare, and the responsiveness of the healthcare system. While the Western Cape recorded the lowest MMFR in 2020, some provinces experienced an increase, highlighting the need for targeted interventions. The report also discusses the accessibility of reproductive health services during the COVID-19 pandemic and the persistence of HIV, particularly among women. Efforts are underway to address associated gender disparities and improve antenatal care for HIV-positive women.

Human trafficking incidences decreased until 2019/20, sharply increasing in 2020/21. Regarding unpaid domestic and care work, women spent less time on unpaid work in 2010 compared to 2000.In decision-making, there is a positive trend in women's political participation. In 2022, South Africa ranked 9th globally. The percentage of women in senior and middle management positions increased from 29.8% in 2008 to 32.0% in 2021.

South Africa has established systems (Gender Responsive Planning, Budgeting, Monitoring, Evaluation and Auditing Framework, the National Strategic Plan on Gender Based Violence Framework and the Integrated Indicator Framework) to track and publicly disclose allocations for gender equality and women’s empowerment.

Despite the above, there are discriminatory practices, social norms and persistent stereotypes that lead to inequitable access to opportunities, resources and power by females (StatsSA, 2023). Race also exacerbates this, due to the legacy of apartheid. The areas of concern in South Africa regarding gender equality relate to high cases of teenage pregnancies, lack of women representation in top management jobs, high rates of gender-based violence, disproportionately high HIV prevalence among women, and low participation of women (particularly black women) in engineering, science and technology professions. Women employment percentages - especially in the private sector - is very low averaging 18%.

Wide gender disparities are more pronounced in rural areas and poor communities. Women far more than men engage in unpaid work within the care economy and the informal sector. Women are the ones who earn less money from equal jobs particularly in the private sector. Women in the country attain lower levels of education. The UN’s Development

[1] This section primarily focuses on women and inadvertently is silent on other genders affected by discrimination, due to insufficient publication or statistics regarding their experiences in South Africa.

Programme's (UNDP's) Human Development Report for 2021 shows a very high gross national income gap based on the 2017 Purchasing Power Parity (PPP)[2] with females earning 9,935 and males earning 16,129 (UNDP 2022). In the agriculture sector, women lack access to credit, inputs and training (Edmond et. al., 2017) and outside the agricultural sector women's businesses tend to be smaller and less profitable. Yet approximately 50% of households in South Africa are headed by females.

[2] Purchasing Power Parity (PPP) is a method used to compare the relative value of currencies in different countries by taking into account the exchange rates and the cost of living differences between them.

# 3 Demographic and Women Empowerment Indicators

## 3.1 NATIONAL GENDER INEQUALITY

### 3.1.1 Situation of Women in the Country

**Demographics**

South Africa's population stands at 62.03 million, according to the 2022 Census by Stats SA. Out of this, approximately 51.5% (31.9 million) are female. Notably, the 10-14 age group exhibited the highest proportion of both males and females, with nearly 66,000 more boys than girls among a total of 5.7 million individuals in that cohort. Across all age brackets from 0 to 39 years, the male population surpasses the female count. However, in the 40 years and above age group, females outnumber males (Women Empowerment 2017-2022).

A significant trend emerges among females aged 35-59 where many tend to live without partners, and this trend intensifies with age (StatsSA, 2016). The findings reveal notable shifts in marital status between 2011 and 2022 (Census 2022). There was an 8.2 percentage point rise in unmarried individuals who have never married, while the proportion of legally married individuals decreased from 29.9% in 2011 to 24% in 2022. Additionally, there was a slight decline in the percentage of couples living together as husband and wife /partners, dropping from 9.2% in 2011 to 7.8% in 2022.This holds considerable implications for societal participation in economic and social development, particularly in a culture where marriage and married women enjoy more favourable perceptions, while men often have greater agency and influence than women.

Nearly 41.9% of households are led by females, marking a rise of 0.4% from 2017 (StatsSA, Women Empowerment 2017-22). In 2021, female-headed households were particularly prominent in provinces characterised by extensive rural areas. Among ethnic groups, the highest incidence of female-headed households was among the coloured community (44%), followed closely by black Africans (43.4%).

Statistics show that over 12.3% of children have lost one or both parents. Disability is more prevalent among females (8.9%) than males (6.5%) within the overall population of South Africa, with this disparity increasing with age (StatsSA, 2016, 2022 Census). The percentage of widowed individuals increased from 0.3% among 25–29-year-olds to 46.3% among those aged 85 and above. Conversely, the proportions of widowed, separated, or legally separated individuals remained relatively stable.

### 3.1.2 Gender Indices and Ratings

South Africa is considered progressive globally in regard to gender equality based on the country's Constitution as well as its legal and policy environment. The country excels on international barometers and these achievements are detailed in table below.

*Table 3-1: Gender related development indicators*

Source: Source: Stats SA Women Empowerment 2017-22

| | Female | Male |
|---|---|---|
| **Gender development index (GDI) (2021)[3]** | | 0.944 |
| **Human development index (2021)** | 0.686 | 0.727 |
| **Life expectancy at birth (2021) years** | 65.0 | 59.46 |
| **Mean years of schooling (2021)** | 9.66 | 12.15 |
| **Expected years of Schooling (2021)** | 13.98 | 13.31 |
| **Gross national income per capita (2017 PPP$) 2021** | 9934.61 | 16129.33 |

Table 3-1 shows the gender disaggregated indicators (health, education and economic resources measured as earnings) that contribute to the GDI. The GDI helps in determining the gender gap and how far women need to catch up with the male counterparts.

The Global Gender Gap Index provides a measure that shows progress towards gender parity- illustrating gender gaps across economic, political, health and education spheres. It is designed to indicate areas that need attention. In 2022, South Africa ranked 20th out of 146 countries in the Global Gender Gap Index (GGGI) globally, with the 0.79 score showing that females were 21% less likely to have the same opportunities as men. In sub-Saharan Africa, South Africa ranked 3rd out of 35 countries. The 2021 score was a 2% improvement from that of 2016. The GGGI comprises metrics across four categories: economic participation and opportunity, educational attainment, health and survival, and political empowerment. South Africa's gender gap was largest in economic participation and opportunity, and educational attainment, ranking 81 and 43 respectively, out of 146 countries (WEF, 20213). The best ranked category was in political empowerment (13th out of the 146 countries) (WEF 2023).

On the UNDP's Gender Inequality Index (GII), South Africa ranked 97 out of 191 countries in 2021, with a score of 0.405 (UNDP 2022). The GII quantifies inequalities based on reproductive health, empowerment and economic activity. The South African gender inequality indicators were as follows (UNDP 2022):

- 46,1% of parliamentary seats are held by females, ranking 2nd in Africa and 10th in the world;
- 68,9% of adult females have reached at least a secondary level of education compared to 87.7% of men;
- For every 100,000 live births, 119 females died from pregnancy related causes; and
- Female participation in the labour market was 46,2% compared to 59,9% for men.

The 2022 World Bank's Women, Business and the Law (WBL) index rated South Africa 88.1 out of a possible 100 points. Most of South Africa's WBL indicators, i.e. mobility, workplace, pay, marriage, entrepreneurship and assets were positive. However, the assessment raised two areas of concern:

- A lack of or inadequate provisions for paid parental leave; and

[3] GDI is a measure in gender equity in access to education, healthcare and living standards. Its value ranges between 0 and 1. A value of 1 means there is no disparity. A high value does not imply complete equality as the measure overlooks other crucial indicators such as employment opportunities and salary levels.

- Inadequate provisions for pension contributions during periods of absence from work due to child care.

From 2012-2022 South Africa has 31.6 % share of managerial positions held by females. On the other hand, 13% of females between the age of 15-49 had been subjected to physical of sexual violence by a former or current intimate partner (CGE, 2024).

### 3.1.3 Financial Resources, Poverty and Employment

This section looks at key indicators to track women's market participation progress in the realm of development and economic empowerment. It links economic participation with resource equity, including social grants, communication access, and asset ownership. Economic empowerment stands as a potent weapon against poverty. Employment or entrepreneurship bestows individuals with economic autonomy, enabling them to contribute significantly to their households' wellbeing. Studies highlight that gender disparities in accessing economic opportunities can distort labour supply quality and quantity, hampering productivity and economic growth. Therefore, women's participation in the economy holds paramount importance, granting them resource access, control, and the means to support their families financially. South Africa has established policies aiming for gender equality, yet gender gaps in employment persist despite these efforts.

**Participation in Labour Market**

In 2022, the participation in labour percentages was lowest for males and females who lived with 5 or more children at 39,6% and 38,2% respectively (Stats SA women Empowerment, 2017-2022). The impacts are further compounded by having limited access to childcare facilities which was more prominent in lower income households. In these situations, childcare, which is unpaid work, is likely to fall on these women because of cultural norms, thereby reducing the time they have for other activities. However, women often face barriers hindering their labour market participation, particularly traditional gender roles that subordinate women to men. Expectations of engaging in unpaid caretaking and household responsibilities limit their professional engagement.

A higher percentage of households living with children were found among female-headed households, ranging from 55% for those living with a child or two to 62,7% for those with five or more children. On the other hand, males commonly resided in households with no children at 60,4% in 2017 and 60,7% in 2022. Notably, the number of children in the household affected participation in labour of females, and the higher the number of children the less likely for females to participate in the labour market. Additionally, females within the reproductive age bracket (15–34 years) face more significant impacts from childbirth and marriages compared to older females.

**Unequal Pay and Unpaid Work**

The 2022 Census and household surveys once more confirmed that females spend a significant amount of their time on unpaid reproductive and other care work including collecting fuel and water across all the racial groupings, with black females spending the most time.

The disparities are mirrored in the contribution to gross domestic product (GDP) despite females spending more time working with a total of 408 minutes in paid and unpaid work per day compared to males (356 minutes). The GDP includes paid work in informal and formal sectors, and the value of goods from subsistence agriculture. The contribution of females to paid work (155 minutes per day) is much smaller than that of males (254 minutes per day). By contrast, the contribution of males (102 minutes per day) to unpaid work is much smaller than that of females (253 minutes per day) (StatsSA, 2012).

The monthly median earnings by sex indicated that males were continually earning higher incomes than females in 2022. In 2020, females' median earnings were 77,8% of males' median earnings. Further details show differences by education. The lower the education attained, the higher the difference in earnings between males and females with this favouring males. Median female earnings as a percentage of median male earnings by province in 2020 found that Northern Cape has the highest gender pay gap, with females earning 52,0% of median earnings within the province, followed by North West (72,7%), KwaZulu-Natal (73,0%), and Western Cape the least at 90,0%.

**Unemployment and Poverty**

Female's official unemployment rates are 36,4% compared to 33.0% amongst males (StatsSA Women empowerment 2017-2022). The younger age groups of 15-24 and 25-34 years are the most affected at 63,9% and 42,1 % respectively. The majority of female-headed households in South Africa do not have an employed household member (StatsSA, Women Empowerment 2017-2022). They also have higher rates of poverty. Females have, over the years, consistently recorded higher headcount gap and severity poverty measures than males (ibid). The socio-economic status of nearly a third of households headed by males residing in urban areas was considered high, compared to a fifth of households headed by females. The living standards of females living in the rural areas was far worse than those in the urban centres (StatsSA 2018).

Unemployment is generally linked to educational attainment with higher rates amongst those with no schooling for both females and males. While this has been true for years, the 2022 surveys showed a drop in unemployment for people without matric. People with higher educational attainment (matric and above) experienced soaring unemployment rates in 2017-2022 and this was observed among both males and females. Despite a strong increase in the number of graduates over the years, unemployment remains a challenge, especially among certain segments of graduates. For this report, 'graduates' are considered to be those with at least a university degree. The unemployment rates varied significantly across fields of study, displaying notable differences. The field of agriculture saw the most substantial increase at 10.5 percentage points, while graduates in economic and management sciences experienced the lowest uptick at 3.6 percentage points.

A noteworthy observation emerges when examining gender discrepancies. Female unemployment rates in physical / mathematical sciences and engineering were half as much as their male counterparts, standing at 6.3% versus 12.1%, even amidst an unfavourable economic period. The widest gender gap was evident in the field of agriculture, with females experiencing unemployment at a rate 1.87 times higher than males. These persistent disparities in unemployment rates across various fields of study hint at entrenched gender stereotypes or suggest that prospective students might not fully consider prevailing labour market demands when choosing their academic paths.

**Sources of Income**

The 2020 general household survey indicated that salaries remain the main sources of income for 50,8% of households, followed by grants (28,8%), remittances (8,8%) and other sources of income (9,3%). The report reveals that in rural areas, 9,5% of males depend on income from a business compared to 2,9% of their female counterparts, whereas the disparity is less pronounced in urban areas where 11,9% of males were likely to be in business than 6,0% of females. On the contrary, females were more likely to receive grants than their male counterparts irrespective of where they reside. However, compared to 26,9% of females in urban areas, 51,8% of rural females received grants. This can be attributed to the unemployment rate in rural areas and the fact that females are more to be unemployed likely than males (StatsSA 2022 - Women Empowerment). In the less affluent and more rural provinces, there is a large dependence on social grants with Eastern Cape (47,8%) being the highest, followed by Limpopo (46,4%) and Mpumalanga (43,8%) (ibid). Remittances were the main source of income for 12,9% of households in Mpumalanga and 12,1% in Limpopo (StatsSA, 2021).

**Education Attainment and Occupation Choices**

There are inequalities in education access and attainment between women, men and race groups. In 2020, although a very small proportion of the population (2,9%) had no schooling, enrolment in higher education institutions was most common among Indians / Asians (23,1%) and Whites (21,8%) compared to Coloured (6,1%) and black Africans (5,7%). Adult literacy rates are arguably based on an individual's functional literacy, a measure closely related to educational attainment. In 2020, 10% of individuals were functionally illiterate. Females were more likely to be functionally illiterate across all age groups, although the gap is smaller in the younger age groups (StatsSA, 2021).

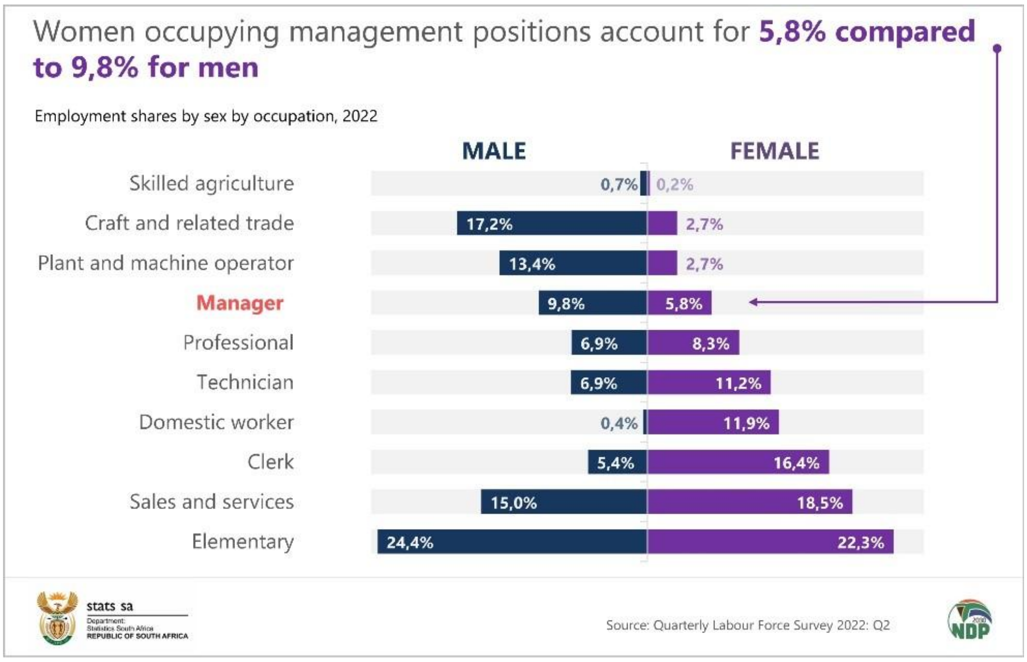


*Figure 3-1: Representation of females in formal employment (StatsSA, 2022)*

In formal employment (Figure 3-1), representation of females in the 2022 labour force survey was skewed towards low earning sectors, namely sales and services (18.5%), elementary (22.3%), domestic work (11.9%) and clerk (16.4%) while males occupied mostly the elementary (24,4%), skilled crafts (17.2%), and plant and machine operator (17.4%) sectors (StatsSA, 2022).

### 3.1.4 Access to Water, Land and Energy

Gender inequality has implications for access to water for both productive and household use and sanitation. Productive water use has impacts on food production, food security and income generation. In 2022, 8,9% of South African households did not have piped water on site. In 2022, 82,4% of households had access to piped water in their dwelling, or inside their yard. However, although households' access to water improved, 8,7% of households still had to fetch water from boreholes, rivers, streams, stagnant water pools, dams, wells and springs (Census, 2022).

In 2022, 82,8% of households had access to improved sanitation (includes pit toilet with ventilated improved pit). Seven-tenths (72,9%) of households had access to hand washing facilities. Household refuse was removed at least once per week for 67,6% of all households, with 27,2% of households relying on communal or household refuse dumps, and 4,5% of households with no facilities (ibid). Urban households are much more likely to receive regular refuse removal services, while rural ones use alternative methods of household refuse disposal (Census, 2022).

Menstrual hygiene is often overlooked. It has been hypothesised that period poverty can lead to girls missing school. Adolescent girls in South Africa can miss up to five days of school per month due to menstruation (Khumalo, 2015). The topic of menstruation can be taboo in many cultures, including those in South Africa (Steinig, 2017; Kirk & Sommer, 2006). Other studies have indicated that adolescent girls, even when they do not miss school, may face shame and embarrassment while menstruating at school, and do not have the resources to manage at school (Steinig, 2017). The disposal of menstrual hygiene products poses an environmental and waste management challenge. In all the DMs targeted in the Eco-DRR project, disposal of diapers caused challenges and contributed to drain blockages thus also contributing to flooding conditions.

The DWYPD champions the Sanitary Dignity Programme to provide free sanitary products to indigent women and girls in low income (quintiles 1-3) schools. This programme is guided by the National Sanitary Dignity Implementation Framework (SDIF). The aim of the SDIF is to promote sanitary dignity and to provide norms and standards in respect of the provision of sanitary products to indigent persons. Starting in 2019/2020, government made available R157 million to provide free sanitary pads to quintile 1-3 schools. In January 2019, the National Student Financial Aid Scheme's began allocating R275 per month to female and male students for personal care.

Regarding energy, 94,7% of households used electricity as their main source of energy, and the greatest proportion of households (64,9%) used electricity for cooking. In contrast, 25,7% used gas, 2,7% paraffin, and 6,1% firewood for cooking (StatsSA, 2022). Wood and coal were mostly used in predominantly rural areas with Limpopo having the bulk of coal and wood users (StatsSA, 2022).

In 2022, 19,9% of households were involved in agricultural production activities. Most of the agricultural households were in KwaZulu Natal (22,3%), Eastern Cape (19,6%) and in Limpopo (21,1 %). The 2021, the survey reported that the goal for the majority of those involved in agriculture was to secure an additional source of food. For others, the motivation was to provide additional income to the main income and as a leisure activity (4,2%) (StatsSA, 2022).

The interconnection between water, sanitation, and hygiene, access to sanitary wear, and food is pivotal cannot be denied, particularly in the context of climate change. These elements are not only essential requirements but also crucial aspects of meeting women's needs during disaster events. Enhancing the capacity to fulfil these needs amidst disasters is integral to bolstering resilience.

### 3.1.5 Access to Information and Technology

The SDGs emphasise expanding freedoms, eliminating discrimination against women, promoting gender equality, and enhancing women's access to education, paid work, political representation, and information and communication technologies (ICTs). SDG 5 indicators stress the significance of enabling technology in facilitating economic empowerment, particularly ICT access and utilisation. Technology, notably the internet, plays a crucial role in skill development, resource access, and enhancing women's participation across various societal sectors.

In 2022, most households in South Africa had access to landlines (5.8%) or cell phones (92.1%). Slightly more than one-tenth (13,3%) of all households had access to fixed internet at home. Cell phones have made internet more accessible to rural communities, even though mobile internet access in rural areas (52,9%) is still below urban (71,6%) and metro (66,8%) areas. Access to computers is limited with 24,7% of households owning one or more computers (Census 2022). Rural households have a lower access at 11,8% (StatsSA, 2021). The predominantly rural provinces of Eastern Cape (34,3%), North West (27,6%) and Limpopo (31,9%) had the most households with no access to the internet (Census, 2022).

Internet access empowers women by providing resources to identify and respond to dangerous situations and connecting them with otherwise inaccessible communities. It facilitates online education for girls who couldn't previously complete their studies and offers crucial information on women's rights, health and other services. It offers the potential for continued learning when school children are unable to attend face-to-face classes due to blocked access to school.

### 3.1.6 Gender-Based Violence

One in five females in South Africa have experienced physical violence from a partner. Females who are divorced or separated are more likely to experience physical (40%) or sexual (16%) violence. Overall, nearly 50% of assaults on females were committed by someone close such as a friend or acquaintance (22%), spouse or intimate partner (15%), relative or other household member (13%). About a third were by unknown people (StatsSA, undated).

The prevalence of physical violence is higher amongst less educated females compared to those with secondary or higher education, and those in the lower wealth quintile compared to the higher wealth quantile (StatsSA, undated). Gender-based violence and sexual abuse are often exacerbated by climate change disaster events due to the breakdown of social systems and infrastructure, as well as the increased vulnerability of marginalised groups.

### 3.1.7 Women in the Rural Context

In 2011, black partners were likely to live apart, with black African females being the most affected, and these females were in rural areas where 34,9% of females were not living with their partner compared to 14,8% in urban areas. In rural areas, the water source was more than a kilometre away for 8% of households compared to 1% in urban settings. Water is mostly collected by females, and when the source was far, females were more likely to fetch the water than males (StatsSA, 2012). Black African households were more likely to use wood or dung for cooking. The work of collecting fuel again fell to females and they were more likely to do so as the distance to the fuel source increased.

Rural women and girls are disproportionately impacted by climate change events due to the distance they must travel to access water sources, which becomes more challenging as these sources dwindle or become contaminated. Additionally, reliance on traditional methods such as fetching firewood and dung for energy makes them vulnerable to climate change impacts, as deforestation and scarcity of resources intensify. These burdens not only strain their physical health but also limit their educational and economic opportunities, perpetuating a cycle of poverty and inequality.

### 3.1.8 Women and Socio-Environmental Management Problems

Women often face greater susceptibility to environmental challenges due to their reliance on natural resources and their overrepresentation in impoverished communities. Limited economic resources further compound this vulnerability, especially among those whose livelihoods heavily depend on natural resources.

National statistics from South Africa reveal a higher male participation rate in the labour force, resulting in disproportionately high unemployment rates among females. Consequently, this contributes to a higher proportion of females experiencing poverty compared to males. This trend is evident in the larger number of female-headed households receiving government grants. Despite notable progress in gender equity in ministerial positions and provincial legislatures, achieving equity at the municipal level remains a significant challenge.

# 4 Baseline Socio-Economic Situation in the Project Sites

## 4.1 ALFRED NZO DM

### 4.1.1 Situational Analysis

Alfred Nzo DM, located in the Eastern Cape province of South Africa, comprises of four LMs: Matatiele, Umzimvubu, Winnie Madikizela-Mandela (previously Mbizana), and Ntabankulu. With a district-wide population of 936,462 people, Winnie Madikizela-Mandela LM houses the largest portion at 37%, followed by Matatiele at 25%, Umzimvubu at 23%, and Ntabankulu at 15%. Notably, females make up over half of the population (54.2%), and the overwhelming majority (99.4%) identify as Black African. The demographic profile reveals that a significant portion of the population is young, with the bulk aged between zero and 34. Within this context, the 198,300 households average 4.7 members each, with 57% headed by females (StatsSA, 2016). This statistic highlights the increasing burden on females, especially in child-headed households where the absence of adult guardians exacerbates vulnerability.

The socio-economic conditions in Alfred Nzo DM are deeply intertwined with its historical legacy as part of the Transkei homelands, a factor that continues to foster high levels of poverty. The DM's economy relies on diverse sectors, with community services leading at 28%, followed by wholesale / trade (15%), agriculture (12%), and manufacturing (10%). However, an alarming unemployment rate of 60% leaves many young people—who make up 80% of the population—struggling to find stable jobs. The educational landscape reflects this challenge, as 8.3% of the population reported having no formal schooling in 2016. Although 79.5% of youth aged five to 24 were in school, the barriers to quality education remain, especially for children in households affected by displacement.

The impact of natural disasters, such as flooding, has further strained these households. For instance, the destruction of bridges has left child-headed households isolated, making it difficult for children to reach schools or access essential health services. These young individuals, often bearing the weight of familial responsibilities, find themselves navigating treacherous routes to secure education and healthcare. The absence of safe passage not only affects their academic progress but also their overall wellbeing and future prospects.

Access to basic services is another pressing issue. According to StatsSA (2018), only 47.6% of the population has access to safe water, a statistic that starkly contrasts with another report indicating 80% access to improved drinking water sources (Edmond et al., 2017). Most households (93.8%) rely on yard facilities, while only a mere 5.8% have waste collection services, forcing many to use their own dumps (StatsSA, 2018). This inadequate waste management contributes to health risks, particularly for the elderly and children who are already vulnerable due to socio-economic hardships.

Electricity is available to about two-thirds (63.3%) of households for lighting, and 46.4% use it for cooking, highlighting ongoing challenges in energy access. Additionally, internet connectivity remains dismally low at just 3.1%, further isolating the community from vital information and technological advancements (StatsSA, 2018).

In summary, the socio-economic profile of Alfred Nzo DM is full of challenges and resilience. The interplay of poverty, displacement, and inadequate access to essential services emphasises the urgent need for targeted interventions that address the specific needs of vulnerable groups, particularly children and the elderly. The story of Alfred Nzo DM is not merely about statistics; it reflects the lives of individuals striving for better opportunities and the community's collective hope for a more equitable future.

## 4.2 EHLANZENI DM

### 4.2.1 Situational Analysis

Ehlanzeni DM, located in Mpumalanga Province, encompasses four LMs - Thaba Chweu, City of Mbombela, Nkomazi, and Bushbuckridge – and covers approximately 27,895.47 km². The district has a population of 2,270,897 individuals according to the 2022 Census by StatsSA.

Ehlanzeni DM is characterised by a higher number of females than males, and the population predominantly consists of Black Africans (93.6%). Disability affects nearly 7% (6.8%) of the population, with higher prevalence among white population groups (8.7%) (StatsSA, 2018a). A significant challenge facing this community is male out-migration as men often leave in search of employment opportunities, leaving behind households led by females. Approximately 43.7% of households are female-headed, with most heads of households aged between 30 and 39 years. Notably, 2.1% of household heads are aged between 10 and 19 years (StatsSA, 2018a). Ehlanzeni DM faces a substantial unemployment rate of 34.4% as of 2011 (StatsSA, 2022). The financial strains on families are particularly evident in child-headed households, where the absence of adult male figures leaves children to assume responsibilities beyond their years. With regards to access to safe drinking water, 4.4% of the DM's population still rely on unsafe sources such as rivers and streams (StatsSA, 2018a). A mere 23.4% benefit from waste collection services, forcing many families to resort to communal or private dumps for disposal (StatsSA, 2018a). Access to information technology is minimal in Ehlanzeni DM, with only 6.7% of the population able to access the internet, dropping to 4.8% for female-headed households (StatsSA, 2018a).

The combination of these demographics shows the kind of life experienced in Ehlanzeni DM, where environmental disasters can have devastating effects on vulnerable populations. For instance, recent floods have displaced many families, particularly child-headed households and the elderly. The destruction of bridges has forced children to undertake long, perilous journeys to school, often compromising their safety and education. Similarly, the elderly, who often depend on accessible healthcare services, face immense challenges when trying to reach clinics, further exacerbating their vulnerability. This Interplay of demographic factors and environmental challenges highlights the pressing need for integrated Eco-DRR strategies that not only address immediate needs but also empower communities to build resilience against future disasters.

## 4.3 NGAKA MODIRI MOLEMA DM.

### 4.3.1 Situational Analysis

Ngaka Modiri Molema DM, located in the North West Province of South Africa, encompasses five LMs: Mahikeng, Ratlou, Ramotshere Moiloa, Ditsobotla, and Tswaing. The population is approximately 937,723 people residing in 257,552 households (Census 2022), the DM presents a unique socio-economic landscape. Notably, around 41.2% of households are headed by females, and females account for 51.3% of the population. This demographic reality shapes the community's response to challenges, particularly in times of crisis, such as displacement from natural disasters.

For instance, the DM has faced significant disruptions due to environmental challenges, including damaged infrastructure like bridges, which are vital for transportation. The displacement of families, especially child-headed households, exacerbates their vulnerability. Many children, already burdened with the responsibilities of adulthood, struggle to attend school or access healthcare services. The absence of reliable transportation due to broken bridges means that these children often have to walk long distances to access essential services. In 2011, there were 12,008 child-headed households, with a notable 41.4% led by girls. This group not only face the emotional toll of their situation but also the practical challenges of navigating a disrupted community.

The socio-economic profile of the DM reflects broader trends of poverty. Approximately 640,000 people, or 67.66% of the population, live in poverty, indicating a slight increase from previous years. This ongoing struggle affects access to basic needs like water, sanitation, and energy. While over 85% of the population has access to safe drinking water, a small fraction still relies on unsafe sources, highlighting the disparities within the community. Furthermore, sanitation facilities remain inadequate for 39.9% of households, compounding health risks that can disproportionately impact vulnerable groups, including children and the elderly.

The economic landscape reveals that 204,593 individuals were formally employed in 2019, yet a substantial portion remained in the informal sector. Agricultural activities dominate, with many households engaging in livestock production and poultry distribution. However, the reliance on subsistence farming can be precarious, especially in the face of climate-related challenges.

Access to education and technology is equally concerning. With only 7.9% of households connected to the internet, the digital divide limits opportunities for learning and economic advancement. Alarmingly, about 26% of the population lacks any formal education, and only 31% of children aged zero to four are attending school. This educational gap not only hampers individual potential but also limits the community's overall resilience to environmental changes.

In summary, the socio-economic conditions in Ngaka Modiri Molema DM reflect the intricate web of challenges faced by its population, especially in light of environmental disruptions. Addressing these issues through an Eco-DRR lens is essential to building a more resilient community that can withstand and adapt to future challenges, ensuring that vulnerable populations—particularly child-headed households, the elderly, and children—can thrive amidst adversity.

## 4.4 SEKHUKHUNE DM

### 4.4.1 Situational Analysis

Sekhukhune DM is a predominantly rural district in the Limpopo Province, encompasses 811 villages and is home to approximately 1,336,806 residents, as per the 2022 Census. Its population is notably young, with 32.9% under the age of 15, indicating a dynamic demographic landscape. The dependency ratio of 66.1 per 100 individuals aged 15-64 highlights the balance between working-age individuals and dependents, a crucial factor in understanding the socio-economic challenges faced by the community.

A closer examination reveals the profound implications of this ratio, especially in light of recent displacements caused by environmental shocks, such as floods that damaged crucial infrastructure like bridges. For instance, child-headed households, often formed due to the loss of parents, face significant obstacles in their daily lives. With damaged bridges isolating their villages, these children find it increasingly difficult to attend school or access healthcare services. The journey to school, once a short walk, now requires navigating longer, treacherous routes or even forgoing education altogether. Similarly, elderly community members, who depend heavily on these services, are left stranded, unable to travel for medical care or social support.

The demographic profile of Sekhukhune DM also reveals that 51.2% of households are female-headed, indicating a significant role for women in family and community structures. Despite their vital contributions, these women often bear the brunt of socio-economic pressures. The existing sex ratio of 89 males for every 100 females further illustrates the challenges faced by women, who make up 53.1% of the population. Predominantly Black African (98.7%), the community is characterised by a rich cultural tapestry, yet they are also grappling with substantial economic hurdles.

With a population growth rate of 2.10% per annum, the DM's ability to provide essential services and opportunities is strained. As families grow, so does the demand for education and healthcare—services that are already under pressure due to high poverty levels and limited resources. By integrating these narratives, the dependency ratio and demographic characteristics reflect the lived experiences of the community, particularly in the context of environmental challenges. Understanding these dynamics is crucial for developing effective Eco-DRR strategies that not only address immediate needs but also build resilience against future shocks.

# 5 Gender Considerations During Stakeholder Engagements

The stakeholder consultation and engagement process undertaken during the FFP development followed not only the Batho Pele Principles (people first), adopted by the South African Government, but also aligned with the principles and approaches outlined in Gann et al (2019)[4] and Dudley et al. (2021)[5] and was benchmarked against global principles and the GCF's "*Sustainability Guidance Note: Designing and ensuring meaningful stakeholder engagement on GCF-financed projects*".

Emphasising the local-level scale that the interventions will take, ensuring meaningful inclusive participation was important. Guidance from GCF's environmental and social management system, the environmental and social safeguards (GCF, Development Bank of Southern Africa), Revised Environmental and Social Policy, and Indigenous Peoples Policy of GCF were key guidance documents.

In addition, to the above, consideration of gender strongly influenced the approach to stakeholder engagements. Ultimately, these principles talk to:

- Respect, courtesy, openness and transparency in approach, ensuring inclusivity and sensitivity to diverse perspectives, including those related to gender;
- Clarifying the mechanisms for engagement and consultation throughout the iterative adaptation planning process, including a focus on the private sector, sub-national governments and civil society organisations, while paying attention to gender-balanced participation;
- Ensure clear communication and accessible information dissemination on climate impact, risk and vulnerability information to relevant stakeholders, recognising and addressing diverse needs based on the audience's characteristics, including gender-specific considerations.;
- Streamlining stakeholder engagement processes within existing broader development planning and coordination mechanisms, such as existing forums, meetings etc.; and
- Continuous communication and engagement to ensure progress is comprehended and actively contributed to, demonstrating accountability and ensuring equitable value for money, considering gender-inclusive impacts and benefits.
- A fundamental requirement of any approach involving building resilience to climate change and DRR, along with restoration and associated approaches (e.g., rehabilitation, mitigation, reducing impact) is genuine and active stakeholder engagement throughout the process.

The planned process followed for stakeholder engagements is summarised in the figure below:

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[4] Gann, G.D.; McDonald, T.; Walder, B.; Aronson, J.; Nelson, C.R.; Jonson, J.; Hallett, J.G.; Eisenberg, C.; Guariguata, M.R.; Lui, J.; Hua, F.; Echeverria, C.; Gonzales, E.; Shaw, N.; Decleer, K.; Dixon, K.W. 2019. International principles and standards for the practice of ecological restoration. Second edition. Restoration Ecology 27(S1): S1-S46

[5] Dudley, N., Baker, C., Chatterton, P., Ferwerda, W.H., Gutierrez, V., Madgwick, J., 2021, The 4 Returns Framework for Landscape Restoration. UN Decade on Ecosystem Restoration Report published by Commonland, Wetlands International Landscape Finance Lab and IUCN Commission on Ecosystem Management.

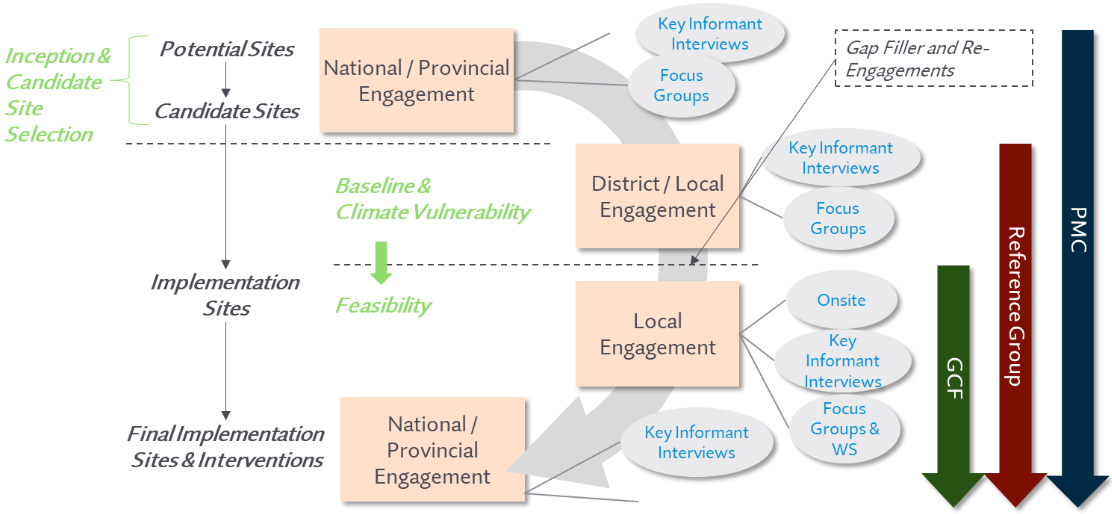


*Figure 5-1: Stakeholder engagement process*

Effectively, the stakeholder engagement process included a suite of initial engagements to provide the basis for future and ongoing engagement across the course of the project development and design. These were then followed up with a series of re-engagements and consultations focused on refining findings, aligning with stakeholders' evolving priorities, and moving forward the project development (Figure 5-2).

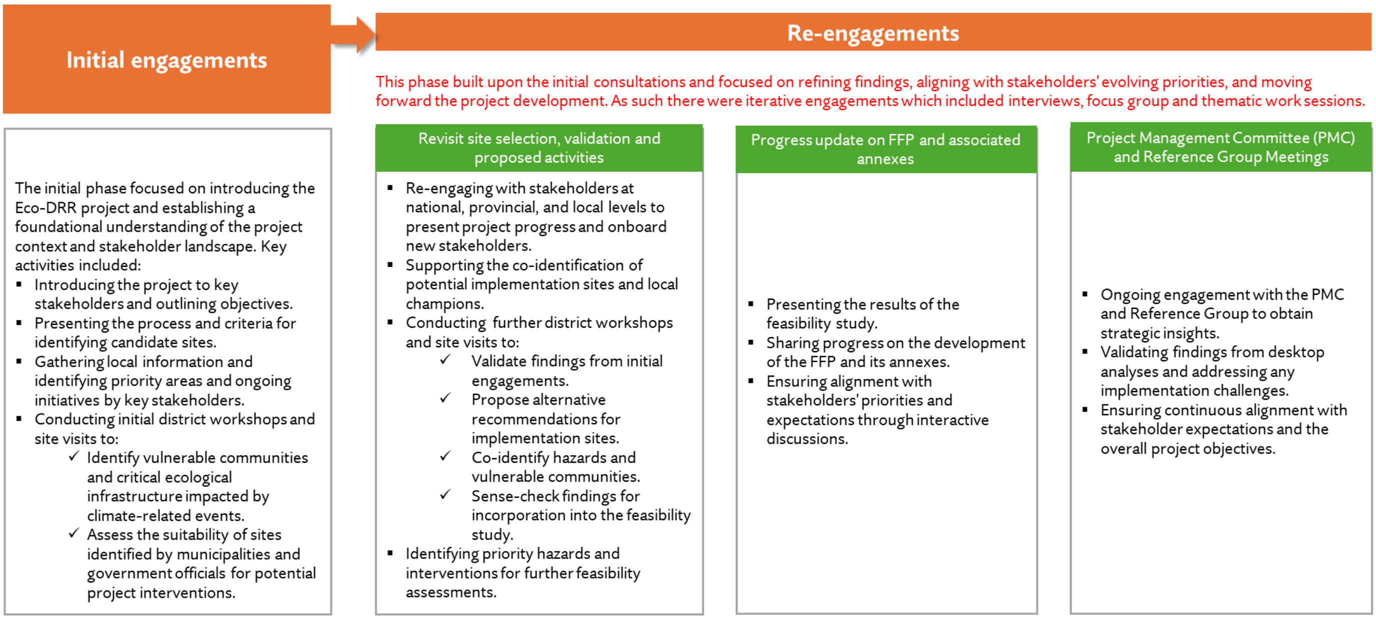


*Figure 5-2: Overview of the purpose underpinning the stakeholder engagement journey*

In the planning and implementation of stakeholder engagements gender and cultural aspects were carefully considered and supported. This included all engagements at national, provincial and local levels, with the more local level engagements taking cultural aspects into consideration of process. These considerations included amongst others:

- **Invitation and Participation Monitoring**: While institutional and organisational representation is not within the control of SANBI or the project development team, there was monitoring of gender participation in processes. All meetings involved both men and women.
- **Consider different and gendered priorities**: All meetings facilitated discussions that carefully considered the different priorities and needs of women and men, including the most marginalized groups.

- **Incorporation of gender-specific feedback**: All meetings, and most specifically in the design of the project interventions, considered the cultural context to capture and incorporate gender-specific feedback into project design and management. This was important noting the differing social and cultural differences between the geographic locations.
- **Use of gender sensitive approaches and language**: Throughout the engagement journey all meetings were gender sensitive in their facilitation and in the language used throughout discussions.
- **Collection of gender specific data and information**: Particularly the meetings that were held within in each District Municipality, the team gathered data and information relating to gender and cultural aspects and how the Eco-DRR project would interface and address these.
- **Cultural and traditional aspects**: Meetings and engagements at local levels were supported and guided by Municipal staff. As such, these staff provided information on the cultural and traditional leadership aspects in their areas. In some instances, meetings with traditional leaders and local councillors were arranged to address specific concerns. The team remained respectful of these norms and approaches and were mindful of the relationships between municipal staff and the local traditional leadership.

Key stakeholders were regularly kept informed of project developments, updates, and community comments. This was done via recurring reports and presentations/meetings that described the progress of the engagement and site selection initiatives to date.

It is important to note that due process was followed during engagements which was determined by government authorities. This entailed engaging with entities at a national level first before moving to provincial, district and local levels. This allowed for buy-in to be secured from the top-down with national-level stakeholders ensuring that approvals were granted at a provincial, district and local level to engage with the project. This process also allowed for national, provincial and district authorities to identify local stakeholders to engage with.

As highlighted by national, provincial and local stakeholders, community engagements need to be handled cautiously to manage expectations and reduce stakeholder and research fatigue. DMs and LMs emphasised the need to engage with communities only when the project has landed and is close to implementation.

## 5.1 GENDER INSIGHTS FROM ENGAGEMENTS

Stakeholder engagements consisted of interactions with a range of stakeholders in the form of key informant interviews (KIIs), focus groups (FGs), in person workshops, site visits and the Reference Group / Project Management Committee (PMG). The various types of meetings and engagements have had differing audiences, inclusive of interactions across gender, culture, and generations. Gender representation was ensured during all stakeholder engagements and opportunities were provided to both men and women to voice their concerns and provide inputs. The engagement process ensured that both men and women were involved in engagement-related activities, while also taking into consideration the cultural context so that gender and culture specific feedback was captured and incorporated into project design. Written comments were also welcomed post engagements to allow for further inputs from stakeholders who may not have been comfortable during the session. Where appropriate, inclusive language was used during engagements to ensure a gender sensitive approach. Engagement objectives also varied across the interactions, all of which have fed into the development of the FFP and annexes.

Some of the key gender insights that were gleaned from engagements with SANBI's Gender Expert, and the Biodiversity Information and Policy Advice (BIPA) Division are presented below:

- It will be critical to align with SANBI's gender policy and frameworks and ensure incorporation of gender perspectives within the project. Understanding how this integration would be guaranteed at the project sites will be necessary.
- The gender lens is critical noting gender response activities such as those empowering women in the project sites.
- Gender is a cross-cutter across the project and gender mainstreaming is required.

In addition, district-level workshops were held, and gender issues were explored at these workshops. The approach to this included:

- Identifying distinct vulnerabilities related to gender resulting from the impacts of climate change.
- Working in smaller groups to identify the barriers to gender equality and causes of these barriers and vulnerabilities.
- Exploring potential solutions catering to gender-specific needs to ensure that women, girls, the elderly, and other vulnerable members of the communities benefit and actively participate in the project.

During the district-level workshops, a gender expert was present to capture the perspectives of stakeholders regarding gender. A presentation was made during the workshops highlighting the imperative for GESI. The workshops were structured to facilitate breakout group discussions. The breakaway groups discussed responses centred around GESI - related questions. The questions concerned four main areas of enquiry:

- Vulnerability of women during previous climate disasters, in each district based on previous events;
- Opportunities to reduce vulnerability in future climate events;
- Identification of barriers that caused gender vulnerability; and
- Identification of opportunities for women to fully participate in the proposed or planned Eco –DRR projects.

Group plenary presentations and discussions followed the breakaway group discussions. Further details were obtained through discussion with field teams and interactions with some community women.

Key findings on stakeholders' perspective from the district-level workshops are discussed below. In general, the responses are very similar between the DMs and the groups engaged. The major impacts suffered by women during climate disasters is listed below according to the climate hazard.

1. **Floods**
    a. Loss of human life
    b. Loss of homes
    c. Relocation
    d. Access issues- No services due to flooding of rivers or bridges being washed away (schools, hospitals, businesses)
    e. Loss of income

f. Increased water-borne and communicable diseases.
g. At times phone network services also affected

2. **Droughts**
    a. Death of livestock due to no water and poor pastures
    b. Poor crop yields or no yields at all
    c. Severe food insecurity

With regards to why women are most affected during climate disaster events, the following was noted:

- Women are responsible for taking care of children and reproduction;
- Women are responsible for subsistence farming;
- Physical aspects of women make them vulnerable;
- Cultural norms exist that discriminate against women;
- No means of income through employment, thus there is an over-reliance on food parcels and social grants;
- Lack of clean (protected) water sources close to homes;
- Settling of households in wetlands which leads to loss of homes during floods;
- Poor planning by the leadership and responsible institutions negatively impacts women; and
- Limited communication on pending weather/climate related events.

Stakeholders' responses to address these barriers that ensure vulnerable women are not disadvantaged in the Eco-DRR project were noted. These included ensuring inclusivity and implementing affirmative actions that prioritise women and vulnerable groups. Capacity development activities is also needed coupled with interventions tailored to meet women's needs (e.g. projects implemented closer to households). The introduction of income generating projects was recognised as well as the establishment of community food safety nets. Other recommendations included improving communication on flood related events and introducing smart agriculture and appropriate rangeland management activities. In addition, it was noted that settlement planning needs to consider rural areas, and the unique context associated with these areas. Furthermore, encouraging good building standards for households is also needed going forward.

Stakeholders were asked to further elaborate on the support required to address gender disparities during climate events. Recommendations included promoting gender awareness programmes at the community level to enhance participation. This should be complemented by robust capacity-building initiatives and skill development. Another proposed strategy involved supporting land users' ownership and employing gender mainstreaming campaigns within climate change agendas.

# 6 Gender Analysis

## 6.1 ASSESSMENT OF DMS' INSTITUTIONAL STRUCTURES AND CAPACITIES

### 6.1.1 DM Institutional Structures and Capacities

At the institutional level, the findings revealed significant gaps in structures supporting GESI mainstreaming. While the National Gender Policy mandated the appointment of Gender Focal Points (GFPs) within government institutions to oversee effective implementation, consultations uncovered widespread unawareness of the GFPs' existence among district staff. Moreover, one instance was noted where the GFP was unfamiliar with their responsibility and lacked authority within their municipality. In some cases, senior managers questioned the necessity of such positions, indicating a lack of institutional buy-in.

Regarding reporting requirements, while there is a national understanding that reports should include gender assessments, this principle was not internalised at district and local levels. Gender aspects in integrated development plans (IDPs) for instance, were often treated as add-ons without corresponding action plans and budgets. Additionally, misconceptions regarding GESI concepts were prevalent among stakeholders, including a limited understanding of equity and equal treatment, confusion between inclusion and meaningful participation, and the misconception that gender solely refers to women's issues, resulting in tokenistic approaches to gender mainstreaming.

Furthermore, there was a reported need for campaigns to increase awareness and shift negative stereotypes regarding GESI and the environment. Although many DM staff had previously participated in gender-related trainings and workshops, there was a lack of full appreciation of the objectives and benefits of gender mainstreaming. Moreover, there was a lack of ownership and commitment to gender strategies at DM and LM levels, resulting in insufficient budget allocation and human resources dedicated to addressing gender issues. This limited ownership also extends to data collection and analysis, with a notable absence of sex-disaggregated data at a local level hindering informed decision-making. Thea absence of sex (GESI) disaggregated data is recognised as a significant obstacle to developing informed transformative interventions.

Overall, these findings point out the urgent need for capacity-building, institutional support, and a shift towards more inclusive and informed approaches to gender mainstreaming at all levels of governance. In summary:

- The findings indicate that GFPs were not adequately trained or supported to promote gender mainstreaming within the LMs and DMs.
- Furthermore, none of the municipalities had gender mainstreaming programmes, and they all lacked gender action plans. The IDPs for these municipalities also failed to address gendered aspects of poverty, inequality, and local social and economic development.
- During discussions with senior officers, there was evidence of gender insensitivity, with a tendency to focus solely on the number of women in senior management or decision-making positions. This suggests that municipalities struggle to mainstream gender due to a lack of understanding of the importance and how to approach it.
- There was no gender disaggregated data available in all of the reports and plans produced by the DMs and LMs.

These findings align with existing literature on gender in LMs, such as studies by Vyas-Doorgapersad (2023), CGE (2022), and Hicks and Buccus (2023), which also highlight significant gender disparities in South African municipalities. Despite national efforts, there is a lack of gender transformation and insufficient internal policies and programmes to support women and address issues like sexual harassment.

To address these challenges, it is important to coordinate gender awareness training and capacity building programmes. GFPs within key departments can assist by driving the mainstreaming process to influence decision-making. Additionally, implementing Gender Equity Plans, as outlined by Vundla (2016), and instituting gender-specific evaluation frameworks for leadership development, as suggested by Nkwana et al. (2021), could be explored to help achieve gender equality in all facets of municipal life. Establishing mechanisms for the collection and analysis of gender-disaggregated data is critical, along with training government and community structures on gender-sensitive data collection methodologies to capture the varying impacts of climate hazards on men and women. Gender sensitive training sessions on Eco-DRR and early warning systems is also necessary, tailored to the needs and roles of both genders, with a focus on facilitating women's participation and leadership in decision-making processes. Gender-sensitive assessments will also inform the integration of gender considerations into policy and planning, advocating for the revision and alignment of national and local policies to address gender disparities at the DM and LM level. These activities aim to ensure inclusive and effective responses to climate hazards in target communities by mainstreaming gender considerations across all project components.

## 6.2 FINDINGS FROM PROPOSED PROJECT IMPLEMENTATION SITES

The Alfred Nzo, Ngaka Modiri, Ehlanzeni, and Sekhukhune DMs reflect the complex challenges faced by women due to climate change and broader societal factors. Each region presents unique adversities tied to climate extremes, often exacerbating pre-existing gender disparities. Examining these areas reveals a concerning pattern of vulnerabilities and the urgent need for inclusive, gender-sensitive interventions.

### 6.2.1 Alfred Nzo DM

During the assessment of Alfred Nzo DM, it became evident that the district is susceptible to climate-induced impacts, particularly flooding, which poses significant risks to communities' livelihoods and infrastructure. Stakeholders identified flooding as a major hazard during heavy rains and hailstorms, exacerbating by deforestation, overgrazing, illegal sand mining, and soil erosion. The consequences of flooding were dire, affecting dwellings, farmers' crops and livestock, as well as damaging roads and bridges, isolating villages from essential services and surrounding towns. Moreover, poor spatial planning, evidenced by houses built along drainage and flood lines, increased the communities' vulnerability to flooding.

Furthermore, the presence of invasive alien plants (IAPs), notably wattle, posed additional challenges during heavy rains or floods. These IAPs are easily dislodged and tend to block watercourses, exacerbating flood events or diverting floodwater to more vulnerable areas. Encroachment of "ouhout" bushes further aggravated the situation, forming dense thickets on overgrazed or eroded areas, contributing to runoff, erosion, and subsequent flooding downstream. Despite efforts to clear IAPs, including historical activities, the problem persists, indicating the need for enhanced strategies and scaling up of existing efforts to combat these invasive species.

*Figure 6-1: Erosion at a house during a site visit in Alfred Nzo DM*

Erosion, particularly visible during heavy rains, emerged as another pressing issue, threatening households, roads, and bridges. Inadequate infrastructure development, such as undersized culverts and insufficient drainage systems, exacerbates erosion, leading to landslides, road failures, and downstream flooding. Pollution, including blockage of culverts by waste like nappies, further compounds the flooding problem across the DM. Wetland degradation, attributed to pollution and encroachment by villages and poor agricultural practices, shows the importance of better spatial planning and local enforcement to address these environmental challenges effectively. These climate-induced impacts disproportionately affect women and other genders in the DM, highlighting the urgency of integrating gender-responsive strategies into climate adaptation and disaster risk reduction initiatives.

The gender issues in the DM include the following:

- **Impact of climate change:** Women in the DM bear a disproportionate burden of the effects of climate change. They face income loss, displacement, and restricted access to essential services during extreme weather events. This exacerbates existing vulnerabilities and makes it challenging for them to cope with the changing climate.
- **Entrenched gender roles**: Traditional gender roles are deeply ingrained in the communities, leading to unequal distribution of responsibilities and opportunities between men and women - thus limiting women's access to resources, decision-making power, and economic independence.
- **Lack of official identification**: Many women in the DM were reported to lack official identification documents, which restricted their access to government services, financial resources, and employment opportunities. This further marginalises them and perpetuates their dependence on others. This was attributed to lack of any formal education.
- **Inadequate healthcare**: Women in the rural areas of Alfred Nzo DM, including the sick and elderly, faced barriers to accessing healthcare services, including limited facilities and long distances to travel. This results in poorer health outcomes for women and contributes to their overall vulnerability.
- **Deficiency of municipal services**: The lack of essential municipal services, particularly in accessing water, poses significant challenges for households led by women. Without reliable access to clean water, women must travel long distances to fetch water, which affects their time, health, and economic productivity.

To address these gender issues, the Eco-DRR project proposes several interventions:

- **Safeguarding water sources:** The project aims to preserve and protect water sources through land management strategies that mitigate erosion and sedimentation, innovative small infrastructure e.g. for spring protection. This is essential for ensuring reliable access to clean water, which is particularly critical for women and their households.
- **Empowerment of women:** Livelihood programmes will be implemented to empower women economically and socially, enhancing their autonomy and overall wellbeing. By providing women with skills training, income-generating opportunities, and support networks, the project seeks to strengthen their resilience to climate change and other challenges.
- **Engagement of NGOs and local leaders:** The active involvement of NGOs and local leaders is crucial for ensuring that the project's interventions reflect the diverse perspectives and needs of the community. By engaging with stakeholders at all levels, the project can achieve more sustainable and inclusive outcomes.
- **Sustainable resource management:** Prioritising sustainable resource management and land conservation initiatives will help protect environmental resources for future generations. By considering the needs and capabilities of vulnerable women in these efforts, the project can promote equitable and sustainable development.

Overall, gender considerations will be integrated into all aspects of planning, implementation, and evaluation. By recognising and addressing the unique challenges faced by women in these communities, the Eco-DRR project aims to promote gender equality and social inclusion while building resilience to climate change and other environmental hazards.

### 6.2.2 Ehlanzeni DM

In the Ehlanzeni DM, the Environmental Management Services Unit of the Community Services Department oversees efforts to maintain a clean and healthy environment. Despite its capacity to address environmental concerns, the DM faces challenges in biodiversity management, notably lacking a specialist in this area. While some climate risk and vulnerability assessments have been conducted, there are limitations in scaling up ecosystem-based interventions due to constrained resources and competencies. However, the DM benefits from the presence of active organisations such as the DFFE's Environmental Programmes (DFFE: EP), along with civil society and NGOs like Conservation South Africa, Kruger 2 Canyons, and AWARD, which offer technical and advisory support.

Through stakeholder engagements, workshops and site assessments, priority areas for ecosystem-based climate adaptation actions have been identified. Flood emerges as a significant hazard, particularly within the Bushbuckridge LM, where localised flooding is exacerbated by various factors including sand mining, deforestation, overgrazing, and unplanned settlements. These floods pose threats to dwellings, infrastructure, and crops, with recent tropical cyclones exacerbating risks. Additionally, the presence of IAPs and erosion further exacerbates environmental challenges, requiring improved management regimes and rehabilitation interventions for upstream wetlands.

During site visits, stakeholders emphasised the vulnerability of communities to intense rainfall and high wind strengths associated with tropical cyclones, especially in the Casteel area. Poor waste management practices, erosion, and inadequate infrastructure like culverts and bridges compound these challenges. The economic vulnerability of the Bushbuckridge LM shows income inequality and low economic diversity, while Thaba Chweu LM faces increasing conflict between population growth and environmental preservation.

Stakeholder engagements during workshops and on online identified several gender issues exacerbated by recurrent flooding and food insecurity during droughts. These challenges disproportionately affect women and amplify their vulnerabilities within the community. The gender issues in the DM include the following:

- **Disproportionate impact on women**: Women are disproportionately affected by flooding and food insecurity due to various factors such as their roles as caregivers, limited access to resources, and societal norms. During disasters, women often bear the brunt of caregiving responsibilities, including taking care of children, elderly family members, and the sick. This increased burden further strains their physical and mental health, making them more vulnerable to the adverse effects of disasters.
- **Inadequate early warning systems**: Stakeholders have identified inadequacies in early warning systems as a significant contributor to exacerbating disasters. These systems often fail to effectively reach women, leaving them ill-prepared and intensifying their susceptibility to the impacts of flooding and droughts. Women may not receive timely and relevant information about impending disasters, making it difficult for them to take necessary precautions to protect themselves and their families.
- **Lack of actionable guidance**: Available information about disasters often fails to provide actionable guidance for effective disaster response, particularly for women. Women may not have access to resources or knowledge about how to prepare for and respond to disasters, further exacerbating their vulnerability.
- **Compounded issues of land tenure:** The compounded issue of land tenure exacerbates the plight of women in disaster-affected areas. Women often have limited access to land and property rights, which hinders their ability to recover from disasters and rebuild their livelihoods.

Addressing these gender issues require the following:

- **Gender-sensitive early warning systems:** The project will need to develop and implement early warning systems that are sensitive to the needs of women. This includes ensuring that warnings are disseminated through various channels accessible to women, such as community meetings, radio broadcasts, and mobile phone messages. Training community leaders and volunteers to effectively communicate warnings to women and providing them with resources to assist women in taking necessary precautions can also enhance the effectiveness of early warning systems.
- **Gender-responsive disaster preparedness training:** The project will provide gender-responsive disaster preparedness training to women and men in disaster-prone areas. This training aims to equip women with the knowledge and skills needed to prepare for and respond to disasters, including first aid, evacuation procedures, and emergency communication protocols. Additionally, training will address gender-specific vulnerabilities and strategies for mitigating risks, such as ensuring access to safe shelters and sanitation facilities for women and girls.
- **Promoting Women's participation in decision-making:** Encourage and facilitate women's participation in decision-making processes related to DRR, preparedness, and response. This includes ensuring that women are represented in local disaster management committees and other relevant forums where decisions are made about disaster preparedness and response strategies. Providing training and capacity-building opportunities to women leaders can also empower them to effectively advocate for their needs and priorities in disaster planning and decision-making processes.
- **Integrating gender mainstreaming in DRR:** The Eco-DRR initiatives will integrate gender mainstreaming principles into all stages of DRR initiatives, from planning and implementation to monitoring and evaluation. This includes conducting

gender-sensitive vulnerability assessments, incorporating gender considerations into disaster risk management plans, and disaggregating data by gender to identify and address disparities in disaster impacts and responses. By mainstreaming gender considerations into DRR efforts, stakeholders can ensure that the specific needs and priorities of women are adequately addressed and that interventions are more inclusive and effective.

### 6.2.3 Ngaka Modiri Molema DM

In Ngaka Modiri Molema DM, flooding poses significant challenges that disproportionately affect women and other vulnerable genders. Through stakeholder engagements, workshops and site assessments involving government officials, NGOs, civil society, and private sector representatives, it was confirmed that flooding is a persistent issue across the DM. During flood events, excessive soil erosion occurs, leading to the collapse of poorly developed road and bridge infrastructure, rendering essential services such as homes, schools, hospitals, and shops inaccessible to communities. Additionally, houses become flooded, and personal assets including livestock are destroyed, exacerbating vulnerabilities, especially among those settling in hazardous areas such as pans due to poor settlement planning.

Water security and supply challenges were also highlighted, with most communities dependent on groundwater supply in the typically arid region. Furthermore, erosion associated with roads and culverts was observed during site assessments, with concerns raised by communities about the dangers of flash flooding, especially for children commuting daily. Poor rangeland management practices linked to livestock also contributed to erosion and environmental degradation, further compounding the impact on vulnerable populations in areas like Ratlou LM.

*Figure 6-2: Washed away bridge in the Ngaka Modiri Molema DM*

The DM's history of flooding and drought emphasises the urgent need for targeted interventions to mitigate future impacts and safeguard lives and livelihoods. While solutions like Eco-DRR interventions were explored, challenges such as the endorheic nature of pans in areas like Deelpan highlighted limitations, with resettlement of communities being a potential solution. Additionally, the DM's experience of recurrent droughts necessitates concerted efforts to address water scarcity and resilience-building measures, particularly for communities reliant on streams for water supply, further emphasising the gendered impacts of climate-induced hazards in Ngaka Modiri Molema DM.

In Ngaka Modiri Molema DM, gender issues intersect with various challenges, particularly those stemming from climate change-induced disasters and socio-economic factors. The gender issues in the DM include the following:

- **Access to vital services:** Vulnerable groups, particularly women, young children, the sick and elderly, face restricted access to essential services such as healthcare, education, and clean water during climate change-induced disasters like floods. This disproportionately affects women who are often responsible for caregiving and household management. The significant prevalence of households headed by girls contributes to a high number of vulnerable individuals.
- **Economic empowerment:** Women's economic empowerment is hindered by challenges such as unemployment, limited access to credit for agricultural production due to land tenure issues, and traditional gender roles that confine them to certain sectors of the economy. Without access to credit and land, women struggle to start or sustain agricultural enterprises, perpetuating cycles of poverty and disempowerment.
- **Gender discrimination and norms:** Traditional gender roles and norms unjustly discriminate against women in, limiting their participation in decision-making processes and excluding them from various societal opportunities such as advancing in education. These norms perpetuate gender disparities and hinder women's ability to fully engage in community development and disaster management efforts.

Through discussions the following solutions were proposed for the project include:

- **Inclusive community engagement**: Ensuring that all engagements include the vulnerable and recognising and acknowledging the crucial role of women and other genders in disaster management and community engagements will be vital. Efforts should be made to involve them in decision-making processes, ensuring inclusivity and fostering a sense of ownership within the community.
- **Tailored support for women's livelihoods:** The interventions will be designed to include tailored support for women's and other vulnerable group's livelihoods and employment opportunities, aligning these interventions with their specific needs and skills, to enhance their economic empowerment and resilience to climate change impacts.
- **Policies promoting women's access to natural resources:** The project will advocate through the appropriate channels the development of policies and implementation frameworks that facilitate women's access to natural resources.
- **Strengthening institutional capacity for climate resilience:** The project will aim to develop codes and standards that will guide investments in climate-resilient infrastructure, including gender-tailored infrastructure, for roads and bridges, and strengthening institutional capacity for infrastructure maintenance to mitigate the impacts of climate change on women and their communities.
- **Integrating gender perspectives into initiatives:** The project will, across all sites, implement awareness campaigns and initiatives that integrate gender perspectives into all project activities to contribute to greater gender equality, inclusivity, and resilience to climate change impacts in the DM.

### 6.2.4 Sekhukhune DM

In Sekhukhune DM, gendered impacts of climate change were highlighted through various stakeholder engagements and site assessments. Government officials, NGOs, civil society, and water users participated, shedding light on the disproportionate effects of floods on dwellings, roads, bridges, crops, and cropping land, particularly impacting women and vulnerable genders. Access to essential services like healthcare became even more challenging during floods. Stakeholders identified overgrazing and illegal sand mining exacerbating flood events, alongside poor settlement planning at both DM and LM levels, leading to regular negative impacts on communities, especially those located close to flood plains and within wetlands.

The site assessments confirmed medium to high flood risks in densely populated peri-urban areas, where poor settlement planning compounds the impact on communities, often situated near flood plains and within known floodlines. Additionally, the region's steep topography contributes to localised flash-flooding, posing threats to homes, livelihoods, and lives, with women and other vulnerable genders disproportionately affected. The presence of IAPs exacerbate these issues, with bush encroachment linked to wetland degradation and poor rangeland management, further impacting women's roles in livestock management and exacerbating flood risks.

Furthermore, extensive erosion during rains creates gullies and dongas, posing risks to communities' livelihoods and property, with dongas also threatening culverts and bridges.

The gender issues in the DM include the following:

- **Female headed households**: In Sekhukhune DM, slightly over 50% of households are headed by females, which contributes to their vulnerability. The sex ratio indicates a higher proportion of females across all municipalities in the project sites. While not solely a gender issue, imbalances in sex ratios can have implications.
- **Care and support burden:** Dependency ratios are high, placing additional burdens on the working class and affecting their ability to support themselves and their families. This may possibly hinder individuals, particularly women, from participating in the workforce or pursuing educational opportunities.
- **Low literacy and limited decision-making power:** Women and girls in the DM have lower educational attainment compared to men due to social norms, economic constraints, and limited opportunities. Despite being the majority, women often felt excluded from decision-making processes. Some men attribute this to limited education among women, implying that they may not fully understand management issues and resource management strategies.
- **Women's role in agriculture:** Women in the DM play crucial roles in agricultural production, including crop cultivation, livestock rearing, and food processing. However, their contributions are often undervalued and marginalised, with limited access to resources, and decision-making power.
- **Access to water and security issues:** During consultations, women expressed greater challenges than men during droughts as they had to find water and food for their families. There are concerning levels of gender-based violence, and women reportedly feel insecure when traveling away from home to collect resources. Additionally, they often lost their agricultural employment, further exacerbating their vulnerability.

To address the gender issues outlined above, several strategies within the Eco-DRR project will be considered for implementation:

- **Promoting gender-responsive land and resource management:** The project will align to the national gender framework to support equitable access to natural resources for women. Review and identify barriers with the existing frameworks will be undertaken alternative approaches developed to address the barriers. The project will implement initiatives that involve women in decision-making processes related to land use planning, conservation, and resource allocation.

- **Capacity building and training:** The interventions in the DM will include targeted training and capacity-building for women in agricultural practices, sustainable land management, and climate-resilient farming techniques. These sessions will aim to empower women with the knowledge and skills needed to actively participate in agricultural production, natural resource management, disaster preparedness and climate adaptation strategies.
- **Supporting women's economic empowerment:** Working with other government partners and NGOs, the project will promote women's entrepreneurship and income-generating activities in agriculture and natural resource-based enterprises. This will include encouraging the formation of women's cooperatives and self-help groups to strengthen collective bargaining power and access to markets.
- **Addressing gender-based violence:** The project takes gender-based violence seriously and will implement a SEAH policy where needed. The project will contribute to ongoing efforts to curtail gender-based violence and will foster partnerships between local authorities, civil society organisations, and community leaders to address the root causes of gender-based violence and promote gender equality and social justice.

# 7 GESI Innovations in the Eco-DRR Project Design

Climate change compounds several ongoing anthropogenic impacts, including inter alia overgrazing, the rapid spread of IAPs, soil compaction and the removal of natural vegetation cover, exacerbating the cycle of land degradation and poverty across large parts of rural South Africa. Due to women's strong reliance on natural resources, the cycle of degradation and decreasing resilience makes them particularly vulnerable to these impacts. For example, the loss of biodiversity forces women to spend more time and walk greater distances to collect fuel, water and food (Mubarak, 2021).

Climate change disproportionally impacts upon people in low-income and impoverished communities. In rural communities, women and girl children are responsible for a range of productive activities, as well as taking care of the family unit. Climate change impacts upon women most significantly, yet they are often excluded from decision making processes that impact upon them, most typically in communal areas where Traditional Leadership is a key part of the governance framework. Women are also vulnerable within peri-urban conditions as women control fewer resources than men in informal settlements and are frequently exposed to gender-based violence (Patel, et al., 2018). Furthermore, women in these settings often lack access to sanitation and face disruptions to paid work as a result of climate change events (Patel, et al., 2018).

South Africa also has a high proportion of peri-urban and rural communities living in formal and informal settlements that often have limited access to safe services with poor infrastructure. Within these affected communities, women and children are often most vulnerable to the impacts of climate change as they are often more reliant on access to natural resources that are required to support livelihoods. These communities are often also situated in areas that are exposed to hazards such as floods, which place both lives and livelihoods at extreme risk.

The Eco-DRR project aims to actively ensure that marginalised groups, especially women, are supported to adapt to climate change and do not face exacerbated inequalities due to their increased vulnerability to the impacts of climate change. To this end, the project will mainstream gender equity outcomes throughout the project life cycle, supported by effective monitoring and evaluation. Understanding the capacities, needs and priorities of women in relation to climate vulnerability will help inform the response and actions by ensuring a gender-sensitive approach. Engagements and direct community involvement throughout the course of the project will explore and develop approaches that not only ensure that the inputs of women and girl-children are brought into the design of climate adaptation responses, but also that these interventions are prioritised towards reduced vulnerability.

The Eco-DRR project will actively engage with women within communities to fully understand their needs and to leverage their local knowledge into site-based actions. The project will design these local interventions to facilitate their participation and involvement, as well as support the development of commodity value-chains that support the economic empowerment of women. This will contribute to attaining SDG 1: No Poverty, SDG 3: Good Health and Wellbeing, SDG 10: Reduced Inequalities and SDG 5: Gender Equality.

## 7.1 CO-BENEFIT 2 (SOCIAL AND GENDER)

Co-benefit 2 (Social and Gender) specifically focuses on women and aims to improve gender parity in representation of females engaged in adaptation decision-making. The indicator for this co-benefit is an increase in adaptation solutions that respond to females' priorities in local planning tools or through design thinking workshops. The target at the end of the project is for 30 to 40% of adaptation actions as per the local planning tools be responsive to priorities expressed by females.

## 7.2 OUTPUT 1.2. LOCAL, GENDER-INCLUSIVE AND SUSTAINABLE ECOSYSTEM-BASED LIVELIHOODS SUPPORT LOCALLY LED ADAPTATION.

Outcome 1 of the Eco-DRR project looks at the incorporation of Eco-DRR strategies into integrated landscape management that enhances the resilience of ecological infrastructure and climate-vulnerable communities. The Outcome will explore how gender-inclusive and sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods can be enabled or improved in support of locally led adaptation. Additionally, the outcome will focus on youth and the criticality of ensuring that the skills deficits that frequently exist within rural contexts are addressed. The upskilling of youths through job creation linked to sustainable ecosystem-based livelihood options by looking at SMMEs and the eco-champs model, will provide opportunities for youth to innovate and to support in developing sustainable and climate resilient futures.

In particular, Output 1.2. focuses on strengthening resilient and sustainable economic frameworks for local communities through the introduction of gender-inclusive, ecosystem-based livelihood stacking strategies to diversify income sources and reduce vulnerability in the targeted landscapes of the Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs.

One of the activities seeks to identify and assess opportunities to develop sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods in support of locally led adaptation. A more detailed assessment of community livelihoods in the Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni DMs will be conducted to assess communities' dependencies on natural, physical and social capital and their vulnerability to climate change. The analysis will link livelihoods to market opportunities for the various ecosystem-based commodity value chains and opportunities linked to green job creation. This will pay particular attention to gender aspects by ensuring women are empowered through gender-sensitive sources of employment, capacity building and awareness raising.

To ensure successful implementation of this activity, the activity's indicator will look at the number of females supported to develop ecosystem-based livelihoods with a target of 300 women (150 per DM i.e. Alfred Nzo and Ehlanzeni) at the end of the project. Specific attention will be placed on supporting women either through SMMEs or through other initiatives focused on the exchange of indigenous knowledge and the improvement of local livelihood practices. Records will be maintained and will be captured in progress reports

# 8 Gender Action Plan

**IMPACT STATEMENT:** The improved economic empowerment of women through the Eco-DRR project by integrating gender-responsive and gender-sensitive initiatives and interventions into the design and implementation of interventions as well as in the procurement, management and operational functions. This will be done by (1) enhancing the capacity of women in communities and implementing partners, (2) undertaking continuous learning and adapting the project to gender sensitive practices, (3) improving the working conditions, procurement processes and creating gender-specific contracting provisions and appointment of staff, (4) selecting interventions that are gender-responsive and that do not exacerbate existing social inequalities and (5) ensuring that that there are appropriate budget allocations for gender activities.

**OUTCOME STATEMENT:** Women are empowered to actively participate and benefit from the Eco-DRR project through improved resilience and disaster preparedness to climate change-induced hazards.

Many of the activities under this plan will be led by staff and support teams that will be appointed. The second in command staff member will also be a monitoring and evaluation expert, and SANBI will also include as part of their shared services staff who can support the M&E and gender aspects too. Once the many initial interventions under A: Planning and Governance have been undertaken, the PMU and key lead staff will be trained to support on the aspects related to gender. Equally the support staff provided by the DFFE will have at least one person who is trained up in both community engagement, gender sensitive approaches and environmental and social safeguards.

The project and intervention level gender action plans are presented below.

## 8.1 PROJECT AND INTERVENTION LEVEL GENDER ACTION PLAN

*Table 8.-1: Project and intervention level gender action plan.*

| Action | Indicator / Target | Timeline | Responsible | Budget |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Project Level** | | | | |
| **Intervention A: Planning and Governance** | | | | |
| **A.1 Embed gender considerations in the establishment and operationalisation of the PMU**<br><br>a) Develop appropriate gender mainstreaming framework for the PMU<br>b) Apply gender specific quotas to staff complement<br>c) Apply gender specific quotas in senior decision-making positions<br>d) Engender participation in project management processes<br>e) Create gender-sensitive working conditions included:<br>• Develop contracts with gender-responsive provisions such as: maternity and paternity leave, childcare and pension provisions, as well as flexible hours and remote working for employees.<br>• Create private and safe facilities for males, females, and gender-neutral parties that are relevant and responsive to project interventions.<br>• Provide safe spaces for religious and cultural observance, and safe and private spaces for breastfeeding and other parenting needs. | a) Gender responsive and inclusive human resources frameworks developed and approved by the Project Management Group (PMG).<br>• 100% of gender issues are considered in the Gender Framework (including procurement policy, sexual exploitation, abuse and harassment (SEAH) and grievance mechanisms).<br>• Communication to 100% of employees, once approved.<br>b) % of females employed in the PMU.<br>• 40% target (national target is a minimum of 30%).<br>c) % of females in senior, decision-making positions.<br>• 40% target.<br>d) % of female participation in sanitation frameworks for committee members.<br>• 40% target.<br>e) Contracts outlining the gender-sensitive work conditions in place.<br>• 100% of appointment contracts are gender sensitive.<br>• 100% of operational office modalities consider gender in their protocols. | Y1 of establishment of the PMU | PMG<br>Project Steering Committee (PSC) | 10 000 USD |
| **A.2 Integrate gender considerations into procurement policy** | a) Contracts to reflect quota for historically disadvantaged companies or female-led companies developed. | Y1 of implementation | PMU<br>PMG | 10 000 USD |

| Action | Indicator / Target | Timeline | Responsible | Budget |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| a) Ensure procurement processes (women in the value chain) target historically disadvantaged run companies and/or female-led companies[6]<br>b) Ensure all interventions have Terms of Reference and Requests for Proposals that are gender responsive. | • 40% of contracts to be contracted to historically disadvantaged companies or female-led companies[7].<br>b) Gender mainstreaming[8] integrated into Terms of Reference and Requests for Proposals.<br>• 100% of Terms of Reference and Requests for Proposals incorporate gender mainstreaming. | | | |
| **Intervention B: Capacity Building and Awareness** | | | | |
| **B.1 Ensure gender inclusion in Eco-DRR brand development and communications strategies**<br><br>a) Develop a specific strategy for communicating gender activities.<br>b) Ensure that communication materials are gender inclusive. | a) Gender communication strategy[9] completed and implemented.<br>• Approved by PMG.<br>b) Annual report that reflects gender activities published.<br>• At least 2-3 gender-activities are coordinated each year.<br>c) Share gender lessons on various communities of practice locally, nationally and internationally.<br>d) Create opportunities to share lessons learned across the project, with different intervention sites/areas. | Y1 of establishment<br><br>Throughout the project | PMU | 20 000 USD |
| **B.2 Publish gender-focused knowledge products** | a) Gender-focused knowledge product developed and published. | Y2 onwards | PMU | 50 000 USD |

[6] Criteria for female-led companies include: companies that are at least 51% owned by one or more women in the case of any publicly-owned business or at least 51% of the stock of which is owned by one or more women and the management and daily business operations of which are controlled by more women. Criteria for historically disadvantaged run companies include: companies that are owned or controlled by historically disadvantaged South Africans. Historically disadvantaged individual is defined as a South African citizen – 1) who, due to the apartheid policy that was in place, had no voting rights in the national elections prior to the introduction of the Constitution of the Republic of South Africa, 1983 (Act No. 100 of 1983) or the Constitution of the Republic of South Africa, 1993 (Act No. 200 of 1993) ("the interim Constitution"), and/or 2) who is a woman, and/or 3) who has a disability.

[7] Government policy has embedded quotas for women. The August 2024 Presidential Pronouncement put forward a target to allocate at least 40% of procurement spend to women-owned businesses.

[8] GCF's Mainstreaming Gender in Green Climate Fund Projects https://www.greenclimate.fund/sites/default/files/document/guidelines-gcf-toolkit-mainstreaming-gender_0.pdf

[9] Communications strategy to be inclusive of gender mainstreaming and focuses on communicating the work of the project through a gendered lens i.e. news articles, opinion pieces, etc.

| Action | Indicator / Target | Timeline | Responsible | Budget |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| a) Develop gender-focused knowledge products at project level to inform intervention level outcomes.<br>• Assess gender participation in decision-making processes and respond to needs and imbalances.<br>• Determine research initiatives to attract women to careers in natural resource management and climate change.<br>• Unpack current social inequalities in the natural resource management sector and publish findings.<br>• Identify the main skills women workers require for capacity building including communication skills, literacy, computer, management.<br>• Research the linkages between gender, natural resource management and climate change. | • At least 1 knowledge products published at the start of the project and 1 product at mid-term.<br>b) Gender guidelines for landscape management developed. | | | |
| **B.3 Strengthen institutional capacity and awareness**<br><br>a) Conduct needs assessment to identify gender-specific training interventions and at which level these interventions must be targeted towards.<br>b) Develop a gender training plan for the project based on outcomes from needs assessments.<br>c) Implement specific training interventions for relevant project staff (including diversity and inclusion workshops, and training on specific gender policy requirements, such as SEAH, and monitoring of gender activities, procurement). See training needs outlined in Environmental and Social Management Framework (ESMF).<br>d) Develop capacity of relevant senior project management regarding gender mainstreaming and its processes (oversight and grievance mechanisms). | a) Capacity amongst relevant staff developed.<br>• 2 training sessions held annually.<br>• 100% orientation and training on diversity and inclusion, gender policy requirements, monitoring of gender activities, procurement).<br>b) Senior management capacity built.<br>• 2 training sessions held annually.<br>• 100% orientation and training on guidance on labour standards and gender terminology. | Annual | PMU | 30 000 USD |
| **Intervention C: Monitoring, Evaluation and Reporting** | | | | |

| Action | Indicator / Target | Timeline | Responsible | Budget |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **C.1 Design a gender framework and monitoring and reporting strategies**<br><br>a) Develop a gender monitoring and evaluation framework and strategy, including a tracking tool. | a) Gender monitoring and evaluation framework, strategy and tracking tool developed and implemented.<br>• Gender monitoring and evaluation framework, strategy and tracking tool developed and approved by PMG.<br>• Intervention level SEAH monitoring and evaluation frameworks developed including specific indicators and monitoring tools to assess the effectiveness of SEAH prevention measures. | Y2 | PMU<br>PMG | 30 000 USD |
| **C.2 Appoint 2 X Process Manager that Fulfils the Functions of a Social and Gender Oversight Officer**<br><br>a) Undertake recruitment and appointment of a process manager that fulfils the functions of a social and gender oversight officer. | b) 2 X Process Manager that fulfils the functions of a social and gender oversight officer appointed.<br>• Appointment of 2 X Process Manager approved by PMG | Y2 | PMU<br>PMG | 2 000 USD (recruitment) |
| **C.3 Measure gender disaggregated outcomes**<br><br>a) Implement monitoring and evaluation framework and tracking tool that collects and collates sex-disaggregated data. | a) Quarterly reports with sex-disaggregated outcomes developed.<br>• Quarterly reports submitted by PMU and approved by PMG. | Quarterly, once the interventions are initiated | Tracked and implemented PMU. Approved by PMG. | 5 000 USD |
| **C. 4 Undertake continuous monitoring, evaluation, and learning**<br><br>a) Implement monitoring and evaluation framework and tracking tool that ensures the following:<br>• Compliance<br>• Employment gender profiles<br>• Training and capacity building<br>• Intervention level benefits and beneficiaries<br>• SEAH<br>• Gender resources utilisation (human and finance) | a) Quarterly reports developed.<br>• Quarterly reports submitted by PMU and approved by PMG.<br>• Amend frameworks, guidelines, etc based on lessons learned through the project. | Annually once the interventions are initiated | Tracked and implemented PMU. Approved by PMG. | 10 000 USD |
| **Intervention Level** | | | | |

| Action | Indicator / Target | Timeline | Responsible | Budget |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Intervention A: Planning and Governance** | | | | |
| **A.1 Alignment to project-level gender framework** | a) Intervention level gender mainstreaming plans developed[10][11].<br>• 100% of all interventions have a gender mainstreaming plan.<br>• 100% of all intervention gender mainstreaming plans are aligned to project's policies and guidance.<br>• All intervention level gender mainstreaming plans to have gender disaggregated indicators and targets (where appropriate), timelines, who is responsible, and costs. | Y2 onwards | PMU and Task Teams | 10 000 USD |
| **A.2 Map institutional / governance gender elements at intervention-level** | a) Intervention level gender mainstreaming assessment to identify risks and clarify gaps and roles and responsibilities of different genders in governance arrangements in the targeted DMs and communities undertaken.<br>• 100% of all intervention gender mainstreaming plans link to municipal and community gaps and opportunities. | Y2 onwards | PMU and Task Teams | 20 000 USD |
| **A.3 Ensure all interventions' designs are gender sensitive** | a) Site specific Gender sensitive intervention designs developed and implemented.<br>• 100% of all interventions' designs prioritises females' needs. | Y2 onwards | PMU and Task Teams | 30 000 USD |

[10] The two process managers (that will perform the functions of the Social and Gender Oversight Officer) will support the development of the intervention level gender action plans.
[11] The intervention level gender mainstreaming plans will describe how gender will be mainstreamed into the different outcomes including Outcome 3 (*Output 3.1. Financial mechanisms developed and strengthened to enhance private and public sector investments in Eco-DRR* and *Output 3.2. Informed decision making for Eco-DRR is supported and promoted*). This will be undertaken during the inception phase. SANBI will ensure that the financial mechanisms that are developed under this Outcome are gender responsive and respond to the traditional barriers for women, women owned businesses and traditionally marginalised people encounter when accessing financing.

| Action | Indicator / Target | Timeline | Responsible | Budget |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **A.4 Align intervention procurement to project's procurement framework** | a) Equipment from female-led[12] SMMEs procured during public procurement process.<br>• 30% of all equipment is purchased from female -led SMMEs.<br>• % of machinery and equipment procured from companies that are owned by historically disadvantaged individuals.<br>• 50% of machinery and equipment purchased from companies owned by historically disadvantaged individuals (in accordance with broad based black economic empowerment).<br>b) Capacitation programmes developed at intervention level to up-skill workers to ensure that the modernisation of technology does not adversely impact the economic empowerment of women.<br>• 100% of all interventions have a gendered capacitation and training programme. | Y2 onwards | PMU and Task Teams | 30 000 USD |
| **Intervention B: Capacity Building and Awareness** | | | | |
| **B.1 Shared repository of resources, templates, information and tools** | a) Database of templates, information and tools developed and operationalised.<br>• 100% of all gender policies, guidance material and tools are available at intervention level through a shared portal.<br>• Training session held on the use of these policies, guidance materials and | Y1<br><br>Throughout the project | PMU and Task Teams | 20 000 USD |

[12] Criteria for female-led companies include: companies that are at least 51% owned by one or more women in the case of any publicly-owned business or at least 51% of the stock of which is owned by one or more women and the management and daily business operations of which are controlled by more women.

| Action | Indicator / Target | Timeline | Responsible | Budget |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | tools at the inception phase of all interventions.<br>b) Document library generated for gender-focused narratives regarding climate vulnerability within targeted communities.<br>• 100% of all gender-focused narratives are available at intervention level through a shared portal. | | | |
| **B.2 Create awareness** | a) Implementing partners and key stakeholders capacitated regarding gender and its intervention and project level implications.<br>• 100% of interventions have an awareness creation session held at the beginning of each intervention regarding gender mainstreaming and its importance.<br>• 100% of all interventions have a mid-term project awareness session on gender mainstreaming and its progress. | Y2 onwards<br><br>Project staff to drive | PMU and Task Teams | 20 000 USD |
| **B.3 Implement training activities** | a) Intervention level training interventions are gender focused and available to all women at intervention level.<br>• 100% of training interventions consider gender aspects.<br>• 100% of intervention training are attended by at least 50% females<br>• All interventions host at least 2 gender training sessions per year. | Y2 onwards | PMU and Task Teams | Budgets linked to ESMF training which included gender, SEAH etc |
| **B.4 Support gender sensitive engagements** | a) Gender sensitive intervention community engagements undertaken<br>• 100% of engagements at intervention level are gender sensitive. | Y2 onwards<br><br>Project staff to support | PMU and Task Teams | 10 000 USD |

| Action | Indicator / Target | Timeline | Responsible | Budget |
| --- | --- | --- | --- | --- |
| | b) Engagements with women focused organisations undertaken during inception.<br>• 8 engagements during inception. | | | |
| **Intervention C: Monitoring, Evaluation, and Reporting** | | | | |
| **C.1 Determine the baseline** | a) Intervention level baseline assessments undertaken for each intervention.<br>• 100% projects included a baseline gender assessment.<br>b) Findings from the assessment collated to support the current gender assessment and action plan.<br>• Finding from the assessments are integrated into intervention level gender mainstreaming plans and monitoring of project impacts. | Y2 onwards | PMU and Task Teams | Costed in M&E Plan Annexure |
| **C.2 Report on monitoring and evaluation activities (with disaggregated data, where available)** | a) Compliance at intervention level assessed.<br>• 90% compliance with policies, guides and tools is ensured in all interventions.<br>b) Employment gender profiles developed for each intervention.<br>• Gender employment targets for all interventions achieved.<br>c) Training and capacity building undertaken at intervention level.<br>• All training and capacity building interventions are monitored and reported upon in terms of gender.<br>• Capture and track stories of change from baseline throughout project implementation.<br>d) Intervention level benefits and beneficiaries tracked and monitored. | Y2 onwards<br><br>Beneficiation and utilisation to be determined by PMU as project is delivered. | PMU and Task Teams | Training costed under M&E plan Annexure. |

| Action | Indicator / Target | Timeline | Responsible | Budget |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | • 100% of interventions are monitored for impact on beneficiaries, using gender disaggregated data collection.<br>e) SEAH tracked and monitored at intervention level.<br>• 100% of all cases of SEAH are addressed in accordance with policies and guidelines.<br>• 100% of all SEAH cases are sensitively documented in alignment with policies and protocols.<br>• In 100% of SEAH cases, appropriate actions and interventions are taken and reported.<br>f) Gender resources utilisation (human and finance) monitored and tracked at intervention level.<br>• 100% of interventions monitor and document the utilisation of gender resources, both in terms of time and budget.<br>• Corrective action to address utilisation of under 50% (on both time and budget) is documented and reported. | | | |
| | | | **TOTAL** | **307 000 USD** |

## 8.2 ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

The PMU will be responsible for implementing the overarching gender action plan for the Eco-DRR project. The process managers (X2) will be responsible for performing the functions of the Social and Gender Oversight Officers at an intervention level. As such, they will be responsible for implementing the intervention-level gender action plans that will be developed during inception.

As highlighted in the ESMF, the Social and Gender Oversight Officers (i.e. process managers) will have expertise in conducting social and gender studies, ensuring compliance and auditing, including knowledge of the supporting legislation and regulations, guidelines and policies related to social, gender and SEAH aspects. The officers must conduct audits in terms of the ESMF and the Gender Action Plan for the intervention. A minimum of one site inspection must be undertaken per quarter, for the duration of the implementation activities.

Each Social and Gender Oversight Officer will be responsible for monitoring, reviewing and verifying compliance with the ESMF and the Gender Action Plan by the Contractor within their respective DMs. Duties in this regard will include the following:

- Monitor and verify that the ESMF, Gender Action Plan and programme policies are adhered to at all times and recommending necessary action if the specifications and mitigation measures are not followed;
- Monitor and verify that social and gender impacts are kept to a minimum;
- Must obtain, examine and approve method statements to overview processes;
- Assist the Contractor in finding socially responsible solutions to problems;
- Report back on the social and gender issues at the site meetings and other meetings that may be called regarding environmental matters, if required;
- Monitor and review the site diary of all activities / incidents / complaints concerning the social and gender aspects onsite;
- Inspect the site and surrounding working areas regarding compliance with the ESMF;
- Be reachable by the public regarding matters of social and gender concerns as they relate to the development;
- Provide social and gender awareness training for site personnel;
- Recommend corrective actions to the Environmental Programmes and Safeguards Officer and the Contractor where activities are not in compliance with the ESMF;
- Inform the Environmental Programmes and Safeguards Officer immediately of the occurrence of non-compliances and recommend appropriate measures of rectification;
- Ensure that activities onsite comply with legislative and regulatory requirements; and
- Undertake quarterly site visits, compile and submit quarterly reports to the Beneficiary, PMU, Environmental Programmes and Safeguards Officer and Contractor.

During closure, the Social and Gender Oversight Officers (i.e. 2 X Process Managers) will be responsible for monitoring, reviewing and verifying compliance with the Closure Plan by the Contractor during intervention closure. The officer must conduct audits in terms of the Closure Plan during the intervention closure. A minimum of one site inspection must be undertaken per month, for the duration of the closure activities.

Duties in this regard will include the following:

- Monitor and verify that the Closure Plan and project policies are adhered to at all times and recommending necessary action if the specifications and mitigation measures are not followed;
- Monitor and verify that social and gender impacts are kept to a minimum;
- Must obtain, examine and approve method statements to overview processes;
- Assist the Contractor in finding socially responsible solutions to problems during intervention closure;
- Report back on the social and gender issues at the site meetings and other meetings that may be called regarding environmental matters, if required;
- Monitor and review the site diary of all activities / incidents / complaints concerning the social and gender aspects onsite, during the closure process;
- Inspect the site and surrounding working areas regarding compliance with the Closure Plan;
- Be reachable by the public regarding matters of social and gender concerns as they relate to the intervention closure process;
- Recommend corrective actions to the Environmental Programmes and Safeguards Officer and the Contractor where closure activities are not in compliance with the Closure Plan;
- Inform the Environmental Programmes and Safeguards Officer immediately of the occurrence of non-compliances and recommend appropriate measures of rectification;
- Ensure that activities onsite comply with legislative and regulatory requirements; and
- Undertake quarterly site visits, compile and submit quarterly reports to the Beneficiary, PMU, Environmental Programmes and Safeguards Officer and Contractor.

## 8.3 MECHANISMS TO PREVENT AND ADDRESS GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE

While the Eco-DRR project does not entail any major construction, the implementation of activities related to rangeland management, wetland rehabilitation, slope management and IAP removal may entail the introduction of contractors and workers in specific areas. Those who are away from home on these types of jobs are separated from their family and may act outside their normal sphere of social control. This can lead to inappropriate and criminal behaviour, such as sexual harassment of women and girls, exploitative sexual relations, and illicit sexual relations with minors from the local community. Influx of male labour may also lead to an increase in exploitative sexual relationships and human trafficking whereby women and girls are forced into sex work.

Projects can create changes in the communities in which they operate and can cause shifts in power dynamics between community members and within households. These changes can contribute to higher levels of gender-based violence associated with the project. Gender-based violence incidents are likely to occur as a result of higher wages for workers in a community contributing to transactional sex. The risk of incidents is among labourers and minors in the community as well as between male workers and lower earning females or adult females in the community. Gender-based violence is also associated with SEAH. Sexual harassment involves any unwelcome sexual or requests for sexual favours or acts of a sexual nature that are offensive and humiliating among the same company's employees, including companies contracted to do works on behalf of government. Sexual exploitation and abuse are more likely and occur when a company's workers use their position to extract an unwanted sexual act from a member of the community in exchange for access to project benefits, including inclusion of households for casual labour positions.

Gender-based violence can also include rape, contracting sexually transmitted diseases and unwanted pregnancies. Male jealousy, a key driver of gender-based violence, can be triggered by an influx of labourers on a project and when the workers are believed / perceived to be interacting with community women. Abusive behaviour can also occur not only between project-related staff and those living in and around the project site, but also within the homes of those affected by the project.

To address these issues, the Environmental Social Management Framework (ESMF) process will be followed during project implementation. During the Screening, Categorisation and Assessment Phase, SEAH and environmental and social screening checklists will be used to ensure that there are no risks to communities in the implementation sites regarding gender-based violence or SEAH. This is also highlighted in the exclusion list which excludes any interventions that:

1. Negatively affect specific socio-economic groups such as ethnic groups, women, minorities, etc., their basic needs (e.g. reducing income and food supply) and strategic needs (e.g. limiting agency and decision-making power).
2. Are likely to intensify discriminatory practices particularly against women, including gender-based violence.

In addition to the above, site specific ESMFs will be developed to provide specify ways to address potential gender-based violence in interventions based on the type of activities. Use of conflict resolution mechanisms, grievance redress mechanism (GRM), SEAH procedures (as guided by national legislation, GCF safeguards and SANBI's gender policy and strategies), gender-based approaches and ongoing stakeholder engagements will support the management of these risks.

Training and capacity building regarding gender-based violence and SEAH is presented in the table below:

*Table 8-2: Capacity development and training plan regarding gender-based violence and SEAH for the Eco-DRR project*[13]

| Capacity Building and Training Plan | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Objectives** | **Issues for engagement** | **Method of engagement** | **Stakeholders / Target population and area** | **Responsible person** | **Timeline** | **Potential Costs (USD)** |
| **Gender-based violence procedures for reporting and prevention** | Training and monitoring during project implementation to prevent GBV and support reporting of cases | Training and monitoring | Community members / vulnerable groups | Process Managers, Gender-Based Violence / Gender Consultant | Prior to commencement of activities ***(Year 1-2)*** | 10,000 |
| **Gender-based violence / SEAH** | Training of all relevant agencies / staff in the ESMF | Training | Eco-DRR relevant agencies / staff responsible for the implementation of environmental and social instruments. | PMU, Process Managers, Gender Specialist | Prior to commencement ***(Year 2)*** | 16,000 |

[13] More details regarding the training and capacity building plan can be found in Annex 6: ESMF

| Capacity Building and Training Plan | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Objectives** | **Issues for engagement** | **Method of engagement** | **Stakeholders / Target population and area** | **Responsible person** | **Timeline** | **Potential Costs (USD)** |
| **Gender-based violence** | Response to domestic issues in a non- gender biased manner. This considers the changes in household power dynamics that may unintentionally increase levels of gender-based violence. To address this potential risk, male engagement strategies will also be included under this activity to mitigate these concerns. | Training | Local leaders in intervention locations | PMU, Process Managers | Prior to commencement of activities ***(Year 2)*** | 10,000 |
| **Mitigate impact of workers on local communities (Labour management procedures and gender-based violence / SEAH)** | Implement training of contracted project workers designed to heighten awareness of risks and to mitigate impacts on local communities and their rights | Training | Contracted workers and community workers in intervention locations | All relevant agencies / staff | Prior to deployment ***(Year 2-3)*** | 5,000 |

### 8.3.1 GRM

According to the UNDP's Social and Environmental Standards, a GRM is defined as an organisational system and resources established by national government, regional or municipal agencies to receive and address concerns about the impact of their policies, programmes and operations on external stakeholders (UNDP, 2017).

The GRM outlined in this section is designed to support the Eco-DRR project and serves as a platform for targeted communities, affected stakeholders, project workers, and other involved parties at the local level to address any grievances related to the project. The GRM presented in the report would not impede access to South Africa's judicial or administrative procedures. Three key GRMs are presented for the Eco-DRR project: 1) Project-Level GRM; 2) SANBI's Whistleblowing Hotline and SANBI's Environmental and/or Social Harms and Gender Discrimination complaints process and 3) GCF's Independent Redress Mechanism (IRM).

**Project Level GRM**

The Eco-DRR Project-Level GRM addresses a variety of pertinent issues related to the project, including environmental impacts, land use conflicts, socio-economic disruptions, discrimination in benefit sharing, violation of rules or cultural practices, and cultural heritage preservation. It focuses specifically on the impacts and risks stemming from the Eco-DRR project throughout its life cycle. Stakeholders involved or affected by the project, such as local communities, government agencies, and project implementers, are within the purview of this mechanism. This framework will handle complaints and requests, which may include but are not limited to:

- Misconduct of project workers towards communities;
- Gender-based sexual harassment;
- Misconduct of project contractors;
- Water and land pollution;
- Damage to private assets, community, and public infrastructure;
- Inappropriate waste disposal;
- Environmental degradation; and
- Other related concerns.

The Project-Level GRM complies with all relevant laws, regulations, and international standards as well as several project specific documents such as the ESMF, SANBI's and DFFE's environmental, social and gender policies and procedures.

**SANBI GRM**

Grievances related to any SANBI activities can be raised through SANBI's Whistleblowing Hotline and through SANBI's Environmental and/or Social Harms and Gender Discrimination complaints process. Information on communication channels for inquiries and complaints can found in the Annex 7: Summary of Consultations, Site Level Stakeholder Plan and Grievance Mechanism.

*Communication channels for inquiries and complaints received*

SANBI has an environmental and/or social harms and gender discrimination complaints process. SANBI's flowchart on complaints regarding Environmental and/or Social Harms and Gender Discrimination demonstrates the mechanism used to deal with complaints. In 2024 minor changes were made to the process to receive and respond to complaints to better align with SANBI's operational procedures. The process is reflected in the flowchart which is available on the "Contact" page of SANBI's website, as per the description below.

SANBI's high-level statement communicating its zero tolerance for environmental and/or social harms and gender discrimination arising from SANBI's activities appears on SANBI's official website (https://www.sanbi.org/contact/). The main landing page (https://www.sanbi.org/) includes the following text: "*Report complaints on environmental and/or social harms and gender discrimination arising from SANBI's activities Email:* safeguards@sanbi.org.za".

This is linked to further details on the Contact page (https://www.sanbi.org/contact/) on the official SANBI website where it states: *"Environmental and/or social harms and gender discrimination... SANBI has zero tolerance for environmental and/or social* *harms and gender discrimination arising from SANBI's activities. To report complaints on environmental and/or social harms and gender discrimination: Email: safeguards@sanbi.org.za*"

*Whistle blowing*

A Whistleblowing Hotline is fully functional and is administered and managed by Advance Call: Ethics and Fraud Hotline. Advance Call reports any cases of fraud or misconduct to SANBI Management for investigation if warranted. The Whistleblowing Hotline can also be used to receive complaints regarding Environmental and/or Social Harms and Gender Discrimination. The Advance Call system allows for anonymous whistleblowing. SANBI also receives and administers formal, informal and anonymous matters from various communication mediums. This includes a dedicated internal SANBI fraud email address, administered by SANBI's Director: Governance, Risk and Compliance. The protection of Whistleblowers is included in SANBI's Fraud Prevention Policy.

SANBI maintains Hotline Registers of all reported matters reported through the hotline. SANBI's Risk Management and Fraud Prevention Committee, which is chaired by the Chief Operations Officer, adjudicates on alleged cases reported through the whistleblowing system or other approved means. These cases are reported quarterly to the Audit and Risk Committee, which is a sub-Committee of the SANBI Board. Enterprise Risk Management Reports are presented at SANBI's Audit and Risk Committee, as per the process above. SANBI's Hotline Registers include details of the incident, progress in its resolution, status and responsible party.

SANBI's Whistleblowing Hotline is accessed through SANBI's website, as per the description below.

SANBI's high-level statement communicating its zero tolerance for fraud and corruption appears on SANBI's official website (https://www.sanbi.org/contact/). The main landing page (https://www.sanbi.org/) includes the following text: "*To report suspected fraud at SANBI. Email: sanbi@behonest.co.za. Call: 0800 160 999*". This is linked to further details on the Contact page (https://www.sanbi.org/contact/) on the official SANBI website where it states:

- Ethics and fraud hotline reporting channels
  - SANBI has zero tolerance of fraud and corruption. To report suspected fraud at SANBI:
  - Tel.: 0800 160 999
  - WhatsApp: 0860 004 004
  - SMS number: 48691
  - Free post: BNT165, Brooklyn Square, 0075
  - E-mail: sanbi@behonest.co.za
  - Website and chat link: www.behonest.co.za

**SEAH in Relation to the GRM**

The Eco-DRR project will develop and implement a zero tolerance approach to sexual harassment to ensure a safe and respectful environment for all participants and stakeholders across the targeted DMs. The prevention of SEAH requires an approach that will address both individual behaviours and systemic factors. The project will, from the onset, implement the following to prevent SEAH:

- **Policy Development:** The project will develop a clear and comprehensive SEAH policy that outline expected behaviours, define prohibited conduct, and establish consequences for violations. The policy will be communicated to all project participants and stakeholders during the inception phase through training and workshops.
- **Training and Awareness**: Throughout the project, gender awareness training will be conducted including regular sessions and awareness campaigns to educate project staff, volunteers, beneficiaries, and partners about SEAH, its impact, and ways to prevent and respond to incidents. The SEAH sessions will include topics such as consent, boundaries, power dynamics, and reporting procedures and should be led by trained gender focal points or other issue experts. Engagements with local communities and stakeholders will help to raise awareness about SEAH, build trust, and foster collaboration in prevention efforts. Community leaders, religious leaders, and other influential figures will be involved in promoting positive social norms and values.
- **Code of Conduct:** To ensures compliance, contractors and implementing partners will be required to sign a code of conduct which will include guidelines for respectful communication, appropriate interactions, and the avoidance of abusive behaviour and consequences should one violate the agreement.
- **Promotion of Gender Equality**: SEAH can also be prevented by promoting gender equality and women's empowerment within the project as well as challenging gender stereotypes and norms that perpetuate SEAH.
- **Safe Reporting Mechanisms**: The project will establish accessible and confidential reporting mechanisms for individuals to report incidents of SEAH. Multiple reporting options, such as hotlines, email, physical drop-boxes, and designated focal points, will be provided to accommodate different preferences and ensure survivors' privacy and safety. In addition, the project will encourage open communication channels and feedback mechanisms to empower individuals to raise concerns and grievances.
- **Response and Support Services**: The project will refer survivors of SEAH to established local-level appropriate support services, including psychosocial support, medical assistance, Legal Aid, and referrals to specialised service providers. The project will also facilitate access to support resources and follow-up services as needed.
- **Monitoring and Evaluation**: The project will collect data on reported incidents, response times, and outcomes to identify areas for improvement and adjust approaches as necessary. This will enable evaluation of the effectiveness of SEAH prevention strategies and interventions.

**GCF's Independent Redress Mechanism (IRM)**

The GCF has established an IRM[14] that is responsible for:

1. Reviewing requests for reconsideration of a project or programme that has been denied funding by the Board and, as appropriate, make recommendations to the Board;
2. Addressing grievances or complaints by a person, group of persons or community who/which have been or may be adversely impacted by a GCF funded project or programme through problem solving and/or compliance review, as appropriate;
3. Initiating proceedings on its own to investigate grievances of a person, group of persons or community who/which have been or may be adversely impacted by a GCF funded project or programme;

[14] Independent Redress Mechanism | Green Climate Fund

4. Monitoring whether decisions taken by the Board based on recommendations made by the IRM, or agreements reached in connection with grievances or complaints through problem solving, have been implemented, and reporting on that monitoring to the Board;
5. Recommending to the Board the reconsideration of existing policies, procedures, guidelines and systems of the GCF based on lessons learned or good international practices;
6. Sharing best practices and give general guidance that can be helpful for the GCF's readiness activities and accreditation process and for supporting the strengthening of the capacities of accountability / redress mechanisms of Direct Access Entities; and
7. Providing education and outreach to GCF staff, relevant stakeholders and the public (GCF, n.d.).

Points 2 and 3 apply to the Eco-DRR project and GRM.

When submitting a grievance or complaint by those adversely affected[15] or who may be affected by GCF funded projects or programmes, the grievance or complaint can be submitted through the Project-Level GRM. If the grievance / complaint is not addressed through the Project-Level GRM and/or the complainant is not satisfied with the outcome, the complainant can submit their grievance / complaint to the IRM. The grievance or complaint can also be submitted by the complainants' government or duly authorised representative.

The GCF's IRM policy notes that there are no formal requirements for filing a grievance or complaint. However, the name, address, telephone number, email, and other contact information of the complainant must be provided. In addition, the following information needs to be provided:

- The name, location, and nature of the project or programme that has caused or may cause adverse impacts;
- A brief explanation as to how the complainant has been, or may be, adversely affected by the GCF funded project or programme; and
- An indication of whether confidentiality is requested by the complainant.

The complainant can also include additional information related to GCF policies and procedures that are not being complied with, a description of other efforts/GRMs that the complainant pursued, and relevant documents, photographs, videos etc.

The grievance or complaint can be submitted to the IRM through any means (online complaints form, mail, email, voice or video recording, or by calling a toll-free hotline setup by the IRM). Within 5 calendar days from the receipt of a grievance or complaint, the IRM shall send an acknowledgment and register the grievance or complaint in the IRM registers. The IRM shall then consider whether the grievance or complaint meets the eligibility criteria set out in its policy (see Appendix E). The eligibility determination shall be made within 30 calendar days from the date of acknowledgment. The IRM will publish its eligibility determination on the IRM website within 5 calendar days of making its determination.

Once the grievance or complaint is determined to be eligible, the IRM will within 60 calendar days engage with the complainant to understand the issue and to ascertain whether the complainant would like to pursue problem solving and/or compliance review (a separate process if followed for compliance review and this is included in Appendix E). The IRM will

[15] This can include by a person or group of persons or community who has/have been or who may be adversely affected

also engage with other stakeholders, comprising of the GCF, NDA or Focal Point, Direct Access Entity and Executing Entity, to understand better the issues and the context, as appropriate. Problem solving will be offered to the complainant, but if this is declined or is unviable, the IRM shall within 5 calendar days of that event refer the grievance or complaint to compliance review in accordance with the provisions in its policy (Appendix E). Within 5 calendar days of the decision to refer to compliance review, in consultation with the other stakeholders, the IRM shall publish a report on the IRM website of this decision and the outcome of problem solving.

# 9 Conclusion and Recommendations

South Africa has made significant strides in bridging the gender gap over the years. One of its notable achievements is the constitutional commitment to gender equality, which is supported by legislative frameworks promoting women's rights and participation in various spheres. The country has witnessed an increase in women's representation in politics and decision-making roles, with women holding key positions in government and the private sector. Efforts to address gender-based violence have also seen improvements through legal reforms and initiatives aimed at supporting survivors and raising awareness. Additionally, educational opportunities for girls have expanded, contributing to greater gender parity in schools and higher education.

However, despite these advancements, challenges persist in achieving full gender equality in South Africa. Gender-based violence remains a significant concern, with high rates of femicide and intimate partner violence affecting women's safety and well-being. Economic disparities continue to exist, with women facing barriers to accessing equal opportunities in the workforce, including wage gaps, engineering and science occupations and limited representation in senior leadership positions. Additionally, cultural norms and societal attitudes perpetuate gender stereotypes and discrimination, hindering progress towards complete gender equality especially for rural communities. To address these remaining challenges, sustained efforts are needed to enforce existing laws, enhance economic empowerment programmes for women, initiate gender indicator tracking in all institutions, promote gender-sensitive education, and foster societal change through awareness and advocacy campaigns.

With regards to this project, the analysis showed that the integration of gender considerations into all development planning and strategies hasn't permeated into local government such as DMs and LMs. The absence of gender-sensitive reports, strategies, tracking gender indicators and budgeting in IDPs suggests a significant gap in understanding and implementing gender mainstreaming in these institutions. The Eco-DRR project aims to address these gaps by adopting and implementing a gender sensitive approach that ensures gender responsiveness to climate change, DRR and ecosystem-based approaches.

The project aims to bridge the gap between the high-level conceptualisation of gender mainstreaming and its practical implementation at the grassroots level. It's crucial to ensure that gender considerations are integrated into every stage of the Eco-DRR project, from planning to execution, to create more effective and inclusive strategies that benefit all members of the community.

Addressing the gender gap in South Africa's rural areas is imperative to confront the unequal impact of floods, wildfires and droughts on women and other marginalised groups. Empowering women and marginalised groups through education, economic opportunities, enhanced participation, and improved infrastructure is pivotal for building resilience and fostering sustainable development. By prioritising inclusive strategies, we can ensure that rural women and marginalised groups are equipped to face climate extremes and contribute meaningfully to their communities' resilience.

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# APPENDIX A Gender Assessment Checklist

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|---|
| *Guidance Note:*<br>• *Part A - CN Stage:*<br>*This section should be completed during the Conceptual Note (CN) stage. At this point, focus on identifying potential risks associated with the project's design and scope.*<br>• *Part B - FP Stage:*<br>*This section should be filled out during the Full Proposal (FP) stage. At this stage, provide a detailed assessment of the identified risks and refine your mitigation strategies based on further analysis and available data.* |
| **Gender Impact Screening questions** |
| **Part A – To be done/ filled/ considered at Concept Note (CN) Stage** |
| 1. Is the Project/Fund/Programme aligned with:<br>- National gender policies?<br>- GCF's gender policy requirements?<br>- International gender commitments? |
| *Answer here providing with the justification:* |
| 1a. Has sex-disaggregated data been collected and provided to GCF Secretariate for review? If not, please provide justification and explain how and when this will be done. |
| *Answer here providing with the justification:* |
| 1b. Has description of gender related country context been provided? |
| *Answer here providing with the justification:* |
| **Part B – To be done/ filled/ considered Funding Proposal (FP) Stage** |
| 2a. Will the Project/Fund/Programme provide gender awareness training for project staff?<br>2b. Will there be a capacity building programme for local women's organisations?<br>2c. How will Knowledge sharing on gender and climate change be facilitated? |
| *2a) Yes. As noted in the Gender Action Plan (Section 6), Action B3 focuses on strengthening institutional capacity and awareness. This includes developing specific training interventions for relevant project staff as well as developing capacity of relevant senior project management regarding gender mainstreaming and its processes (oversight and grievance mechanisms).*<br><br>*2b) Yes. Output 1.2 of the project looks at local gender-inclusive and sustainable ecosystem-based livelihoods that supports locally led adaptation. This will include capacity building initiatives that target local women's organisations, particularly SMMEs.*<br><br>*2c) As per Action B2, gender focused knowledge products will be developed at project and intervention level to promote knowledge sharing. This includes determining research initiatives to attract women to careers in natural resource management and climate change; unpacking current social inequalities in the natural resource management sector; and researching the linkages between gender, natural resource management and climate change.* |
| 3. Consultation process:<br>- Includes participation of both women and men<br>- Covers vulnerable groups in consultations<br>- Uses gender-sensitive consultation methods<br>- Documents stakeholder inputs and concerns |

*The consultation process will ensure meaningful inclusive participation that promotes inclusivity, transparency, accountability and non-discrimination. In addition, this emphasis ensures that gender considerations are included throughout the planning and engagement processes. All interactions should promote inclusivity across gender, culture, and generations, including marginalised groups, while paying close attention to the cultural customs, practices, and values of all parties.*
*Some of the key principles that will underline stakeholder engagements include:*

- *Respect, courtesy, openness and transparency in approach, ensuring inclusivity and sensitivity to diverse perspectives, including those related to gender;*
- *Clarifying the mechanisms for engagement and consultation throughout the iterative adaptation planning process, including a focus on the private sector, sub-national governments and civil society organisations, while paying attention to gender-balanced participation;*
- *Ensure clear communication and accessible information dissemination on climate impact, risk and vulnerability information to relevant stakeholders, recognising and addressing diverse needs based on the audience's characteristics, including gender-specific considerations.;*
- *Streamlining stakeholder engagement processes within existing broader development planning and coordination mechanisms, such as existing forums, meetings etc.;*
- *Continuous communication and engagement to ensure progress is comprehended and actively contributed to, demonstrating accountability and ensuring equitable value for money, considering gender-inclusive impacts and benefits; and*
- *Genuine and active stakeholder engagement throughout the process.*

*Stakeholders will need to be regularly kept informed of project developments, updates, and community comments. This will be done via recurring reports and presentations/meetings that describe the progress of the project and key decisions made. More details regarding the stakeholder engagement plan can be found in Annex 7.*